

Fate's Edge

Amaranthine Worldbook

The Northern Shores and the Lands Beyond

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Part I

The World & Its Ways

Chapter 1

The Amaranthine Sea

The Amaranthine Sea lies at the heart of the known world, a salt expanse ringed by marble quays, vineyard hills, and smoke-blue mountains. For millennia it has served as the circulatory system of trade, faith, and conquest. Tides are subtle, but seasonal winds and river-feeds set the rhythm of commerce, pilgrimage, and war.

Unlike the dry southern coasts of distant lands, the wind patterns here reverse: the hot, arid air of the Sahel belt is pushed south, leaving the northern and eastern shores with ample rainfall and the southern shores as temperate grasslands. Thus the lands around the Amaranthine are lush and productive—olive groves in Ecktoria, wheat fields in Acasia, horse pastures on the Vilikari steppe.

North of the Amaranthine rise the Aelerian mountains, a spine of stone that separates the mild coastal lowlands from the colder northern reaches. Beyond those peaks lie the Violet Steppe and the Mistlands, where the Direwood presses against the fog-hung border. To the east, the Dolmis Sea (a dark inland basin) connects to the Amaranthine through the Astroegro Straits, guarded by the towers of Thepyrgos. The Aberderrin Sea, farther north, is a cold, wave-lashed expanse that borders both the Linn homelands and the Valewood.

A people without a single homeland, the Sidhi are a diaspora born from the ancient cities of Ashaan and Galanina. Their ships carry spice, silk, and secrets across every sea, and their enclaves thrive in Zakov, Kahfagia, and the port-towns of the Dolmis. Feared as pirates and respected as intermediaries, the Sidhi speak a dozen tongues and honor bargains with a blade if necessary. They are the frame through which many distant shores are glimpsed, though those shores lie beyond the scope of this book.

Chapter 2

Travel & Navigation

2.1 Core Travel Procedure

For each leg of a journey, draw 3–4 cards using the decks for your destination and controlling authority.

- ♠ from the destination deck: sets the scene (place).
- ♥ from the destination deck: introduces the local actor or faction.
- ♣ from the Wilds (general hazards) or destination (if strongly policed): brings pressure.
- ♦ from the authority that gates the route: papers, escorts, rights, or exceptions.

Set a travel clock by the highest rank:

- 2–5 $\Rightarrow$ 4 segments
- 6–10 $\Rightarrow$ 6 segments
- J/Q/K $\Rightarrow$ 8 segments
- A $\Rightarrow$ 10 segments

On success, advance to the next leg; on failure, mark delay, debt, or diversion and resolve a consequence in the fiction.

2.2 Mode Rules

2.2.1 Sea Legs

(Amaranthine/Dolmis/Aberderrin). If Theona or Valewood 9s show up anywhere in the seed, add an omission or taboo to the leg (a missing step, an unsaid name).

2.2.2 Passes & Underways

(Aeler). Any A may convert a surface route to an under-route. ♦ from Aeler always codifies outcomes—no roll—for sealed doors, breath time, and escorted segments.

2.2.3 Rivers

Bridges, booms, and law in Ecktoria/Viterra; reed-mazes and bell-lines in Mistlands/Linn waters.

2.2.4 Frontier Blends

When origin and destination disagree on law, draw two $\diamond$ (one from each law) and choose which you will be judged by at the end of the leg.

2.3 Regional Routes

2.3.1 Amaranthine Coastway

Kahfagia $\rightarrow$ Ecktoria $\rightarrow$ Acasia $\rightarrow$ Marcott (Vhasia) $\rightarrow$ Fairport (Viterra).

- Draw $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ from the port you are entering.
- Draw $\clubsuit$ from the Wilds (gales, quarantine, harbor booms).
- Draw $\diamond$ from the port's deck (permits, berths), or Kahfagia if convoy/lantern law applies.

Silkstrand is Acasia's sole metropolis and a major trading hub; even land caravans risk the marches to reach it.

2.3.2 Astroegro Straits

Thepyrgos controls the hinge between seas via sentinel islands in the straits.

- Draw $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ and $\clubsuit$ from Thepyrgos (stairs, boom, synod).
- Draw $\diamond$ from Thepyrgos (harbor pass, crane allotment).
- Switch to Dolmis/Amaranthine modules once the boom is lowered.

2.3.3 Dolmis Circuits

Fairport (Viterra) $\rightarrow$ Theona (Three Greens) $\rightarrow$ Ubral fjords $\rightarrow$ Aelinnel west shore $\rightarrow$ Zakov (north coast).

- $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ from destination; $\clubsuit$ from Linn or the Wilds; $\diamond$ from Theona when island custom matters.
- Zakov: Draw $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ from Zakov deck; $\clubsuit$ from Zakov or Linn; $\diamond$ from Zakov (harbor-green, corsair charter).

2.3.4 Aelerian Passes & Underways

Vhasia/Viterra/Ubral south slopes $\rightarrow$ Aeler gates $\rightarrow$ Mistlands.

- $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ and $\clubsuit$ from Aeler; $\diamond$ from Aeler (Underway pass, Key-Writ, Breath time).

2.3.5 Shadow Corridors

Thin Shore (Valewood east coast): risky misted corridor north-south toward Zakov.

- $\spadesuit$ from Valewood, $\heartsuit$ from Mistlands (or Valewood), $\clubsuit$ from Mistlands (wraiths, bell-line failures), $\diamond$ from either Mistlands (Ward-salt, Lantern Writ) or Valewood (Way-cord, Truce-bough) depending on which law you invoke.
- *Rule of 9s*: any 9 in the seed adds an omission.

Green Gate hops (Aelinnel): tide-timed arches.

- $\spadesuit+\clubsuit$ from Aelinnel (tides, geasa), $\diamond$ from Aelinnel (Tide-path Key, Host-rights).

2.3.6 River Roads

Belworth: forms the boundary between Vhasia and Viterra. Twin ports at the mouth (Marcott and Fairport); at mid-reach Tarlington Falls requires lift/portage up to the plateau town. The Lence joins here from Vhasia. Use Viterra for east-bank audits/bridges, Vhasia for west-bank politics.

Yloka: raids run down from the north into the Aberderrin and Dolmis—overlay Linn ♣ and draw destination for ♠+♥.

Acasian rivers: hazardous but profitable approaches to Silkstrand; use Acasia ♣ (feuds/levies/curse) and ◇ (condotta, bridge rights).

2.3.7 Steppe Frontiers

Ykrul ↔ Vilikari ↔ Ecktoria/Acasia borders ↔ Black Banner territories.

- ♠ from the road you ride (Wolf Road or Foedus Stone), ♥ from the counterpart (envoys, comitatus), ♣ from Wilds or frontier decks (rasputitsa, hostage protocol, foedus recall), ◇ from either Ykrul (paiza, remounts) or Vilikari (foedus seal, bench-right).
- Black Banner: Draw ♠ from Ykrul/Vilikari decks (shared territory), ♥ from Black Banner, ♣ from Wilds or frontier decks, ◇ from Ykrul/Vilikari/Black Banner.

2.4 Gateways & Control Points

Gate	Deck	Diamond Source	Typical Leverage
Kassamira (Kahfagia)	Kahfagia	Kahfagia	Convoy letter; lantern-law warrant; pilotage token
Ecktoria Capital Port	Ecktoria	Ecktoria	Berth priority; coin-house credit; procession permit
Silkstrand	Acasia	Acasia	Exchange floor; condotta; watergate priority
Marcott	Vhasia	Vhasia	Letters patent; safeconduct; fairground precedence
Fairport	Viterra	Viterra	Customs seal; ferry priority; Dawn escort
Tarlington Falls	Viterra	Viterra	Lift priority; bridge/portage pass; County Thing
Thepyrgos (boom)	Thepyrgos	Thepyrgos	Harbor pass; crane allotment; Synod indulgence
High-Mist Pass	Aeler	Aeler	Underway pass; Key-Writ; Breath time allotment
Payden's Port	Mistlands	Mistlands	Lantern writ; ward-salt; wraith indemnity
Thin Shore (Valewood)	Valewood	Valewood/Mistlands	Way-cord; dew-mirror; lantern writ
Green Gate (Aelinnel)	Aelinnel	Aelinnel	Tide-path key; host-right bough; salt license
Ubral Passes	Ubral	Aeler/Ubral	Vurim pass-ring; hill-fort shelter writ; guide's bribe
Thing-holm (Linn)	Linn	Linn	Thing ruling; harbor-green; escort writ
Foedus Stone (March)	Vilikari	Vilikari/Ykrul	Foedus renewal; remount allotment; hostage treaty
Zakov Roadstead	Zakov	Zakov	Harbor-green chit; corsair charter; pilot token
Black Banner Camps	Black Banner	Black Banner/Ykrul/Vilikari	Safe-conduct; remount chit; clan truce

Table 2.1: Gateway Control Points

2.5 Overlay: Gatekeepers (Zakov Roadstead & Harbour Quarters)

Draw **one** micro-card each time you *enter*, *shift wharfs*, or *depart* Zakov. Combine with the normal seed.

Zakov Gatekeepers Micro-Cards (draw 1)

1. **Bureaucrat Quirk** — stamps only at *eighth bell*; night filings need a *Night Magistrate* countersign.
2. **Required Stamp** — *Harbor-Green* chit for boom passage this tide; without it, DV +1 on all port checks.
3. **Preferred Gratuity** — figs or lamp oil; wrong gift offends, marking 1 *Exposure* on your port reputation.
4. **Audit Trap** — “contraband tallies”; if carrying *bell-metal* or *dyestuffs*, start a 4-seg *Inspection* clock.
5. **Local Courtesy** — speak the *Dock Oath* (short pledge not to knife on planks) or suffer *Desperate* position in brawls.
6. **Shortcut Rumor** — *Smuggler’s Ladder* on the sea wall; spend a ◇ (*Ladder Map*) to skip one queue.
7. **Pilot’s Privilege** — a *Pilot Token* bumps you ahead on boom lift; otherwise pay tow or lose 1 segment.
8. **Silent Court** — the *Black Bishop* is sitting tonight; legal ♣ escalate by +1 SB if you contest a ruling.

2.6 Special Rules & Taboos

2.6.1 Theona / Valewood 9s

Whenever a 9 appears in a seed involving Theona or Valewood, add an omission: a missing step, an unsaid name, an unseen guest. If the 9 is a ◇, you may break the taboo once—someone will come to collect.

2.6.2 Aeler Aces

An A can rewire routes beneath the mountains. You may swap your ♠ to Aeler (keeping the other seed cards) and continue under-vault procedures.

2.6.3 Echoing Omens

Any A adds a motif you can echo later (ash on the wind, a bell heard underground, a landmark that returns elsewhere). Make the world feel like it remembers.

2.7 Worked Itineraries

2.7.1 West-to-East Coastal Haul (Kahfagia → Viterra)

Leg 1: Kassamira → Ecktoria Seed:

Ecktoria ♠ (Aqueduct arcades), Ecktoria ♥ (Coin-house factor), Wilds ♣ (gale), Kahfagia ◇ (convoy letter).

Clock: 6. Read: cross under coin-house eyes with convoy priority; bad weather strains schedules.

Leg 2: Ecktoria → Silkstrand Seed:

Acasia ♠ (Three-Queens Bridge), Acasia ♥ (Dyers' Guildmistress), Acasia ♣ (loom strike), Acasia ♦ (Exchange pass).

Clock: 6–8 depending on unrest.

Leg 3: Silkstrand → Marcott Seed:

Vhasia ♠ (Pont-du-Tithe), Vhasia ♥ (Parlement clerk), Vhasia ♣ (coin rumor), Vhasia ♦ (letters patent).

Leg 4: Marcott → Fairport Seed:

Viterra ♠ (Fairport tideworks), Viterra ♥ (shipwright), Linn ♣ (boom lifts), Viterra ♦ (customs seal).

Clock: 6.

2.7.2 Acasia → Mistlands (Forgotten Pass + Under-Gate)

Leg 1: Silkstrand → Aeler Gate Seed:

Aeler ♠ (Avalanche gallery), Aeler ♥ (Geometer), Aeler ♣ (Engineer requisition), Aeler ♦ (Underway Pass).

Leg 2: Gate → Mistlands Seed:

Mistlands ♠ (Bell-Line levee), Mistlands ♥ (Bell-warden), Mistlands ♣ (wraith crossing), Mistlands ♦ (Ward-salt).

2.7.3 Thin Shore → Zakov Corridor

Leg 1: Payden's Port → Thin Shore Seed:

Valewood ♠ (Green lane), Mistlands ♥ (Protectorate clerk), Mistlands ♣ (bell failure), Mistlands ♦ (Lantern writ).

Leg 2: Thin Shore transit Seed:

Valewood ♠ (Unfound stile), Valewood ♥ (Path-warden), Valewood ♣ (Sweet wind), Valewood ♦ (Way-cord).

Rule of 9s applies.

2.7.4 Frontier Mediation (Ykrul ↔ Vilikari)

Leg: Foedus Stone parley Seed:

Vilikari ♠ (Foedus Stone), Ykrul ♥ (Noyan envoy), Wilds ♣ (rasputitsa), Vilikari ♦ (Foedus Renewal).

Blend: also draw a Ykrul ♦ (Paiza). Choose which law saves your schedule.

2.7.5 Worked Itinerary: Thin Shore → Zakov → Theona (Corsair Jobs)

Leg 1: Payden's Port → Thin Shore (Shadow Corridor) Seed:

Valewood ♠ (Green lane / Unfound stile); Mistlands ♥ (Protectorate clerk); Mistlands ♣ (bell-line failure); Mistlands ♦ (Lantern Writ).

Clock: 6. *Rule of 9s*: any 9 adds an omission.

Leg 2: Thin Shore Transit (Skirting toward Zakov) Seed:

Valewood ♠ (Sea-mist arcade); Valewood ♥ (Path-warden); Valewood ♣ (Sweet wind); Valewood ♦ (Way-cord).

Clock: 6. *Note*: spending *Way-cord* negates one *Sweet wind* lie.

Leg 3: Approach to Zakov (Roadstead & Booms) Seed:

Zakov ♠ (Boomhouse or Red Wharf); Zakov ♥ (Pilot-Matron or Night Magistrate); Zakov ♣ (Boom Drop or Customs Sweep); Zakov ♦ (Harbor-Green Chit or Pilot Token).

Clock: 6–8 (apply the Gatekeepers overlay draw on arrival). If a 9 shows: *Missing Ninth*—remove one critical step/name until paid in favors.

Leg 4: Corsair Job Inside Zakov (Pick 1) A) Lift a Hull from Drydock Four:

Zakov ♠ (Drydock Four); Zakov ♥ (Corsair Quartermaster); Zakov ♣ (Admiralty Audit); Zakov ♦ (Shipwright's Lien Release).

Goal: tow a seized hull at night; *Lien Release* avoids bond but flips a debt later.

B) Court the Black Bishop for Indulgence:

Zakov ♠ (Black Bell Tower); Zakov ♥ (Black Bishop); Zakov ♣ (Bounty Proclamation); Zakov ♦ (Magistrate's Hush).

Goal: seal a case/docket so a rival can't use it. Hook: rumor must be paid (coin or gossip).

C) Smuggler's Ladder Run:

Zakov ♠ (Lantern Ladder); Zakov ♥ (Lampman); Zakov ♣ (Informant Flip); Zakov ♦ (Smuggler's Ladder Map).

Goal: bypass boom eyes with a wall-stair. Complication: your tip was sold twice.

Leg 5: Zakov → Theona (Isles & Moot) Seed:

Theona ♠ (Uncounted Bridge); Theona ♥ (Matron of Wells or Moot Envoy); Linn ♣ (fogfall raids); Theona ♦ (Moot Token).

Clock: 6–8. Taboo: do *not* count the steps aloud; breaking it imposes *Controlled* on all isle bargains this scene.

Leg 6: Theona Contract (Pick 1) A) Raid-Truce at the Skerries:

Theona ♠ (Tide caves); Theona ♥ (Isle Moot Envoy); Theona ♣ (Muster drum); Theona ♦ (Raid-truce Ribbon).

Goal: secure safe passage window; failure triggers a Linn muster clock.

B) Deliver the Ledger Shard:

Theona ♠ (Well-yard); Theona ♥ (Matron of Wells); Zakov ♣ (Debt Call follows you); Theona ♦ (Sanctuary Night).

Goal: hide a Zakov debt long enough to copy data; sanctuary buys time.

2.7.6 Steppe Passage: Black Banner Territory

Leg: Foedus Stone → Black Banner Camp Seed:

Ykrul/Vilikari ♠ (Wolf Road milepost or Foedus Stone); Black Banner ♥ (Clan Elder or War Captain); Wilds ♣ (Rasputitsa or Remount Sickness); Black Banner ♦ (Safe-conduct or Remount Chit).

Clock: 6–8. Complication: Foedus recall may invalidate your papers.

Leg: Black Banner Camp → Ykrul Territory Seed:

Ykrul ♠ (Winter camp ring or Khagan's way-station); Ykrul ♥ (Khatun of the Ring or Noyan envoy); Frontier ♣ (Hostage protocol or Feud spark); Ykrul ♦ (Paiza tablet or Foedus seal).

Clock: 6–8. *Note*: Choose which law applies—Black Banner customs or Ykrul traditions.

2.8 Pace, Clocks, and Consequences

- Road/river leg: 6-segment clock; +2 segments if crossing a law boundary (new passports, new prayers).
- Sea strait/mountain pass: 8-segment clock; −2 segments if you spend a $\diamond$ that codifies priority (pilotage, pass, convoy).
- Shadow corridor: 6-segment clock; on any A, add a free omen to echo later.
- Failure defaults: delay (lose time; an enemy advances), diversion (alternate route; new $\clubsuit$), or debt (promise, fine, or favor owed to the authority that controls the gate).

SB Note. Re-rolling 1s does *not* erase their SB; any new 1s on the re-roll add more SB.

2.9 Story Beat (SB) Menus

2.9.1 Universal SB Spend Menu

- **1 SB** — Shave time/position: add +1 segment to the current clock *or* drop Position one step *or* impose a small fee/toll *or* mark 1 step of *Asset Exposure*.
- **2 SB** — Escalate the pressure: upgrade the active $\clubsuit$ (e.g., “inspection” → “seizure attempt”) *or* force a *choice of Diamonds* (pick which law you’ll be judged by) *or* tick a relevant *Front* by 1.
- **3 SB** — Lock a gate/taboo: close a route (boom drops; pass closes) until a named $\diamond$ is spent *or* invoke a regional taboo (Theona/Valewood 9s; oath backlash) with teeth *or* auto-trigger a *Debt Flip* on a Diamond already in play.
- **4+ SB** — Reshape the leg: rewrite the route (Aeler under-way reroute; sea lane reversal), start a *new* 4–6 segment complication clock *and* tick a *Front* by +1; demand immediate payment on a Patron/Asset Exposure (lose it if refused).

End-of-leg conversion (optional): Unspent SB convert to *world motion* at a rate of **3 SB** → **tick 1 Front** (GM choice).

2.9.2 Sea (Amaranthine/Dolmis/Aberderrin)

- **1 SB:** Fogfall nips visibility; DV +1 for the next pilotage check.
- **2 SB:** Boom shifts; pilot required (spend a *pilotage* $\diamond$ or delay +2 segments).
- **3 SB:** Lantern-law change mid-leg; choose: pay fine *or* reroute clock +2 *or* spend *Convoy Letter*.
- **4 SB:** Squall wall: split the convoy; lose an escort unless *Moot token* or *Escort* Diamond is spent.

2.9.3 Passes & Underways (Aeler)

- **1 SB:** White wind; breath-time check (mark Fatigue or slow +1 segment).
- **2 SB:** Engineer requisition; surrender cargo slot *or* coin *or* DV +1 until the gate.
- **3 SB:** Under-audit; must go below (swap $\spadesuit$ to Aeler) unless you spend *Key-Writ*.
- **4 SB:** Cave-in detour adds a fresh 4-segment clock unless *Underway Pass* is spent.

2.9.4 Rivers (Belworth & friends)

- **1 SB:** Sandbar drift; portage a beat or pay for a tow.
- **2 SB:** Lift strike at Tarlington; need *Bridge/Portage Pass* or delay +2 segments.
- **3 SB:** Cross-mouth embargo (Marcott/Fairport); choose which harbor’s law applies (draw/commit its $\diamond$).
- **4 SB:** Ice-break or flood surge; split cargo (random item at risk) unless an *Escort Diamond* is spent.

2.9.5 Shadow Corridors (Valewood/Mistlands)

- **1 SB:** Bell-line stutter; next guidance roll at Disadvantage (or DV +1).
- **2 SB:** Omission manifests; something necessary is “missing” until *Ward-salt* or *Way-cord* is spent.
- **3 SB:** Host-law claims you as *host/guest*; accept a service clock or pay with a memory (lose a minor Contact until end of leg).
- **4 SB:** Wraith procession crosses your path; create a 6-segment *Don’t Look Back* clock; spending *Lantern Writ* downgrades it to 4.

2.9.6 Steppe Frontiers (Ykrul/Vilikari/Black Banner)

- **1 SB:** Remount fatigue; lose 1 “fresh mount” use or slow +1 segment.
- **2 SB:** Hostage protocol; must place/accept a token-kin until the next gate (or spend *Safe-hostage*).
- **3 SB:** Foedus recall; your papers conflict—pick Ykrul *Paiza* or Vilikari *Foedus Seal* and offend the other.
- **4 SB:** Muster checkpoint; disarm unless traveling under *Standard Protection* or *Khagan’s Writ*.
- **Black Banner Specific:** Clan feud erupts; choose sides or pay double tolls.

2.9.7 Ports & Forums (Marcott, Fairport, Silkstrand, Thepyrgos, Zakov)

- **1 SB:** Clerk error; pay a “stamp” fee or answer questions (DV +1).
- **2 SB:** Rival petition; they jump the queue unless you spend a Warrant/Letters $\diamond$.
- **3 SB:** Audit cascade; open a new 4-segment *Inspection* clock tied to cargo/ledger.
- **4 SB:** Edict flare; convert today’s $\clubsuit$ into a temporary “law” everyone must obey or take on a *Debt Flip*.
- **Zakov Specific:** Silent Court ruling; legal $\clubsuit$ escalate by +1 SB.

2.9.8 Diamond & Exposure Interactions

- **2 SB:** Flip any $\diamond$ spent this leg: its *Debt Flip* is collected now (not later).
- **2 SB:** Mark 1 step on a named Asset/Patron’s *Exposure* track.
- **3 SB:** Downgrade an *Intricate* success to *Detailed* (remove the flourish or DV 1 benefit).
- **4 SB:** Seize or suspend a visible Diamond’s benefit until another is played (e.g., convoy letter overridden by emergency edict).

Part II

The Northern Shore

Chapter 3

Kahfagia

The Empire of Wakes and Storm-Flags. Kahfagia is a maritime power whose strength lies not in territory but in control of the sea lanes. The Lantern-Law, administered by the Admiral of Lantern-Law, governs every beacon, boom, and berth. Pilots carry mirrors that speak in code, and the spice auctions of Kassamira set prices across the Amaranthine. To sail under Kahfagia's protection is to move with the tide; to defy it is to find the beacons turned against you.

3.1 Kahfagia — “Pilot’s Mirror”

Admiral of Lantern-Law (Elite): “Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights — and woe to the fool who rows against them.”

Dockside Factor (Commoner): “The pilots see farther than kings. A gesture in lantern-code can open ports, or close them. Keep your debts paid, and your lamps trimmed.”

Theme & Atmosphere

In Kahfagia, the sea is a contract. Every channel is a clause, every beacon a signature. The Admiralty of Lantern-Law does not rule with armies—they rule with light. Shift a beacon, and a harbor closes. Dim a mirror, and a fleet founders. Foreign powers curse the “pilot’s monopoly,” but they still pay the toll. Because the alternative is sailing blind.

What you notice first: The constant chime of bell-buoys. The smell of salt, tar, and burnt oil from a thousand lanterns. The way everyone—admiral to dockhand—glances at the tide clock before speaking.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never argue with a Mirror-Keeper about where the channel lies. If they say the safe water moved, it moved. Your chart is already kindling.

Regional Mood: The Lantern’s Vigil

Power is visible here—literally. Every night, a thousand lamps burn along the channels, each a statement of control. To dim a light is to declare bankruptcy. To move a beacon is to declare war. Commodores sit in their mirror-towers, watching reflections, while tide-clocks tick down to the next auction, the next inspection, the next quiet murder in a fog-shrouded creek.

Starting Location: The Lantern Pier admiralty chapel, where votive ships hang from the ceiling and brine drips from the icon of a drowned saint. A sea-notary unlocks a salt-stained

reliquary and produces a chart with gilt edges. “Fetch the contraband bell from the corsair galleass *Santa Dolorosa* before moonrise—or the harbor names you accomplices.”

(Littoral/Lane/Law) Tidal mudflat with hidden plank-way at low water; salt-scar pier behind dawn spice auctions.

Spades — Places

2. **Tidal Mudflat** — Hidden plank-way at low water; smugglers’ shortcut. *At ebb, the planks rise like the ribs of a drowned whale.*
 3. **Salt-Scar Pier** — Behind dawn spice auctions; where fortunes wash ashore. *Auditors check the salt-scars—white crust that proves cargo was cleaned, not stolen.*
 4. **Reedbelt Creeks** — Smuggler paths where tax boats won’t follow. *A hanged man’s boots hang from a piling; those who pass tug their collars.*
 5. **Breakwater Gap** — Under repair; cutters slip at dusk through the works. *The stone is still loose. A wrong step, and the sea claims another toll.*
 6. **Dredged Channel** — Fresh with temporary beacons; tomorrow’s safe water. *The buoys are painted yellow—the color of “maybe.”*
 7. **River Sluice** — Tide-gate and boom-chain; access controlled by rope and writ. *The chain has a notch where a slaver’s ship tried to flee. It still drips oil.*
 8. **Cutter Yard** — Narrow-keel vessels; apprentices work night shifts. *They sing old work songs—the kind that skip the ninth beat.*
 9. **Lantern Alley** — Fog-lane where beacons migrate with the tide. *Follow the lights. Two blinks means you’re expected. Three? You’re prey.*
 10. **Admiralty Quay** — Bonded warehouses under seal; law walks the decks. *The seal on the door changes with the tide. Today it’s a serpent eating its tail.*
- J **Red Shoal** — Quiet water, loud reputations; where deals are made. *Old barges moored together; a floating court with no bailiff.*
- Q **Mirror Tower** — Pilot station that certifies safe water—today. *The mirror at the top shows not the sea, but the face of the last captain who argued.*
- K **Kassamira Port** — Presidial; auctions at dawn, courts by noon. *The auctioneer’s gavel is wrapped in a page torn from a debtor’s ledger.*
- A **The Pointe** — Strait of storm-lights and wreckers’ tales. *On still nights, you can hear the drowned singing the names of those who owe.*

(Pilot/Corsair/Admiral) Tide-runner with bell and rope; pilot’s apprentice with perfect memory for shoals.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tide-Runner** — Bell and rope; knows every tide-table by heart. *“The table says high water at noon. The moon lies. Trust my rope.”*
3. **Pilot’s Apprentice** — Perfect memory for shoals; tomorrow’s navigator. *Touches a brass talisman before every sounding. No one knows why.*

4. **Lantern Clerk** — Knows which lights moved, and why; keeper of the shifts. *Docks with a ledger that smells of smoke. Adds a surcharge for “recent adjustments.”*
5. **Oshiiran Factor** — Two ledgers; one for Kahfagia, one for truth. *The left ledger records bribes as “conciliation fees.” The right one is never shown.*
6. **Dock-Syndic** — Makes queues vanish; power in the pause. *He never raises his voice. The harbor master listens anyway.*
7. **Lantern Advocate** — “Jurisdiction moves like tide”; law in flux. *She carries a water-clock in her sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.*
8. **Privateer Captain** — “Crooked” letter of convoy; profit in the margins. *Her ship flies three flags; the one she lowers last is the one that matters.*
9. **Thalasso Sergeant** — Shore leave but still on duty; marine precision. *A tattoo of a lighthouse on his forearm; the light is his wife’s name.*
10. **Admiralty Magistrate** — Rules fast, travels faster; justice in a hurry. *She once sentenced a man to the galleys and boarded the ship before he did.*
- J **Dredging Foreman** — Channel follows their purse; water reshaped. *His crew are ex-criminals; he pays them in salt pork and absolution.*
- Q **Mirror-Keeper (Elite)** — Commodore’s confidante; places beacons that bind. *Their faces are never seen—only reflected. Some say they have none.*
- K **Kahfagian Commodore** — Off the books but on the water; shadow admiral. *His flagship is a fishing smack. Its nets drag up letters of marque.*
- A **Admiral of Red Shoal** — Offers wine, figs—once. Price in stories. *She pours the first cup herself. If she pours a second, you’ve already agreed.*

(Tide/Law/Weather) Tide turns two bells early—grounding risk rises; smothering fog where sound travels but sight does not.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Early Tide** — Turns two bells early; grounding risk rises like the sea. *Someone bribed the tide-clerk—or the moon is angry.*
3. **Smothering Fog** — Sound travels, sight does not; navigation by ear alone. *You hear oars. Then you don’t. Then they’re behind you.*
4. **Boom Slam** — Harbor chain slams shut; wrong side means delay or danger. *The chain’s links are inscribed with names of debtors. Each one rattles differently.*
5. **Light Shift** — Beacons change mid-approach; your lane just moved. *Someone paid the Lantern Clerk. Find out who—or drift into the reefs.*
6. **Pilot Strike** — No escorts available; average unpaid, risk assumed. *The pilots sit in their guildhall, drinking tea, watching ships founder.*
7. **Customs Inspection** — Ladder audits cargo and crew; delays bite deep. *The inspector has a silver tooth. He smiles when he sees a manifest.*
8. **Reef-Runners** — Corsair skiffs circle with boarding hooks; steel in the spray. *Their leader wears a Mirror-Keeper’s badge—stolen or earned, you cannot tell.*
9. **Jurisdiction Flip** — Lantern-law shifts; your writ no longer bites. *The tide turned. So did the magistrate. Your safe-conduct is now kindling.*

- 10. **Fire Risk** — Alchemical cargo aboard; quarantine if anything spills. *A single spark and the whole quay becomes a crater. The factor wants you to know this.*
- J **Quartermaster Betrayal** — Tide-tables sold to rival; route compromised. *The betrayal is written in lemon juice; heat reveals the name.*
- Q **Yellow Flag** — Port quarantine; deadlines rot on the hook. *The flag is dyed with turmeric and something else—something that smells sweet.*
- K **Fleet Redeploy** — “Safe” corridor becomes parade ground; chaos in formation. *Admirals play chess with real ships, and you are a pawn.*
- A **Black Squall (at the Pointe)** — Scatters ships and stories alike. *This is no natural storm. The water hisses. Something below is waking.*

(Paper/Right/Priority) Priority mooring chit (skip Mooring Roll once); pilotage token for certified escort through bad channel.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

- 2. **Mooring Chit** — Skip the Mooring Roll once; harbor favors you. *The chit is a dried seahorse shell. Keep it away from salt.*
- 3. **Pilotage Token** — One certified escort through a bad channel. *The pilot who accepts it must touch your shoulder before speaking.*
- 4. **Fee Waiver** — Cargo cleared today; ledger smiles included. *The clerk stamps it twice—once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
- 5. **Safe-Conduct** — Along specific beacons lane; law walks with you. *The commodore’s seal is warm. It cools as the exit nears.*
- 6. **Salvage Rights** — On named quay or reach; flotsam becomes fortune. *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
- 7. **Warehouse Access** — Bonded storage; seal prize before rivals sniff. *The key is a bronze finger. It fits only one lock—and breaks after use.*
- 8. **Lantern Code** — Tonight’s signals revealed; navigation advantage. *Three quick flashes: safe passage. One long, two short: the Admiralty is watching.*
- 9. **Dredging Grant** — You decide where next channel runs; reshape the sea. *The dredgers are convicts. They work faster if you promise a name in their favor.*
- 10. **Letter of Marque** — Convoy protection for one season; legal blades. *The ink is mixed with gunpowder. It smokes slightly when read.*
- J **Admiralty Judgment** — Precedent travels with you; law bends. *The case number is burned into a leather tag. Tag it to a belt loop.*
- Q **Mirror Warrant** — Legal right to post a beacon; redraw the map. *The Mirror-Keeper’s seal, still warm. The channel you mark becomes law—until challenged.*
- K **Spice Share** — Stake in Kassamira auction floor; profit in pepper. *The share is a peppercorn sealed in wax. Bite it to test authenticity.*
- A **Lantern License** — Temporary authority to redefine the lane. *The harbor master spits when he hands it over. Use it wisely—or not at all.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/rights/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea & signal** motifs—beacons that migrate, tides that remember, law that flows like water.

Additional Features

- **Pilot’s Mirror:** Kahfagia’s strength is not fleet but monopoly on light and lane. To post a beacon is to redraw the map.
- **Oligarchic Rule:** Families rule by shares in ports and auctions; politics is brokerage in ledgers and lanterns.
- **Western Reach:** Captains boast of ports “beyond the mirror,” bringing rumors, goods, and curses the Amaranthine can scarcely name.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run the hospice on Deadman’s Quay. They ask no payment—but they remember faces. A renegade Sister hides in the reedbelt creeks.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Mirror Towers double as observation posts for those who hunt the unquiet dead. The Lantern Code can reveal spirits—or trap them in reflection.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** The Pointe’s storms answer to a drowned cult of the Cruel Messenger. Sailors whisper that the Black Squall has a face.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Psions who read tides are called “Weather Readers.” The Admiralty licenses them—and disposes of the ones who see too far.
- **The Ninth:** In any lantern-lit scene, the ninth lamp lit in a room reveals a threshold. The wise stop at eight.

Kahfagia Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over your shoulder before entering a new channel. Ignore the first *Smothering Fog* penalty.
- **Turn the Lantern:** Spin the binnacle lamp once counter-clockwise. Cancel *Boom Slam* or take –1 die on your next pilot check (your choice).
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a true name into a lead line. Gain +1 Effect against corsairs for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Tide Court.

Patronage & Power

In Kahfagia, power flows through control of the sea lanes themselves. The maritime oligarchs have built their empire not through conquest of territory but through mastery of navigation. Every beacon, every channel marker, every mirror-light is both a navigational aid and a legal instrument. To control the lights is to control the sea.

For the GM: Kahfagian patronage revolves around access—to channels, to cargo, to legal protection. Rewards often take the form of pilotage tokens, safe-conducts, or salvage rights that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (beacons, writs, lantern codes) that can be challenged, moved, or voided.
- Let rival admirals issue conflicting safe-conducts, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the Admiralty courts and spice auctions as arenas for social contests, where legal maneuvering determines success.

In Kahfagia, your route is your rank, and your rank determines your right to passage.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **harbor guards or rival pilots**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **ships or dock workers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **customs or trackers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Admiralty magistrate or harbor master becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift or beacon change**.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival ship or customs cutter arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **ships, marines, or privateers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **beacon moved/channel blocked/law invoked**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Admiral, Commodore, or Mirror-Keeper** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **storm hits/beacons shift/quarantine declared**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Kahfagia (Lantern Law):** Beacons shift without warning, writs expire mid-sentence, jurisdiction flips underfoot.
- **Kahfagia (Western Trade):** Strange cargo manifests, foreign spices bloom in wounds, rumors prove true.
- **Kahfagia (Tide Masters):** Channels silt overnight, tides run backward, anchors refuse to hold.

Western Reach Rumors (d6, fast hooks)

1. A harbor where bells toll under water; cargo *must* be named aloud.
2. A spice that stops bleeding—until moonrise.
3. A mirror-reef that reflects storms from a week ahead.
4. A pilotage guild that uses birds, not beacons.
5. A fleet that sails by *shadow* cast on fog.
6. A court that weighs debts in *breath*, not coin.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your color, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal)

- **The Mirror-Keeper of Kassamira** (signal tyrant): *Phases*—Audit → Blacklist → Light Embargo. Counters: rival beacon logs, Tide Court precedent, stolen codebook.
- **Corsair-Chaplain of the Pointe** (relic raider): *Phases*—Charm → Board → Bell-Wake. Counters: sanctified boom, cofradía oath, drowned-saint tithe.

Chapter 4

Ecktoria

Marble & Fire. Once the furnace of the Utaran Imperium, Ecktoria remains a palimpsest of power—old stones bearing new banners, old laws written under fresh seals. Its marble forums and coin-houses still echo with imperial precedent, yet the Black Banners march on its purse, and rival dukes stage processions that collide at every bridge. The Everflame burns in every basilica, judging truth and debt alike.

4.1 Ecktoria — “Marble & Fire”

Grand Magistrate (Elite): “The law here is written not in books but in marble and flame. Every edict carries the weight of centuries, and every judgment echoes in the very stones of the Forum.”

Ferrymaster (Commoner): “I’ve seen the city burn three times and rise again like a phoenix made of stone. The marble remembers, the bells tell the truth, and the fire judges all – especially those who think coin can buy clean hands.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Once the heart of the Utaran Empire, Ecktoria has worn its laurels into chains. Three centuries of sack, fire, and slow decline have not stripped its marble forums nor its gold-sealed coin-houses – but each day, more of its wealth slips into the hands of mercenaries and factions. The Black Banners march on its purse, avenging old Ykrul wounds by proxy. Processions still crown its stairways, yet ash lines every step. The city burns not only with memory, but with ambition still unquenched. Beyond the capital’s walls, the province is a patchwork of struggling towns, abandoned fortresses, and grainlands whose harvests are disputed by rival tax-collectors. The Everflame Orthodoxy preaches unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The statues watch. The fire judges.

What you notice first: The smell of old incense and fresh bread. The way crowds part for a procession—and close again for a knife. The marble steps, worn smooth by centuries of petitioners.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a toast in a coin-house. The ledgers are the true judges, and a declined cup is a declined credit. You will not borrow again.

Regional Mood: The Flame That Remembers

Here, the past does not fade—it is polished into monuments. Every statue, every obelisk, every triumphal arch is a legal precedent carved in stone. Ecktoria is not one city but three: the marble forums of the old patricians, the soot-stained alleys of the mercenary camps, and the basilicas where the Everflame’s priests balance piety against profit. The Grand Magistrate presides over a skeleton empire, but the real power moves in coin-houses, grain ledgers, and the whispered judgments of the Censor’s Hall. The Black Banners are not invaders; they are employees. The Ykrul are not enemies; they are creditors. And the Everflame is not a god; it is an auditor that never sleeps.

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons. A factor with smoke-singed ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him. Your credit is good—for now. Find out who lit the fire, or the Flame will audit your soul at dawn.”

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Marble grandeur, ash-tipped ambition, and the slow rot of imperial forms.
- **Key Conflict:** Legitimacy versus wealth; old families, new mercenaries, and the Everflame’s judgment.
- **Notable Threats:** Bread riots, arena spills, ducal conflicts, inquisitorial visits, and the Red List.
- **Common Rewards:** Procession permits, coin-house credit, laurel deeds, and a Golden Edict carved in precedent.

The Three Ecktorias: Faction Spectrum

Ecktoria is not a single polity but a battlefield of three competing visions. Most citizens and factions fall somewhere between these poles, shifting allegiance as the grain price changes.

- **Old Blood (Patrician Traditionalists)** – The ancient senatorial families who remember when Ecktoria ruled the world. They worship precedent, hoard marble, and see mercenaries as necessary filth. Their power is in law, lineage, and the silent networks of the Censor’s Hall. *Clocks: PATRICIAN PATIENCE [4], BLOOD DEBT [6].*
- **Black Purse (Mercenary & Trade Leagues)** – The new power: condotta brokers, coin-house factors, and mercenary captains who have bought what birth could not give. They care about supply lines, not bloodlines. Their loyalty is to the next contract, and their god is the ledger. *Clocks: CONTRACT SPIRAL [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6].*
- **The Everflame (Church & Inquisition)** – The priests, inquisitors, and relic-keepers who claim that the Eternal Flame is the only true sovereign. They offer legitimacy to whoever pays the tithe—and withdraw it from whoever forgets. Their power is in pulpits, processions, and the fear of excommunication. *Clocks: HERESY INDEX [4], SANCTUARY VIOLATION [6].*

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul creditors** (who hold Ecktoria’s debt like a leash) and the **Black Banners** (who hold its streets like a lease). A wise politician learns to balance all three—and keeps a boat ready on the Dolmis.

Spades — Places

2. **Petition Steps** — Milk-stone steps where dawn petitions are pinned. *The petitions are written in ink and hope. The steps answer in marble and silence.*
3. **Tally-Ford Ferryhouse** — Rope-drums thrum all day; the ferrymaster watches coin and banners. *The rope-drums have a pattern. It spells the names of those who paid late.*
4. **Arena Hypogeum** — Practice sand and whispered secrets beneath the games. *The sand is from the Tiber. It still remembers the blood of the last revolt.*
5. **Everflame Cloister** — Candle markets and side-chapels where flame speaks truth. *The flame has a voice. It is the voice of the last liar who tested it.*
6. **Shatterline Bazaar** — Between quake-toppled columns, merchants hawk broken dreams. *The columns were toppled by an earthquake that killed a senator. He still haunts the rubble.*
7. **Coin-House Floor** — Counting ledgers under glass; factors seal credit with three ribbons. *The ribbons are colored: white for “ask,” red for “now,” black for “never.”*
8. **Mile-Zero Obelisk** — Surveyors’ starting point; all roads measured from here. *The obelisk has a crack. The crack is a mile long—in the other direction.*
9. **Triumph Stairs** — Processional Way switchback; marble worn smooth by ambition. *The stairs have a name: “The Rise of the Forgotten.” No one remembers why.*
10. **Aqueduct Walk** — Narrow guardpath above the city’s arteries; perfect for ambush or escape. *The water below tastes of iron. It is the city’s memory of its own blood.*
- J **Ducal Loggia** — High above a packed square; a duchess watches and waits. *The duchess has not blinked in three hours. She is counting.*
- Q **Censor’s Hall** — Red-lacquered tablets record every name, every shame. *The tablets are redacted in invisible ink. The truth is underneath.*
- K **Grand Forum** — Statues tarped, echoes loud; where crowds become mobs. *The tarps were a gift from a dead emperor. The statues do not thank him.*
- A **Imperial Arena** — The Marble Bowl, gates chained – for now. *The chains are warm. Something inside is breathing.*

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Torchbearer Child** — Ash-smudged hands; knows every shortcut through the ruins. *She has never been lost. The ruins speak to her in dust.*
3. **Ferrymaster** — Knows which banners pay late; collects more than coin. *His ledger is a net. The names are the catch.*
4. **Coin-House Factor** — Seals credit with three ribbons; eyes twitch at defaults. *His eyes are the color of old silver. They see through your purse.*
5. **Lanista** — Owns fighters – and their secrets; sells victory in the sand. *His grin is a brand. The brand is on his fighters’ necks.*
6. **Decumanus-Master** — Surveyor who “moves” stones; rewrites the city’s shape. *His rod is a finger bone. The bone belonged to the last surveyor who argued.*
7. **Procession Marshal** — Permits and whistle; keeps order in ceremonial chaos. *His whistle is for the living. His bell is for the dead.*
8. **Grain-Prefect** — Allots loaves; knives in the margins of every ledger. *His ledger has a stain. The stain is wine—or blood.*

9. **Censor's Clerk** — “Misfiles” careers; knows which names to forget. *His inkwell is a skull. The skull belonged to a name he forgot.*
10. **Veteran Standard-Bearer** — Sells honor as a retainer; medals heavier than sword. *His medals are from a war that never happened. The corpses are from one that did.*
- J **Gladiatrix** — Darling of the crowds; owes no one but the sand. *Her sword has no name. The sand has many.*
- Q **Duchess-Regent** — Behind a silk screen; speaks through cousins, rules through silence. *The screen has a hole. The hole is for a dagger—hers.*
- K **High Priest of Everflame** — Smiles like law; flame judges truth and debt. *His smile is a candle. It can warm—or burn.*
- A **Grand Magistrate** — Guardian of forms, breaker of them when needed. *His gavel is a sundial. It only strikes at noon.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Blocked Bridge** — A procession blocks the only crossing till sundown. *The procession is for a saint who died hungry. The saint is not forgiving.*
3. **Proscribed Sigil** — A sudden edict: your mark is now forbidden. *The edict was written in the dead of night. The ink is still wet—and warm.*
4. **Bread Riots** — Grain barges are late; hunger hisses at the city's edges. *The hunger has a face. It is the face of a baker who ran out of flour.*
5. **Arena Spill** — A riot spills into streets; shutters slam, guards draw steel. *The riot started over a point. The point was a sword.*
6. **Ducal Conflict** — Rival dukes levy the same ward; your recruits vanish. *The recruits are not dead. They are hired. They are now your enemies.*
7. **Border Dispute** — A re-plat redraws boundaries; your deed becomes “disputed.” *The surveyor's rod is bent. He calls it “context.”*
8. **Frozen Purse** — A coin-house calls in notes; your purse freezes at the worst moment. *The notes were called by a dead man. His signature is still warm.*
9. **Inquisitorial Visit** — A relic's authenticity is questioned; penalties are swift and public. *The relic is a nail from a cross. It has been forged seven times. It still works.*
10. **Aftershock** — Masonry and timetables fall; scaffolds groan with new cracks. *The crack has a name. It whispers it to the wind.*
- J **Counterfeit Laurel** — Your win is void unless you find the forger. *The forger is a child. The child is a slave. The slave is a senator's son.*
- Q **Church Purge** — “Spectacles” are banned; your venue is canceled by zealots. *The zealots are paid by a rival. The rival is in the front row.*
- K **Rerouted Triumph** — The crowd follows the favored path; your moment is stolen. *The favored path is lined with archers. The archers are not there for the ceremony.*
- A **Red List** — A secret ledger; your patron's name appears overnight. *The list is written in a dead hand. The dead are still collecting.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bread Chit** — Ward sustenance for a week; street patience guaranteed. *The chit is a clay token. Break it to eat—or to bribe.*
 3. **Procession Permit** — Move sacred flame through a crowded quarter; law walks with you. *The permit is a torch. Carry it, and the city will part—or burn.*
 4. **Arena Purse** — Settles debts and hires mouths; blood-money in coin. *The purse is a helmet. The helmet belonged to a champion who lost.*
 5. **Survey Writ** — Reset one boundary stone; redraw the city’s shape. *The writ is a stone. Move it, and the map changes—on paper.*
 6. **Ducal Safe-Conduct** — Four guards and a trumpet; noble favor walks ahead. *The guards are paid by the duke. The trumpet is paid by you.*
 7. **Coin-House Credit** — Silent and immediate; debt becomes opportunity. *The credit is a ribbon. Cut it to spend—or to owe.*
 8. **Magistrate’s Postponement** — Buy a tenday against any suit; law delayed, not denied. *The postponement is a letter. The letter is sealed with a tear.*
 9. **Laurel-Deed** — Crowd favor follows you into court; glory as a shield. *The deed is a leaf. It was plucked from a victor’s crown. The victor is dead.*
 10. **Grain Ledger** — Name who eats this month; hunger bends to your will. *The ledger is a stomach. Feed it, or it will feed on you.*
- J **Minor Title** — A style that opens doors that bolts resist; rank as a key. *The title is a word. The word is “Patrician.” The doors do not ask questions.*
- Q **Basilica Audience** — One private hour with the High Priest; the flame speaks truth. *The hour is a candle. When it burns out, so does your favor.*
- K **Censor’s Indulgence** — One banned thing becomes permitted (for you). *The indulgence is a silence. The silence is a scream.*
- A **Golden Edict** — An exception carved in marble; precedent travels like law. *The edict is a crack. The crack in the law is now an opening.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/favor/precedence) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **marble and fire** motifs – statues that watch, flames that judge, and law that remembers every name.

Additional Features

- **Imperial Ruins:** Every district bears half-collapsed arcades, serving as markets, courts, or shelters for mercenary companies.
- **Competing Factions:** Dukes, guilds, and priests stage processions that collide at bridges and squares, each claiming legitimacy.
- **Monuments as Weapons:** Statues, obelisks, and colonnades are not only symbols – they

are barricades, rallying points, and high ground when the city riots.

- **Everflame Orthodoxy:** The basilicas preach unity, but each sermon is a coded signal for a political camp. The High Priest plays balance while cultivating his own following.
- **Black Banner Contracts:** Foreign mercenaries fill the gaps left by a shrinking citizen levy, their loyalty secured only by steady coin.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in the Shatterline Bazaar. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the torchbearers, trying to untie her cord from a Censor’s red tablet.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Grand Forum’s statues are Class II Anchors—the bound spirits of forgotten emperors. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin at every pedestal.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the coin-houses. Take it, and your credit is always good—but the coin will taste of ash every time the Everflame speaks.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ecktorian psions are called “Flame-Readers.” They taste the truth in candle flickers. The High Priest employs three—and has never trusted a confession they didn’t witness.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ecktorian court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous. The wise stop at eight and settle.

Ecktoria Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Flame:** Crumble a crust into the Everflame. Ignore the first *Bread Riots* penalty.
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a coin-house credit ribbon. Cancel *Frozen Purse* or take –1 die on your next debt roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Marble:** Whisper a dead debtor’s name into a statue’s ear. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their heirs this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Grand Magistrate.

Patronage & Power

Ecktoria’s decline is not collapse, but transformation. Wealth bleeds into patronage webs: a senator’s indulgence, a censor’s indulgence, a noble’s purse. The city’s great houses keep mercenary captains on retainer, while priests sell ritual processions as public theater and private favor.

For the GM: Patronage should function as both opportunity and trap. Any gift (a purse, permit, or charter) binds the receiver to service, but patrons can die, fall from favor, or suddenly proscribe what they once allowed. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, ribbons, laurel crowns) that can be stolen, forged, or voided.
- Let rival patrons issue conflicting “safe-conducts,” forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use processions, funerals, or trials as arenas for social contests, where patronage debts surface and shift allegiances.

Patronage in Ecktoria is not mere background – it is the engine of politics, coin, and survival.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city guards or rival factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds or ceremonial processions**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **patrols or inquisitors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or ceremonial opportunity**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **City authorities or noble house** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement or procession**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction member or city official** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **guards, mercenaries, or zealots** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **procession turns violent/boundary dispute erupts/patron turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: High Priest, Grand Magistrate, or Duchess-Regent** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **procession erupts/arena gate opens/monument collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **flame speaks/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ecktoria (Marble & Fire):** Statues turn their heads, flames burn blue, ceremonial masks appear in windows.
- **Ecktoria (Procession):** Crowds chant your name, banners block your path, trumpets announce your arrival.
- **Ecktoria (Patronage):** Seals break in your hand, favors are revoked, noble houses compete for your allegiance.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Cross-Region Hooks (optional draws):**
 - *Aeler True Masons* bid to shore a failing aqueduct; accepting stabilizes *Aftershock* but grants them soft leverage in the ward.
 - *Aelinnel Green-Market broker* offers “truth-credit” on court gossip; pay later in favors or names.
 - *Black Banner retainer* parade demands back pay on the Triumph Stairs; crowd sympathy tilts your next parley.
- **Faction Entanglements During Travel (use en route or on city entry):**
 - If the party holds any *Condotta* Diamonds, begin with *Bread Riots* at +1 segment (mercenary grain trains re-routed).
 - Entering with an *Underway Pass* (Aeler) grants +1 Position on *Aqueduct Walk* scenes but ticks *Ducal Conflict* once (guild jealousy).
 - Carrying *Green Market* tags downgrades one *Censor’s Hall* action but flags *Inquisitorial Visit* at the next temple.
- **Patron Touchpoints:**
 - **Maelstraeus (Cosmic Ledger):** Coin-houses keep shadow ledgers; once/session convert one social success into a *Coin-House Credit* Diamond but start a *Karmic Debt* [6].
 - **Mykkiel (The Writ):** Any *Procession Permit* can be notarized as an *Oath Irons* lite: breaking its terms applies –1 die to legal actions for a scene.
 - **Lunara (Witchlight):** *Everflame Cloister* niches hide “silver mirrors”; on use, ask one yes/no about civic intrigue; mark Exposure +1.
 - **The Traveler (Ways):** Map the *Triumph Stairs* as a living route: spend 1 Boon to treat one crowd scene as *overland progress* for clocks.
- **Trade Good Consequences (pick 1 when a haul sells):**

- *Arena Steel* → street duels spike → start *Arena Spill* at 1.
- *Relic Fragments* → basilica prestige swings → tick *Church Purge* or grant *Basilica Audience*.
- *Survey Rights* → boundary re-plot → downgrade one *Border Dispute* or upgrade a rival's.
- **Diplomatic Favor (minor currency):**
 - Earn by resolving a public scene without bloodshed (Forum, Procession, Coin-House).
 - Spend 1 to reduce DV of a permit/audience by 1, or to ignore *Blocked Bridge* for one crossing.
 - Holding 2+ makes you “interesting”: start a *Red List* [4] that advances on snubbed patrons.
- **Reputation Echoes (soft power):**
 - *Crowd-Loved (Laurel-Deed)*: first time per session you face a mob, set Position one step safer.
 - *Coin-House Trusted (Credit)*: ignore the first *Frozen Purse*; next time, it returns at +1 severity.
 - *Clerically Vouched (Everflame)*: downgrade one *Inquisitorial Visit*; if abused, promote *Church Purge*.

Monuments as Mechanics (opulence with teeth)

- **Processional Geometry:** When acting on the *Triumph Stairs*, choose: +1 Effect *or* –1 Heat; on a miss, *Rerouted Triumph* advances.
- **Aqueduct Leverage:** Securing an aqueduct span grants a one-scene *high ground* tag in any linked ward; if collateral hits, tick *Aftershock*.
- **Forum Acoustics:** Rally speeches at the *Grand Forum* grant an extra assist die if at least 20 witnesses; failure spawns *Bread Riots* at +1.

Plug-in SB Conversions (Ecktoria flavor)

- Any 1 SB may become *Crowd Drift*: shift the scene's terrain in favor of or against you (bridges clog, stairs clear).
- Any 2 SB may become *Seal Revoked*: void one paper (Permit/Chit/Indulgence); to avert, sacrifice *Diplomatic Favor*.
- On 3+ SB offer *Patron Bargain*: accept a visible mark (ribbon, laurel brand) to halve consequences; start a *Patron Debt* [6].

Hidden Orders & Ancient Conspiracies (d12 hooks)

1. **The Ash Senate** – a ledger of “extinguished” patrician lines still voting by proxy through funerary guilds.
2. **Surveyors of the Ninth Mile** – decumanus-masters who can *move* boundaries with ritual math; a lost rod sets precedent across the city.
3. **Lantern Tetrarchy** – four basilica beadles who decide which miracles are counted; the fifth lamp was broken in a purge.
4. **The Red Marble Compact** – coin-house founders who tithe 1 in 100 coins to a secret indemnity fund used to flip coups.

5. **Archivum Umbrae** – censor clerks maintaining a *shadow index* of names that must not stand trial (yet).
6. **Peregrine Brotherhood** – ferrymasters trading in sealed confessions; blackmail that floats.
7. **The Laurel of Dust** – a gladiators’ mutual that chooses which champions live long enough to hold office.
8. **Aqueduct Collegium Obscura** – engineers who keep a second set of sluice keys; droughts become elections.
9. **Order of the Broken Obelisk** – survey-cult that believes Mile-Zero is *wrong* and can re-found the city with one stone.
10. **The Funeral Republic** – undertakers running a parallel courier state through catacombs and wakes.
11. **The Ember Vault** – a sealed reliquary under the Arena; victors’ sweat was bottled for augury.
12. **Triumphal Maskers** – procession costumers who encode heretical theses into robe pleats and torch patterns.

Cults & Mystery Rites (d10)

1. **Children of the Phoenix** (*rebirth by fire*): ash-marks grant +1 die vs. fear in crowds; mark Fatigue if you hesitate near open flame.
2. **Verdant Laurel** (*blood to marble, sap to coin*): once/session turn 1 Harm into 1 Coin-House Credit; start a *Green Debt* [4].
3. **Mask of the Thirteenth** (*forbidden procession step*): walk through a riot unmolested; next parley with clergy begins one step worse.
4. **Brotherhood of the River Tongue** (*truth ferried at night*): ask the Dolmis one yes/no; a ferryman shows up later to collect a name.
5. **Candlemakers of Ever** (*flame remembers lies*): blue flame points to falsehood; the liar dreams of you for three nights (Exposure +1).
6. **Sable Standard** (*war saint cult*): your banner ignores morale checks once; start a *Blood-Tithe* [4] owed to the saint’s chapel.
7. **The Ninth Bell** (*hour that is not kept*): skip a queue or sentence; next edict you need arrives late (Delay SB free once).
8. **Guild of Red Accountants** (*sin as ledger*): convert 2 SB into a *Magistrate’s Postponement*; add *Karmic Debt* [6].
9. **The Marble Eaters** (*mortification sect*): bite stone, gain +1 Effect resisting crowd crush; take Harm 1 (Stress) if you boast.
10. **Torch of Saint Vessa** (*saint of necessary arson*): sanctify a fire to purge a tag (Plague/Corruption); City Heat +2.

Religious Schisms & Trials

The Everflame Divide (choose a live schism)

1. **Orthodox Basilica vs. Ember Reformers**: Is miracle *counted* by law or *kindled* by need?
2. **Laurel Theologians vs. Street Saints**: Does glory flow *down* from triumphs or *up* from bread-lines?

3. Iconoclast Ward vs. Reliquary Keepers: Is the flame purer without images?

Schism Mechanics (table-facing)

- **Heresy Index** [0–6]: ticks when players publicize a stance, defy clergy, or wield cult rites in view. At 3: inquisitorial audits become common; at 6: *Church Purge* (Q) auto-triggers once/session until lowered.
- **Sanctuary / Anathema Tags:** locations acquire tags during arc scenes. *Sanctuary*: first harm in scene becomes Fatigue; *Anathema*: first social miss spawns “Proscribed Sigil.”
- **Trial by Fire (mini-procedure, 3 beats):**
 1. *Assembly*: set the forum/stair as arena; state thesis in one sentence (players or NPCs).
 2. *Witness*: three proofs (relic, miracle, precedent). Each proof: test Social/Arcana/Resolve vs. crowd DV; on success, reduce Index by 1 or gain *Basilica Audience*.
 3. *Judgment*: roll Crowd Mood (1d6): 1–2 mobs, 3–4 silent acceptance, 5–6 laurel toss (gain *Laurel-Deed*). If Index ≥ 4 , –1 to the roll.

Ecktoria – Marble and Fire

Starting Location: The Coin-House floor, marble cracked with soot lines, where votive candles burn beside melted icons.

“In Ecktoria, even faith must balance its ledgers, and the gods audit in ash.”

In... the Coin-House floor, a factor with smoke-singed ledgers offers a purse. “The Lame King moves,” she says. “And the Basilica burns with him.”

Regional Motifs Coin-oaths, basilica relics, marble acoustics, augury smoke.

Whispers to Offer “Bid against the city,” “Pocket the relic shard,” “Name an innocent debtor.”

External Clocks Threat: *Procession of Ash* [6]; Community: *Credit Panic* [4]; Anchor: *Basilica Choir* [4].

Complications Smoke speaks truths; coins stick to skin; a reliquary runs hot.

Anchors at Risk A choir novice; a patron account.

Escalation Beat The Basilica tolls a note only one PC hears.

Relief Return the shard; pay a city-debt in blood or ; route the procession elsewhere.

Boss Seeds (Cults & Conspiracies)

- **The Ember Prefect** (schismatic inquisitor): *Phase* [8] Citation → Censure → Auto-da-fé → Purge. Lair: Everflame Cloister. Counters: relic provenance, crowd-favor, rival sermon.
- **The Surveyor-Primus** (geomantic usurper): *Phase* [6] Re-plat → Dispossess → Erase. Lair: Mile-Zero. Counters: Aeler measure-rods, witness line, broken rod.
- **Phoenix of the Arena** (miracle or hoax?): *Phase* [10] Hype → Immolation → “Rebirth” → Riot. Lair: Imperial Arena. Counters: doused ash, Mask of the Thirteenth, Everflame test.

Diamonds: Forbidden Leverage (add to §4.1)

14. **Shadow Index Leaf** – remove one name from the Red List for a week; add *Countercoup* +1.
15. **Ember Writ** – sanction one cult rite as “orthodox” for a scene.
16. **Surveyor’s Ninth Rod** – redraw one ward line unnoticed (until dawn).

Cross-Contamination (fast ties)

- **Aeler True Masons:** backing an iconoclast audit grants shoring crews; bell-codes now gate temple entries.
- **Aelinnel Thorn Courts:** hawthorn chaplains host “mirror sermons”; a basilica gains *Sanctuary* while a rival becomes *Anathema*.
- **Black Banners:** war-chaplains monetize indulgences; clearing *Payday* risks +1 *Heresy Index*.

Chapter 5

Acasia

The Broken Province. Acasia is a land of petty kingdoms, free companies, and border lords. The Curse of the Blackwood haunts its crossroads, and every hill-fort flies a different banner. Silkstrand, its sole metropolis, sits at the mouth of the Acasian rivers, a city of bridges and dyewater where merchants and mercenaries mingle.

5.1 Acasia — “Broken Marches”

Margravine of the Broken March (Elite): “The tithe must be paid, not merely offered. A promise written in ash and sealed with iron will is worth more than a thousand gold coins scattered on the wind.”

Hedge-Witch (Commoner): “Don’t cross the Pale Causeway at dusk, especially not if you’ve got a silver tooth. The bridge’ll remember it, and next time you pass, it’ll want more than just your footfall. In Acasia, every road owes a debt. The question is who pays.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Acasia is a former province of the Utaran Empire that rots in the space between famine and ambition. Every hill wears a crown, every bridge bears a toll, and every road curves back to the same cursed crossroads. Where once the Empire’s coin and grain flowed, now tithe-collectors gnaw the marrow of starving villages, and warlords dress themselves as kings. The land itself has grown bitter: grain blights spread like gossip, wine turns to vinegar in the cask, and the old Imperial roads have forgotten where they lead. The Curse—the nameless thing that makes crossroads loop back on themselves—is not a myth. It is the price of broken promises, and Acasia is drowning in them.

What you notice first: The smell of mildew on old parchment and wet ash. The way every milestone has been recarved. The silence of a village that heard you coming and chose not to open its gates.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sign a contract on a bridge. The river is a witness, and it never forgets a signature.

Regional Mood: Famine and Ambition

Here, the past is not a memory—it is a predator. The Utaran Empire left behind roads that lead to nowhere, laws that contradict each other, and a hunger that no harvest can fill. Acasia’s petty kings hold court in burned keeps, their crowns forged from iron nails pulled from famine coffins. The Margravine keeps a ledger of feuds, binding bloodlines to her feast days. Free Companies trade loyalty like grain, swapping colors mid-march. And beneath it all, the Curse waits. It is not a monster. It is a geometry: the wrong turn, the bridge that leads back to the same shore, the bell that tolls for no funeral. In Acasia, the land itself has become a contract, and the fine print is written in mildew.

Starting Location: The Pale Causeway’s last inn, walls soot-blackened by coal and a century of gossip. A bounty poster flutters beside a half-empty hearth. The innkeeper is a one-eyed woman who pours small beer without asking. A stranger at the bar offers a sealed contract: retrieve a dowry chest from a Blackwood matriarch before the Margravine’s feast day. “The chest contains a claim, not coin,” the stranger whispers. “But a claim in Acasia is worth more than gold—it is a key to a bridge that does not loop.”

(Pass/Ruin/Toll-Town) Broken milestone on the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight. Vine-terrace hillside with an abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now.

Spades — Places

2. **Broken Milestone** — On the old Imperial Road; borders “moved” overnight. *The stone has been chiseled seven times. The last mark is still wet.*
 3. **Vine-Terrace Hillside** — Abandoned press; strangler ivy owns it now. *The ivy has grown around a skeleton. The skeleton still holds a wine cup.*
 4. **Toll-Bridge Town** — Over a cold river; two tolls, no receipts. *The second toll is collected by a child. The child does not speak.*
 5. **Wolfstairs Pass** — Switchbacks beneath a stonefall cliff. *The stones were placed by a landslide that knew your name.*
 6. **Sootfall Abbey Ruins** — Bell tower intact; crypts breathing. *The breathing is a prayer. The monks are still down there.*
 7. **Hill-Motte** — Fresh palisade; ditch scattered with caltrops. *The caltrops are from a siege that ended last week. The bodies are still rotting.*
 8. **Border-Stone Ring** — Carved with seven crowns; each points wrong. *The crowns belong to kings who never existed. The stones remember them anyway.*
 9. **Blackwood Charcoalers’ Hollow** — Witch-posts at every path. *The witch-posts were made from the gibbets of tax collectors. The tax collectors still swing.*
 10. **Salt-Road Ford** — Rains expose old bones in the chalk banks. *The bones are from three wars. They are not all human.*
- J **Iron Mine Adits** — Held by a miners’ commune; the air is full of whispers. *The whispers are the mine’s memory. It remembers every collapse.*
- Q **Margravine’s Hunting Lodge** — Tapestries of victories that never were. *The tapestries were woven by a blind weaver. The threads are from her own hair.*
- K **War-Camp City** — Tents around a burned keep; every banner claims the throne. *The keep was burned by its own lord. He did not want to share the heat.*

A **The Pale Causeway** — The last high road that survives the spring thaws. *The causeway is made of bones. The bones are from the workers who built it.*

(Petty Crowns/Priests/Companies) Tithe-collector’s runner with a tally-rod and an empty stomach; roadside prior with three lay brothers guarding a relic.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tithe-Collector’s Runner** — Tally-rod, empty stomach, and a list of names. *His tally-rod has notches from a dozen villages. The villages are now empty.*
3. **Roadside Prior** — Three lay brothers guarding a relic. *The relic is a finger bone. The prior claims it belonged to a saint who starved to death.*
4. **Hedge-Witch** — Knows which bridges eat travelers. *Her price is a story. The story must have a bad ending.*
5. **Free Company Captain** — Pike and shot between contracts. *He has served three kings this year. He does not remember their names.*
6. **River Reeve** — Rents every boat twice. *His ledger is a single page. The page is folded into a boat.*
7. **Salt-Baron** — Hired blades; owns the ford and your timetable. *His salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned village.*
8. **Blackwood Matriarch** — Tends the feud like a garden. *Her garden grows tombstones. She waters them with tears—her enemies’.*
9. **Ex-Imperial Surveyor** — Has the last accurate map. *The map shows villages that no longer exist. The surveyor visits them anyway.*
10. **“King” of Three Villages** — Iron-nail crown, iron-will taxes. *His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse.*
- J **Bride with No Dowry but a Claim** — Daggers in the wedding chest. *The claim is to a bridge that drowned. The bride intends to collect.*
- Q **Margravine of the Broken March** — Half saint, half tax roll. *She has never lost a feud. Her ledger is her sword.*
- K **The Lame King** — Traveling throne; makes law by pointing. *His throne is a sedan chair carried by debtors. They owe him everything.*
- A **The Cursed Child of Silkstrand** — A rumor more than a person; her laughter ends sieges. *She is said to be twelve years old. She has been twelve for a century.*

(Feud/Levy/Weather/Curse) Peat-fog; all horns sound like someone calling your name. Sudden levy—every traveler pressed for a day’s service. Bridge feud; rival banners drop the chain on your cart.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Peat-Fog** — All horns sound like someone calling your name. *The name is not yours. Answer it, and the fog will take you.*
3. **Sudden Levy** — Every traveler is pressed for a day’s service. *The levy master has a list. Your name is on it—in fresh ink.*

4. **Bridge Feud** — Rival banners drop the chain on your cart. *The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach.*
5. **Grain Blight** — Doubles the tithe; refusal means torches at night. *The blight has a face. It is the face of a tax collector who died hungry.*
6. **Scree Slide** — Seals the pass; the “safe” detour is owned by your enemy. *The enemy raised the toll yesterday. He was expecting you.*
7. **Wedding Turns Ambush** — You are caught between two bloodlines. *The bride’s veil is a shroud. The groom’s ring is a knife.*
8. **Witch’s Tithe Night** — Lights move in the woods; owe nothing or else. *The lights have voices. They are arguing over who should collect.*
9. **Pox Sign** — On a village gate; your escorts desert you. *The pox is a rumor. The desertion is real.*
10. **Condotta Breaks** — The Free Company flips colors mid-march. *The new colors are the same as the old colors. The captain just wanted to raise morale.*
- J **Heretic Preacher** — Sparks a march; toll-gates come down in splinters. *The preacher’s text is a tax receipt. He reads it like scripture.*
- Q **Imperial Pretender** — Arrives; every petty lord changes tabards. *The pretender’s seal is a sunburst. The sunburst is slightly crooked.*
- K **River Overruns the Levee** — The pontoon goes; your rivals don’t. *The river’s name is “Debt.” It remembers every unpaid crossing.*
- A **The Curse Stirrs** — No matter the road, you return to the same crossroads. *The crossroads has a signpost. The arms are labeled “Regret,” “Hunger,” “The Same.”*

(Papers/Claims/Safe-Conduct) Toll-exemption plaque for one bridge (once); monastery letter for bed and bread on a named road.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Toll-Exemption Plaque** — For one bridge (once). *The plaque is a bronze leaf. Hold it up, and the toll-keeper will spit—but step aside.*
3. **Monastery Letter** — For bed and bread on a named road. *The letter is sealed with a wax tear. The monks will honor it—or they will not.*
4. **Wine-Right** — On an abandoned terrace; locals will work for shares. *The wine is from a vine that grows over a mass grave. It tastes of iron.*
5. **Condotta Contract** — A signed pike contract (one battle on your terms). *The contract is written in blood. The blood is from the captain’s own finger.*
6. **Tithe-Remission Writ** — For a village; they owe you a season’s labor. *The writ is stamped with a bell. The bell’s clapper is a finger bone.*
7. **Border-Stone Adjustment** — Move a line two fields over. *The adjustment is a lie. The truth is that the line was always there.*
8. **Pass-Key Charm** — Recognized by Pale Causeway watchmen. *The charm is a knotted cord. Untie it to pass—or to stay.*
9. **Sealed Dowry Chest** — Of claims, not coin; certain doors open. *The chest is locked with a riddle. The answer is a name you do not know.*

10. **Mine-Share** — In the commune; they fight like they mean it. *The share is a pickaxe. The commune will lend you a miner—or a grave.*
- J **Blood-Peace Charter** — Suspend a feud long enough to move your wagons. *The charter is a white ribbon. Blood will not be spilled while it flies—but blood will remember.*
- Q **Marriage Proxy** — From the Margravine; bind a hill-king to your cause. *The proxy is a wedding veil. The veil was worn by a ghost.*
- K **The Lame King’s Traveling Writ** — Troops must make way (for now). *The writ is a broken scepter. The Lame King’s seal is a footprint.*
- A **Curse-Redemption Rite (Temporary)** — For one night, no crossroads can hold you. *The rite is a whisper. The whisper is a name you have never spoken.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/claims/safe-conducts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo plague and curse motifs—crossroads that turn back on themselves, bells tolling for no funeral, banners blackened by mildew.

Additional Features

- **Feud as Currency:** Any insult, accident, or rumor can birth a feud; the GM may replace an SB result with a feud-token tied to a petty lord or house. Feud-tokens act as reusable complications: once per scene, the GM can spend a feud-token to have a rival appear, a bridge close, or a village refuse aid.
- **Rot & Tithe:** Each market or harvest scene carries a risk of rot—add a pressure if food or coin are exchanged without a blessing or a seal. A failed roll may double the tithe or spoil stored supplies.
- **The Curse Remembers:** When roads or negotiations stall, the GM may quietly repeat imagery—crossroads, whispers, mildew—to remind players that Acasia itself resists resolution. If the party ignores three such omens, the *Curse Stirrs* complication triggers automatically.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in a burned abbey. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the charcoalers, trying to untie her cord from a Rothari death warrant.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Pale Causeway is a Class II Anchor site—the ghosts of workers who died building it still carry stones. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin in every crack.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the toll-collectors. Take it, and your passage is always free—but the coin will taste of blood every time the Causeway floods.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Acasian psions are called “Feud-Readers.” They taste the weight of old grudges in the water. The Margravine employs two—and has never trusted

a settlement they didn't whisper.

- **The Ninth:** In any Acasian scene, the ninth toll paid at a bridge is never the last. The wise pay eight and barter for the ninth.

Acasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Milestone:** Crumble a crust at a broken milestone. Ignore the first *Peat-Fog* penalty.
- **Knot the Contract:** Tie a single knot in a writ's ribbon. Cancel *Bridge Feud* or take -1 die on your next negotiation (your choice).
- **Name to the Blight:** Whisper a dead tax collector's name into a grain sack. Gain +1 Effect when avoiding tithes this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Margravine.

Decline & Patronage

Patronage here is as brittle as candle wax. The Rothari Clan holds their marches by fear and iron law—patronage from them is real, but cruel, demanding service in blood or levy. Elsewhere, noble names are little more than titles printed on parchment and sold like debts. The Margravine keeps a ledger like scripture, binding feuds to her feast days, while mercenary captains trade loyalty for coin, switching colors with each bell.

To seek a patron in Acasia is to choose which hunger you will feed: the Rothari's iron teeth, a Free Company's purse, or the hollow blessing of a saint who may never have lived. Yet even false crowns cast shadows long enough to shelter those desperate enough to kneel.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tithe-collectors or petty lords**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **Free Company patrols or village watchmen**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **feud-trackers or hedge-witches**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable road conditions**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **River reeve or Free Company captain** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or bridge closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival bloodline or toll-lord's enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **feud-kin, Free Company deserters, or Margravine's guards** arrive.

- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided/levy doubled/curse triggered**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** Margravine, **Lame King**, or **Cursed Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/bridge falls/curse loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Acasia (Feud & Tithe):** Toll collectors demand double, bloodlines take offense, wagons are seized as “payment.”
- **Acasia (Rot & Famine):** Grain blights spread, wells run dry, abandoned villages hold only ghosts.
- **Acasia (Curse & Crossroads):** Roads loop back, milestones point the wrong way, the same bridge appears twice.

Boss Archetypes in Acasia

- **The False King (Feud/Authority)** — A petty lord or pretender who crowns themselves on the ruins of empire. *Phases:* Levy Demanded → Feud Declared → Hasty Coronation. *Cracks:* a **Blood-Peace Charter** suspends his authority; a **Marriage Proxy** binds him to a rival.
- **The Witch of the Blackwoods (Witchcraft/Curse)** — A hedge-witch, matriarch, or revenant who manipulates feuds and curses. *Phases:* Tithe of Fear → Curse of the Crossroads → Hollow Wedding. *Cracks:* a **Curse-Redemption Rite** breaks her hold; a **Mine-Share** gives the commune courage to defy her.
- **The Tithe Collector (Greed/Extortion)** — A bureaucrat-priest with writs, escorts, and the ability to summon feuds or famine with a single decree. *Phases:* Audit of Souls → Seizure of Grain → The Ledger’s Reckoning. *Cracks:* a **Toll-Exemption Plaque** voids his claim; a **Wine-Right** pays off his debtors.
- **The Rotting Child (Mystery/Curse)** — A folkloric horror tied to Acasia’s plague of false crossroads. *Phases:* Laughter in the Fog → The Bridge That Loops → The Feast of Ends. *Cracks:* a **Tithe-Remission Writ** fed to the fog; a **Monastery Letter** read aloud at the crossroads.

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Dowry That Walked:** A Blackwood matriarch’s dowry chest has been stolen. The chest contains a claim to a bridge that never floods—and a curse that the Margravine wants

broken.

- **The Lame King's Feast:** The Lame King invites the party to a feast. The feast is a trial. The food is memory. The wine is lies.
- **The Curse of the Pale Causeway:** The Causeway is repeating. Every crossing brings the party back to the same inn. The innkeeper is missing a finger. She says she gave it to the bridge.

Chapter 6

Vhasia

The Fractured Sun. A kingdom split between rival crowns, Vhasia’s chevauchée raids and parlement intrigues echo the twilight of empire. The Pont-du-Tithe is blessed by competing bishops, and the Last Dauphin is a rumor with a birthmark. Here legitimacy is a weapon, and every seal can be forged—or denied.

6.1 Vhasia — “The Fractured Sun”

Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (Elite): “The sun may be fractured, but our authority is absolute within our domains. Every coin minted here carries our blessing, and every law written bears our seal – the rest is just politics.”

Road Warden (Commoner): “I’ve served under three different banners on this same stretch of road, and the only constant is that someone always wants to collect tolls. My horn calls honest warning – best heed it. The Fenwoods burned Lence, and now every duke with a coin purse thinks he’s king.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Vhasia is a realm of broken coronations and split loyalties. Once a proud province of the Utaran empire, the unified Sun-court shattered like its heraldic sunburst when the Fenwoods of Viterra and their allies sacked the capital of Lence and cast down the old Blood line. Now rival dukes, duchesses, abbesses, and parlements claim the fractured light. Everywhere, signs of fracture: chipped sun-discs on milestones, worn tabards bearing half a crown, coins minted in rival cities with different suns. In Vhasia, legitimacy is as fragile as a mirror, and every oath risks breaking along the fault lines of politics, faith, and fortune.

What you notice first: The smell of old smoke and fresh ink. The way every noble’s seal has a hairline crack. The constant, nervous laughter of courtiers who remember whose head rolled last season.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never carry a coin that bears only one sunburst. The realm has three mints, and the wrong metal on the wrong road is treason.

Regional Mood: Crowns, Courts, and Companies

Here, the past is a weapon and the future is a debt. The Fenwoods came from Viterra with fire and iron, broke the Sun-king’s army at the Ford of Ashes, and burned Lence until the mirrors melted.

They left the throne empty—not destroyed, but open. Now every duke with a long purse and a short conscience backs a claimant. The Queen-Mother weaves alliances from her riverside keep. The Two Crowns—rival dukes crowned in rival cathedrals—march their levies through fields that can feed neither. Routiers sell their swords by the season, and parlement clerks drown justice in procedure. Vhasia is not a nation at war. It is a nation that forgot how to be at peace.

Starting Location: The Pont-du-Tithe, its golden arches catching fire in the sunset as pilgrims chant from both banks. A Duchy Constable in splendid armor guards the toll gate. “The Chevauchée burns,” he says, gesturing to distant smoke. “Two Crowns march to meet it. Whose seal do you carry? Speak quickly—the levy waits for no one.”

(Château/Cathedral/Forest) Wayside shrine with pilgrims tacking petitions to a scorched sun-disc; vine-terraced clos above a millstream with napping watchmen.

Spades — Places

2. **Wayside Shrine** — Pilgrims tack petitions to a scorched sun-disc; each parchment curls in different winds. *The petitions are never answered. The shrine is a mailbox for the dead.*
3. **Vine-Terrace** — Clos above a millstream; watchmen nap, halberds traded for bottles. *The best vintage is called “Crownbreaker.” It tastes like smoke and regret.*
4. **Bastide Square** — Neat as a canray board; merchants pay homage to different “hours” of the Sun. *The square has a gallows. It rotates to face whichever claimant lost the last duel.*
5. **Royal Forest** — Antler posts mark laws no king remembers; poachers still hang. *The forest’s deer have grown bold. They wear crowns of shed antlers.*
6. **Pont-du-Tithe** — Toll-bridge flanked by chapels and crossbows; chains blessed by rival bishops. *The chains were forged from melted sunbursts. They ring in different keys.*
7. **Great Fair** — Outside a chartered town; counting sheds ring like bells, rumors louder still. *The fair has a Court of Miracles where counterfeiters sell to informers.*
8. **Salt Pans** — Wind-pumps on an estuary; gulls own the law, smugglers own the night. *The salt is grey. It tastes of old tears and older debts.*
9. **Siege-Château** — Hoardings patched, cistern low, banners cut into ragged suns. *The banner’s ragged edges are from a Fenwood sword. The owner still limps.*
10. **Cathedral Yard** — Cranes creak, stones fly, scaffolds bristle with rival masons’ marks. *The mason’s marks are clan signs. A scratched-out mark means a dead foreman.*
- J **Parlement Hall** — Hung with faded tapestries; sunbursts spliced and re-stitched by claimants. *The tapestries show battles that never happened—and some that shouldn’t have.*
- Q **Queen’s Causeway** — Mile-long oath paved in quarried stone; half-sunk each spring. *The sunken half is a graveyard for vows. The stones are slippery with old lies.*
- K **Sun Palace (Lence)** — Shattered mirrors, brambled gardens; courtiers playing at kingship. *The mirrors were covered after the sack. No one wants to see what they show now.*
- A **King’s High Road** — Mile-stones chipped of crowns; yet every army still marches it. *The road is paved with the bones of tax collectors. They are not missed.*

(Lord/Court/Company) Road warden with dented badge and honest horn; vintner-guild syndic counting saints’ days as credit terms.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Road Warden** — Dented badge, honest horn; ignored by both crowns but knows the roads. *His horn is cracked. It still sounds—but the note is always half a step flat.*
3. **Vintner Syndic** — Counts saints’ days as credit terms, vintages as treaties; wine as diplomacy. *He keeps a bottle of Crownbreaker in every cellar. He knows which vintage each duke prefers.*
4. **Abbess-Chatelaine** — Rules a fortress-convent with iron accounts and sharper scripture. *She has never drawn a blade. The scaffold has, on her orders.*
5. **Routier Captain** — Scarred and mercenary; prefers ransoms to loyalty; coin as conscience. *He switches banners as often as his shirt. His loyalty is to the paychest—and his mother.*
6. **Duchy Constable** — Splendid armor, empty coffers, pride swollen as a banner; glory over gold. *His armor was his grandfather’s. It still has the dent from a Fenwood axe.*
7. **Parlement Clerk** — Drowns foes in procedure, fishes them out for fealty; law as a weapon. *His quill is a dagger. He sharpens it every morning.*
8. **Salt-Farmer** — Gabelle lessee with cudgels, writs, and a river-chart no crown has; tax as tyranny. *His ledger is written in salt. One drop of water and the debts vanish—along with the evidence.*
9. **Trouvère** — A scandalous lay about the last Sun-king brings knives to tavern doors. *He sings the truth. That is why he sleeps in a different inn every night.*
10. **Marshal-Exile** — The Sun-court’s hammer; now wielded by whoever pays in silver. *He lost the Battle of Ashes. He still sees it in his dreams—and his nightmares.*
- J **Heretic Perfect** — Preaches peace while tucking hidden daggers into parchment margins. *His sermon is a code. The psalms tell you which bridge to cross—and which to burn.*
- Q **Queen-Mother** — Riverside keep; weaves alliances as if they were dowries. *She has outlived three husbands and two sons. She is not mourning.*
- K **Two Crowns** — Rival dukes, each “crowned” in rival cathedrals, neither whole. *One wears a crown of iron. The other wears a crown of words. Both rust.*
- A **Last Dauphin** — A rumor with a birthmark; armies march for whispers alone. *He may be a baker’s son. The armies don’t care. They need a sun to follow.*

(Chevauchée/Law/Church) Chevauchée burning loyalty oaths as well as barns; interdict falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Chevauchée** — Raiders burn loyalty oaths as well as barns; smoke curls like scripture. *The raiders wear no colors. Their horses answer to whistles—and grudges.*
3. **Interdict** — Falls on a county; bells silenced, trade stalls, heretics prosper. *The bells were melted for shot three wars ago. The silence is old.*
4. **Forest Law** — Venison becomes treason; poachers hang from antler posts. *The antler posts are carved with the names of the hanged. They whisper at dusk.*
5. **River Spate** — Ferries chained, bridges drowned, pilgrims stranded mid-prayer. *The water is the color of old gold. It washed away a mint last spring.*
6. **Coin Debasement** — Three mints, three suns, no trust; soldiers demand silver alone. *The silver is from the same mine—but the stamp is a prayer, not a promise.*

7. **Parlement Divided** — A siege laid on parchment before walls; war by paperwork. *The clerks duel with citations. The loser pays the winner's ink bill.*
8. **Company Mutiny** — Unless arrears are paid—in blood or coin; mercenaries as a time bomb. *The mutineers have a list. Your name is on it—or will be by nightfall.*
9. **Relic Dispute** — Two abbeys claim the same saint's bones; mobs answer with stones. *The bones are actually from a cow. The saints don't mind. They like the attention.*
10. **Harvest Blight** — Bread locked behind pikes; bakers guarded as lords. *The blight has a name. It is the name of a duke who raised the levy too late.*
- J **Tournament "Accident"** — Hides an assassination; your favor is now evidence. *The lance was filed with a prayer. The prayer was answered—but not for the target.*
- Q **Royalist Restoration** — Sunburst badges painted overnight on doors and graves. *The paint is the color of dried blood. The badges face the wrong direction.*
- K **Feudal Levy** — Lords demand levies in days, not months, with three days' bread. *The bread is hardtack from the last Fenwood siege. It still smells of smoke.*
- A **Winter Campaign** — Roads turn to mud, hooves to ice, armies to ruin. *The snow is grey with ash. The Pass of Ashes has a sister pass now.*

(**Charter/Patent/Right**) Safe-conduct sealed by a duke or abbey; honored only once, on one road; burgess charter for a market ward.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Safe-Conduct** — Sealed by a duke or abbey; honored only once, on one road. *The seal is cracked. The road is watched. Use it before the seal breaks.*
3. **Burgess Charter** — A market ward; walls, watch, and revenue at your call. *The charter is a bell. Ring it, and the town answers—or it doesn't.*
4. **Bridge Farm** — Tolls at Pont-du-Tithe for a season, if you can hold it. *The tollkeepers are loyal to the last coin. Yours or theirs.*
5. **Paréage Charter** — Shared rule with a monastery—half justice, half rent, no peace. *The monks pray for you. They also pray for your enemies. Balance.*
6. **Wardship** — Over a minor heir; lands obey you "for now." *The heir has a knife. He knows how to use it. He learned from watching you.*
7. **Gabelle Lease** — Salt-tax rights; lucrative, hated, and dangerous. *The lease is a death warrant written in profit. Cash it wisely.*
8. **Letters Patent** — Raise a free-company under your banner; an army as a business. *The letters are signed in blood—yours or the notary's. Both are valid.*
9. **Remission** — Of feudal dues for a village; they'll march when called. *The village has a long memory. They remember the last lord who promised mercy.*
10. **Low-Justice** — Grant (stocks, fines, gallows) in a troublesome hamlet. *The gallows rope is new. The notches are from the last hamlet.*
- J **Confiscation Writ** — Against a royalist estate—if you can seize it first. *The writ is a race. The other claimant rides a faster horse.*
- Q **Queen's Audience** — Private with the Queen-Mother; a whisper becomes policy. *The audience is a chess game. She always wins—but she lets you take a pawn.*

- K **Sunburst Warrant** — Of the fallen court—most still bow if shown boldly. *The warrant is a ghost. It has no power—only the power of belief.*
- A **General Pardon** — Temporary: rebels absolved if they bend the knee. *The pardon is a spring. It will close when the season turns.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/patents/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **fractured sun** motifs—light that splinters, oaths that crack like glass.

Additional Features

- **Fractured Seals:** When brandishing a writ, badge, or charter tied to a Sun-court claimant, step **Position** up one step for the scene’s next interaction at a gate, court, or checkpoint. Each use advances a **Legitimacy** [4] clock linked to the claimant; when it fills, rivals challenge the authority on sight.
- **Parlement Games:** If a scene touches petitions, guild disputes, or feudal appeals, the first **Diamond** played becomes a *policy lever*: treat it as two Diamonds toward swaying a decision or rewriting a custom. Afterward, start or advance a **Whispered Precedent** clock; when it fills, backlash spreads as other courts cite the case against you.
- **Gabelle Knife-Edge:** At bridges, fairs, or salt depots, convert **Diamonds** tied to tolls, leases, or safe-conducts into immediate passage or tariff relief for the company (no roll). Each conversion ticks a **Resentment** [4] clock for the locale; when it completes, expect boycotts, ambush rumors, or an audit by rival officials.
- **Viterran Holdings:** Much of northern Vhasia is held by Viterran dukes, abbots, and condottieri. Any travel seed through Vhasia may be overclaimed by Viterran authority. Safe-Conducts are fragile—Viterra treats them as favors, not guarantees. When this occurs, the GM may pull an additional **Club** from the Viterra deck (if available) or introduce a **Royal Incursion** complication.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in the burned quarter of Lence. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the salt-farmers, trying to untie her cord from a Fenwood death warrant.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Parlement Hall’s tapestries are Class II Anchors—the woven sunbursts remember the dead clerks. Saikou Ira would trade his silver mirror for a single thread.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the routiers. Take it, and your company’s paychest never empties—but your name will appear on every mutiny list.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Vhasian psions are called “Crown-Readers.” They hear the weight of legitimacy in a claimant’s voice. The Queen-Mother employs two—and has never let them meet.

- **The Ninth:** In any Vhasian scene, the ninth signature on a petition invalidates all others. The wise sign eighth and leave.

Vhasian Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Sun:** Crumble a crust onto a cracked sun-disc. Ignore the first *Chevauchée* penalty.
- **Knot the Seal:** Tie a single knot in a charter's ribbon. Cancel *Parlement Divided* or take -1 die on your next legal argument (your choice).
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead claimant's name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect when collecting debts from their faction this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Queen-Mother.

Patronage & Power

In Vhasia, power flows through the remnants of imperial authority, fractured legitimacy, and the careful manipulation of legal and religious institutions. Former Utaran provincial structures still provide a framework for governance, but competing claimants to the Sun-court have created a complex web of overlapping jurisdictions and conflicting loyalties. The true power lies with those who can navigate this legal maze and maintain the appearance of legitimate authority.

For the GM: Patronage in Vhasia revolves around legitimacy, legal documents, and the ability to command respect from institutions that no longer have a clear central authority. Rewards often take the form of charters, writs, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, badges, writs) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the parlements, cathedrals, and châteaux as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.

In Vhasia, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are ruled.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **rival officials or court guards**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **parlement clerks or routier patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or tax collectors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable legal window**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Duchy constable or abbess-chatelaine** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or road closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival claimant or free-company** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **routiers, parlement guards, or rival ducal forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **writ voided/interdict declared/levy called**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Two Crowns, Queen-Mother, or Marshal-Exile** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **chevauchée hits/river floods/parlement erupts**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Vhasia (Fractured Authority):** Seals break mid-signing, legal papers rewrite themselves, badges refuse to be honored.
- **Vhasia (Legal Warfare):** Court decisions reverse without warning, precedents are cited against you, writs expire at crucial moments.
- **Vhasia (Sun Symbolism):** Sun-discs crack underfoot, light splits into contradictory shadows, oaths shatter like glass.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **Cardinal-Regent of the Broken Sun (scarlet gloves)** — *Phases:* Interdict Blade → Seal Both Ways → Confessional Leak. *Cracks:* **Queen’s Audience** cancels *Interdict Blade* once; a **Synod Indulgence** treats a church check as controlled for one scene.
- **Marshal-Exile, the Sun’s Hammer (tabard stitched over old loyalties)** — *Phases:* Chevauchée Call → Banner Turn → Lists to War. *Cracks:* **Letters Patent** buys one round of obedience; **General Pardon** lets a unit stand down.

- **Abbess-Chatelaine of Pont-du-Tithe (ring of keys, ring of scripture)** — *Phases*: Tithe Tripled → Sanctuary or Snare → Relic Audit. *Cracks*: **Paréage Charter** splits her power for one exchange; **Bridge Farm** counters *Tithe Tripled* once.
- **Parlement Spider (chief clerk; quills like daggers)** — *Phases*: Motion to Delay → Counter-Citation → Filed at Dawn. *Cracks*: **Sunburst Warrant** opens a “royal window”; **Burgess Charter** lets a town court overrule once locally.
- **Routier King (mercenary captain of captains)** — *Phases*: Company Mutiny → Pay in Plunder → Switch the Colors. *Cracks*: **Letters Patent** + **Remission** shifts one company to your side; **Gabelle Lease** buys supply favor but starts *Resentment*.
- **The Two Crowns (rival dukes)** — *Phases*: Contradictory Edicts → Levy in Hours → Coin Trial. *Cracks*: **Sunburst Warrant** + public mass unites them for one scene; **General Pardon** calms levy unrest once.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Tournament Ordeal (Bastide Square)** — Declare *Purse*, *Patent*, or *Pardon* as stakes. Win to cash a matching $\diamond$; *loseandspawnTournament* “Accident”.
- **Cathedral Scaffold Assize** — Argue law atop creaking beams; each good point moves Position up; each slip marks *Exposure*. A **Paréage Charter** lets you call a recess once.
- **Pont-du-Tithe Vigil** — Keep the bridge peaceful through dusk: clear 3 segments on *Bridge Peace* by feeding pilgrims, quieting relic zeal, and paying one tithe from your purse.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Legitimacy Dial (Claimant ↔ Neutrality)**: Track the party’s public stance.
 - *Claimant High*: +1 Position when invoking seals, warrants, or feudal rights; first parley with a rival claimant starts one step worse.
 - *Neutrality High*: +1 Effect when brokering truces or smuggling between factions; first petition to a court or cathedral starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by paying wergild to both sides or hosting a neutral moot.
- **Parlement Mini-Game (legal duel)**:
 - Lay three counters: **Precedent**, **Equity**, **Force**.
 - Argue a point (roll Lore+Diplomacy vs DV 3). On a hit, move one counter to your side. On a miss, the clerk gains *Citation Edge*.
 - Win two counters to secure a temporary **Parlement Ruling** (treat as a Diamond for one scene).
 - *Spider’s Interjection (2 SB)*: flip **Precedent**, but start *Whispered Precedent* [2].
- **Chevauchée Pressure (raid clock)**:
 - Two opposed clocks: *Outrun the Fire* vs *Scorched Earth* (size by highest rank in seed).
 - Each leg, choose *High Road* (fast, exposed), *Bypass* (slow, hidden), or *Ford* (risky, shortcut).
 - Advantage: Bypass→High Road (cover), Ford→Bypass (speed), High Road→Ford (navigation).

- Spend a **Watch-Code** (from Three-Fires Ridge) to shift one segment from *Scorched Earth* to *Outrun*.
- **Favor of the Sun (prestige track):**
 - Earn by resolving disputes between claimants without bloodshed, or by returning stolen relics.
 - At 3 Favor, treat one **Safe-Conduct** or **Sunburst Warrant** as unquestioned for a scene.
 - Each use after the first advances *Legitimacy Challenge* [4] against that claimant.
- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**
 1. *Cracked Bell*: first legal action gains +1d; first boast draws *Parlement Divided*.
 2. *Smoke on the Ridge*: *Chevauchée* advances once; shortcuts open.
 3. *Three Suns*: three claimants claim the same road; pick a side or start *Coin Debasement*.
 4. *Queen’s Dove*: a message arrives; +1d on the next *Queen’s Audience* attempt.
 5. *Salt Wind*: **Gabelle Lease** counts double value today; smugglers’ ears open.
 6. *Routier Campfire*: mercenaries are hireable for one scene at half price—but they’ll ask questions later.
- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Vhasia Flavor):**
 - 1 SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its value until re-witnessed.
 - 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a *◊orrecallapastruling*).
 - 3+ SB → *Crown Fracture*: the claimant’s legitimacy splits; halve a consequence by accepting a rival’s seal on your paper (start *Legitimacy Challenge*).
- **Reputation Echoes:**
 - *Court-Favored*: once/session, downgrade **Parlement Divided** to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
 - *Chevauchée-Tested*: +1 Position when evading raids; supply lines run 1 segment longer.
 - *Neutral Broker*: +1d with both claimants in a truce scene; any betrayal earns *Resentment* [2] from both sides.
- **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration):**
 - *Thepyrgos Synod Leak*: a **Synod Indulgence** can suspend a Vhasian interdict—but starts *Whispered Precedent* in Thepyrgos.
 - *Ubral Feud Echo*: paying wergild to a Vhasian claimant instead of a clan starts *Feud Rekindled* along the border roads.
 - *Kahfagian Salt War*: cashing a **Gabelle Lease** to outbid corsair lanes adds *Market Knives* [4] in Silkstrand or on the coastal quays.
 - *Valewood Relic Interest*: a relic from a Vhasian cathedral may be claimed by fae courts; a Diamond spent on relic control may instead draw *Court Tithe*.

Chapter 7

Viterra

The Hedge-Law Realm. Viterra breathes with the careful rhythm of precedent and petition. The Warrior Queen rules through legal precision as much as military might. Every hedge-row, every parish stone, every ferry crossing carries the weight of custom older than memory. In Viterra, a well-placed document can open doors that armies cannot breach.

7.1 Viterra — “The Hedge-Law Realm”

Warrior Queen (Elite): “Every hedge here marks not just a boundary but a principle – the careful balance between order and freedom, justice and mercy. Our law grows like the hedges themselves, tended with precision and patience.”

Fen Reeve (Commoner): “The dikes hold back more than water – they hold back chaos. Every rod measured, every stone placed, keeps the flood from washing away not just our fields but our very way of life. And across the Belworth? The Vhasians still claim our hedges are theirs. Let them try.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Viterra breathes with the careful rhythm of precedent and petition. Once a proud kingdom before becoming a Utaran province, it is now reborn under a new Warrior Queen who rules by legal precision as much as military might. The realm's true sinews lie not in steel but in writs, charters, and the ancient rights that bind lord to tenant, crown to county, and church to common. Every hedge-row, every parish stone, every ferry crossing carries the weight of custom older than memory.

But Viterra is also a kingdom of restless ambition. Northward, the Ubral highlands reject any crown but their own moots. Southward, the City of a Thousand Stairs—Thepyrgos—watches with scholarly scorn and synod edicts. Westward, across the Belworth River, lie the fractured cantons of Vhasia, where Viterran dukes hold ancient claims to estates and abbeys—claims that have fueled decades of raiding, ransom, and legal warfare. And in the Dolmis, the isles of Theona pledge nominal fealty but keep their own taboos, a constant tug between crown law and green custom. Viterra is not a nation at peace. It is a realm that wages law as war, and war as law.

What you notice first: The smell of damp parchment and fresh ink. The clatter of writ-runners' boots on cobblestones. The way every noble's hand rests on a seal ring—and every commoner's hand rests on a hatchet.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never cross the Belworth without a charter recognized on both banks. Viterran law and Vhasian claim fight every crossing, and the river takes the losers.

Regional Mood: Hedge, Crown, and Claim

Here, law is a blade. The Warrior Queen rules from Valora, her throne a bench of precedents. The old Fenwood dukes—whose ancestors sacked Lence and left the Vhasian Sun-court fractured—still hold vast estates in the northern marches, and their claims across the Belworth keep the border smoking like a low fire. Every spring, the Queen's justiciars ride west with warrants and escorts, demanding homage from villages that have paid Vhasian tithes for a generation. Every autumn, Vhasian routiers raid the grain convoys, and the legal duels that follow are fought with steel and citation alike.

North, the Ubral clans watch from their cairns, ready to rekindle feuds if a Viterran levy crosses the passes. South, Thepyrgos sends clerks and spies, testing the edges of Viterran jurisdiction with every disputed toll. And in Theona, the Three Greens mumble old curses while Viterran bailiffs try to count their cattle—and always miscount by one.

Starting Location: The Hall of Dawning tilt-yard at first light. Dawn-knights drill in armor polished like mirrors. Beside them, advocates rehearse arguments with the same intensity. A Queen's Justiciar slides a parchment across an oaken rail. "Three charters, one road across the Belworth. The Vhasian claimant says the bridge is theirs. The local reeve says it's crown land. And the abbey says it's a pilgrimage, not a toll. Carry the Queen's writ, break the Quiet Tolls, and make them agree—by clause or by cut."

(Court/Law/Border) Court gossip in Valora's law quarter; writ-runners queue at dawn; border sheriffs argue over a hay-cart's toll rights; dueling advocates prepare legal challenges like generals planning campaigns.

Spades — Places

2. **Fen Causeway** — Stile with toll-rod and eel carts queueing; each reeve claims right to collect under a different charter. Dueling advocates argue cases on makeshift platforms. *The causeway sinks an inch each year. The lawyers argue over whose fault that is.*
3. **Hedgerow Green** — In the Dales; bows strung under apple trees where justices of the peace hold court beneath makeshift arbors. Court duels permitted for matters of honor. *The apple tree is called “the Hanging Judge.” Its fruit tastes of iron.*
4. **Beacon Hill** — Above the Highlands; fire-grate still warm from last winter’s levy call, signal tower with semaphore arms for legal dispatches and military alerts. *The hill has three beacons. One for Ubral raids, one for Vhasian incursions, one for paperwork.*
5. **Belworth Stairs** — Ferry ledgers gone damp with river-mist; three manors claim toll rights, writs in three different hands. Legal challenges fought in boats while waiting. *The stairs were repaired last year. The Vhasian side uses a different measurement.*
6. **Bloom Quarry** — Old iron-bloom turned drill yard; hammer echoes carry, forge-reeve holds tally of crown contracts. Military contracts awarded through legal bidding wars. *The forge-reeve has never lost a contract. His opponents have a habit of finding better jobs elsewhere.*
7. **Parish Maze** — Stone maze where three maps disagree; hedge-priest’s vote decides who pays tithe and who holds freehold. Legal disputes settled by navigating the maze correctly. *The maze changes at night. The hedge-priest says that’s God’s will.*
8. **Fairport Works** — Tideworks at the Dolmis mouth; customs writs in three languages flutter, inspectors with magnifying glasses examine every manifest. Maritime law enforcement includes boarding actions. *One language is Utaran, one is Linn, one is for the smugglers.*
9. **Law Quarter** — Valora archives, oath-rooms, Hall of Dawning where precedent is birthed in ink and sealed with wax. Adjacent training grounds for legal advocates. *The archives have a locked wing. The key is a legal argument no one has won.*
10. **Counting Fields** — Tarlington beside muster ground; wagons load, ledgers mis-sum, auditors with quill-pens and suspicious eyes. Military mustering follows strict legal procedures with armed oversight. *The auditors carry swords. They say it’s for counting cattle. No one asks further.*
- J **Dike Crown** — Ring of turf and timber; brotherhood bells warn of flood—and spies who move like water through the fen. Legal sanctuary for those fleeing court judgments. *The sanctuary lasts for one tide. After that, the reeves can come—if they can find you.*
- Q **Progress Camp** — Queen’s canvas palisade, banners stiff, whispering old courtiers plot advancement through legal maneuver and sanctioned duels. *The camp moves every week. The lawsuits follow at a measured pace.*
- K **Tilt-Yard** — Hall of Dawning at first light; Dawn-knights drill clean, loyalties in contracts signed with careful pen. Legal challenges often end in trial by combat. *The sand is raked between duels. Sometimes the rake turns up old blood—or old oaths.*
- A **Highway Stone** — Queen’s milestone above the Dolmis road; three sheriffs post seals over hers, each claiming different jurisdiction. Territory disputes resolved through armed arbitration. *The stone has been broken and reglued seven times. Each crack is a forgotten compromise.*

(Reeve/Guild/Knight/Legal Advocate) Fen reeve with tally-rod speaking for dike guilds; river-carter syndic moving grain faster than rumor; justices of the peace settling disputes with careful pen; master advocates who duel with words and swords.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Fen Reeve** — Tally-rod; speaks for dike guilds, remembers every flood-year's debts and the charters that govern them. Authorized to call local levies for legal disputes. *His tally-rod has notches from three floods. The next notch will be from a Vhasian raid.*
3. **River Syndic** — Moves grain faster than rumor; knows which writs matter and which customs officials can be... persuaded. Maintains armed merchant guards. *His ledger has a watermark—a crown on one side, a sunburst on the other. He shows the right side to the right audience.*
4. **Parish Surveyor** — Three maps, one opinion; hedge-walks settle more disputes than courts, measures boundaries with careful chain. Expert witness in property disputes. *His chain is exactly one rod long. The rod changes length depending on who is paying.*
5. **Dawn Quartermaster** — Ledgers sharper than tongue; logistics before lances, counts every farthing spent in the Queen's name. Legal authority over military supplies. *He once tracked a missing farthing to a Vhasian counting house. The farthing was returned—with interest.*
6. **Levy Serjeant** — Dales bow calm, cider breath, memory keen for every loophole in the mustering laws. Commands armed civilians in legal enforcement actions. *His bowstring is made from a cancelled writ. He says it shoots truer now.*
7. **Cleric-Pair** — Light preacher vs. Everflame canon lawyer; debates decide tithe law, one for the spirit, one for the letter. Religious law carries weight in secular courts. *They share a room at the inn. They have not spoken outside court in seven years.*
8. **Fairport Shipwright** — Dolmis cousins; skiff carries more secrets than cargo, knows which manifests to forge and which to honor. Expert in maritime law and naval combat. *Her skiff has no name. The customs clerks have given it three.*
9. **Fenwood Comptroller** — Conjures wagons with a signature, silence with a seal, counts the Queen's coin and tracks every debt owed to the crown. Legal authority over taxation. *His quill is a dagger. He has used it as both.*
10. **Queen's Justiciar** — Law on the road, polite as a noose; bearing three kings' judgments and a purse full of pardons for the right price. Authorized to conduct trial by combat. *She has never lost a legal duel. Her opponents have a tendency to fall down stairs.*
- J **Border Routier** — Reads ledgers as ambushes; serves two crowns, collects from both, knows which border posts take bribes in what coin. Expert in frontier law enforcement. *His loyalty is to the highest bidder. The Queen and the Vhasian claimant are currently in a bidding war.*
- Q **Warrior Queen** — Crown on helm, sword at side, patient sums behind her gaze; rules by law's sharp edge and knows every precedent that supports her claim. Final arbiter in legal duels. *Her crown has no jewels—only seals. Each seal is a conquered claim.*
- K **Crown Council** — Fenwood dukes, guild envoys, abbots; weighing grain against glory, charters against coin, precedent against practicality. Legal battles fought through proxy advocates. *The council has a standing rule: no weapons within the chamber. The advocates have found seventeen loopholes.*
- A **Master Advocate Halric** — Silver-tongued legal warrior who settles disputes through verbal duels that can end in physical combat. Keeper of legal combat traditions. *He has argued cases in Vhasian, Thepyrgosian, and Ubral courts—and won all three using their own precedents.*

(Writ/Charter/Duel/Legal Challenge) Dike breach in black-rain; wrong reeve claims credit while wagons drown; feast-day clash of Light vs. Everflame processions; secret meetings in counting

houses; legal duels fought in courtyards.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Dike Breach** — Black-rain; the wrong reeve claims credit while wagons drown, insurance claims and liability writs fly like autumn leaves. Legal liability may require armed enforcement. *The water is brown with peat and lies. It carries old deeds downstream.*
3. **Feast Clash** — Light vs. Everflame processions collide; shutters slam, writs fly, justices of the peace called to settle which holy day takes precedence. Honor disputes may require legal duels. *The processions take different routes now. The clash was not an accident.*
4. **Quiet Tolls** — Sprout on the Queen’s Highway; escorts sniff traps, sheriffs argue rights, customs officials demand duties no one knew existed. Territorial disputes resolved through armed arbitration. *The toll posts have fresh paint. The paint is from the keep of a Vhasian claimant.*
5. **Audit Freeze** — Counting-house freezes cargo; Queen’s seal vs. old writs, auditors with suspicious eyes and quill-pens sharp as daggers. Legal challenges may escalate to physical confrontation. *The auditors work by candlelight. The shadows on the walls look like gallows.*
6. **Border Snarl** — Three courts arrest the same hay-cart; whose hay is it? Which lord’s charter takes precedence? Bribes flow like wine. Frontier justice often involves armed standoffs. *The hay is from a field that was Vhasian last spring. Now it’s Viterran. The field hasn’t moved.*
7. **Isle Refusal** — Theona withholds levy; the quays choke on rumor, ships idle while lawyers debate maritime law and ancient treaties. Naval blockades become legal enforcement actions. *Theona’s envoy carries a hawthorn branch. The Queen’s justiciars will not touch it.*
8. **Delta Spat** — Fairport vs. Marcott customs; barges stack three deep, merchants pick sides, inspectors with magnifying glasses examine every manifest. Trade disputes fought with merchant guards. *The magnifying glasses reveal truth and also start fires. Both are useful.*
9. **Routier Arrears** — A free-company flips unless someone pays; your name on a ledger, a debt owed to men who know the price of blood. Legal debts enforced through hired swords. *The routiers have a list. Your name is on it—or will be by sunset.*
10. **Salt Pinch** — Import spikes, bakers barricade; the Queen’s promise tastes like thin gruel, merchants hoard salt like gold, riots brew in back alleys. Economic warfare becomes physical conflict. *The salt is grey. It was cut with ashes from a burned Vhasian customs post.*
- J **Dawn Recall** — Escort pulled to a flood-struck parish; the writ argues with the river, justices demand inquiry into who neglected the dikes. Military enforcement of legal judgments. *The escorts are back in a week. They bring new writs—and fewer men.*
- Q **Aberielist Intrigue** — Royalist seals in wrong hands; the Queen’s patience thins, conspirators plot in counting houses, whispers of rebellion. Treason charges carry death penalty in legal duels. *The seals are from a dead duke. The duke’s ghost is said to approve.*
- K **Levy Call-Up** — Dalesmen mustered; your wagons seized “for the realm,” conscription writs signed with careful pen, families left to tend fields alone. Legal authority backed by armed force. *The conscription writs have a clause: “void if Belworth freezes.” The river is still warm.*
- A **Legal Duel Challenge** — Master Advocate Halric issues a formal challenge; refuse and lose legal standing, accept and risk life and fortune in court-yard combat. The ultimate legal weapon. *The challenge is written on both sides of the parchment. There is no blank space to refuse.*

(Bribe/Seal/Writ/Duel Warrant) Ferry priority at Belworth crossing; dike-work allotment with brotherhood labor granted; market license sealed with proper wax; sanctioned duel to settle property dispute.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ferry Priority** — Belworth crossing (once); a horn answers, though perhaps the wrong ferry; customs officials look the other way for the right coin. Legal right of way backed by armed escort. *The priority token is a writ signed by both banks. The ink on one side is newer.*
3. **Dike Allotment** — Brotherhood labor granted if three clerks are convinced and proper bribes distributed among the right hands. Work performed under legal contract with military oversight. *The allotment includes a clause: “as tides permit.” The reeve decides what the tides permit.*
4. **Market License** — Valora’s square; a guild nod still needed, but the right seal on the right parchment opens many doors. Legal protection from merchant guild enforcement. *The license is written on vellum from a Vhasian abbey. The irony is noted.*
5. **Dawn Escort** — Four lances at dawn; loyalty waxes and wanes with pay, but their presence keeps lesser men from troubling you. Legal authority to enforce your writs. *The lances are from the Fenwood armory. The Fenwood dukes have their own plans.*
6. **River Charter** — Guaranteed haul on a grain artery—weather permitting and proper duties paid to the right officials. Legal right protected by river patrol. *The charter is stamped with a seal that looks like a crown—or a sunburst. No one can agree.*
7. **Map Correction** — A hedge moves, borders shift, lawsuits bloom; a new survey can make or break a man’s fortune overnight. Legal survey backed by armed surveyors. *The surveyors carry chains and swords. The swords are for when the chains disagree.*
8. **Customs Seal** — Fairport for Dolmis cargo; honored today, disputed tomorrow, but tonight it clears the way for what needs moving. Legal immunity from customs enforcement. *The seal is a wax crab. It pinches when pressed.*
9. **Thing Ruling** — Sharp local bite, but appeals run swifter than oaths; justice swift but not always just, depending on which purse feeds the judge. Court decisions enforceable by local levy. *The ruling is carved on an oar. Break the oar, and the ruling breaks with it.*
10. **Salt Allotment** — Winter depot; the Queen’s writ opens doors, old hands still count sacks, but the right connections ensure the best salt reaches the right tables. Legal monopoly backed by military force. *The salt is from a pan worked by Ubral exiles. They still count in clan measure.*
- J **Wardship** — A minor fen-keep; men-at-arms “for now,” a tutor has plans, but the right guardian can be found for the right price. Legal guardianship with military authority. *The ward is a child. The child has a seal ring. The ring is older than the kingdom.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Private; her questions strike like thrusts, but her favors can elevate a man from nothing to something overnight. Royal decree carries immediate enforcement power. *The audience lasts one hour. The paperwork lasts a generation.*
- K **Ducal Warrant** — Fenwood to enforce customs; old power bows, new power watches, but the parchment carries weight in any court. Legal authority backed by noble house military. *The warrant is signed in blood—or ink that looks like blood. The difference matters at trial.*
- A **Duel Sanction** — Right to challenge in legal combat; the Queen’s seal makes it official,

Dawn-knights serve as seconds, the winner takes all legally. Ultimate legal enforcement mechanism. *The sanction is a coin. Heads you duel, tails your opponent chooses the weapon.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (writs/charters/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **hedge-law** motif—boundaries blur, charters contradict, precedent splinters, and the careful web of legal authority shows its cracks. Legal warfare escalates to physical conflict.

Additional Features

- **Hedge-Law Momentum:** When a valid *writ*, *charter*, or *warrant* is presented in the proper parish, step **Position** up one category on social or logistical actions in that locale for the scene. The first contradiction starts a **Border-Lace** [4] clock; advance each time competing papers are invoked.
- **Beacon & Bell Chain:** If two adjacent *beacons* or *brotherhood bells* are under your influence, convert one **Club** draw into a travel delay for *others* while the party proceeds with improved **Effect** for movement and logistics. The signal draws scrutiny; the GM may bank 1 SB tied to local authority.
- **River-Right Window:** At a ferry, tidework, or customs stair, play any **Diamond** tied to crossings or seals to open a short *window of lawful passage*: one convoy passes uninspected, or one cargo clears at priority. The window closes immediately if a storm, audit, or levy card is revealed.
- **Legal Duel Protocol:** When legal disputes cannot be resolved through argument, parties may challenge each other to a duel. The winner’s position becomes legally binding. Requires proper sanction and seconds.
- **Vhasian Claims:** Any Viterran noble with land across the Belworth may invoke a *Ducal Warrant* to attempt to collect rents or enforce judgments in Vhasia. Doing so starts a **Border Snarl** clock, as the Vhasian claimants are unlikely to cooperate.
- **Theona Contest:** The Warrior Queen’s authority over the Three Greens is nominal at best. Any attempt to enforce Viterran law in Theona triggers a **Isle Refusal** complication, and the local taboos may twist the law into knots.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice near the Belworth Stairs. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the fen reeves, trying to untie her cord from a Fenwood death warrant.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Hall of Dawning tilt-yard is a Class II Anchor site—the ghosts of slain legal duelists still argue their cases. Saikou Ira would trade his silver mirror for a single deposition.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the border routiers. Take it, and your legal fees are always paid—but the coin will appear in the pocket

of the opposing counsel tomorrow.

- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Viterran psions are called “Oath-Readers.” They taste the weight of a promise in the speaker’s sweat. The Warrior Queen employs three—and has never trusted a verdict they didn’t whisper.
- **The Ninth:** In any Viterran court, the ninth citation of precedent voids all previous citations. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court.

Viterran Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Hedge:** Crumble a crust at a parish boundary stone. Ignore the first *Border Snarl* penalty.
- **Knot the Writ:** Tie a single knot in a charter’s ribbon. Cancel *Audit Freeze* or take –1 die on your next legal argument (your choice).
- **Name to the River:** Whisper a dead claimant’s name into the Belworth. Gain +1 Effect when arguing against their heir’s claim this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Queen’s Justiciar.

Patronage & Power

In Viterra, power flows through the careful application of law, the management of ancient rights, and the delicate balance between imperial legacy and reclaimed sovereignty. The Warrior Queen maintains authority through a combination of military might and legal precision, while the old duchies and local officials wield influence through their knowledge of traditional customs and hedge-law. The true power lies with those who can navigate this complex legal landscape and maintain the appearance of legitimate authority while building genuine support.

But remember—in Viterra, law is warfare. Every document is a weapon, every courtroom a battlefield, and every advocate a soldier. The pen cuts as deep as any blade, and legal victory can be as decisive as military conquest.

For the GM: Patronage in Viterra revolves around legal documents, local rights, and the ability to command respect from institutions still finding their post-imperial identity. Rewards often take the form of writs, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, charters) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival duchies and Vhasian claimants issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the courts, parishes, and muster grounds as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.
- When legal conflicts escalate beyond words, transition naturally to physical confrontation with appropriate stakes.

In Viterra, your papers are your power, and your power determines whether you rule or are ruled. But when words fail, steel speaks—and the law says both are valid.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **crown officials or rival advocates**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **writ-runners or levy guards**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or customs inspectors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable court date**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Queen’s Justiciar or fen reeve** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or river closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival claimant or border routier** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **Dawn-knights, levy forces, or Vhasian routiers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **writ voided/duel declared/levy called**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Warrior Queen, Crown Council, or Master Advocate Halric** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **dike breaks/river floods/court erupts**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Viterra (Hedge Law):** Boundary stones shift, charters contradict themselves, legal precedents split mid-citation.
- **Viterra (Cross-Border Claims):** Vhasian landlords appear with older deeds, Theonan taboos void writs, Ubral cairns declare neutrality with axes.
- **Viterra (Legal Warfare):** Court decisions reverse without warning, witnesses recant, duel seconds change sides.

Legal Combat System (Summary)

When legal disputes cannot be resolved through negotiation, parties may engage in formal legal duels. These combine verbal sparring with physical combat:

Phase 1: Pleadings

- Each advocate presents their case (Wits + Sway vs. DV 3)
- Success grants +1 die to the next phase
- Failure creates 1 SB that the opponent can spend

Phase 2: Cross-Examination

- Attack opponent's arguments (Wits + Insight vs. DV 3)
- Success inflicts Fatigue 1 on the opponent
- Critical success forces opponent to answer truthfully

Phase 3: Trial by Combat (if unresolved)

- Physical combat with legal stakes
- Winner's position becomes legally binding
- Loser suffers legal consequences plus physical harm

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Violet Clerk (Master of Counter-Seals)** — *Phases*: Produce Earlier Patent → Split the Writ → Seal Fast. *Cracks*: a **Queen's Audience** overrules his seal; a **Duel Sanction** forces personal combat.
- **The Thorn Captain (Queen's Quiet Hand)** — *Phases*: Queenspeace Zone → Duel Warrant → Swap the Field. *Cracks*: a **Map Correction** reveals a loophole; a **Dike Allotment** lets you claim the field as "flood zone."
- **The Saffron Abbess (Keeper of Bell-Law)** — *Phases*: Wrong Hour → Bless or Damn → Mixed Tribunal. *Cracks*: a **Queen's Justiciar** invokes crown supremacy; a **Border Routier** bribes her bell-ringer.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Belworth Stairs Ordeal** — Cross the river without a charter. On success, you prove that possession is nine-tenths of the law. On failure, the river takes your name—and your cargo.
- **Hall of Dawning Vigil** — Spend a night in the tilt-yard. At dawn, you recall a forgotten legal precedent. Gain a one-use *Precedent Edge* (+1 die in any court). The ghost of a dead duelist may challenge you.
- **Hedge-Moot at Dusk** — Settle a boundary dispute by walking the hedge. Each successful navigation test clears 1 segment from a **Border Snarl** clock. A miss plants the thorn of a future feud.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Legal Dial (Crown ↔ Local Custom)**: Track the party's stance on authority.
 - *Crown High*: +1 Position when invoking royal writs, charters, or the Queen's name; first appeal to local custom starts one step worse.

- *Local High*: +1 Effect on hedge-law, parish rights, or ancient precedent; first royal petition starts one step worse.
- Center the dial by hosting a mixed moot or surrendering a contested seal to a neutral third party.
- **Courtroom Mini-Game (fast trial):**
 - Lay three stones: **Precedent**, **Equity**, **Force**.
 - Argue a point (roll Lore+Diplomacy vs. DV 3). On a hit, move one stone to your side. On a miss, the opposing advocate gains *Citation Edge*.
 - Win two stones to secure a temporary **Court Ruling** (treat as a Diamond for one scene).
 - *Halric’s Interjection (2 SB)*: flip **Precedent**, but start **Whispered Precedent** [2] with the losing side.
- **Cross-Border Tensions (fast pressure):**
 - Two opposed clocks: *Queen’s Peace* vs *Border Fire* (size by highest rank in the seed).
 - Each leg, choose *Viterran Road* (safe, slow), *Vhasian Claim* (fast, risky), or *Ubral Pass* (hidden, costly).
 - Advantage: Vhasian Claim→Viterran Road (shortcuts), Ubral Pass→Vhasian Claim (concealment), Viterran Road→Ubral Pass (supplies).
 - Spend a **Ducal Warrant** to shift one segment from *Border Fire* to *Queen’s Peace*.
- **Start-of-Scene Rumors (1d6):**
 1. *Wrong Wax*: a rival’s seals softened; +1d to forgeries this scene.
 2. *Empty Beacon*: tower unmanned; travel faster, scrutiny harsher.
 3. *Dawn-Lane Cleared*: first convoy action gains +1 Position.
 4. *Clerk’s Wedding*: filings delayed; first petition ignores *Audit Freeze*.
 5. *Fen High Water*: ferries slow; river-charters count double value.
 6. *Mask at Progress*: someone uses your name at court; +1d to social opens, +1 SB banked by GM.
- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Viterra Flavor):**
 - 1 SB → *Hedge Shift*: a boundary moves; increase DV by 1 for navigation or legal rolls this scene.
 - 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a $\diamond$ or recall a past ruling).
 - 3+ SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its value; swap one held $\diamond$ for a less right until re-witnessed.
- **Reputation Echoes:**
 - *Court-Favored*: once/session, downgrade **Audit Freeze** to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
 - *Fen-Tested*: +1 Position when resolving dike or flood crises; legal arguments about water rights start one step worse.
 - *Double-Sealed*: +1d with both royal and local courts in a truce scene; any betrayal earns **Border Snarl** from both sides.
- **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration):**
 - *Ubral (Stone & Oath)*: A **Ducal Warrant** acts as a *Guest-Token* once at a clan hearth,

but starts a **Feud Rekindled** tick if you collect tolls twice in a tenday.

- *Thepyrgos (Synod Law)*: A **Queen’s Audience** can suspend a synod interdict—but starts *Whispered Precedent* in Thepyrgos.
- *Vhasia (Fractured Sun)*: A **Duel Sanction** is recognized on the Pont-du-Tithe—but a rival abbey can turn it into *Parlement Divided* on a Club draw.
- *Theona (No Ninth)*: **Ferry Priority** overrides a local taboo once; if the Ninth custom is in play, the writ “forgets” one clause on use (GM banks 1 SB).

Conspiracy Flourishes (keep it close, keep it quiet)

- **Hedge-Moots at Dusk**: Parish elders “trim hedges” while trading sealed whispers.
- **Cipher Roses**: Folded writs stamped with thorn-petals; one petal missing marks a false clause.
- **Mirror Hours**: Beacons flash lawful signals—reversed for those who know the counter-code.
- **Eel-Letters**: Oiled parchment smuggled in eel-baskets; ink runs in water, truth does not.
- **Quiet Steel, Quieter Quills**: Dawn-knights duel at first light; advocates settle three duels before breakfast with ink alone.
- **Progress Masks**: Courtiers wear legal devices as masque motifs (seal, chain, beacon) to signal faction at a glance.
- **Bell Penance**: A single off-hour peal grants amnesty to those who confess a clause before the twelfth echo.

Chapter 8

Thepyrgos

City of a Thousand Stairs. Thepyrgos rises in tiers of towers, terraces, and endless stairs. Its universities and synods debate philosophy and precedent, while the Chain-Lanterns patrol the countryside, hunting unsanctioned magic. The Library of Keys holds forbidden knowledge, and the Harbor Boom answers only to the Archon’s seal.

8.1 Thepyrgos — “City of a Thousand Stairs”

The Archon (Elite): “Every stair climbed is a word in the great conversation between earth and sky. This city is not built – it is grown, stone by stone, law by law, until the very architecture speaks wisdom.”

Bell-Runner (Commoner): “I know every step that creaks a warning and every landing that whispers gossip. The bells tell the city’s mood better than any lord – three chimes means business, six means trouble, and nine means the hunters are coming.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Thepyrgos is both realm and city, a former Utaran province whose capital rises in tiers of towers, terraces, and endless stairs above the Dolmis shore. Once a military bastion, now a nation unto itself, it is famed for its universities, libraries, and debating synods, where precedent and philosophy weigh as much as pikes or coin. Outside the city, the countryside reflects a rugged coastal landscape of whitewashed villages, olive groves, and timber churches—home to the Hyro people, humans with an unusually high rate of arcane talent. This region is also the land of Canré, a Kon'reh variant that deliberately ignores its historical roots in favor of pure geometry.

The Chain-Lantern order and other Witch-Hunter Commissariats ruthlessly patrol the villages and hamlets, using bounty postings, candle-smoke tests, and stair-seizures to identify and kidnap children with arcane talent for the university's hidden colleges. The enigmatic Witness and the Ninth fight proxy wars via fraternal orders and occult mystery cults, their influence felt in the political maneuvering of the Synod and the mysterious disappearances that plague the countryside. Every stone stair carries the echo of old campaigns and civic quarrels, every bell carries law across the wind. Here, authority climbs as much as it rules: archons elected by the city's wards, synods decreeing rites and edicts, guilds policing ropes, cranes, and chains. In Thepyrgos, height is hierarchy, sound is sovereignty, and law is etched into every rung.

What you notice first: The endless chime of bells from different tiers, never quite in sync. The smell of brine and olive oil and candle wax. The way locals glance at the sky when a child coughs.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never let a bell-ringer count your breaths. The Chain-Lanterns pay well for names that ring false on the test stairs.

Regional Mood: Stairs, Bells, and Smoke

Here, every ascent is a plea and every descent a confession. Thepyrgos the city is a vertical labyrinth of stair-rights, rope-guilds, and synod edicts that shift with the tide. Thepyrgos the province is a haunted countryside of hidden talent and state-sanctioned abduction. The Hyro keep their arcane children in root cellars and haylofts, praying the hunters take the neighbor's instead. The Chain-Lanterns move at dawn, their brass censers swinging, their bells tuned to the frequency of latent magic. In the university's forbidden tiers, the Witness and the Ninth arm rival fraternities with citations and curses, and no one is sure which side the Archon secretly favors.

Starting Location: The Synod Hall at dusk. Gold-glass mosaics glitter as a Matriarch reads a scroll aloud. "The Beacon Crown sees traitors in the smoke. A child's talent was sold to the Commissary last night. Find the informer—or the next stair seized will be yours."

(Tower/Stair/Sea-wall) Pilgrim's Stair zig-zagging sea-cliff to wicket gate; Tower Quarter with family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges.

Spades — Places

2. **Pilgrim's Stair** — Zig-zagging sea-cliff to wicket gate; ascent as devotion. *Every hundredth step has a bell. Pilgrims ring once for mercy, twice for memory.*
3. **Tower Quarter** — Family keeps stitched by ladders and bridges; vertical neighborhoods. *The lowest rung of each ladder is painted red—a toll for the rope-guild.*

4. **Chain-Barbican** — Harbor gate; capstans ready to raise the boom at horn’s call. *The capstan pins are carved from the thighbones of executed smugglers.*
5. **Blue Cistern** — Under the forum; cool echo, strict tally; water as law. *The water tastes of copper and old prayers. Drink deep, and you may forget a debt.*
6. **Ropeyard Terrace** — Cranes walk cargo up slope by treadwheel; muscle and machinery. *The treadwheel operators sing in eights. The ninth beat is always silent.*
7. **Storm-Wall Arcades** — Wind shrieks through arched galleries; defense as architecture. *The wind carries voices from the last siege. Some say they’re warnings.*
8. **Beacon Crown** — Ring of watchtowers signaling along the Dolmis; eyes of the city. *The beacons burn juniper and saltpeter. Black smoke means fire; white smoke means hunters.*
9. **Library of Keys** — Archive vaults; shelves locked by rung and rite; knowledge as power. *The keys are graded by sin. The ninth key opens nothing—and everything.*
10. **Siege Court** — Test ramp and scarred stones; war never far from peace. *The ramp’s stones are stained with lamp oil and regret. Practice charges end in the cistern.*
- J **Ladder Monastery** — Perched on a needle of rock; monks climb toward truth. *The monks never speak. They write commandments in chalk on the rungs.*
- Q **Synod Hall** — Gold-glass mosaics; judgment audible at a whisper’s distance. *The acoustics are enchanted. A lie told here echoes twice—once in the liar’s voice, once in truth’s.*
- K **Archon’s Citadel** — Acropolis peak; mirror tiles glare like noon’s justice. *The mirrors were a gift from Kahfagia. They show not the sea, but the faces of debtors.*
- A **Sky-Bridge** — Twin cliff towers joined over the inner harbor; height as connection. *The bridge has no railings. The Archon says the wise don’t need them.*

(Archon/Synod/Guild) Bell-runner child whose feet know every stair by heart; Master of Ropes with palms like oak, voice like a whistle.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bell-Runner** — Child whose feet know every stair by heart; speed as currency. *She ties a knot in her hair for each hunter she’s outrun. Her hair is a thicket.*
3. **Master of Ropes** — Palms like oak, voice like a whistle; guild head of lifters. *He lost two fingers to a frayed line. He keeps them in a jar as a warning.*
4. **Icon-Smith** — Portable shrine, temper about pigment; faith in detail. *His pigments are ground from stolen icons. He calls it recycling the divine.*
5. **Wall Strategos** — Drills levies on the test ramp; defense as daily ritual. *She lost a son to a Linn raid. She trains orphans now—and keeps a list.*
6. **Chain-Keeper** — Harbor boom; hates “surprises” at dusk; order as obsession. *His bell never rings the same note twice. He says the tide changes its mind.*
7. **Oath-Examiner** — Weighs words like iron; notary of truth and consequence. *She carries a scale with one pan empty. The empty pan is for lies.*
8. **Archive Sister** — Key to the “forbidden rung”; keeper of dangerous knowledge. *Her left eye is milk-white—a price for reading a cursed shelf.*
9. **Salt-Fish Syndic** — Warehouse queen of the quays; profit in preservation. *Her salt is cut with ground bone meal. The fish stay fresh—and quiet.*

10. **Nomophylax** — Law-scholar whose citations close mouths; precedent as weapon. *He has never lost a case. His opponents have a habit of vanishing.*
- J **Palikar Captain** — Tower guards; ladder-quick and letter-shy; strength in motion. *His shield is painted with a ladder—each rung a battle he survived.*
- Q **Matriarch of the Ladder** — Synod primate; calm as stone, wisdom in height. *She speaks once a session. When she does, the bells listen.*
- K **The Archon** — Elected, entrenched, counting bells; ruler of the ascent. *He wears a key around his neck. No one knows what it opens.*
- A **Lighthouse-Patriarch** — Reclusive seer; said to steer beacons in storms. *He has no eyes—only mirrors where his eyes should be.*

(**Edict/Quake/Chain**) Tremor with hairline cracks racing down a stair; crowds freeze; iconoclast riot in the Tower Quarter.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Tremor** — Hairline cracks race down a stair; crowds freeze, dust speaks. *The dust spells names. Yours appears if you've broken a stair-right.*
3. **Iconoclast Riot** — In the Tower Quarter; pigments and teeth fly through the air. *The riot started over a missing icon's eye. The eye was a hunter's informer.*
4. **Chain Jam** — At the barbican; capstan pins shear at the worst moment. *The pins were filed by a saboteur. The chain will hold—or not.*
5. **Black Northerly** — Pins cranes; cargo hangs between tiers, prayers below. *The wind smells of iron and ice. Someone is using weather magic.*
6. **Cistern Taint** — Sour water; inspectors padlock spouts, thirst rises. *The taint is sweet—too sweet. Someone poisoned the cistern to flush out a talent.*
7. **Synod Summons** — A chant or badge is suddenly proscribed; law shifts like wind. *The summons is written on a bell-clapper. Read it, and you are a witness.*
8. **Rope Guild Interdict** — No lifts until a grievance is heard; the city stops climbing. *The guild's grievance is a single name. The name is yours.*
9. **Siege Drill Panic** — Practice horns mistaken for real; chaos in the ranks. *The horns were blown by a child who didn't know the difference. Or did they?*
10. **Smuggler's Ladder** — Discovered; the whole stair sealed, routes rerouted. *The ladder was built by a Hyro family. Now they are all "guests" of the Commissariat.*
- J **Ropeyard Fire** — Sparks leap uphill faster than boots; smoke chokes the ascent. *The fire was set to cover a kidnapping. The victim's name is on the bounty board.*
- Q **Exarch's Claim** — "Thepyrgos under my protection"; arrests follow the papers. *The Exarch is a puppet of the Chain-Lanterns. His seal is a bell without a clapper.*
- K **General Watch** — All towers manned; levies seize carts "for the walls." *The levies are looking for one thing: children who flinch at candle-smoke.*
- A **Seaquake Seiche** — Surges the harbor; chain, quays, timetables snap like twine. *The seaquake was no natural event. Something beneath the Dolmis is waking.*

(**Key/Rite/Paper**) Stair token passes a barricaded stair without delay; harbor pass lowers the boom for your vessel on command.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Stair Token** — Pass a barricaded stair without delay (once); height as right. *The token is a bronze step. It fits into a missing rung.*
 3. **Harbor Pass** — Boom lowers for your vessel on command; sea as ally. *The pass is a note written on a fish scale. The gate-keeper will not ask why.*
 4. **Cistern Draw-Right** — A named ward during scarcity; water as favor. *The right is a clay cup. Break it to claim your share.*
 5. **Crane Allotment** — One guaranteed lift on the Ropeyard Terrace; height as service. *The allotment is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each use.*
 6. **Icon License** — Display a disputed image without penalty; faith as leverage. *The license is stamped with the Archon’s ring. The ring is warm—the Archon is watching.*
 7. **Archive Hour** — Library of Keys; one shelf opened to you; knowledge as power. *The shelf is sealed with a riddle. Solve it, or the key will break.*
 8. **Bellmark** — Lawful right to ring a tower bell (summons the watch); sound as law. *The bellmark is a brand on your palm. Show it, and the watch bleeds for you—once.*
 9. **Watchlight Code** — Today’s beacon and mirror signals; navigation as paper. *The code is written in lemon juice. Heat it to read, then hide it again.*
 10. **Synod Indulgence** — One proscribed chant or rite permitted (for you). *The indulgence is a bell-note held in a jar. Break the jar to release it.*
- J **Pronoia Grant** — Temporary farm/tax of a terrace hamlet; land as income. *The grant is a wooden token. Present it to the village elder—if she is still alive.*
- Q **Synod Audience** — Private with the Matriarch and clerks; wisdom as policy. *The audience is held in a fog hollow. What is spoken there is never written.*
- K **Archon’s Writ** — Palikars escort you between towers; authority as escort. *The writ is a bell-rope. Tie it to your belt, and the guards will know your voice.*
- A **Golden Key** — Open or seal any city gate once; access as power. *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist. It will work—once.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (keys/rites/papers) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **height and sound** motifs—bells that carry, wind that remembers, stairs that echo with purpose.

Additional Features

- **Bell-Law:** Bells are law made sound. Once per session, a Bellmark or tower bell summons the watch, a levy, or a decree. False rings stain a reputation; the Synod may inquire.
- **Stair-Rights:** Every stair is owned, owed, or leased. A token bypasses barricades and tolls; climbing the wrong stair without leave sparks a riot or a duel.
- **Synod Edicts:** Voice reshapes daily life. Once per session, a decree grants or strips rights: a

chant forbidden, a symbol proscribed, a stair sealed. Rulings create leverage and risk.

- **The Chain-Lanterns:** The most feared of the Witch-Hunter orders. Their captains carry brass lanterns that reveal latent magic through candle-smoke tests. A Chain-Lantern raid is heralded by a single, low bell—the death knell of innocence.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in the lower tiers. They ask no payment—but they take names. A renegade Sister hides among the bell-runners, trying to unbind her Hollowed from the Commissariat’s ledger.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Library of Keys holds a Class II Anchor—a scholar who died mid-citation. Saikou Ira would trade his silver mirror for a single shelf.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A cursed bell in the Tower Quarter rings once a year at midnight. Hear it, and you gain a year of luck—but the Chain-Lanterns will know your face forever.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Thepyrgos psions are called “Stair-Readers.” They climb in darkness, tasting each riser’s memory. The Commissariat employs three—and has never let them meet.
- **The Ninth:** In any Thepyrgos scene, the ninth bell rung in an hour opens a threshold. The wise stop at eight and cover their ears.

Thepyrgos Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stair:** Toss a crust onto a rung before climbing. Ignore the first *Tremor* penalty.
- **Knot the Rope:** Tie a single knot in a crane line. Cancel *Rope Guild Interdict* or take –1 die on your next lift (your choice).
- **Name to the Smoke:** Whisper a hunter’s name into the Beacon Crown’s fire. Gain +1 Effect when evading the Chain-Lanterns this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Synod.

Patronage & Power

In Thepyrgos, power flows through elevation, education, and the precise application of law. The Archon maintains authority through a complex web of guilds, synods, and civic institutions that govern every aspect of vertical life. Social mobility is literally upward mobility, with stair-rights, bellmarks, and archive access serving as both currency and status symbols.

For the GM: Patronage in Thepyrgos revolves around access—to towers, to knowledge, to the right to climb. Rewards often take the form of keys, passes, or legal exemptions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, keys, papers) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guilds issue conflicting rights, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the synods, towers, and staircases as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.

In Thepyrgos, your ascent is your standing, and your standing determines whether you rise or fall.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **tower guards or guild masters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **bell-runners or civic patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or archive keepers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable ascent**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Wall Strategos or guild head** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **quake damage or stair closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction or civic enforcer** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **palikars, guild enforcers, or synod guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **bell rings falsely/stair collapses/law changes**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.

- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Archon, Matriarch, or Lighthouse-Patriarch** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **quake hits/bells ring/bridge collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Thepyrgos (Height & Law):** Stairs shift position, bells ring with the wrong tone, legal papers rewrite themselves.
- **Thepyrgos (Synod Power):** Edicts change mid-speech, citations appear in the air, wisdom comes unbidden.
- **Thepyrgos (Vertical City):** Ropes fray without warning, cranes swing cargo unexpectedly, tower windows show wrong views.

The Magic Colleges (University Extensions)

- **College of Ladders & Lines** — geomancy, architecture, constraint; stairs as sigils, capstans as circles.
- **College of Bells & Beacons** — acoustics, omen-fire, signal calculus; law made audible, augury made measurable.
- **College of Waters & Weights** — alchemy, cistern rites, dyes; solutions, precipitates, and lawful flow.
- **College of Names & Oaths** — nomikon theurgy; citations that bind, clauses that compel.
- **College of Mirrors & Haze** — illusion, scrutiny; seeing, being seen, un-being seen.
- **College of Quiet** — ethics of death, memory rites; permitted remembrances—anything more is heresy.

The Witch-Hunter Province (Commissariat Extensions)

Thepyrgos-the-Province funds Witch-Hunter Commissariats—ministries with bounties posted per ward. Notices hang on stair-landings; bells announce *hunts lawful and hunts less so*. The Chain-Lantern order is the most feared, but others compete for quotas.

Hunter Hearts (faces of the persecution)

- **Commissary-Exarch** — Writs in triplicate; quotas in private.
- **Bounty-Reader** — Weighs children like coin; “verification” by bell.
- **Pardoner-Chaplain** — Sells absolution to informers; keeps a careful ledger.
- **Stair-Runner Informant** — Knows which doors open to the right knock.
- **Chain-Lantern Captain** — Commands the most feared order; his lantern reveals truth through flesh.

Hunter Clubs (pressures and sweeps)

- **Bounty Posting** — New price on “untutored talent”; crowds turn into nets.
- **Candle-Smoke Test** — Lines at the Blue Cistern; smoke curls toward the Gifted.
- **Commissary Sweep** — Ladders chained; a whole tier searched under horn.
- **Quieted Child** — An “accident” near the Exam Stair; evidence goes missing.
- **Chain-Lantern Raid** — Dawn assault on a hamlet; children taken before the rooster crows.

Hunter Diamonds (leverage and reprieve)

- **Witness Pardon** — Informer absolved and paid; cancels one legal fallout *once*.
- **Archon’s Clemency** — Suspends a bounty clock for one named; bell-marked and public.
- **Hidden Stair Token** — Through a maintenance run unseen; good for one group escape.

Detection & Denial (Fast Procedures)**Scry & Deny (evading the tests)**

1. **Mask the Trace:** dye, salt, bell-oil; pick *one* (each grants +1 die to one approach).
2. **Pick the Test:** *Smoke, Sound, Mirror*. State how you spoof it (alchemical veil, bell overtones, angle games).
3. **On a hit:** cancel a **Candle-Smoke Test** or **Proctors’ Gate** tag for this scene. **Consequence:** start *Bell Debt* [2] or *Rector’s Notice* [2].

Bounty Economy (quick table, GM picks or 1d6)

1. *Whisperer* (faint talent): 1 purse; informers abundant.
2. *Spark-Hand* (cantrip): 2 purses; “rehabilitation” promised.
3. *Mirror-Bent* (glamour): 3 purses; seized at once.
4. *Bell-Singer* (acoustic): 4 purses; Synod claims jurisdiction.
5. *Oath-Breaker* (binding): 5 purses; Exarch insists on custody.
6. *Quiet-Worker* (death-ethic): 6 purses; College of Quiet petitions for trial.

Scenario Starters (Plug-and-Play)

The Bright Child on the Exam Stair *Hook:* A Bell-Runner begs you to get a latent child to campus before the dawn sweep. *Complications:* **Candle-Smoke Test**, **Commissary Sweep**, a jealous **Street Thaum**. *Relief:* Trade a *Latency Seal* for testimony; or ring a lawful *Bellmark* to create a corridor—accept *Censure Murmurs* [2].

The Black Ledger of Bounties *Hook:* The College of Quiet wants proof that a Commissary inflates prices to fill quotas. *Complications:* **Synod Summons**, **Smuggler’s Ladder**, **Chain Jam**. *Relief:* Publish via a *Nomikon* colloquy (gain *Synod Indulgence*); or sell it to the Archon (gain *Archon’s Clemency* but start *Faculty Feud* [4]).

The Golden Key and the Silent Stair *Hook:* A dying Archivist gives you a Golden Key. “It opens the stair the hunters fear.” *Truth:* The stair leads to the Beacon Crown’s secret basement—a prison for children who passed the smoke test. *Relief:* Free the children and expose the Commissariat.

(gain *Archon's Clemency* for the whole party, but start *Exarch's Claim* at full); or seal the stair forever (gain *Golden Key* to use elsewhere, but the children are lost to memory).

Part III

The Northern Reaches

Chapter 9

Aeler

Crowns & Under-Vaults. The Aeler hold the mountains by breath, bell, and bargain. Their cities open in thunderous caverns where bridges leap between ribs of stone. Survival is the first law: air is counted, water is barred, light is rationed by wick and prayer. Tradition is the second: seals are kept, measures remain true, and the dead keep their offices as carefully as the living.

9.1 Aeler (Dwarves) — “Crowns & Under-Vaults”

Elite (Vault-Queen of a crownland)

“The mountain remembers every word carved in its stone, every seal pressed into its walls. To govern here is not to command, but to harmonize with the ancient songs that still echo in the deep places.”

Commoner (Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away)

“When the stone starts singing a different tune, you best listen. Three knocks in the morning means all’s well, but three knocks at night means something’s coming through the walls that wasn’t meant to walk.”

Crowns & Under-Vaults

The Aeler Kingdoms hold the mountains by breath, bell, and bargain. Dozens of sovereign holds – some sealed for centuries, others trading openly with lowland markets – share only the deep roots of stone and the supremacy of the High King Beneath the Peaks. Their halls run like arteries, their cities open in thunderous caverns where bridges leap between ribs of stone and cisterns shine like night skies turned inward. *Survival* is the first law: air is counted, water is bartered, light is rationed by wick and prayer. *Tradition* is the second: seals are kept, measures remain true, and the dead keep their offices as carefully as the living. Between the two, a people learn to argue quietly and build loudly.

Collectives (clans, guild-kin, lamp-companies) own what the mountain allows; individuals are custodians by oath. Trade runs under and over the range through under-ways and pass-forts, stitching protectorates and lowland markets to vaultmouth gates. When tunnels whisper or the air tastes wrong, the Aeler move as one animal; when the Kingsmoot calls, crowns and abbesses argue in bell-code and sealed writs until the stone itself seems to lean in.

The Fractured Crowns: Aeler Faction Spectrum

Aeler society is not monolithic. Beneath the High King’s nominal authority, each crownland follows its own star. Attitudes toward the surface range from open partnership to militant isolation, and even the most reclusive holds maintain **Edgewalker** contacts to monitor the world above.

- **Traditionalist / “Reactionary”** – These holds idealize the old mountain-empire: closed gates, iron tariffs, and the certain knowledge that surface-dwellers cannot be trusted. They resemble the dwarves of fireside tales: stubborn, insular, and quick to reach for an axe when a human mentions “progress.” Their kings speak of the days when no foreigner stepped past the vaultmouth. *Clocks: FOREIGNER SUSPICION [4], HOLD SEALED [6]*.
- **Cooperative / “Open Hand”** – These holds trade freely with Aelaerem, Kahfagia, and even the Vilikari. They staff the under-markets, send engineers to repair bridges in Viterra, and treat the surface as a resource to be managed, not a threat to be shunned. *Clocks: TRADE ROUTE PROSPERITY [6], CULTURAL FRICTION [4]*.
- **Isolationist / “Silent Stone”** – Deep holds that have not answered a Kingsmoot call in living memory. Their gates are lost, their peoples rumoured to have turned inward, worshiping forgotten depths. They neither help nor harm the surface – but when a White Flood or a gas flare occurs, their silence becomes a hazard of its own. *Clocks: SILENT HOLD AWAKENS [8], ANCIENT GRUDGE [6]*.

Most Aeler characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same hold might shift its stance over a season, depending on grain prices, a new Vault-Queen, or a disaster that forces its hand.

Spades — Places (vaultmouths, descents, underways, crown seats)

2. (Security/Gatekeeping) Vaultmouth Gate in a hillslope: bronze lungs for breath-tests, tally-niches for lamps.
 3. (Tradition/Oaths) Crown-Crypt Porch where oaths are sworn to sleeping kings.
 4. (Commerce/Underground) Under-Market: lantern alleys between cistern pillars; damp coin, dry wit.
 5. (Labor/Danger) Smoke-Shaft Stair spiraling up to a soot hatch; handprints black as seals.
 6. (Mystery/Whispers) Gloam Cistern—black water, lead scales, whispers carry too far.
 7. (Maintenance/Travel) Lamplighter’s Mile on the Under-Road; niches sting with spent wicks.
 8. (Precision/Authority) Measure Vault: standard rods and weights chained under glass and oath.
 9. (Sacred/Knowledge) Reliquary Arcade: bell-chimes answer drafts; saints keep their own tallies.
 10. (Military/Strategic) Twin-Throne Gate—surface fortress straddling a chasm bridge.
- J (Knowledge/Secrecy) Deep Archive Stacks behind grillwork; scriptoria cells breathe ink and dust.
- Q (Royalty/Privilege) Queen’s Descent: private stair from palace to royal vault-house.
- K (Politics/Power) Kingsmoot Cavern—crownstones in a ring around a bottomless dark.
- A (Infrastructure/Majesty) The Spine Underway, a great tunnel linking crownlands beneath the peaks.

Hearts — People & Factions (crowns, keepers, guilds, legates)

2. (Apprenticeship/Dedication) Lamplighter apprentice with a jingling key-ring and soot in the lungs.
 3. (Craft/Knowledge) Under-Mason who can hear stone shift a room away.
 4. (Authority/Duty) Vault Warden with breath-ledger and seal-rods; patient as granite.
 5. (Protection/Faith) Censer-Knight of the Dawn – fights miasma and men with equal zeal.
 6. (Sacred/Craft) Key-Sister (monastic locksmith) who names wards like prayers.
 7. (Commerce/Authority) Under-Market assessor whose stamp can starve or save a stall.
 8. (Engineering/Expertise) Engineer of Underways (geometer) with rod, hammer, and the right maps.
 9. (Tradition/Law) Oath-Keeper of the Crown Crypt – memory like iron, smile like law.
 10. (Diplomacy/Authority) Legate of the Under-Seal, royal commissioner between kingdoms.
- J (Communication/Loyalty) White-Ribbon tunnel courier; runs blind, rings true.
- Q (Royalty/Authority) Vault-Queen of a crownland, sovereign above and below.
- K (Supreme Authority/Tradition) High King Beneath the Peaks, first among crowns by ancient concord.
- A (Spiritual Power/Resolution) Lumenor of the Under-Altars, one sentence opens doors and closes debates.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (air, water, stone, rite, jurisdiction)

2. (Danger/Disorientation) Bad air pocket—candles gutter blue; lungs complain, schedules fail.
 3. (Disruption/Flood) Drip-flood from a burst cistern reroutes corridors without asking.
 4. (Accident/Destruction) Gas flare kisses a lamp; eyebrows and evidence vanish.
 5. (Error/Security) Seal misread—the wrong door opens, the right one will not.
 6. (Quarantine/Delay) Under-mold quarantine shuts the market just as your crate arrives.
 7. (Danger/Warning) Settling crack—dust snow warns the roof wants down.
 8. (Accusation/Suspicion) Stolen key turns up in your kit; accusations ring like bells.
 9. (Conflict/Jurisdiction) Bell-code conflict—two authorities claim the same chime.
 10. (Political Conflict/Violence) Vault-right feud: crown guards face basilica wardens on a stair.
- J (Disaster/Trapped) Cave-in behind—proof, friends, and retreat on the far side.
- Q (Religious Conflict/Inquisition) Heresy inquest in the under-chapel; arrests in whispers.
- K (Authority/Restriction) General Under-Seal—all vault traffic halted by royal decree.
- A (Natural Disaster/Destruction) White Flood—mountain thaw becomes a river through your route.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (keys, passes, breath, priority, precedent)

2. (Utility/Time) Lamp-priority tally—skip one lamplighter queue.
3. (Safety/Access) Breath-measure allotment—lawful time in a sealed chamber (once).
4. (Security/Authority) Key-Writ—operate a named lock one time, witnessed.

5. (Travel/Security) Underway Pass—escorted travel between two vaultmouths.
 6. (Commerce/Rights) Stall-Right in the under-market for a season.
 7. (Engineering/Safety) Engineer Shoring—a crew stabilizes your chosen corridor on your timetable.
 8. (Commerce/Trust) Assay Mark—your coin/metal accepted sight unseen below.
 9. (Protection/Law) Crypt Asylum—temporary sanctuary under crown law.
 10. (Authority/Access) Vault Inventory License—remove a named cache under witness.
- J (Military/Authority) Under-Guard Commission—command a vault detachment for a day.
- Q (Royalty/Privilege) Private Descent with the Vault-Queen or High King’s chancellor.
- K (Supreme Authority/Access) High King’s Sealed Writ—doors open, mouths close across crownlands.
- A (Exception/Power) The Under-Seal Clause—temporary exception to any lock, levy, or rite below.

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5→4, 6–10→6, J/Q/K→8, A→10).
- Treat **Diamonds** as codified outcomes (keys/passes/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo stone & breath motifs—keys click, bells answer, and the mountain listens (and remembers).

Additional Features

- **Count the Air:** When a scene establishes scarce air, a character who actively paces their breathing (counted steps, measured rests) may shift *Position* one step safer on their next physical action in a confined space.
- **Bell-Code Courtesy:** If the party adopts local bell etiquette (asking a warden which chime applies and heeding it), gain +1 assist die on negotiations or passage requests within a vault or under-market.
- **Measure is Mercy:** Presenting a certified measure (rod, weight, sealed tally) calms a dispute: cancel the first SB generated by commerce or jurisdictional friction in the scene.

Stone & Sovereignty

In the deep places, survival depends on precision and tradition. The Aeler understand that stone does not forgive error – a misread seal can mean death, a miscalculated air measure can doom an expedition, and a broken bell-code can spark jurisdictional war. Their society is built on layers of authority, each with its own rites, rights, and responsibilities. To navigate their realm is to learn a complex dance of deference and demand, where even the humblest lamplighter holds power over the darkness, and the smallest key can unlock the greatest vault.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **vault wardens or lamplighter companies**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **under-guards or echo bats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or assessors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable air**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Breath warden or vault warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **air shift or seal change**.
- **Foe Appears:** A rival crown’s **guard or gas wraith** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **crown guards, true masons, or lamp companies** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **seal misread/cave-in/flare ignites**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Vault-Queen, High King’s Legate, or Lumenor** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **gas floods/water breaks/floor collapses**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aeler (Stone & Breath):** Keys click in the wrong locks, bells answer without being rung, mountain air grows thin without warning.
- **Aeler (Authority & Tradition):** A seal is misread, bell-codes conflict between jurisdictions, a vault warden demands proper credentials.
- **Aeler (Underground Hazards):** Bad air pockets form, settling cracks warn of collapse, gas flares ignite unexpectedly.

Aeler — Under-Vault Tensions

Starting Location: An Underway junction lit by guttering brass lanterns, its stone walls scored with tally-marks from a dozen forgotten crowns.

“Among the Aeler, stone remembers the weight of oaths, and every echo calls a reckoning.”

In... An Underway junction, a Geometer halts the party with a tally-rod. “The Spine shifts,” he says, stone-dust in his beard. “Choose a crown—or be buried by one.”

Regional Motifs Load-bearing oaths, fault-prayers, crown-rights, catacomb guilds.

Whispers to Offer “Cut a supporting tie,” “Sign for another’s debt,” “Take a shortcut through the sealed tunnel.”

External Clocks Threat: “The Spine Slips”; Fracture: “Maps Reorder”; Community: “Surface Panic.”

Complications Load-lights dim; echoes reply in politics; crown agents arrive early.

Anchors at Risk A PC’s workshop; a shared refuge tunnel.

Escalation Beat The tally-rod points to the most guilty PC.

Relief Shore a vault with sacrifice (1 anchor), or complete a truce between crowns; Spirit + Resolve (5) to hold a cave-in long enough to evacuate.

Faction Entanglements

- **Edgewalkers (Prospectors):** If you accept their escort or intel, start a 4-segment *Opportunity* clock you can cash for +1 Effect on one venture. If you refuse a posted hazard, they post *your* route as “open” (first stealth or smuggling roll this leg suffers –1 die).
- **True Masons (Infrastructure Orders):** Pledge tools or labor to earn a *Mason’s Stamp* (treat as papers to traverse construction zones). Cross a marked barrier without their leave and gain the *Tampered Work* tag—first structural mishap SB against you is free.
- **Lamplighter Companies:** Donate wick, oil, or time on the Mile to bank a *Lamp Credit*; spend to ignore darkness penalties once on the Under-Road. Skip a service bell and all under-market buys that scene cost +1 clock tick (queues & suspicion).
- **Under-Market Assessors:** Submit to measure/weigh and reduce Commerce DV by 1 this scene. Try to pass unassayed goods—on a Miss, lose the load *or* accept a *Caveat Stamp* that poisons your price two markets downstream.
- **Breath Wardens:** Register bodies & flames before sealed work; compliance cancels the first air-hazard SB. Skipping registry adds a *Thin Air* tick to the leg (applies –1 die to the first exertion test in confinement).

Cross-Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Agrarian Reliance (Human Breadbelts):** Grain, timber, tallow, and fleece convoys from Acasia/Vhasia/Viterra sustain vault populations. Famine or levy spikes uprange impose night rationing: Under-Road checks +1 DV and food trades add +1 SB pressure until relief.
- **Standards Diplomacy:** Aeler *Measure Vault* rods adopted abroad grant +1 die to settle disputes in foreign markets; rejecting Aeler standards increases toll and inspection frequency (first border scene gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB).
- **True Mason Missions Abroad:** Accept a Mason cadre to “stabilize” bridges, ports, or sluices: reduce Travel DV by 1 on that route for the arc, but the route now respects Aeler closure bells (authorities can halt traffic with one writ).
- **Edgewalker Concessions:** Prospect notes traded to frontier lords exchange for wayleaves and salvage rights; cash once for an *Under-Seal Clause (local)* or accept a rival claimant clock that will mature if you delay.
- **Kahfagian Interface (Sea Monopoly):** Aeler export hard-goods via Kahfagian factors; storm seasons or privateer scares add a *Harbor Quarantine* tick to any surface leg feeding those ports (customs DV +1).
- **Aelerem/Aelinnel Fallout:** When *Valewood Weather* is signaled, Aeler works creak; all bell-codes in mixed settlements (Aelerem/Aelinnel) are one step easier to misread (first bell-etiquette scene: add a free “Error/Security” SB unless you consult a local).

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Airworks & Wick (Oil, Char, Filters):** Donate to a vault—bank a *Breath Favor* to cancel the next bad-air complication. Hoard in a shortage and your lot is flagged; all purchases beneath that crown suffer −1 die until you settle a fine or tithe.
- **Stonework & Ironwork (Beams, Keys, Rods):** Selling to foreign keeps spreads Aeler codes: once per arc, treat a foreign gate as if it used Aeler warding (gain +1 die with Key-Sisters/warders there). Counterfeit measure rods trigger a cross-border inquest clock.
- **Foodflows (Grain, Fleece, Tallow):** Move relief trains to clear one *Rationing* tag for a settlement (DV −1 for social checks there). Divert a relief train and gain an *Audit* clock that follows you three markets hence.
- **Cistern-Right & Water Engineering:** Fund a sluice or cistern abroad to gain *Water Priority* (skip one queue during drought). Neglect maintenance and the keeper may invoke *Aeler Liability*—pay or lose access to the route for a season.

Patron Networks (Below and Beyond)

- **The Sealed Gate:** Consecrated door-nails from True Mason kits act as single-use *stay* writs (negate one forced entry this scene).
- **The Traveler:** Spine milestones double as wayshrines; leave a brass chit to reroll one failed travel test on that segment this arc.
- **Inquisitor Prime:** Breath-pure censers sanction “clean rooms”; once per delve, dispel one ambient miasma or ward-rot effect at cost of +1 Obligation to local abbey-knights.
- **Maelstraesus:** Under-Market stalls tithe to the Great Ledger; cash a *Market Dominance* tick to flip one price band in your favor for a scene, then mark a 4-segment *Karmic Debt* with assessors.

Survival-Horror Procedures (Use Often)

- **Headcount & Flamecount:** At scene start in confinement, ask “Who breathes, what burns?” If headcount+flamecount exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start a 4-segment *Stale Air* clock.
- **Two Bells to Safety:** Any time the fiction stalls underground, ring two nearby bells (authority vs. sanctum). PCs must pick one to heed; ignoring both increases the next hazard’s Cap by +1 (stone holds grudges).
- **Measure or Mistrust:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB this scene; failing to present one imposes –1 die on haggling or passage until appeased.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Breath Favor (minor resource):** Earned by donating wick/oil or assisting air wardens. Spend to downgrade one underground hazard outcome or to bypass a lamplighter queue.
- **Stamps & Seals:**
 - *Mason-Marked:* Doors to worksites open; smugglers avoid you (harder to buy contraband, easier to cross safely).
 - *Edge-Trusted:* Prospectors share fresh maps—first detour per leg is free; officials eye you as opportunists (first civic audience DV +1).
 - *Assessor-Clean:* Under-markets honor your assay; rivals spread rumors—add a trailing *Audit* clock if you score a windfall.

Boss Archetypes in Aeler

Systemic / Economic / Conspiracy

- **Under-Market Syndic (Cartel/Measure Fraud):** Price-fixes breath, wick, and water; wields corrupt assay marks to starve rivals. *Win by exposing forged measures or seizing the Assay Chain.*
- **True Mason Provost (Infrastructure Coup):** Locks cities behind “safety closures,” weaponizes detours and permits. *Win by forcing a public bell-code audit or breaking the Permit Clock.*
- **Edgewalker Concessionaire (Route Monopolist):** Controls salvage and short-cuts, posts hazards to strangle traffic. *Win by proving route tampering or opening a sanctioned bypass.*
- **Bell-Code Inquisitor (Silent Coup):** Rewrites chimes to shift jurisdiction; arrests arrive as echoes. *Win by restoring canonical bell charts or capturing the Chime Key.*

Survival Horror (Environment as Boss)

- **White Flood (Water/Pressure):** Thaw-swollen river through the halls; phases at *trickle* → *surge* → *roar*. *Win by sluicework, sacrificial breach, or riding the flood.*
- **Bad Air (Miasma/Invisible):** Candles gutter blue; thoughts slow; corridors choose the slowest. *Win by air discipline, filter rites, or opening a lung-shaft.*
- **Hungry Stone (Creep/Collapse):** Settling cracks hunt noise and heat; shudders on every miss. *Win by shoring, silence, and rerouting stress through old ribs.*
- **Lamp Famine (Darkness/Isolation):** Wicks fail in sequence; last lights lure you deeper. *Win by restoring the Lamplighter’s Mile or kindling a saint-wick.*

Undead / Fallen Kingdom / Eldritch / Demonic

- **Crown-Lich of the Crypt (Undead Sovereign):** Keeps ancient offices; binds petitioners with oaths to the dead. *Win by repealing a mortmain writ or severing the Oath-Chain.*
- **Echo-King in the Deep (Eldritch Memory):** A throne of voices; answers every argument you will ever make. *Win by changing the Measure (new precedent) or striking the Silent Note.*
- **Seal-Devil (Demonic Contract):** Lives in locks and signatures; eats exceptions. *Win by offering a flawless counter-seal or starving it of loopholes.*
- **The Hollow Architect (Fallen Works):** A ghost-guilder rebuilding the empire wrong on purpose. *Win by unkeying the master plan or collapsing the false load paths.*

Boss Mechanics Notes

- **Air & Light Tracks:** In confined scenes, track *Headcount*, *Flamecount*. If *Headcount* + *Flamecount* exceeds posted limit, add a free “Thin Air” SB and start **Stale Air** [4]. Each tick imposes −1 die to exertion until vented.
- **Jurisdiction Clocks:** Many bosses run a **Bell-Code Conflict** [4] or **Seal Dispute** [6]. On fill, the boss gains *Authority Surge*: increase their social DV by +1 and seize initiative once.
- **Lair Actions (choose 2–3):**
 - *Collapse Probe:* Mark “Settling Crack”; nearest noisy PC tests PROWESS or risk *Pin/Separate*.
 - *Breath Tax:* Reduce *Flamecount* by 1; next exertion in zone costs Fatigue 1 on a miss.
 - *Blackout/Glare:* Snuff or flare lamps; impose Disorient (−1 die) until a *Lamplighter Action* restores balance.
 - *Bell Overrule:* Swap which faction’s law applies; social actions vs. boss gain +1 DV this round.
 - *White Flood Surge:* Advance environment clock; force MOVE/WRECK or be *Separated*.
- **Phase Triggers:** Environment bosses phase when *Air* hits 2/4, *Water* hits 3/6, or *Light* hits 0; Conspiracy bosses phase when *Audit* or *Permit* clocks fill.
- **Truth & Measure:** Producing a certified rod/weight cancels the first commerce/jurisdiction SB each phase; forging one gives the boss 1 SB and a free *Expose Fraud* reaction.
- **Crowd Pressure:** In under-markets, add **Panic Crowd** [4]; each tick adds +1 DV to precise actions (shoot, pick, ritual) unless calmed with bell-code or coin.
- **Fear Hooks (optional):** *Bad Air* inflicts FEAR vs. suffocation; *Echo-King* inflicts FEAR vs. isolation; *Seal-Devil* inflicts FEAR vs. helplessness. On Fail: mark *Shaken*; on Critical Fail: drop a resource (*lamp*, *key*, *breath*).

Chapter 10

The Mistlands

Bells, Salt, and Breath. A protectorate of the Aeler, the Mistlands belong to fog and bells. Every levee hums with ward-notes, every ferry takes salt as tithe, and every shadow is measured against the Direwood's endless breath. The people here live by the weight of salt, the echo of bells, and the hope that their names will not be spoken by the mists.

10.1 Mistlands — “Bells, Salt, and Breath”

Legate of Mists (Elite): “The bells here do more than mark time – they weave the very fabric of reality, keeping the mist at bay and the dead in their proper places. Each chime is a thread in the pattern that holds the world together.”

Salt-Monk (Commoner): “Salt don't just preserve the fish – it holds back the things that shouldn't walk. Every grain blessed is a prayer, and every prayer keeps the mist from remembering your name.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Mistlands lie north of the Aelerian mountains, where the Aberderrin Sea laps against reed-fens and drowned shores. It is a Protectorate of the Aeler, but their iron passes only hold the southern roads—the land itself belongs to fog and bells. Every levee hums with ward-notes, every ferry takes salt as tithe, and every shadow is measured against the Direwood's endless breath. The people here live by the weight of salt, the echo of bells, and the hope that their names will not be spoken by the mists.

What you notice first: The constant, distant chime of bells—never quite in sync. The taste of salt on your lips even inland. The way everyone holds their breath when crossing a bridge.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a voice that calls your name from the fog. The mist collects names, and once it has yours, the ferryman will always know where to find you.

Regional Mood: Bells and Breath

Here, breath is currency and silence a sin. Every exhalation is counted by the ward-bells, and every stolen inhalation feeds something that should not be. The Aeler Protectorate maintains order with

ledgers and patrols, but the real law is older: salt lines drawn at dusk, iron nails hammered into threshold posts, and the unspoken knowledge that the ninth bell must never ring. The Mistlands do not forgive forgetfulness. The mist has a long memory, and it shares its grudges freely.

Starting Location: A Bell-Line levee veiled in fog, where bell-ropes sway though no wind stirs, and each ring tastes like a heartbeat. A Ferryman demands a name as toll. When the party hesitates, a Bell-Warden steps forward. “The Ninth Bell rings tonight. Will you answer—or flee?”

(Fen/Levee/Bell-line) Reed-fen causey with chalked ward-runes on every milestone; Bell-Line levee with iron posts and eight bells per span.

Spades — Places

2. **Reed-Fen Causey** — Chalked ward-runes on every milestone; safe path through the mist. *Step only on the chalked stones. The mud between has no bottom.*
3. **Bell-Line Levee** — Iron posts, eight bells per span; one bracket empty, one note forbidden. *The empty bracket is for the bell that never rings. The rope is still there.*
4. **Ghost-Ferry Slip** — Rope crosses black water; fares paid in salt and whispered names. *The ferryman never blinks. Some say he traded his eyelids for the right to collect.*
5. **Pall Watch-Tower** — Piles above mire; mirrors face west to the Direwood’s breath. *The mirrors are silvered on both sides. The wardens watch their own reflections as much as the trees.*
6. **Mist-Chapel** — Stilted planks; votive lanterns gutter under damp rafters. *The icon has no face. Worshippers say it lost its features to the fog, one by one.*
7. **Dead-Cut Canal** — Old imperial ditch; patrolled by eel boats and law. *The eels have eyes like men. Fishermen throw back any that blink.*
8. **Drowned Copse** — Root-tangles clutch tide like old hands; bones in the bark. *The trees were planted on a mass grave. They grew twisted, hungry.*
9. **Fogmill Ridge** — Wind vanes vanish into cloud; gears hiss like prayers to fog. *The miller grinds salt, not grain. His customers pay in breath, not coin.*
10. **Salt-Pan Terraces** — Patched with peat; ward-salt dries under nets, watched by monks. *The monks chant without ceasing. If they stop, the salt spoils—and so does the warding.*
- J **Fort-Stair** — Stacked timber and stone; flags swallowed by mist, guards by routine. *The flags are changed daily. The ones that vanish are never spoken of again.*
- Q **Witchlight Bridge** — Over black runnel; ninth plank “counted” but unseen. *The missing plank is there—you just can’t see it. Step where it should be, or don’t step at all.*
- K **High-Mist Pass** — Through Aelerians; cairns ringed in iron nails, bells in the stones. *Each cairn holds a bell that rang once at the death of a warden. They ring again when mist takes another.*
- A **Weeping Gate** — Western palisade facing Direwood; bells wired to bones of trees. *The gate weeps sap that smells of iron and old grief. Wardens collect it in silver cups.*

(Warden/Ferryman/Aeler) Bell-warden whose ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts; oath-ferryman collecting fares in salt and names.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Reed-Cutter** — Peat-black hands, precise opinion on fog; knows every safe path. *She cuts reeds in a pattern—one snip, two snips, then a pause for the ninth.*
3. **Salt-Monk** — Blesses pans, keeps ward-measure honest; salt as both shield and vow. *His tongue is white with salt. He speaks only in blessings or silence.*
4. **Bell-Warden** — Ringbook decides which notes keep which ghosts at bay. *She refuses to write down the ninth note. It lives only in her memory—and that memory is fading.*
5. **Oath-Ferryman** — Fares in salt and names; remembers both, collects both. *His left hand is always gloved. Underneath, the names are carved into his palm.*
6. **Lantern Acolyte** — Trims wicks and arguments; light as law in the mist. *He carries a bell on his belt. It rings once for each lie he hears.*
7. **Mist-Pilot** — Linn refugee; ghosts ships through reed-lace—if paid in breath. *She never speaks above a whisper. Her voice is currency, and she spends it carefully.*
8. **Protectorate Clerk** — Aeler oilskin ledgers, narrow smile; law in triplicate. *His stamp is a bell. He presses it twice—once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
9. **Shroud-Diver** — Harvests tokens from drowned fields before dawn’s false light. *He wears a bell around his ankle. If it rings, he’s stayed too long.*
10. **Direwood Refugee** — Cold breath, colder stories; knows what the trees whisper. *She carved out her own tongue. The trees still speak through her—in a voice not her own.*
- J **Fog-Knight** — Cavalry rides levee crowns by bellcode; mist as their steed. *Their horses have no shadows. Some say they traded them for fog-sight.*
- Q **Legate of Mists** — Aeler governor; equal parts mercy and decree, bells at their command. *She carries a bell that has never been rung. It will ring once, at the end of her reign.*
- K **Lord Warden** — Local strong hand sworn to Legate’s seal; law walks the fens. *He lost an eye to a wight. He wears a bell in the socket.*
- A **Mist-Seer** — Bargains breath for answers; candles shorten when she speaks. *She has no shadow. The mist took it as a down payment.*

(Undead/Weather/Law) Ground-mist lifts off fen and eats tracks by the yard; witchlights try to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets you.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Lifts from fen; eats tracks by the yard, names by the breath. *Your footfalls vanish behind you. The mist is following, not rising.*
3. **Witchlight Count** — Trying to count you; step wrong and bridge forgets your path. *The lights flicker in a pattern—two short, two long. They’re signaling someone.*
4. **Ward-Salt Short** — Pans go green; bells ring, nothing answers from the other side. *The salt is grey, not white. Someone cut it with grave dust.*
5. **Wrong Bell** — Cracked note opens a door the Legate can’t close; mist takes the gap. *The bell’s clapper is a finger bone. The original owner wants it back.*
6. **Linn Raid** — Slips reed-maze; hearths douse, horns travel on the fog. *The raiders wear bells on their belts—stolen from the last village.*

7. **Direwood Moan** — At dusk; Weeping Gate ropes go taut by themselves. *The moan has words. You don't want to understand them.*
8. **Valewood Wind** — Crosses Aberderrin; voices sweet, landmarks false. *The wind smells of honey and rot. Do not follow it.*
9. **Bell-Line Failure** — Levee breaks silence; wraith steps across like it owns the road. *The wraith carries a lantern. The light is blue—the color of drowned breath.*
10. **Marsh-Quake** — Sod heaves, dyke slumps; proofs and bodies sink together. *The ground exhales. Your name rises from it like smoke.*
- J **Protectorate Interdiction** — All ferries sealed “until review”; routes dry up. *The seals are stamped with a bell. The wax is mixed with bone ash.*
- Q **Rite-Purge** — Inspectors call local customs heresy; tempers at a boil. *The inspectors carry blank ledgers. They fill them with names of the accused.*
- K **General Alarm** — Pall horns sound; every lantern becomes law, every shadow suspect. *The horns are made from the tusks of a sea beast. The beast's ghost is angry.*
- A **Tide-Mist** — Rolls from Aberderrin; spirits ride the white and won't be named. *The spirits have no faces—only the faces of the drowned.*

(Pass/Seal/Token) Ward-salt allotment draws safe circle once; ferry token crosses named black runnel regardless of curfew.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Ward-Salt** — Pure measure draws safe circle once; mist parts, briefly. *The salt is warm. It knows it will be used.*
3. **Ferry Token** — Cross named black runnel regardless of curfew or tide. *The token is a knuckle bone. The ferryman accepts it without comment.*
4. **Bell-Key** — Unlock and set one bell on the Line to your note; change the song. *The key is a tuning fork. Strike it once to claim your note.*
5. **Lantern Writ** — Lawful travel at night along levee crown with escort. *The writ is written on dried bladder. It crinkles when you lie.*
6. **Exorcist's Seal** — Stamped clause downgrades “haunt” to “nuisance.” *The seal is a bell without a clapper. It's silent, like the wraiths it binds.*
7. **Codeleaf** — Today's mirror and horn sequences; fog cannot hide what you know. *The leaf is soaked in brine. Read it before it dries.*
8. **Protectorate Mark** — Priority rations and rope from Fort-Stair stores. *The mark is a brand. It smokes when you show it.*
9. **Wraith-Indemnity** — Legal immunity for actions taken under apparition threat. *The indemnity is signed in salt water. It will dissolve if you misuse it.*
10. **Bone-Field License** — Salvage rights at drowned hamlet (with witnesses). *The license is a map drawn on a shroud. Follow the stitch marks.*
- J **Refuge-Right** — Move a named household through Gate unchallenged; breath as passport. *The right is a bell-rope. Tie it to your belt. Nonna will ask.*
- Q **Legate's Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; bells ring your decree. *The Legate's ear is a silver bell. Speak into it once.*

- K Warden’s Commission** — Raise levee guards; local doors open, purses too. *The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the fens answer.*
- A Pall Indulgence** — Temporary exception to ward law, spoken and sealed by bell. *The indulgence is a single bell-note, held in a jar. Break the jar to release it.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/seals/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **breath and boundary**—bells answering across water, salt that won’t dry, voices returning late.

Additional Features

- **Breath-Toll:** Many claim the mist remembers every breath. Travelers hold breath crossing bridges, fearing the mist will count them wrong.
- **Salt as Promise:** A handful of salt is more than warding—it is a vow. Spill it on plank or stone to swear safety; break that vow, and invite the Direwood’s claim.
- **The Ninth Bell:** Legends say a ninth bell once rang on the Line. The note is not in any ringbook; no warden speaks of it. Some nights, though, it rings—and gates open where none should be.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice on a drained pan. They ask no payment—but they take names. A renegade Sister hides among the salt-monks, trying to unbind her Hollowed.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Bell-Lines are Saikou Ira’s preferred containment for Class II Anchors. The Weeping Gate is a Class IV Poltergeist waiting to happen.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** The fog sometimes carries silver coins. Pick one up, and you can breathe underwater—but the mist will know your face forever.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Mistlands psions are called “Breath-Readers.” They taste your last exhalation and know how you will die. The Protectorate employs them as investigators—and disposes of those who see too clearly.
- **The Ninth:** In any Mistlands scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the mist’s attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count.

Mistlands Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Fog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a bridge. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty.
- **Hold the Ninth Breath:** Cross a threshold while holding your breath. Cancel *Witchlight Count* or take –1 die on your next action (your choice).
- **Name to the Salt:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into a salt pan. Gain +1 Effect against undead for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Legate.

Patronage & Power

In the Mistlands, power flows through ritual, warding, and the careful balance between the living and the dead. The Aeler Protectorate maintains nominal control through military presence and legal frameworks, but true authority lies with those who understand the bells, the salt, and the breath of the land itself. Local wardens, salt-monks, and bell-keepers hold sway over daily life, while the Legate of the Mists mediates between imperial law and ancient custom.

For the GM: Patronage in the Mistlands revolves around protection—from mist, from spirits, from the encroaching forest. Rewards often take the form of tokens, seals, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater security. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (salt, bells, lanterns) that can be challenged, depleted, or voided.
- Let rival factions issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the levees, ferries, and watchtowers as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of the old ways determines success.

In the Mistlands, your safety is your standing, and your standing depends on who remembers your name.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or fog-knights**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **spirits or patrol boats**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Protectorate forces or local warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift or bell failure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **wraith, raiding party, or inspector** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fog-knights, spirits, or Aeler forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.

- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **bell-line fails/ward broken/mist claims name**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Legate, Lord Warden, or Mist-Seer** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **mist thickens/bells ring/forest breathes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Mistlands (Bells & Breath):** Bells ring without cause, breath forms visible words, mirrors reflect wrong faces.
- **Mistlands (Salt & Warding):** Salt refuses to dry, ward-runes bleed color, protection tokens crack.
- **Mistlands (Direwood Threat):** Trees whisper your name, roots shift position, forest breath grows stronger.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Ninth Bell Ringer (Direwood herald)** — *Phases:* Lost Names → Broken Lines → Open Gate. *Cracks:* restore a ringbook; trade a breath; rehang a forbidden bell with copper nails.
- **Queen of Counting Lights (fae arbiter)** — *Phases:* Courteous Tithes → Geas-Market → Ledger of Leaves. *Cracks:* return stolen way-marks; speak said and meant; gild the iron.
- **Reed-Wolf Captain (Linn raider)** — *Phases:* Smoke Signals → Night Oars → Thing Verdict. *Cracks:* name a feud-token; win a skald-duel; force harbor-truce under bell and banner.

Chapter 11

Ykrul

Wolf Standards, Winter Camps. The Ykrul ride the Violet Steppe where horizon meets sky and law rides in saddlebags. Hosts gather by the thousand yet break into fragments at a word. Their banners are wolves' teeth, their treaties braided strings, their memory longer than the rivers that cross their roads. Midh-Akhaz, the war-camp turned city, marks the eastern edge of their grazing grounds.

11.1 Ykrul (Orc) — “Wolf Standards, Winter Camps”

Khatun of Ring (Elite): “The steppe remembers every oath sworn beneath its endless sky, and the wolf-standards carry the honor of clans that have outlasted empires. To lead here is to keep the old ways sharp as winter steel.”

Herd-Scout (Commoner): “The horses know the weather before it comes, and the wolves know the thoughts in a man's heart. Best speak true and ride steady – the steppe don't forgive lies or clumsy hands on the reins. Kon'reh says: the straight road is a lie. The wise follow the bent twig.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Ykrul ride the endless steppe where horizon meets sky and law rides in saddlebags. Their sacred geometry is the Kon'reh—not a written code, but a living calculus of routes, exits, and blood-price. Every crossing has a number, every ford a weight, every feud an angle that can be measured in horse-lengths and heartbeats. Hosts gather by the thousand, yet break into fragments at a word; one night you share their fires, the next they test your bonds. Their banners are wolves' teeth, their treaties braided strings, their memory longer than the rivers that cross their roads. The old folk still recite the Thirty-Six Sayings of Kon'reh, but the wisest know that the thirty-seventh saying is the one you learn alone, on a night when the stars blink out and the wolf doesn't howl.

What you notice first: The smell of horse sweat and woodsmoke. The way every rider counts hoofbeats under their breath. The silence when a stranger approaches the fire.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ride between two wolves at dusk. The space between them is the Kon'reh's blind angle—a route with no exit, a debt with no payment.

Regional Mood: The Geometry of the Steppe

Here, the horizon is not a line—it is a question. The Ykrul measure distance in oaths, not miles. A camp is a graph of favors owed and honor satisfied. A feud is an unsolved equation: blood in, blood out, with interest compounded by winter. The Khagan rules not by force but by the Kon'reh—the sacred geometry that governs every crossing, every treaty, every duel. Break the angle, and the steppe itself will turn against you. Keep it, and even enemies will share their salt. The Ykrul do not build monuments. They build relationships, and each one is a stone in an invisible cairn that stretches from the Dolmis to the Aberderrin.

Starting Location: A winter camp on the steppe edge, banners snapping in frost-bright wind as the Khagan's fires burn in the east. A Khatun of Ring offers a clay cup of salted tea. "The Khagan's kin ride from the salt pan. Kon'reh says the straight road is a lie. You came by the bent path—the wolf knows you. Speak your errand before the wind changes."

(Steppe Road/Winter Ring/Ford) Wolf Road milepost of stacked stones with wind whining through eye-holes; winter camp ring with felt tents in horseshoe facing wind.

Spades — Places

2. **Wolf Milepost** — Stacked stones; wind whines through eye-holes. *Each stone is a treaty. Remove one, and the wind names you oath-breaker.*
3. **Remount Station** — Low corral with stamped snow and tether-posts. *The tether-posts are carved with the names of dead horses. The living ones remember.*
4. **Birch Windbreak** — Above black-earth tracks; old offerings in the bark. *The offerings are strips of wool. Each strip is a prayer for safe crossing.*
5. **Salt Pan** — Crusted white; hoof-prints like stars across the void. *The pan has a name: "The Khagan's Mirror." Look into it, and you see your debts.*
6. **Reed Ford** — River braids; poles mark yesterday's safe line. *The poles shift in the night. The river's Kon'reh changes with the moon.*
7. **Trading Palisade** — Way-post with wolf-skull pennons snapping. *The skulls face outward. They watch for liars and bad weights.*
8. **Winter Camp** — Felt tents in a horseshoe facing the wind. *The open end is for guests. The closed end is for the ancestors.*
9. **Kurgan Field** — Low barrows; horse-bones bead the grass like prayer beads. *The bones were placed by a bone-singer. Each bead is a name.*
10. **Watch Kopje** — Lonely tor with signal fire-scar; the eye of the steppe. *The fire-scar is from a signal that saved a host. The smoke still smells of hope.*
- J **Pontoon Crossing** — Laced hides creak; the current speaks fast and hungry. *The hides are from horses that died crossing. Their ghosts still pull.*
- Q **Council Hollow** — Standards planted; the ground tamped like a war-drum. *The standards have ears. Speak a treason here, and every clan will know by dawn.*
- K **Khagan's Station** — Broad ger on a timber platform; guards in silence. *The guards never blink. They are paid in salt and secrets.*
- A **Sky Steppe** — Open, wind like a voice; tracks keep pace beside you. *The tracks are not yours. They belong to the ancestors who ride with you.*

(Host/Envoy/Rider) Herd-scout with three ponies and six opinions; camp-mother who chooses where fires live.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Herd-Scout** — Three ponies and six opinions; the horizon as a map. *He can read a trail by the way the grass bends. He can read a lie by the way a rider sits.*
 3. **Camp-Mother** — Chooses where fires live; hospitality is law. *She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.*
 4. **Banner Youth** — Minding the wolves’ tooth standard; pride as duty. *The standard is older than his grandmother’s grandmother. He will die before it falls.*
 5. **Salt-Broker** — Weighs promises like grain; trade as precision. *Her scales are honest—except when they aren’t. The difference is a prayer.*
 6. **Remount Keeper** — String-master with a book of brands; horses as currency. *His book is written in hoof-prints. He can read a horse’s soul.*
 7. **Bone-Singer** — Knows the kurgans’ proper names; death as memory. *She sings the names of the dead each dawn. The dead sing back.*
 8. **Road-Judge** — Tümen scribe with seals and a patient ear. *His seals are from three empires. He uses whichever one is still valid.*
 9. **Noyan Envoy** — Silver paiza, iron smile; diplomacy as a blade. *His paiza was a gift from a Khagan who is now dead. He does not mention that.*
 10. **Host Captain** — The tent-wall is a map; strategy in every fold. *He can see a battle in the way smoke rises. He is usually right.*
- J **Falcon Courier** — Leather gauntlets, answers sooner than asked. *The falcon is a sleeper agent. It belongs to a different clan. The courier doesn’t know.*
- Q **Khatun of Ring** — Keeper of camp-law and hostage strings. *Her strings are braided from the hair of hostages. She knows each strand’s owner.*
- K **Khagan’s Kin** — A nephew or niece sent to bind a foedus with a look. *They have never lost a negotiation. They have never needed to speak.*
- A **Sky-Speaker** — Shaman of storms; shortcuts owe them a price. *They can call lightning—or call it off. The price is always a story.*

(Law/Weather/Feud) White squall with dry snow, lost horizons; rasputitsa turning the road to porridge; a feud spark from a name spoken wrong.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **White Squall** — Dry snow, lost horizons; navigation by instinct alone. *The snow tastes of iron. Someone is bleeding nearby.*
3. **Rasputitsa** — The road becomes porridge; wheels are lies on the earth. *The mud has a smell—old blood and older lies.*
4. **Remount Sickness** — A cough in the string; swaps get awkward, trust thinner. *The cough is a curse. The horses know who cast it.*
5. **Salt Shortage** — Meat spoils; tempers thin like winter air. *The salt was cut with grave dust. Someone wanted the winter to be hard.*

6. **Hostage Call** — Protocol invoked; someone must sit in the tent. *The tent has no floor. The hostage can see the earth beneath—and the bones.*
7. **Feud Spark** — A name spoken wrong reopens an old cut; blood remembers. *The name was spelled correctly. The insult was in the pause before it.*
8. **Grassfire** — Runs with the wind faster than horses; escape as a prayer. *The fire has a face. It is the face of a Khagan who burned a village.*
9. **Foedus Recall** — Treaty terms re-read; your papers disagree. *The treaty was written on both sides. The other side used a different ink.*
10. **River Break** — Ice goes; ferries don't; crossing becomes a gamble. *The ice is still thick in the middle. The edges are lying.*
- J **Raid Shadow** — Another banner follows at a patient distance. *They are not attacking. They are waiting for you to make a mistake.*
- Q **Kurultai Call** — Camps converge; travel becomes politics. *The kurultai has a list of grievances. Your name is near the top.*
- K **Wolf Muster** — A levy raised; every road a checkpoint, every rider a judge. *The muster horn is a wolf's skull. It sounds like a dying man.*
- A **Sky Omen** — Three suns, or none; routes rewrite themselves. *The omen is a wedge of cranes flying north in winter. The sky is wrong.*

(Pass/Remount/Truce) Camp token for one night's lawful fire and fodder; salt allotment from a named store without quarrel.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Camp Token** — One night's lawful fire and fodder; hospitality as a right. *The token is a horsehair braid. Burn it to claim your fire.*
3. **Salt Allotment** — Draw from a named store without quarrel. *The allotment is a salt-cake. Break it in half to share.*
4. **Ford-Right** — Cross a named braid at lawful depth. *The right is a pole. Plant it in the river, and the ford will hold—once.*
5. **Remount Chit** — Swap two tired mounts for fresh. *The chit is a horse's tooth. The remount keeper will not smile when you present it.*
6. **Escort Braid** — Two riders see you through a bad stretch. *The braid is woven from the riders' own hair. They will die before they cut it.*
7. **Safe-Hostage** — Place or take token-kin for a truce. *The hostage is a child. The child is patient.*
8. **Paiza Tablet** — Priority on the Wolf Road and at posts. *The tablet is bronze. It is warm when your reputation is good.*
9. **Foedus Seal** — A treaty clause that trumps petty order. *The seal is a wolf's head. Press it into wax, and the steppe listens.*
10. **Market-Green** — Trade under a banner; weapons sheathed. *The banner is a green field. No blood may be spilled beneath it.*
- J **Standard Guard** — Travel under wolf-tooth; raiders defer. *The standard is a wolf's tooth on a pole. Raiders will bow—or die.*

- Q Ring Audience** — The Khatun hears you alone; precedent sticks. *The audience is held at midnight. The fire is the only witness.*
- K Khagan’s Writ** — Doors open, mouths close across the steppe. *The writ is a sheet of hammered silver. It bends, but it does not break.*
- A Sky’s Exception** — Once, the weather ignores you (storm, whiteout, dust). *The exception is a single breath. Use it well.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/remounts/truces) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **steppe and sky** motifs—wind that speaks, horses that remember, treaties that bind across generations.

Additional Features

Hostage Strings. Every oath is secured with a **hostage string**—a token kin, retainer, or sworn ally left in the other camp. If the deal is broken, the hostage’s fate becomes the story’s next beat. (Mechanically: create a 4-segment *Hostage* clock; on breach, the clock becomes a countdown to vengeance.)

Steppe Law. Travelers are bound by **steppe law**: hospitality lasts three nights, insults last three generations. The Keeper may demand 1 SB when either law is broken.

Sky Omens. When the sky shows strange signs—mock-suns, green fire, thunder without storm—the steppe itself speaks. Once per scene, players may treat an omen as a *Diamond*, shifting Position without a roll. The GM may bank 1 SB for future weather complications.

Kon’reh: The Sacred Geometry. Ykrul elders settle disputes not by shouting but by drawing a **board** in the dirt—roads, exits, and concessions become lines. A successful *Wits + Kon’reh* (or Lore) roll creates a *Seasonal Concession String* at a ford, harbor, or pass. On a miss, the **Market Moot** [4] clock advances as factions argue over the pattern.

The Thirty-Seven Sayings of Kon’reh (Excerpts)

The Ykrul teach strategy not in manuals but in proverbs—each a single line of play. The colors refer to pieces in the Kon’reh game: **Salt** (white, camp guardians), **Iron** (grey, heavy riders), **Blood** (red, raiders), **Storm** (blue, war-chiefs), **Grass** (green, scouts). A few of the most quoted sayings:

Let the river freeze before you cross. — Do not rush from your home apex. Let the opponent make the first shape; your bridge will be built upon their impatience.

Borrow a corridor to trap a king. — When the enemy carves a path toward your sanctum, let it deepen while you count his exits. Then seal the mouth behind him.

Loot a burning house. — Strike only when the enemy is committed elsewhere. A Storm in the Cross is a house with one door.

Hide your dagger behind a smile. — Telegraph a threat on one flank. When they shift their lattice to meet it, strike on the silent file they were forced to weaken.

The reed bends, the oak breaks. — Yield to overwhelming force, but do not break; preserve your core to fight another day.

A distant banner casts no shadow. — A threat far away is no threat at all; control the center, and distant kings will kneel or starve.

The guest who outstays his welcome steals the host's peace. — Allow no force, however small, to remain within your lines uncontrolled.

Count exits, not victims. — The greatest strategy is not listed, for it is the breath before all breaths. Before you move, count the number of ways your foe can flee. If the number is greater than zero, you have not yet won.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice near the salt pans. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the herders, trying to untie her cord from a Ykrul blood-debt.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The kurgans are Class II Anchor sites—the spirits of old Khagans bound by unfinished wergild. Saikou Ira would carry a bag of salt in each hand here.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the salt-brokers. Take it, and your store never runs dry—but the coin will reappear in the salt pan at every new moon.
- **The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire:** Ykrul psions are called “Weather-Readers.” They taste the future in the wind. Road-judges employ two—and have never trusted a verdict they didn't hear from the sky.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ykrul camp, the ninth cup poured at a feast is for the ancestors. The wise pour eight and leave the ninth as a pause.

Ykrul Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Salt to the Wind:** Toss a pinch into the air before a long ride. Ignore the first *White Squall* penalty.
- **Knot the String:** Tie a single knot in a hostage cord. Cancel *Feud Spark* or take –1 die on your next oath (your choice).
- **Name to the Kurgan:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into a horse's ear. Gain +1 Effect when raiding their clan this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Bone-Singer.

Patronage & Power

In Ykrul society, power flows through the careful management of hospitality, the binding of oaths with hostages, and the ability to navigate the complex web of tribal relationships. The Khagan maintains authority through the loyalty of noyans and the respect of khatuns, while local leaders wield influence through their control of resources like salt, remounts, and safe passage. The true power lies with those who understand the ancient customs and can maintain the delicate balance between hospitality and honor.

For the GM: Patronage in Ykrul society revolves around hospitality, hostage exchanges, and the ability to command respect from hosts and courts. Rewards often take the form of tokens, treaties, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the Kon’reh:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, braids, standards) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Use the *Bowl and Board* procedure for disputes—first fairness (Bowl), then geometry (Board), then a seasonal concession.
- Let rival hosts issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.

In Ykrul society, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you ride as guest or ghost.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **camp guards** or **herd-scouts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **riders** or **wolf-standards**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **bone-singers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable weather**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Camp-mother** or **road-judge** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift** or **ford closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival host** or **raiding party** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wolf-riders**, **host members**, or **noyan guards** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.

- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **feud declared/treaty broken/omen appears**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Khatun, Khagan's Kin, or Sky-Speaker** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **storm hits/camps converge/river breaks**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ykrul (Steppe Law):** Hospitality expires without warning, insults carry forward through generations, treaties are reinterpreted mid-conversation.
- **Ykrul (Horse Culture):** Mounts refuse to obey, remount stations are empty, riding skills become unreliable.
- **Ykrul (Sky Omens):** Weather patterns shift unpredictably, celestial signs contradict each other, navigation becomes mystical.

Ykrul — Wolf Standards

Starting Location: A winter camp on the steppe edge, banners snapping in frost-bright wind as the Khagan's fires burn in the east.

"In Ykrul, the wind carries the pack's oath, and mercy is left to thaw."

In... A Winter Camp, a Khatun of Ring offers salt-allotment. "The Khagan's kin ride," she says. "And the sky omens bleed east."

Regional Motifs Hearth-ring law, wolf totems, bone-lot omens, steppe trials.

Whispers to Offer "Eat salt without being invited," "Ride a sacred mount," "Claim an omen for yourself."

External Clocks Community: "Ring Divided"; Threat: "Kin Raid"; Anchor: "Salt Peace."

Complications Wolves refuse shadow; lots stain hands; riders circle dreams.

Anchors at Risk A hearth-mother; a winter store.

Escalation Beat The sky opens a red seam.

Relief Share salt and story; win the trial without blood; send the omen back with a song.

Mobility & Logistics (Fast Play)

Host Posture (declare before a leg) Pick *two*: **Speed, Screen, Spare Mounts, Scavenge**. Each grants +1 Position on one relevant action this leg; neglected ones are -1 Position if tested.

String Roles Name: **Point-Scout, Remount-Keeper, Salt-Warden, Banner-Talker**. Each can cover one miss per leg by marking a minor cost (a pony, salt, time, favor).

Remount Rhythm A rider with **2+ fresh mounts** may *double-march* once per day (mark *Fatigue 1*). Spending a *Remount Chit* clears that *Fatigue* for one rider and negates *Pursuit* once.

Steppe Weather & Ground (d12)

d12	State	Tags / Effects
1	Blue Vault	+Survey; long sight cuts both ways
2	River Breath	Low fog in hollows; -Speed off-road, +Stealth in reeds
3	Dry Snow	Tracks show, hooves sure; cold bites fingers (gear tests -1)
4	Black Ice	Fords become coin flips; carts lie
5	Rasputitsa	Earth to porridge; wheels -2 Effect; sleds +1
6	Dust Devil	Ranged beyond close is risky; eyes sting
7	North Knife	Wind shear; tents fight, words don't carry
8	Heat Shimmer	Mirage bands; long shots misjudge distance
9	Grassfire Smell	Any spark can turn Club into <i>Elemental Front</i>
10	Star-Hard Night	Camp mends are brittle; sleep restores less
11	Wolf Moon	Animals keen; omens cheap but sticky (see Sky Omens)
12	Three Suns	Omen; GM may bank 1 SB to twist weather next leg

Hostage Strings (Custom Subsystem)

Make a String Name the **token-kin** (page, foster, sworn hand) and knot a *Hostage String*. While the string stands:

- Parties treat each other as *Camp Token* guests on sight.
- First betrayal converts one **Diamond** to *Safe-Hostage* instead of breaking truce.

Cut a String When a string is cut (ritual, flight, or knife), trigger one:

- **Blood Call:** Immediate *Feud Spark*.
- **Salt Call:** A council demands wergild in *Salt Allotment* or stock.
- **Road Call:** The *Road-Judge* schedules a trial-ride (race, bout, riddle).

Camp & Council Procedures

Three-Fire Camp Ykrul hospitality lasts **three nights**. Each night, pick one boon and accept one cost:

- **Boons:** mend tack; swap mounts (-1 Fatigue for one rider); hear a *Bone-Song* (ask one question of the dead of this land); secure *Escort Braid*.
- **Costs:** sit watch; tell a true story; gift salt or steel; accept a minor geas (don't ride east at dawn, etc.).

Council Hollow (kurultai mini-game) Frame three *beats*: **Salt, String, Standard**. Win two to carry the vote.

- **Salt (economy):** Offer stores, routes, or *Market-Green*. Failure births *Salt Shortage*.
- **String (kin):** Place/accept *Safe-Hostage*, cite adoption, foster, marriage-feast.
- **Standard (prestige):** Gift wolf-tooth, recount raid, pledge riders; victory grants *Standard Guard*.

Trade & Tribute

Steppe Staples

- **Salt & Fat:** Currency and winter life. Spend *Salt Allotment* to cancel *Supply Strain* for a week or bribe a *Remount Keeper*.
- **Horses:** Money that moves. A *Remount Chit* equals one serious favor at *Trading Palisade*.
- **Stories:** Soft currency. A true raid-tale can stand in for coin once per council.

Palisade Rates (d6) 1 fair trade 2 short scales 3 hidden tithe 4 hostage asked 5 rival claim 6 market under *Market-Green* today

Feud & Reconciliation

What starts a Feud (d6) 1 insult at fire 2 horse swapped sick 3 string cut 4 grave ridden over 5 name spoken wrong 6 salt denied

How to end it (pick two)

- **Wergild:** Pay in *Salt Allotment*, mounts, or labor.
- **Trial-Ride:** Outrun, outshoot, or outstand the winter. Winner declares terms.
- **Bone-Song:** Ask the kurgan; accept the dead's price.
- **Marriage-Fire:** Feast that binds hosts; costs you a *Safe-Hostage*.

Hit-and-Run Warfare (Three Beats)

1. **Screen:** Scouts contest vision with dust, snow, reeds. Win: choose engagement range; loss: ambushed (Position -1).
2. **Shock:** Loose, loose, loose—then crash. Spend *Standard Guard* to ignore first rout check or *Escort Braid* to peel a unit free.
3. **Break-off:** A clean ride beats a clean kill. Spend *Remount Chit* or test under *Rasputitsa/Black Ice*.

On a miss at any beat, mark *Stragglers*: you leave someone or something behind.

Sky Omens (d8)

1 wolves howl at noon 2 aurora like braids 3 three suns 4 moon with teeth 5 thunder without storm 6 stars “follow” riders 7 dust column stands still 8 hawk falls asleep mid-flight

Reading an omen creates a one-scene tag you can cash as a **Diamond** or force as a **Club**; doing so changes someone’s mind about the omen’s meaning.

Clocks & Escalations

Ring Divided (6) 1–2: Standards drift. 3–4: Camps split routes. 5: A string is cut. 6: Winter ring becomes two hosts.

Wolf Road Tightens (6) 1–2: Posts check brands. 3–4: Papers challenged. 5: *Foedus Recall*. 6: *Wolf Muster*—road becomes checkpoints.

Salt Peace (4) 1: Stores counted publicly. 2–3: Sharing enforced by Khatun. 4: Feast; next *Salt Shortage* is ignored once.

NPC Templates

Camp-Mother (Fire-Chosen) *Wants*: No famine this winter. *Leverage*: Can bless/deny *Camp Token*. *Cost*: Speak a hard truth by second firelight.

Road-Judge (Seal-Patient) *Wants*: A treaty rewritten for sense. *Leverage*: Upgrades one paper to *Paiza Tablet* for a day. *Cost*: Accept that their ruling stands—even if it cuts you.

Remount Keeper (String-Math) *Wants*: A rival’s book of brands. *Leverage*: Two fresh ponies at dawn. *Cost*: Return them better than you found them—or owe a foal.

Names, Bands, & Titles

Titles *Khagan* (over-king), *Khatun* (camp-law), *Noyan* (banner-lord), *Tümen-Scribe* (road-judge), *String-Mother* (hostage keeper).

Band Styles (d4) 1 Red Reeds (river tacticians) 2 Salt Wolves (logistics first) 3 Moon Spurs (night riders) 4 Bone Chorus (kurgan loyalists)

Given Names (mix two) Bor-, Tem-, Sar-, Uru-, Kha-, Asha-, Yen-, Dor- + -tai, -mur, -gan, -khi, -jin, -mar, -sai, -lok

Cross-Regional Conversions

- **Vilikari**: *Paiza Tablet* reads as *Purple Warrant* at *Milefort*; tick **Two-Law** once.
- **Vhasia**: *Standard Guard* counts as *Safe-Conduct* on *King’s High Road* until next *Chevauchée*.
- **Theona**: *Safe-Hostage* may stand in for a *Bride-Charter* (peace for a season) if bells ring eight and not nine.
- **Valewood**: A *Bone-Song* grants a one-scene *Dew-Mirror* if sung at a *Barrow Field* grove.

Encounter Seeds

- **Kurgan Debt:** A *Bone-Singer* bids you return a stolen bridle; success earns *Ring Audience*, delay wakes an *Echo-Legionary*... from under grass.
- **Salt for Strings:** The *Trading Palisade* is out of salt; only your *Market-Green* can open stores—if you place a *Safe-Hostage*.
- **Wolf on the Road:** A wolf with a torn banner in its mouth paces your camp; follow to a lost *Pontoon Crossing* before the river breaks.

Designer Hooks (Optional)

Banner-Deeds Record one daring ride as a *Deed*. Once per session, flash the Deed to step Position up on rally/negotiation with riders who honor that style.

Storm-Borrow Offer a steel gift to the *Sky-Speaker* during *Three Suns*; on a hit, bank *Sky's Exception*. On a miss, weather splits—half on you, half on your friends.

Steppe Homage Sites & Lairs (drop-in hexes)

- **Wolf-Teeth Palisade** — Trading yard ringed with jawbone pickets; scales hang from rawhide cords that only balance for fair deals.
- **Sky-Drum Kopje** — Wind hollows beat like hooves at dusk; a buried drum answers only to the Khagan's cadence.
- **Salt-Wheel Flats** — Crust pans etched with cart runes; turning the sun-bleached axle calls remounts from mirage distance.
- **Nine-Kurgan String** — Barrows aligned to winter stars; a bone-singer can “pluck” omens like notes to sway a council.
- **Frost-Bitten Forum** — Utaran milestone half-swallowed by loess; steppe law carved *over* imperial script decides ford rights.
- **Sable-Creek Corrals** — Hides stretch on willow frames; a ghost ledger tallies every foal traded, never wrong, never kind.
- **Black Hoof Monastery** — Rock hermitage with hoofprints set in basalt; novices test honesty against a hoof-bell that rings for lies.
- **Storm-Bone Causeway** — Vertebrae bridge across a reed-gorge; crossing at a gallop wakes the bones to judge riders' courage.

Steppe Bestiary (palette)

- **Steppe Manticores** — Lionine torsos, porcupine tails of bone quills. *Signs:* quills in fence-posts; ponies refuse to drink. *Hook:* play a raid-song backward; they circle to listen.
- **Dust Hulks** — Wind-packed silhouettes that rise from dunes. *Signs:* dunes “breathe”; grit sifts upward. *Hook:* spill water on their shadow; they settle for a watch.
- **Bone Kites** — Carrion birds with rune-etched pinions. *Signs:* spiral flights over kurgans. *Hook:* offer a name-stake (twig with hair) to barter silence.
- **Frost Wargs** — Blue-pelt wolves that steam cold. *Signs:* rime on tracks; breath that crackles. *Hook:* warm milk poured on ice buys one unchallenged crossing.

- **Reed Stalkers** — Long-necked marsh hunters, gait like stilts. *Signs*: pole-pocks where no ferryman walks. *Hook*: carry reeds in your mouth; they read it as truce.
- **Salt Screamers** — Pale eels in dry pans; voices like flutes. *Signs*: fissures crusted with salt frost. *Hook*: scatter ash; they coil to sing and forget to bite.

Terrain Stock (d20 quick)

- 1 Wolf milepost with fresh red thread; someone retied the law.
- 2 Reed ford poles lying on bank; current whispers a different depth.
- 3 Fallen standard tooth used as a chopping block; grooves still warm.
- 4 Circle of pony skulls facing east; one blinks when the wind shifts.
- 5 Snow trench with cudgel steps; no prints leave it.
- 6 Copper salt-scale hung from a birch; pans balance only under oath.
- 7 Hoof-bells threaded on hair; ringing calls riders—or storms.
- 8 Abandoned paiza shard wedged in a milestone; edges bite skin.
- 9 Kurgan capstone chalked with a name misspelled; feud waiting.
- 10 Flint knapper’s tarp half-buried; a perfect arrowhead points north.
- 11 Blue-fledged signal arrow stuck in frost; message in the vane.
- 12 Camp-sweep marks: three rings—last night was a council.
- 13 Wheel rut frozen like glass; a face looks up from inside.
- 14 Salt-brined jerky hanging from a tripod; untouched by birds.
- 15 River ice singing in thirds; ferryman’s pole wedged under.
- 16 Pony hobble-rope knotted in hostage-string pattern.
- 17 Cold forge dug into loess; tools wrapped in wolfskin.
- 18 Child’s braid-bead dropped in snow; still warm to the tongue.
- 19 Thorn-tether scratched with clan brands; two over-scratched.
- 20 Bone flute lodged in a cairn; playing it summons a road-judge.

Lair Seeds (d12 one-page rides)

1. **Ger of Echoes** — Empty felt walls repeat anything uttered in the Khagan’s voice once per night.
2. **Salt-Pit Shrine** — Rope winch to brine caverns; offerings are tears and horsehair.
3. **Remount Vault** — Subterranean stables under reed mats; mounts won’t leave without a tale.
4. **Kite-Maker’s Bluff** — Bone kites pinned on racks; their shadows scout for raiders.
5. **Storm-Rider’s Stone** — Pillar that hums to hooves; racing round it sets weather wagers.
6. **Frozen Court** — Ice dais in a dry riverbed; law held here counts triple until thaw.
7. **Banner Grave** — Flags planted like trees; each knows the battle it died in.
8. **String-Mother’s Yard** — Web of hostage cords; cutting one opens a secret but starts a feud.
9. **Fire-Under-Snow** — Warm vent where foals winter; spirits ask for salt-song.
10. **Quiet Palisade** — Trading post where voices fail; deals done in gesture and cut meat.
11. **Ashen Trident** — Three lightning-split birches; tie a braid to choose a road’s luck.

12. **Grey Ger** — Moves at night; inside, a camp-mother tests your hospitality the other way around.

Boss Hooks (banner crowns)

- **The String-Mother of Nine Kurgans** — Matriarch who holds more hostage cords than any noyan; her nod ties wars into weddings.
- **The Dust Prince** — Raider who rides the wind's lee, never seen from the front; offers *Escort Braid* for a secret standard.
- **Storm-Singer Urum** — Sky-speaker who sells weather on credit; his bills come due during *Wolf Moon*.
- **The Ledger Khan** — Road-judge turned warlord; his seals move hosts like abacus beads.

Relics & Finds (d10)

- 1 Wolf-tooth standard tip; planted, it demands silence for parley.
- 2 Bronze paiza half; merchants honor it as full once—then talk.
- 3 Salt-needle that points to the nearest brine store.
- 4 Frost-bitten stirrup: mount that wears it ignores ice once.
- 5 Braid-bead of hostage glass; melts when a string is cut nearby.
- 6 River-depth rod carved with safe counts for three fords.
- 7 Iron hoof-bell that rings for liars at council.
- 8 Bone-lot cup; roll it to name which feud clause applies.
- 9 Wind-wrung scarf; pass it round to share breath in a white squall.
- 10 Wolf-road tablet scrap; reads as *Foedus Seal* to one clerk.

Complication Twists (d8)

1. *White Squall* reveals a remount vault's smoke hole; entering angers reed stalkers.
2. *Rasputitsa* exposes kurgan stones; riding around them starts a name-claim.
3. *Feud Spark* was staged by a salt-broker; paying in *Salt Allotment* unmasks them.
4. *Hostage Call* is for a *Safe-Hostage* you already carry—by another name.
5. *Grassfire* runs uphill toward a council hollow; smoke votes before riders do.
6. *Foedus Recall* cites a river you crossed yesterday—now it flows the other way.
7. *Raid Shadow* is your own tracks, mirrored by sky omens; choose which you admit.
8. *Kurultai Call* stacks councils; words spoken in one bind you in the other.

Mini-Procedures (quick steppe play)

Wolf Road Etiquette When you arrive at a *Trading Palisade* or *Remount Station*, choose one and pay its price:

- **Salt First:** Spend *Salt Allotment* to gain *Market-Green* for the scene.
- **String First:** Place a *Safe-Hostage* to bank +1 Position in all parleys here.
- **Story First:** Recount a true raid; cancel one *Paper vs Spear* style objection.

Trial-Ride (three beats) *Mark, Loose, Hold.* Win two beats (navigation shot, archery shot, nerve test) to claim verdict; each failed beat marks 1 Fatigue or 1 honor cost (your pick).

Adventure Seeds

- **Strings in Winter** — Three hostage cords go missing from the String-Mother’s yard; each is tied to a different treaty you need.
- **Storm on Credit** — Storm-Singer Urum sells you *Sky’s Exception*; someone else already owes the same storm.
- **Ledger of the Road** — A road-judge’s seal-book was buried in a dust hulk; opening it retitles the Wolf Mileposts for a day.
- **Feast of Two Standards** — A kurultai invites rival banners to dine under one ring; the first to eat salt owes the first blood—or peace.

11.2 Midh Ahkaz — “The Violet Gate”

Khatun of the Ring (Ykrul Elder): “The wind carries names, not ledgers. But here, in the shadow of the Oasis Compact, both trade and oaths change hands. Do not mistake our patience for weakness. The grass remembers every hoof that crossed it.”

Vilikari Factor (Night Market Regular): “Ecktoria calls it uncivilized. We call it unbeatable. No tariffs, no seals, no questions. Coin talks. The rest walks.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Midh Ahkaz is not a city of stone—it is a city of felt, iron, and shifting grass. A day’s ride north of the Ecktorian border, it squats on the edge of the Violet Steppe like a patient wolf. Here, the Ykrul, Vilikari, Ostrihari (their eastern kin from the grassy fringes of this same prairie), and a dozen other peoples gather to trade, haggle, and settle grudges. The air smells of horse sweat, cedar smoke, and the faint copper tang of blood money.

The city has no walls. Instead, rings of tents and caravanserais spiral outward from the central Counting House. At dawn, the grass—tall enough to hide a horse—is cut back. At dusk, the perimeter fires are lit. The colour of the steppe comes from the violet hue of mature grass seeds, which ripen in waves across the prairie. The Ecktorian emissaries call it “the Brink.” Locals call it home.

What you notice first: The constant low drumming of hooves. The way every merchant has a scale on their table. The braids in every horseman’s mane—each knot a story, a debt, a promise.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse the guest-cup. The first pour is courtesy. The second is negotiation. The third is a blood-price unspoken.

Western Steppe vs. Eastern Steppe (GM Sidebar)

The Ykrul divide their world into two great grass seas:

Western Steppe (Violet Prairie): Rolling, fertile, forgiving. The grass grows tall enough to hide a crouched rider, but the land is laced with caravanserais, seasonal wells, and the smoke of permanent camps. This is where Midh Ahkaz sits—the soft underbelly of the steppe, where trade happens and clans winter. The violet seed-heads give the prairie its name.

Eastern Steppe (True Steppe): Vast, dry, harsh. Shared with the Kuvani horse-clans, it stretches east of the Valewood. Grass is shorter, winds are colder, and a rider can see a day's ride in every direction. The Ostrihari who appear in Midh Ahkaz are from the eastern fringes of the *Western Steppe*—they speak with a harder accent, braid their horses' tails differently, and carry bows of horn and sinew, not wood.

Why this matters: A Ykrul from the Eastern Steppe might find Midh Ahkaz almost claustrophobic. A trader from the Violet Prairie might feel lost in the east. Use the contrast to create tension between clans or to flavour foreign visitors.

Regional Mood: Wind, Grass, and Contract

Midh Ahkaz thrives on movement. Caravans arrive from every direction: Ykrul horse-tribes from the deep steppe, Ostrihari mercenaries from the eastern fringes, Vilikari traders from the river towns, and the occasional bold Ektorian factor with a silver tongue and a hidden dagger. The city's "law" is the Oasis Compact—a shifting web of seasonal rights, grazing permits, and arbitration courts held under open sky. Disputes are settled by the Bowl (fairness) then the Board (geometry). A broken promise can cost a herd. A kept oath can buy a ford for a generation.

Starting Location: The Violet Bazaar, a sprawling market of felt tents and chalk circles, where horse traders shout over the jingle of brass bridles. A Vilikari merchant with oiled braids hands you a sealed letter. "The Coin-Weigh Tribunal suspects a counterfeit seal. Find the forger before the Grass Moon, or the contract on your head becomes public."

(Ring/Well/Cairn) The Oasis Well where water shares are drawn; counting pebbles placed on stone ledges; the distant smoke of a Steppe Ranger campfire.

Spades — Places

2. **Violet Bazaar** — Felt stalls, chalk circles, horse traders and rumor merchants. *The chalk circles are for disputes. Step inside and speak truth—or pay in grass.*
3. **Coin-Weigh Tribunal** — Tariff court under a canvas dome; scales of bronze and iron. *The scales were blessed by a dying Sky-Speaker. They tip even when the wind is still.*
4. **Oasis Well** — Stone-rimmed pool, token-keeper with a leather bag of water rights. *Each token is a carved pebble. Lose it, and your herd drinks dust.*
5. **Steppe Ranger Camp** — Tent line on the eastern edge; trackers, scouts, feud mediators. *The rangers wear wolf tails. They do not smile—they wait.*
6. **Caravan Rings** — Concentric circles of wagon shelters; fires lit inward, watch posts on ox carts. *The inner ring is for sworn allies. Outsiders sleep in the second ring, coin in hand.*

7. **Sky-Speaker’s Cairn** — Stone heap atop a low hill; wind-knot ropes and bones. *The shaman leaves offerings of horsehair. The wind carries his prayers to Kuva.*
8. **Dust Market** — No-questions auction at the city’s edge; stolen goods, cursed relics, bad memories. *The auctioneer wears a hooded mask. No one knows his face. No one has asked twice.*
9. **Silver Stall Stable** — Remount station; horses for hire, gossip for free, blood for more. *The stable master has three fingers on his left hand. He lost the others in a bet over a mare.*
10. **Grass Ring** — Ritual dueling ground; mourners and bookies share benches. *The grass grows back faster after a duel. The dead fertilize the peace.*
- J **Foreign Quarter** — Ecktorian, Vhasian, and Viterran merchants in permanent felt mansions. *The Ecktorian envoy winters here. He has not left in five years.*
- Q **Khatun’s Ring** — Largest tent, carpeted with woven battle scenes; the old chieftain’s seat. *The carpet is made of enemy cloaks. Each sash is a surrendered banner.*
- K **Under-Arcades** — Earthen tunnels below the bazaar; root-walled, bone-dusted. *The walls are packed with bone dust and old burrows. The dead whisper route tips.*
- A **Iron Well** — Ancient Aeler shaft, now used for vengeance contracts and whispered names. *The water tastes of rust and memory. Those who drink never lie again—or never speak.*

(Horse/Tally/Token) Sky-Speaker’s apprentice with a drum and a dream; Ostrihari arms-master selling short bows; Ykrul elder counting braids.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Horse-Braid Apprentice** — Young Ykrul with a head full of trade routes and a knot diary. *She ties a new braid for every paying passenger. Her hair is a map of debts.*
3. **Ostrihari Arms-Master** — Selling short bows and longer grudges; fights for coin. *He names each bow after a dead rival. The bows never miss.*
4. **Coin-Weigh Clerk** — Ink-stained, patient, scales in her eyes; never lies, never forgives. *She records weights in blood. A single drop seals a verdict.*
5. **Vilikari Factor** — Braided, oiled, quick with a smile and a second ledger. *His caravan has three names. Only the real one buys safe passage.*
6. **Steppe Ranger** — Tracker with a wolf-tail cloak and a debt to the Sky-Speaker. *He never draws his bow unless watched. Hunger is his real weapon.*
7. **Tokan (Ykrul Scout)** — Mute, sharp-eyed, always smelling the wind; her ears miss nothing. *She signs with her knuckles. Three taps is “danger.” One tap is “run.”*
8. **Ecktoria Emissary** — Proud, wax-sealed, fuming at the “primitive” customs. *He carries a copy of Imperial Code that he has never opened. The flies love his ink.*
9. **Sky-Speaker’s Shadow** — Elder’s quiet apprentice; listens more than the wind. *She can name every clan’s sky-omen. She cannot name her own origin.*
10. **Knot-Keeper (Tulkani)** — Counts caravan promises with a rope of nine strands. *Each knot is a contract. Untie one and the deal dissolves.*
- J **Dust Market Auctioneer** — Hooded, genderless voice; knows the weight of every sin. *The hammer is a thigh bone. The block is a skull altar from the Direwood.*
- Q **Khatun of the Ring** — Grey-haired, one-eyed, still deadly at sixty; speaks for seven clans. *She lost her eye to a Linn raider. She killed him with his own hook.*

- K **Kuva's Voice (Wandering Priest)** — Weathered, ash-marked, offers omen readings for grass. *He prays to the sky by throwing bones. The bones never lie—they just mislead.*
- A **Iron Well Keeper (Vengeance Broker)** — Mute, scarred, accepts names written in ash. *A drink from the well costs a memory. A death costs a fortune.*

(Drought/Feud/Blight) Dry well cuts water rations; blood-price feud spills into the bazaar; locust swarm from the east grains.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Dry Well Ration** — Water shares halved; prices spike, tempers fray. *The token-keeper has a list. The list has a knife mark beside your name.*
 3. **Blood-Price Feud** — A killing in the Horse Ring; kinsmen demand wergild in coin or flesh. *The victim's tribe drums the death rhythm. Every beat is a deadline.*
 4. **Locust Swarm** — Grass blackens; caravans stranded, fodder worthless. *The swarm leaves a sticky residue. It smells of burnt honey and dread.*
 5. **Counterfeit Coins** — Light silver floods the Dust Market; Oasis Compact inquiry. *The counterfeit coins are warm. The real ones are cold. Touch quickly.*
 6. **Grass Fire** — Wind-whipped flame from the east; evacuations, scorched trade paths. *The smoke spells a name. Yours. Or your debtor's. Hard to tell.*
 7. **Horse Sickness** — Contagion at the Silver Stall Stable; quarantines, lost mounts. *The sick horses dream. Their screams sound like your last argument.*
 8. **Khatun's Illness** — Old chieftain fading; succession knives out. *Her death will split seven clans. The Sword Oath lasts one year.*
 9. **Census Raid** — Ecktorian legion patrol “just visiting”; tensions high, bribes higher. *The patrol leader wears a mask of imperial wax. Pull it off and see a dead man's face.*
 10. **Sky-Omen (Red Wind)** — Dust storm from the Ashaani desert; all navigation Desperate. *The dust tastes of iron and old blood. Breathe it and dream of falling.*
- J **Oath Challenge** — A Kon'reh master demands geometry arbitration; your bond is the stake. *The board is a painted skull. The pieces are horse teeth.*
- Q **Tariff Strike** — Coin-Weigh clerks refuse to audit; trade freezes, tempers explode. *The clerks chant a counting rhyme. Stop them before they reach nine.*
- K **Duel for Rights** — Two clans claim the same well; witnesses needed to prove water share. *The duel is fought with blunt spears. First blood wins the well. Both bleed.*
- A **Kuva's Vengeance** — The sky itself turns; hail, lightning, and a voice from the clouds. *The voice names a sinner. Your name. The hail has teeth.*

(Writ/Token/Pass) Grass Right for one season of grazing; Oath-Bead to compel a Kon'reh master's arbitration.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Grass Right** — One season of grazing on a named meadow; herders pay you tribute. *The right is a branded stick. Burn it to end the lease—or renew.*

3. **Oath-Bead** — A single knot of horsehair; compels a Kon’reh master to arbitrate your dispute. *The bead grows warm when the master speaks truth. Cold when he lies.*
4. **Water Share** — Priority access to a well during drought; token from the Oasis Compact. *The token is a polished pebble. Drop it in the well to claim your draw.*
5. **Steppe Ranger Favor** — One dangerous tracking job resolved off-screen. *The ranger marks your name on his tent pole. He never forgets a favor.*
6. **Vilikari Voucher** — No-questions cargo space on three caravans; smuggle as you will. *The voucher is a strip of oiled leather. The factor’s scent guides the mules.*
7. **Census Waiver** — Ecktorian patrol leaves you alone for one crossing; paper shield. *The waiver is stamped with a bear. The bear’s eyes follow you.*
8. **Khatun’s Whistle** — Summon a small warband once (Cap 3) for a single scene. *The whistle is a hollow horse tooth. Blow it and the grass shivers.*
9. **Sky-Speaker’s Omen** — One weather forecast that cannot fail; plan your escape. *The omen is a bone thrown into fire. Read the cracks—carefully.*
10. **Silver Stall Chit** — One free remount exchange; never be horseless. *The chit is a brass hoof. Present it and the stable master nods once.*
- J **Black Ledger Entry** — A written promise from a rival, witnessed by three camp elders. *The entry is written in ash on felt. Wash it and the vow dissolves.*
- Q **Dust Market Cut** — A share of the auctioneer’s commission for a season; wealth in sin. *The cut is paid in mismatched coins. Spend them fast before they curse you.*
- K **Blood-Price Bond** — A criminal clan owes you a life; they will kill once for you or die trying. *The bond is a braid of enemy hair. Cut it to call the debt.*
- A **Seal of the Oasis Compact** — Casting vote on any water right dispute. Once. *The seal is a bronze well with a snake curled at the bottom. Turn it and the water booms.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are narrative permits (grazing rights, oaths, witnesses) that shift Position rather than demand a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **grass and wind** motifs—shifting alliances, debts that ride with the seasons, the sky as witness.
- The violet seed-heads of the steppe are a recurring omen: when they glow under moonlight, a spirit walks; when they shed, a caravan will be late.

Additional Features

- **Kon’reh Arbitration:** Disputes are settled on a board painted on hide. Winners gain seasonal rights. Losers pay in grass or labor.
- **Grass Omens:** The steppe flickers violet when rain is near; when the seed-heads droop at noon, a blood-feud approaches.
- **Khatun’s Braid:** The chieftain’s hair holds the memory of every oath she swore. Cutting a braid voids a promise.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a “free soup” wagon near the Dust Market. They ask no coin—but they measure your shadow.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Saikou Ira once tracked a ghoul to the Under-Arcades. He left a silver mirror in the wall. It still shows the ghoul’s face.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A broken Kon’reh board at the Iron Well is said to compel truth. Players who touch it gain +1 die to resist lies—but mark 1 Obligation to Malachai.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Midh Ahkaz psions are called “Wind-Readers.” They sense lies by the tremor in grass. The Khatun employs two; they never speak to each other.
- **The Ninth:** In any Midh Ahkaz scene, the ninth horse table in the Violet Bazaar sells nothing but bad advice. Spend a Boon to reroll a failed negotiation—but the advice may haunt you.

Midh Ahkaz Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Hoofprint Pour:** Pour a cup of water into the first hoofprint of a new horse. Ignore the first *Horse Sickness* penalty.
- **Braid the Knot:** Tie a strand of mane hair around your wrist. Cancel *Counterfeit Coin* or take –1 die on your next Charisma roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Grass:** Whisper a debtor’s name into the wind at noon. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from them this scene, but mark *Obligation* to a Sky-Speaker.

Patronage & Power in Midh Ahkaz

In Midh Ahkaz, power flows through horseflesh, water rights, and the geometry of oaths. The Khatun rules by consensus, but the true authority rests with the Oasis Compact—a loose council of clan elders, Vilikari factors, and Steppe Rangers who interpret the Wind Law.

For the GM – Actionable Examples:

- A player who wins a Kon’reh match earns a **Grass Right** (Diamond). That right could be contested by a rival clan the very next session—forcing a rematch or a chase across the prairie.
- A **Water Share** token is stolen. The thief leaves a violet seed-head as a signature. Tracking them leads to a seasonal camp where debt is repaid not in coin but in stories.
- The Khatun’s illness (Club) is not natural. A Vilikari factor (Heart) knows the poisoner’s name but demands a **Black Ledger Entry** (J Diamond) in exchange—a dangerous witness the player must then protect.

These hooks turn the generator entries into immediate playable situations.

Thematic SB Spend Table (Midh Ahkaz)

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw attention from **Steppe Rangers** or **Coin-Weigh** clerks.
- **Noise:** The sound carries across the grass; a **rival clan’s scout** overhears.
- **Trace:** Hoofprints, broken grass, or losing an arrow marks your path.
- **Delay:** A water ration takes longer; a horse tires without rest.

- **Grass Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Border riders** converge on your position; a horn sounds.
- **Position Lost:** You lose high ground/cover/the wind due to a **grass fire or horse stampede**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **Vengeance broker, Ostrihari sell-sword, or clan champion** arrives.
- **Gear Trouble:** A **bridle breaks, bow string snaps, waterskin leaks**.
- **Oath Hearsay:** A false rumor about your oath reaches the wrong ear.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **horsemen, blood-price hunters, or Dust Market thugs** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A horse goes lame, seal ring cracks, trade ledger burns.
- **Major Twist:** The situation changes – **Khatun dies, well runs dry, duel interrupted by grass fire**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** (e.g., Blinded by dust, Parched).

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A **hidden pit, poisoned water share, or false oath** activates.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Khatun’s warband, Ecktorian patrol, Sky-Speaker** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes – **grass fire sweeps through, dust storm blinds, night falls without warning**.
- **Patron Omen:** A **bolide, strange animal, or wind that speaks your name** appears.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn – **the real forger was your ally; the water right was a trap**.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Midh Ahkaz (Grass & Trade):** Grass catches fire, horses spook at shadows, bargains settled with a knife on the table, violet seed-heads floating in the wind.
- **Midh Ahkaz (Oath & Sky):** Clouds spell forgotten names, wind carries false testimony, a duel’s outcome shifts with the sun, a violet dusk signals a spirit.
- **Midh Ahkaz (Horse & Bow):** An arrow splits in flight, a horse refuses a rider, a bowstring sings a dying clansman’s tune, a braid comes undone at the wrong moment.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Counting Circle (cursed scale bound to the Oasis)** — *Phases:* Fair Auditing → Retroactive Drought → Naming of Debtors. *Cracks:* burn a counterfeit token in the Oasis well; settle a seven-clan water debt; let a Sky-Speaker rebell the scale.
- **Grass Reaver (vengeful horse-lord, half-legend)** — *Phases:* Hoof Drum → Ghost Herd → Blood-Price Ride. *Cracks:* confess a broken oath at his cairn; return a stolen foal; outrun him on a borrowed horse.

- **Coin-Weigh Wraith (greedy merchant who sold his shadow)** — *Phases*: Tally of the Lost → Ledger Chain → Crack the Seal. *Cracks*: pay a forgotten wergild; break his contract with a witnessed error; let the Iron Well drink his name.

Chapter 12

Vilikari

Laurels & Longhouses. The Vilikari straddle the frontier between empire and steppe. They are tillers and treaty-makers who balance survival between Ecktoria, the Ykrul, and the Black Banners. Their halls are longhouses raised over ruined forums; their laws carved on both oak and marble; their loyalties braided like the braids of their war-maidens' hair.

12.1 Vilikari — “Laurels & Longhouses”

Federate King (Elite): “We are the bridge between empire and wilderness, the marriage of law and custom. Our strength lies not in choosing one path but in walking both with equal surety.”

Hearth-Mother (Commoner): “The old ways and new laws both have their place at our table. Serve the right mead to the right guest, honor the proper customs, and you’ll find we’re better hosts than most kings.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Vilikari are the agrarian peoples straddling the frontiers between Ecktoria and Kahfagia, tillers and treaty-makers who balance survival between empire, steppe, and sea. In a three-way war with the Ykrul and the Black Banners, they live by the cleverness of their diplomacy, the leverage of their markets, and the shifting weight of oaths. Their halls are longhouses raised over ruined forums; their laws carved on both oak and marble; their loyalties braided like the braids of their war-maidens' hair.

What you notice first: The smell of woodsmoke and old parchment. The way everyone speaks two languages at once—switching mid-sentence. The longhouse roofs that use broken imperial tiles as shingles.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never invoke only one law. The mallus (oak-ring) and the basilica (marble bench) must both be honored. Choose one, and the other will find you.

Regional Mood: Laurels and Longhouses

Here, the past is not a ruin—it is a landlord. The old Utaran forums still echo with the footsteps of legionaries, but now those columns hold longhouse roofs. The Vilikari do not choose between

empire and tribe; they marry them, awkwardly, imperfectly, and with frequent arguments. Their kings wear both a laurel wreath and a wolf-tail cloak. Their courts meet twice: once under the oak for blood-price, once on the marble bench for statute. No verdict is final until both have spoken. In the marches, a man can be a barbarian in the morning and a citizen by noon—if he knows which door to knock on.

Starting Location: A longhouse quarter tucked into an old forum. Laurel garlands hang from broken columns. Smoke from a dozen hearths curls under cracked marble arches. A Hearth-Mother offers a cup of small beer and a piece of oatcake. “The Foedus Stone cracks,” she says. “The steppe listens. Which law will you speak when the Ykrul envoy arrives—oak or marble?”

(**March Town/Villa-Fort/Old Road**) Longhouse Quarter tucked into old forum with hearth-smoke under broken eaves; Milefort XVII with earth bank and faded eagle.

Spades — Places

2. **Longhouse Quarter** — Tucked into old forum; hearth-smoke under broken eaves. *The forum’s marble floor is worn smooth by dancing feet, not sandals.*
3. **Milefort XVII** — Earth bank, stone gate; faded eagle over fresh knotwork. *The eagle’s stone wings were reglued after a lightning strike. It still leans left.*
4. **Stone Ford** — Plank-palings and a customs table at knee-height; border as bureaucracy. *The ford changes hands every season. The customs table never moves.*
5. **Villa Granary** — Barracks with a tile roof; spear racks where olives once slept. *The olive press still works. The pressers are now armorers.*
6. **Twin Court** — Mallus ring beneath an oak, basilica bench across the lane. *The oak and the bench are the same distance from the well. The well is neutral ground.*
7. **Blackwood Road** — Milestones re-carved in runes and Latin both. *The runes say “safe passage.” The Latin says “toll payable twice.”*
8. **Staple Market** — Frontier where Ykrul horses meet Vili-kari iron. *The horse-traders and smiths speak a pidgin of gestures and grudges.*
9. **Burial Field** — Ship-ridge mounds beside tiled mausolea, both garlanded. *The mausolea have fresh offerings. The ancestors are not picky.*
10. **Repaired Bridge** — An arch of stone, a Vili-kari trestle stitched on; past and present joined. *The trestle creaks in Vili-kari, the stone groans in Utaran. They argue at midnight.*
- J **Hill Amphitheater** — A lord’s hall raised in an old arena’s curve; power in architecture. *The lord’s throne is a gladiator’s chair. He does not know who last sat in it.*
- Q **New Raivon** — March capital; grid-streets colliding with wandering lanes. *The grid was laid by a surveyor who never came back. The lanes are older.*
- K **Dux’s Palace** — Purple awnings, wolf-hides, law tablets on the wall. *The tablets list every treaty broken. The wolf-hides are from the treaty-breakers.*
- A **Foedus Stone** — At a crossroads; every treaty carved, every hand weighed. *The stone has grown. Each new treaty adds a finger of granite.*

(**Federate/Mixed Court/Diaspora**) Hearth-Mother with guest-cup and wergild chest key; Shield-Brother with oaths braided into hair.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hearth-Mother** — Guest-cup and wergild chest key; hospitality as power. *She has never lost a quarrel. Her voice is soft, her memory longer than the Foedus Stone.*
 3. **Shield-Brother** — Comitatus oaths braided into hair; loyalty as bond. *His braids are his ledger. Each knot is a debt paid—or owed.*
 4. **March Notary** — Utaran-trained; writes three scripts without blinking. *His left hand writes Latin, his right writes runes. He signs with his foot.*
 5. **Horse-Reeve** — Rations pasture between plows and warbands. *He measures grass in fistfuls. The Ykrul respect his arithmetic.*
 6. **Ykrul Envoy** — Riding under safe-conduct; speaks debts in proverbs. *He never carries a weapon. His tongue is sharp enough.*
 7. **Old Legionary** — Drill-master for Vilikari levies; Utar in muscle memory. *He still marks time in paces. The recruits call him “Grandfather Eagle.”*
 8. **Ecktorial Factor** — Vilikari blood, Ecktorial coin; flows where the ledger points. *His coat has two collars—one for each loyalty. He wears whichever is warmer.*
 9. **Kahfagian Pilot** — Lantern-law chit and clan tattoo; sea-law on land. *He navigates by stars and tariffs. Both change with the season.*
 10. **Marcher-Lord** — Iron-nail crown, Vilikari law in pocket; a frontier king. *His crown was a plowshare. He reversed the curse.*
- J **War-Maiden** — Oath-braid names the dead and the owed; vengeance as memory. *Her braid is longer than her sword. Both have drawn blood.*
- Q **Queen of Marches** — Consort-regent; smiles like precedent. *She married the Federate King for peace. She kept the kingdom for herself.*
- K **Federate King** — Rex-Dux sworn to forms, sung by his own. *He has three thrones—oak, marble, and saddle. He uses whichever is not being argued over.*
- A **Elder of Elders** — Thing-council speaker; a nod can unmake a clan. *He speaks once a year. The rest of the time, he listens—and remembers.*

(**Two Laws/Two Fronts/Old Grudges**) Annona late—grain stipend misses the comitatus; tempers quicken; jurisdiction tangle of mallus vs. basilica writ.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Annona Late** — Grain stipend misses the comitatus; tempers quicken like flint. *The granary is full. The keys are in the wrong vault. Someone is waiting for the price to rise.*
3. **Law Tangle** — Mallus verdict vs. basilica writ—whose seal bites? *The oak judge and the marble judge are cousins. They send each other holiday cards.*
4. **Raid Rumor** — A Ykrul boyar; levies panic the plowlands. *The boyar is a ghost—or a tax collector. The farmers don’t wait to find out.*
5. **Bridge Levy** — Doubled for road-works; caravans balk, fists rise. *The road-works are a ditch. The ditch fills every spring.*
6. **Succession Feud** — Wolf-brother claim vs. purple-charter heir. *The wolf-brother has a better sword. The purple-charter has a better notary.*

7. **Foedus Recall** — A prefecture resettlement is “requested”; homes bristle. *The prefecture’s map is forty years old. It shows a village that drowned.*
8. **Coin Talk** — Debasement; pay demanded in salt, hides, or hostages. *The salt is from a disputed pan. The hides are from cattle that were never born.*
9. **Grave Offense** — A burial field disturbed; omens ride with the news. *The ancestors are angry. They have a list. Your name may be on it.*
10. **Port Clash** — Lantern-law vs. street-law; confiscations bloom. *The lanterns were moved last night. The old safe channel is now a reef.*
- J **Warband Flip** — Colors change mid-pay; hostage protocol snaps shut. *The hostages are eating well. Their captors are not.*
- Q **Restoration Preacher** — Stirs crowds against the “barbarian king in purple.” *The preacher’s license was signed by a dead abbot. The seal is still warm.*
- K **General Levy** — The march is closed; markets freeze into spears. *The levy notice is posted in three languages. None of them are local.*
- A **Spring Melt** — Eats the Wolf Road; proofs, plans, and armies bog. *The road is a memory. The ruts fill with water—and older things.*

(Charter/Right/Escort) Foedus Renewal Seal for settlement and stipends; Mallus Bench-Right to hold court under the oak.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Foedus Seal** — Settlement and stipends confirmed for a season. *The seal is a bronze wolf’s head. It warms when the treaty holds—and cools when it doesn’t.*
3. **Mallus Right** — Hold court under the oak and be obeyed. *The oak is older than the kingdom. Its roots have seen more verdicts than the throne.*
4. **Stipend Arrears** — Paid in salt and grain; portable, persuasive. *The salt is grey. The grain is from last harvest. Both are worth more than coin.*
5. **Utaran Patent** — Citizenship-style privilege; doors open, bows deepen. *The patent is a worn scrap of vellum. It has been folded and refolded for a century.*
6. **Stall-Right** — Customs favor on a frontier market line. *The stall is a painted plank. Plant it, and the tax man will pretend not to see you.*
7. **Hostage Treaty** — Exchange fosters; grudges trade for leverage. *The hostages are children. Their parents are patient.*
8. **Remount Allotment** — Fresh horses from royal paddocks, no questions. *The horses are from the king’s own herd. They know the roads better than you.*
9. **Wergild Table** — Recognized by both codes; vengeance priced and paid. *The table is a slate slab. The prices are carved deep—and often recarved.*
10. **Bridge Farm** — Imperial for a season; funds and friends accrue. *The bridge toll is a copper a head. The bridge keeper is your new best friend.*
- J **Purple Warrant** — Wear the stripe; officials defer on sight. *The stripe is a sash. It was a curtain in a past life.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Private; a whisper becomes policy. *The audience is held in a garden. The flowers are listening.*

- K Dux Commission** — Command a mixed unit with pay authority. *The commission is a baton. It doubles as a mace in a pinch.*
- A Great Law Day** — Proclaim a new concord; one temporary exception to old law. *The proclamation is made at noon. By sunset, everyone will have an opinion.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charters/rights/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **law and bond** motifs—oaths that bind, stones that witness, treaties that remember every hand.

Additional Features

- **Two-Law Balance:** Whenever a *jurisdictional conflict* arises (mallus vs. basilica, oak vs. marble), players may step Position up by citing the Foedus Stone or an older precedent—but every use adds a tick to a **Two-Law** [4] clock. When it fills, one side demands exclusive authority.
- **Frontier Diplomacy:** If a *Heart* card involves a foreign envoy, a federate, or a mixed-blood courtier, treat the first **Diamond** played in the scene as doubled leverage. Once per session, a deal struck reverberates—advance or start a **Border Tension** front.
- **March Markets:** At any *Staple Market, Ford, or Bridge*, Diamonds tied to rights or escorts may be cashed as currency in lieu of coin, one-for-one. Doing so creates a **Ledger Debt** that the GM may call in later through factions or raiders.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in the longhouse quarter. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the horse-reeves, trying to untie her cord from a Ykrul blood-debt.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The burial field is a Class II Anchor site—ship-ridge spirits bound by unfinished wergild. Saikou Ira would carry a silver coin in each hand here.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the staple markets. Take it, and your stall yields triple profit—but the coin will reappear in your pocket every dawn until you pay the toll.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Vilikari psions are called “Oath-Readers.” They taste the weight of a promise in the speaker’s sweat. The Federate King employs two—and has never trusted a verdict they didn’t whisper.
- **The Ninth:** In any Vilikari scene, the ninth witness called to a mallus court is always a ghost. The wise stop at eight and settle out of court.

Vilikari Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stone:** Crumble a crust at the base of the Foedus Stone. Ignore the first *Law Tangle* penalty.

- **Knot the Braid:** Tie a single knot in a horse's tail. Cancel *Annona Late* or take -1 die on your next supply roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Oak:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into the hollow of the mallus oak. Gain +1 Effect when collecting werigild from their kin this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Elder of Elders.

Patronage & Power

In Vilikari society, power flows through the careful balance of multiple legal traditions, the management of frontier diplomacy, and the maintenance of complex oaths and treaties. The Federate King maintains authority through a combination of imperial forms and traditional customs, while local leaders wield influence through their knowledge of both Utaran law and tribal custom. The true power lies with those who can navigate this complex legal and diplomatic landscape while maintaining the loyalty of their people and the respect of their neighbors.

For the GM: Patronage in Vilikari society revolves around legal documents, diplomatic relationships, and the ability to command respect from institutions that operate under multiple legal systems. Rewards often take the form of treaties, charters, and official positions that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, writs, treaties) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival legal systems issue conflicting authorities, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the courts, markets, and frontier posts as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of law and custom determines success.

In Vilikari society, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you rule or are ruled.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **march officials or tribal elders**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **levy guards or market patrols**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or treaty keepers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable legal window**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Horse-Reeve or March Notary** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **legal challenge or border closure**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival faction or warband** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **shield-brothers**, **levy forces**, or **foreign troops** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **treaty voided/levy called/border dispute erupts**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Federate King**, **Queen of Marches**, or **Elder of Elders** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **raid hits/levy called/treaty breaks**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Vilikari (Two Laws):** Legal documents contradict each other, courts issue conflicting rulings, oaths bind to different authorities.
- **Vilikari (Frontier Diplomacy):** Treaties expire without warning, foreign envoys demand additional concessions, mixed-blood courtiers shift allegiances.
- **Vilikari (Border Tensions):** Frontier posts close without notice, markets shift locations, safe-conducts are revoked mid-journey.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The March Notary (quills like daggers)** — *Phases:* Citation Tangle → Seal Swap → Precedent Trap. *Cracks:* produce a **Foedus Seal** to quiet him; a **Queen’s Audience** overrules his filing.
- **Ykrul Storm-Rider (wolf-cloak, bone whistle)** — *Phases:* Raid Cry → Herd Stampede → Blood Price. *Cracks:* a **Wergild Table** settles the feud without combat; a **Hostage Treaty** buys a season’s peace.
- **The Prefect’s Auditor (Ecktorial ink on his fingers)** — *Phases:* Ledger Seizure → Tax Levy → Fort Closure. *Cracks:* an **Utaran Patent** grants immunity; a **Mallus Right** transfers jurisdiction to the oak.
- **The Direwood Whisperer (moss in her hair)** — *Phases:* Name Theft → Bell Failure → Breath Claim. *Cracks:* a **Stipend Arrears** paid in blessed salt; a **Purple Warrant** invokes imperial ward-law.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Foedus Stone Oath** — Place your hand on the stone and speak a treaty term aloud. On success, the stone warms; gain +1 Position on all negotiations this scene. On a miss, a crack appears—start a **Law Tangle** clock.

- **Twin Court Ordeal** — Argue the same case before oak and marble. Win both to secure a **Great Law Day**. Win one and lose the other to spawn **Law Tangle**. Lose both—the ancestors laugh, and you owe a feast.
- **Burial Field Vigil** — Spend a night among the ship-ridge mounds. Dawn reveals a memory of a broken treaty. Learn a secret weakness of a rival faction—or gain a haunting.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Two-Law Dial (Oak ↔ Marble):** Track which legal tradition holds sway.
 - *Oak High*: +1 Position when invoking mallus, blood-price, or tribal custom; first basilica petition starts one step worse.
 - *Marble High*: +1 Effect when citing charters, patents, or Utaran precedent; first mallus oath starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by offering a wergild recognized by both sides or hosting a joint moot.
- **Treaty-Feast Procedure (fast diplomacy):**
 1. **Set the Table:** Name 2–3 *terms* (what both sides want) and 1 *taboo* (off-limits).
 2. **First Cup (Position):** Roll a social test; success grants +1 die to bargain, failure grants the host 1 SB.
 3. **Bread & Salt (Offer):** Put *one* leverage on the table (Diamond or oath-promise). Host matches with an obligation (escort, market access, or hostage).
 4. **Smoke (Complication):** The GM reveals a pressure tied to *Old Grudges* or *Two Laws*. Resolve it or accept a *Rider Clause*.
 5. **Knot the Braid:** On success, create a **Feast-Bond** [3] clock that protects both parties from betrayal in that matter while it has segments; on breach, the breaker immediately takes 1–2 SB and the clock flips to **Blood-Owed** [3].
- **Frontier Market (quick trading):**
 - At any *Staple Market* or *Stone Ford*, players may convert a held $\Diamond$ into a *Market Edge* (+1 die to all buy/sell rolls).
 - Each conversion ticks a **Market Knives** [4] clock for that locale. When it fills, a rival factor challenges your right to trade—face a duel, a bribe demand, or a confiscation.
- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**
 1. *Laurel Wilt*: first legal action gains +1d; first boast draws **Law Tangle**.
 2. *Smoke on the Steppe*: **Raid Rumor** advances once; shortcuts open.
 3. *Twin Bells*: both courts are in session; pick a side or start **Law Tangle**.
 4. *Queen's Dove*: a message arrives; +1d on the next **Queen's Audience**.
 5. *Grey Salt*: **Stipend Arrears** counts double value today; smugglers' ears open.
 6. *Old Eagle*: an Utaran relic surfaces; **Utaran Patent** use is free this scene.
- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Vilikari Flavor):**
 - 1 SB → *Seal Crack*: a writ loses half its value until re-witnessed.
 - 2 SB → *Citation War*: increase DV by 1 unless you produce a precedent (spend a $\Diamond$ or recall a past ruling).
 - 3+ SB → *Crown Fracture*: a treaty splits; halve a consequence by accepting a rival's seal on your paper (start **Two-Law** clock).

- **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Court-Favored*: once/session, downgrade **Law Tangle** to a minor delay; the next document you present is scrutinized (+1 DV).
- *Raid-Tested*: +1 Position when evading Ykrul or Black Banners; supply lines run 1 segment longer.
- *Neutral Broker*: +1d with both oak and marble in a treaty scene; any betrayal earns **Blood-Owed** [2] from both sides.

- **Cross-Region Hooks (quick integration):**

- *Kahfagia (Lantern-Law)*: A **Foedus Seal** may stand in for a *Safe-Conduct* along a beaconsed lane once. Doing so starts **Port Clash** [2] in the next harbor touched.
- *Ecktoria (Imperial Remnants)*: An **Utaran Patent** counts as either *Archive Hour* (scholars open doors) or *Icon License* (display symbols) in Ecktorial sites—choose once per session.
- *Aelerian Mountains (Pass & Toll)*: A *Pass-Ring* (from the Aeler expansion) grants priority at dwarf switchbacks; cashing it to bypass inspection spawns **Ledger Notice** [3].
- *Direwood (Breath & Bells)*: Spending **Stipend Arrears** for levee labor converts one Direwood **Clubs** draw into a *Ward-Salt* Diamond for a scene, then begins **Names Disputed** [3] with bell-wardens.

Chapter 13

Black Banners

Condotta & Crowns. Mercenary leagues born from ex-Utaran legionaries, second sons, debt-dodgers, and exiles. The Black Banners sell steel to the highest bidder, today's ally becoming tomorrow's quarry. Between them move the Ykrul steppe-clans and the Vilikari hill tribes, while Ecktorian ministers call it "pressure management." The companies call it a season.

13.1 Black Banners — “Condotta & Crowns”

Banner-Captain (Elite): “A contract is only as good as the next payday, and a grudge is only as sharp as the sword backing it. In this game, we sell steel by the season and vendettas by the year.”

Veteran Sergeant (Commoner): “I’ve seen three captains rise and fall in the time it takes to grow a beard, but the mud stays the same and the pay comes when it pleases. Best keep your own counsel and your blade sharp. The camp sings? You live. They stop singing? Even the best charter bleeds.”

Condotta & Crowns

Ecktorian treasuries bankroll a perpetual border-war they claim to be *containing*. In truth, the gold keeps the fire burning. The Black Banners are mercenary leagues—ex-Utaran legionaries, second-sons, debt-dodgers, and exiles—who sell steel to the highest bidder, today's ally becoming tomorrow's quarry. Between them move the Ykrul steppe-clans (swift, pragmatic, oath-canny) and the Vilikari hill tribes (crafty, patient, and proud). Ecktorian ministers call it “pressure management.” The companies call it a season.

What you notice first: The smell of wet wool and old blood. The way every tent has a ledger pinned to its flap. The silence when the paychest is opened—and the murmur when it's light.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never break a Bell Dawn. Three bells at sunrise means bury the dead, trade prisoners, fix the wells, no ambushes. Violating it is how legends end badly—and how captains end hanging.

Regional Mood: The Theater of Banners

Here, war is a marketplace. The Black Banners are not a single army but a squabbling league of freelance violence, bound by camp law, pay customs, and the shared knowledge that tomorrow's

enemy might be today's employer. The real battles are fought in counting-tents over clauses and riders; the clash outside is just the audit. Loyalty is a coin that fluctuates with the market, and a captain's true skill lies in reading the political winds that blow across contested borders. Between the rigid honor codes of Ecktorian nobility and the fluid pragmatism of steppe clans and hill tribes, mercenaries navigate a dangerous middle ground where survival depends on knowing when to keep an oath and when to break one—always at dawn, with a witness, and with surety paid.

Starting Location: A war-camp crossroads where two banners snap in the same wind, their sigils bleeding into one another. A Condotta broker with ink-stained fingers lays two contracts on a barrel—one from Ecktoria, one from Ykrul. "Pick a war. Pick a grave. The bell tolls at noon."

(Camps/Battlefields/Fortresses/War-roads) Burned village turned field-hospital; flies, tinctures, and fever-prayers. Frozen ford with last month's dead held under glass; standards trapped in the ice.

Spades — Places

2. **Burned Village** — Field-hospital; flies, tinctures, fever-prayers. *The flies are fat. They've eaten well this season.*
 3. **Frozen Ford** — Last month's dead held under glass; standards trapped in the ice. *The ice is clear—clear enough to read the terror on their faces.*
 4. **Latrine Row** — At dusk; mud, shame, whispered mutiny, a sergeant who hears too well. *The sergeant's ears are scarred. He listened to a mutiny once and survived.*
 5. **Crater Pasture** — From an alchemical barrage; in spring, glass flowers sprout like guilt. *The flowers cut. They remember the hands that sowed them.*
 6. **Supply Road** — Twelve broken wagons; oxen nose the wreckage for salt. *The salt is from a burned caravan. The oxen are from the same village.*
 7. **Half-Raised Siege Tower** — In an abandoned camp; every rung creaks with grudges. *The tower was paid for twice. It still leans toward the richer patron.*
 8. **Salt-Cured Cache** — Behind the surgeon's tent; the wrong kind of maggots move. *The maggots have a pattern. It spells a name—yours, or the surgeon's.*
 9. **Command Tent** — Maps show borders that diplomacy has already erased. *The maps were drawn by a clerk who died last winter. He was still updating them.*
 10. **Watch-Tower** — Stacked from skulls and slate; the crows know the countersign. *The crows are paid in eyes. They are very well paid.*
- J **Ancient March-Keep** — Held by a skeleton garrison of veterans; they remember when the banners were gold. *The veterans are dead. They just haven't noticed yet.*
- Q **The Bone Fields** — Where Ykrul elders parley among cairns and reckon oaths with the dead. *The dead vote. Their votes are always for war.*
- K **Marcher's Fortress** — Three walls, two sieges' scars, one gate that opens inward only. *The gate opens inward so the dead can leave. The living are not invited.*
- A **The Singing Wastes** — Fallen weapons hum with the voices of their last wielders on a wind that tastes of iron. *The hum is a petition. The dead want their names back.*

(Captains/Cadets/Clans/Tribes) Young cadet with a father's sword and a mother's debt; veteran sergeant who counts scars like coins—and spends them on whiskey and mercy.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Young Cadet** — Father’s sword, mother’s debt, and a hunger to prove himself. *The sword is old. The debt is older. Both weigh the same.*
3. **Veteran Sergeant** — Counts scars like coins—spends them on whiskey and mercy. *His left ear is gone. He says a mutineer took it. He says the mutineer apologized.*
4. **Ecktorian Banner-Captain** — Griffon standard, a ledger of noble grudges, and a smile like a winter. *The griffon’s eyes are rubies. They were looted from a temple. The god still watches.*
5. **Condotta Broker** — Changes colors when the wind turns, but always lands on his feet. *His feet are calloused from landing. He has never broken an ankle.*
6. **Ykrul Clan Emissary** — Speaks in riddled proverbs and pays in copper and promises. *The copper is from a cursed mine. The promises are from a cursed tongue.*
7. **Vilikari War-Chief’s Second Son** — Honor burns brighter than his father’s patience. *His father’s patience is measured in seasons. This is the last season.*
8. **Surgeon of the Red Ledger** — Treats friend and foe alike; her ledger balances only in blood. *Her ledger is bound in human skin. The skin was a gift from a patient who lived.*
9. **Quartermaster** — Knows where every coin went and every man will fall. *His bribe book is thicker than his roster. He calls it “risk assessment.”*
10. **Tribune’s Aide-de-Camp** — Sealed orders that contradict the general’s intent. *The general’s intent was to retire. The seals say otherwise.*
- J **The Black Colonel** — Legendary commander not seen in the line for months, yet his banner still rides. *The banner rides alone. The horse is riderless. The men follow anyway.*
- Q **Ykrul Clan-Mother** — Weaves war-braids from the hair of oath-breakers. *Each braid has a name. The names are still attached.*
- K **Vilikari High Chief** — Trades mercenaries like game pieces and never tips the board. *The board is an old treaty map. The pieces are real.*
- A **The Bannerless One** — Commands loyalty without rank or flag; men follow because they want to. *They follow into the Singing Wastes. They follow into the ice. They follow because she asked.*

(Betrayals/Weather/Politics/War) Payday delayed; supplies die before coin arrives. False orders: your target is now your ally—on paper. Blizzard pins two rival companies in the same cloister; vows and knives both come out.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Payday Delayed** — Supplies die before coin arrives. *The coin was eaten by interest. The interest has teeth.*
3. **False Orders** — Your target is now your ally—on paper. *The paper is from a dead notary. The signature is warm.*
4. **Blizzard Pins** — Two rival companies, one cloister; vows and knives both come out. *The cloister’s abbot is counting. He will sell the winner’s story.*
5. **Ykrul Counter-Offer** — Better terms than Ecktoria; your contract becomes a liability. *The terms are written in salt. They will dissolve in rain—or blood.*

6. **Condotta Flip** — Unit switches colors mid-battle; your “relief” hits your flank. *The new colors are the same as the old colors. The captain just wanted a raise.*
 7. **Camp-Fever** — Blooms in the surgeon’s tent; the counting-house for the dead. *The fever has a face. It is the face of a soldier you left behind.*
 8. **Vilikari Raid** — Cuts your supply road; winter moves the schedule. *The raiders took the salt and left a recipe. The recipe calls for tears.*
 9. **Honor Code Collision** — Ecktorian ideals vs. mercenary pragmatism; the camp splits by doctrine. *The doctrine is written on a napkin. The napkin is from a feast that ended badly.*
 10. **Tribune Captured** — The aide must choose: the rescue or the war. *The war is a ledger. The rescue is a name. Names are heavier than ledgers.*
- J **Black Colonel’s Banner** — Appears on the wrong field; confusion is a weapon. *The banner is frayed. It has seen too many wrong fields.*
- Q **Blood-Feast** — Clan-Mother calls it; all contracts suspended until dawn’s judgment. *The judgment is a feast. The feast is a trial. The trial is a knife.*
- K **High Chief’s Game** — Plays companies against each other; “winner” takes obligations, not spoils. *The obligations are written in invisible ink. You will see them when it is too late.*
- A **The Singing Wastes Awaken** — Every fallen blade rises to seek its last hand. *The blades remember the grip. They do not remember mercy.*

(**Contracts/Claims/Dispensations**) Emergency requisition—strip a fallen company for what you need (and their ghosts for what they’re owed). Dual contract—serve two masters with goals that cannot both be met.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Emergency Requisition** — Strip a fallen company; their ghosts watch. *The ghosts will remember. They will collect.*
3. **Dual Contract** — Serve two masters whose goals cannot both be met. *The masters are both paying. The interest is your reputation.*
4. **Honor Dispensation** — Your acts are justified regardless of code (for now). *The dispensation is a bell. Ring it, and the tribunal looks away—once.*
5. **Condotta Rider’s Pass** — Cross any camp perimeter unchallenged. *The pass is a feather. The feather is from a messenger who arrived too late.*
6. **Ykrul Safe-Conduct Token** — Pass a named clan’s lands unmolested (until the moon changes). *The token is a horse’s tooth. The horse was a gift from a Khagan. The Khagan is dead.*
7. **Vilikari War-Mark** — Their scouts guide you through hostile hills—and remember the favor. *The favor will be called at dawn. The location will be a ridge. The odds will be even.*
8. **Surgeon’s Debt-Note** — Medical care when no coin remains; the interest is names. *The names are of people who owe the surgeon. You are now one of them.*
9. **Tribune’s Cipher Ring** — Decode orders that do not exist yet. *The ring is warm. The future is cold.*
10. **Banner-Captain’s Seal** — Commandeer resources from junior companies (and their resentment). *The seal is a skull. The jaw moves when you press it.*

- J Field Promotion Warrant** — Assume command of a shattered unit, inherit its clocks. *The clocks are ticking. The unit is watching.*
- Q Clan-Mother’s War-Braids** — Her chosen fight beside you this battle, then judge you after. *The judgment is a song. The song will be sung at your funeral.*
- K High Chief’s Trading Charter** — Buy or sell *anything* in any camp, no questions asked aloud. *The questions are asked in silence. The answers are paid in silence.*
- A The Bannerless Word** — Loyalty that outruns rank, law, and coin. *The word is a whisper. The whisper is a promise. The promise is a grave.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (contracts/claims/dispensations) that shift position rather than call for a roll.
- If any Ace appears, echo war and winter motifs—ice that keeps the dead, weapons that remember, loyalty that needs no banner.

The Fractured League: Banner Alignments

The Black Banners are not a single army but a squabbling market of violence. Three loose alignments shape the loyalties of any war-camp. Most companies shift between these poles depending on the season, the paychest, and the weather.

- **Condotta Brokers (The Paper Men)** – They own the contracts, not the swords. They flip companies like playing cards and measure victory in percentages. Most captains hate them, but everyone pays them. *Clocks: BROKER’S GRIP [4], DOUBLE CHARTER [6].*
- **Company Loyalists (The Old Banners)** – Veterans who remember when a banner meant a blood-oath, not a season’s wage. They grumble, they desert, they are sometimes bought – but they fight like demons when the paychest is full. *Clocks: VETERAN WRATH [4], OATH REMEMBERS [6].*
- **Free Companies (The Tide)** – Newly raised, culturally mixed, and chronically unpaid. They are as likely to mutiny as to charge, and their loyalty can be bought with a hot meal and a day’s rest. *Clocks: MUTINY WHISPER [4], PAYDAY FEVER [6].*

Superimposed on these are the **Ykrul steppe-clans** (honour-bound, quick to take insult) and the **Vilikari hill tribes** (pragmatic, patient, and skilled at ambush). A wise captain learns to read all three.

Additional Features

- **Payday & Supply Clocks:** Track two pressures common to the Black Banners: **Payday** [4] and **Supply** [4]. When Payday fills, morale falters and the Keeper may peel away a squad or impose a desertion SB. When Supply fills, all risky maneuvers begin one step worse Position until the players secure fresh provisions or bargain a Diamond.
- **Allegiances in Flux:** At the start of a scene, roll 1d6 to see if loyalties shift:
 1. Condotta broker flips colors mid-parley.
 2. Ykrul emissary offers better terms; accept and mark Obligation, or refuse and tick Payday.

3. Vilikari scouts reveal a shortcut; gain +1 Effect but risk SB from hostile terrain.
 4. Ecktorian clerk “corrects” your orders; obey for +1 Position, defy and gain a Diamond but earn a Black Mark.
 5. Rival captain spreads falsified orders; unless revealed, counters are harder this scene.
 6. The Bannerless One’s messengers arrive; accept their word to clear 1 Payday, but the Keeper gains 1 SB.
- **Honor vs. Pragmatism Dial:** Place a two-step dial between *Honor* and *Pragmatism*.
 - **Honor:** +1 Position in parley or oathbound actions; logistics costs rise faster.
 - **Pragmatism:** +1 Effect in ambushes or sabotage; parley begins one step worse Position.

Center the dial by a symbolic act—repaying arrears, returning prisoners, or honoring a broken writ.

Mercenary Realpolitik

In the world of the Black Banners, loyalty is a currency that fluctuates with the market. A man’s worth is measured not in noble blood or ancestral holdings, but in the sharpness of his blade and the reliability of his word. The condotta system creates a web of shifting allegiances where today’s enemy may become tomorrow’s employer, and a captain’s true skill lies not in strategy alone but in reading the political winds that blow across contested borders. Between the rigid honor codes of Ecktorian nobility and the fluid pragmatism of steppe clans and hill tribes, mercenaries navigate a dangerous middle ground where survival depends on knowing when to keep an oath and when to break one.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in the burned village. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the quartermasters, trying to untie her cord from a condotta broker’s ledger.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Singing Wastes are a Class II Anchor site—the bound spirits of fallen soldiers. Saikou Ira would trade his silver mirror for a single harmonic.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the paychests. Take it, and your company’s arrears vanish—but the coin will taste of blood every time the camp sings.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** War-camp psions are called “Banner-Readers.” They taste the weight of a contract in the captain’s shadow. The Bannerless One employs three—and has never trusted a signature they didn’t witness.
- **The Ninth:** In any war-camp, the ninth tent pitched in a row will collapse before dawn. The wise pitch eight and leave a space.

Black Banner Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Paychest:** Crumble a crust into an empty chest. Ignore the first *Payday Delayed* penalty.
- **Knot the Colors:** Tie a single knot in a banner’s cord. Cancel *Condotta Flip* or take –1 die on your next morale check (your choice).

- **Name to the Wastes:** Whisper a dead captain’s name into the wind. Gain +1 Effect when rallying their former unit this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Bannerless One.

Boss Archetypes in the Black Banners

Contract & Command (Human Adversaries)

- **Banner-Captain (Fixer General)** — Wins by paperwork and parade-ground precision. *Break their chain-of-command clock [6] by flipping lieutenants, forging orders, or seizing the paychest.*
- **Condotta Broker (Color-Flipper)** — Turns loyalties like cards. *Expose a dual contract or force public arbitration under neutral bells to collapse their leverage track.*
- **Quartermaster-Provost (Logistics Tyrant)** — Starves you with ledgers. *Complete the Three Cuts: road, ration, rumor—any two stalls them; all three topple their supply engine.*

Tribe & Tactic (Field Sovereigns)

- **Ykrul Raid-Mother (Oath-Weaver)** — Fights with remounts and safe-hostages. *Honor horse-rites to gain truce windows; break one braid in parley to end a phase.*
- **Vilikari Hill-Fox (Ambush Architect)** — Owns ridgelines and feint paths. *Clear Three High Stones (overwatch, supply cache, signal cairn) to force even ground.*

Faith & Fear (Camp Powers)

- **Field Chaplain-Inquisitor (Morale Engine)** — Smelts guilt into zeal. *Win by sanctifying plague-ground or redeeming prisoners; each rite drops their Zeal track [0–3].*
- **Surgeon of the Red Ledger (Mercy’s Price)** — Keeps units marching past sense. *Expose graft or pay blood-debts; on three reconciled names the operating tent stands down.*

The Unquiet Field (Supernatural Front)

- **The Singing Wastes (Weapon-Host)** — The battlefield itself retaliates. *Complete the Silencing Acts: oil the choir (funeral honors), bury the standards, ring the wind-break bell—each lowers its Tier for one exchange.*
- **Black Colonel’s Banner (Legend in Motion)** — A rumor that commands. *Prove the lie or become the truth: either unmask the courier network (three ciphers cracked) or fly a counter-sigil to pull rank on the myth.*

Faction Entanglements

- **Condotta Brokers’ Syndicate:** Register your charter and bank a *Broker’s Favor* – spend to reduce one parley DV inside a war-camp. Skipping registration flags your unit with *Unauthorized Colors*: the first checkpoint scene gains a free “False Orders” SB.
- **Camp Quartermasters:** Accept ration-scale audits to cancel the first *Supply* tick this leg; refuse and mark a 4-segment *Short Rations* clock that worsens Position on marches.
- **Field Chaplains & Leech-Circles:** Donate time or tithe to clear 1 segment from *Camp-Fever*; if ignored, the Keeper may convert the first 1 SB of a scene into “Disease/Death.”
- **Steppe Envoys:** Honor horse-rites (salt, water, shade) to gain *Remount Rights* – once, treat a retreat as movement with +1 Effect. Break rites and add a *Soured Oath* tag that raises parley DV with riders until cleansed.

- **Hill Truce-Holders:** Enter a stones-circle under their witness to bank a *Blood-Truce* – spend to negate one ambush on hill roads. Violating the circle spawns a 4-segment *Guest Right Forfeit* clock.

Field Procedures (Use at the Table)

- **Colors & Countersigns:** Declaring correct countersigns cancels the first “False Orders” SB each night; wrong signs worsen Position on first contact.
- **Payline Drill:** If a scene depicts orderly pay, clear 1 *Payday*. If pay is “creative,” clear it but mark *Black Mark* – future officers begin one step colder in parley.
- **Scavenge Doctrine:** After battles, you may gain 1 temporary Gear tag or advance *Supply* by 1; on a 1–2 on 1d6, spawn “Honor vs. Pragmatism” conflict immediately.

Chapter 14

The Linns

Skerries & Storm-Oaths. North of the Aberderrin Sea, where fjords split the coast and skerries break the tide, dwell the Linn. They are traders and raiders in equal breath, their longships crowding the whale-road and river mouths. Their oaths are sworn to storm and sea, and their skalds compose law as easily as they compose satire.

14.1 Linn — “Skerries & Storm-Oaths”

High Jarl (Elite): “The sea keeps better counsel than any scribe, and the storm remembers every oath sworn upon its winds. To rule these shores is to dance between their moods and never miss a step.”

Net-Wife (Commoner): “The water speaks to those who know how to listen – the way it moves tells you if the fish are running, if the weather’s turning, or if something’s coming that wasn’t invited to the feast.”

Theme & Atmosphere

North of the Aberderrin Sea, where fjords split the coast and skerries break the tide, dwell the Linn. They are traders and raiders in equal breath, their longships crowding the whale-road and river mouths. They descend the Ylolka like an axe-blade and cut into southern shores, or slip through the Thin Strip where the Valewood dares not touch salt. Yet even these storm-oath people dread the Mistlands and the Valewood, whose fog and trees have no need of ships or harbors to claim their due.

What you notice first: The smell of tar and salt fish. The creak of oars from unseen boats. The way everyone—jarl to thrall—touches a knotted cord before speaking of the sea.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never name a drowned person aloud while underway. The sea collects names, and if it hears you speaking one it doesn’t recognize, it may reach up to correct the ledger.

Regional Mood: Skerry Stormcall

Power here is spoken, not written. A jarl’s authority rests on the weight of his oath-chest and the sharpness of his skald’s tongue. Longships are not vessels; they are promises carved in timber. Every voyage is a gamble against tide, reef, and the attention of things that sleep beneath the waves.

The Linn do not fear death—they fear dying without a witness, swallowed by fog where no verse will remember their name.

Starting Location: A longship house lined with storm-charms and whale-bone runes, salt wind clawing at the doors. A Net-Wife binds a storm-token into a PC's palm. "The Whale-Road sings," she says. "But the Mistlands whistle back. Bring us three keel-lengths of ironwood from the Valewood edge, or the tide will take our boats in the spring."

(Fjord/Skerry/Hall) Kelp-skerry gut: a narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock; tide-shed of longship houses with tar smoke and gulls for sentries.

Spades — Places

2. **Kelp-Skerry Gut** — Narrow channel where oars scrape weed and rock. *Kelp strands like dead men's hair; row silently or the reef listens.*
 3. **Tide-Shed** — Longship houses; tar smoke and gulls for sentries. *Each shed holds a keel's ghost; old crews sleep under the floor planks.*
 4. **Wave-Gate Reef** — Just off a raiding beach; only locals know the cut. *One wrong turn and the wave breaks over you—twice.*
 5. **Runestone Causey** — Across tidal flat; names half lost to barnacle. *Touch the stone with your left hand. If it's warm, the ancestors approve.*
 6. **Herring-Stairs** — Drying racks above cliff path; knives flicker like fish. *Workers sing a counting song—eight verses, never nine.*
 7. **Winter Hall** — Turf walls, smoke-eye roof, benches crowded with shields. *The fire never goes out. Feed it a story each night or it goes hungry.*
 8. **Mistlands Maze** — Reed-channels braid and vanish; navigation by instinct. *The reeds whisper names you've forgotten. Do not answer.*
 9. **Boomed Harbor** — Iron rings in whale-bone posts; controlled access. *The chain was forged from a broken oath. It rattles when liars approach.*
 10. **Aberderrin Headland** — Current rips past wreck timbers in the kelp. *On foggy nights, the drowned signal with lanterns. Never follow.*
- J **Dolmis Waystation** — Low isle with fresh water and old debts. *The well is lined with copper. A single dropped coin returns as a blessing.*
- Q **Thing-Holm** — Flat islet ringed with stones for speaking and swearing. *The stones have ears; oaths spoken here echo for three tides.*
- K **High Jarl's Seat** — Above fjord, beacon tower glaring out to sea. *The beacon oil is mixed with whale fat. It burns green when a storm is close.*
- A **Whale-Road Horizon** — Open water where storms are born and names are made. *Here, the sky meets the sea. Here, the dead meet the living.*

(Jarl/Oar-Crew/Keeper) Net-wife who reads the sea like a ledger and the sky like a mood; steersman whose tiller-hand never shakes.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Net-Wife** — Reads sea like ledger, sky like mood; weather-witch in all but name. *She ties a knot for every storm she’s survived. Her belt has thirty.*
 3. **Steersman** — Tiller-hand never shakes, even when keel does. *His left ear is scarred—he listened too long to a siren’s promise.*
 4. **Shipwright** — Pitch on palms, schedule in teeth; knows every plank’s story. *He names each timber after a dead relative. The keel is his grandmother.*
 5. **Oar-Master** — Sets beat that decides if home is today or never. *He drums on a hollowed skull. The rhythm is a prayer to the sea.*
 6. **Mist-Pilot** — Ghosts boats through marsh lanes; reed-runner with secret paths. *He never blinks in fog. Some say he traded his blink for safe passage.*
 7. **Skald** — Verses buy silence, start fights, end them; law in rhyme. *Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath.*
 8. **Shield-Band** — Cousins fine with coin, better with cattle. *They sharpen their swords on runestones. The sparks tell fortunes.*
 9. **Foster-Son** — Southern coast birth; speaks both laws and subtext. *He wears two brooches—one iron, one bone. Neither is his true allegiance.*
 10. **Thing-Speaker** — Makes war into lawsuit, lawsuit into lunch. *He carries a water-clock. When it runs out, so does your patience.*
- J **Sea-Queen’s Hand** — Envoy with seal-bag and sword-belt; queen’s will made manifest. *He never draws his blade. The threat is enough.*
- Q **Sea-Queen** — Crown of hammered silver, eyes for weather and law. *She lost an eye to a storm—or to a spy. She won’t say which.*
- K **High Jarl** — First among raids, last to boast; paramount over strands. *His beard is braided with silver from every ship he’s taken.*
- A **Volva of Mist** — Oath-reader whose nod stills surf; seer of tides and truth. *She speaks once a year. The rest of the time, she listens to the fog.*

(**Weather/Reef/Feud**) Black squall drops from clear band; oars or prayers—pick one; fogfall makes friend and reef trade places.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Black Squall** — Drops from clear band; oars or prayers—pick one. *The wind screams a name. Listen carefully—it might be yours.*
3. **Fogfall** — Sound travels, sight does not; friend and reef trade places. *You hear oars. Then you don’t. Then they’re behind you.*
4. **Boom Lift** — Harbor chain rises; schedules drown in harbor mouth. *The chain’s links are inscribed with names of debtors. Each one rattles differently.*
5. **Levy Clash** — Viterra’s wardens arrive with polite spears. *They carry a writ stamped with the queen’s seal. The seal is still wet.*
6. **Keel-Rot Rumor** — Crews beach mid-voyage; trust in timber fails. *The rot smells sweet—too sweet. Someone poisoned the tar.*

7. **Feud Token** — Raid becomes wedding... or funeral; oath-debt called due. *A bronze ring arrives on an arrow. The meaning is clear.*
8. **Oath Matured** — Verse sworn last winter comes due today. *The skald clears her throat. The room goes cold.*
9. **Mistlands Miscount** — Channels “move,” cargo vanishes without witnesses. *The fog lifts to reveal a different shore. Your charts are now lies.*
10. **Aberderrin Race** — Contrary currents split flotilla; half late, half lost. *The water churns like a dying man. Something beneath is feeding.*
- J **Southron Fire-Pots** — Night-run turns to daylight; surprise ashore. *Pots shatter on the deck. The fire burns blue—alchemical.*
- Q **Thing Injunction** — No sailing till grievance heard (hours? days?). *The Thing-Speaker smiles. He has all the time in the world.*
- K **General Muster** — Horns on every headland; all bays become spears. *The war fleet assembles. Your ship is the smallest.*
- A **Ground-Sea** — Long, blind swell rolls under; steering lies. *The swell has a rhythm—two short, one long. A signal from below.*

(Right/Token/Escort) Harbor-green mark—dock without levy in named strand; oar-share claims two benches on fast longship.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Harbor-Mark** — Dock without levy in named strand (once). *The mark is a notch cut in a bone. Match it to the harbor post.*
3. **Oar-Share** — Claim two benches on a fast longship for a season. *The oars are carved with your name. Row well, or they’ll be recarved.*
4. **Pilot’s Token** — Mist-runner guides through reed-maze safely. *The token is a dried eel skin. Keep it dry.*
5. **Wharf-Right** — Dolmis waystation loading priority; first ashore. *The harbormaster frowns but steps aside. Your name is now on a list.*
6. **Salvage Claim** — Flotsam on reef stretch becomes “inventory.” *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
7. **Thing Ruling** — Verdict in your favor that travels with you. *The verdict is carved on a whale-rib. Carry it as a shield.*
8. **Raid-Truce** — Immunity in named bay for one market day. *A white banner on your mast. No one will attack—openly.*
9. **Foster-Bond** — Guest-kin by jarl’s house; hospitality guaranteed. *You share a cup with the jarl. The cup is silver. The promise is iron.*
10. **Herring Allotment** — Priority barrels when the run hits; silver in season. *The barrels are sealed with your mark. Break one to test quality.*
- J **Escort Writ** — Eight shields and wolf-banner from cape to cape. *The shields are painted with a wolf’s head. They die before you do.*
- Q **Queen’s Audience** — Whisper exits as policy; sea-law bends. *The Queen’s hand writes your words on vellum. The ink is her blood.*

- K High Jarl’s Pennon** — Levies open booms and mouths when it flies. *The pennon is torn from a captured ship. Fly it proudly—or else.*
- A Storm-Oath Clause** — Temporary exception to any sea-law, sealed. *The clause is whispered, never written. The sea hears and obeys—once.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (rights/tokens/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea-omens**—horns on wind, white horses on swell, verse unfinished until landfall.

Additional Features

- **Storm-Oaths:** Every raid or voyage sealed by oath to sea and storm. Break one, invite the sea’s judgment.
- **Skald’s Burden:** Verses are law, history, curse. A poor rhyme can damn a crew as surely as a reef.
- **Mist-Dread:** The bravest Linn will not enter the Direwood’s breath or the Valewood’s shade. Even the Sea-Queen pales at the Ninth Bell of the Mistlands.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Frost Ledger:** The Linn tell tales of draugr who rise from unpaid weregild. A High Jarl’s ghost now haunts the Thing-Holm, demanding a blood-price paid in stories.
- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice on a skerry. They take no payment—but they take names. A renegade Sister hides among the herring-stairs.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** The Sea-Queen’s court whispers of a cursed coin that grants fair winds—for a year, then collects. The coin is in the hands of a rival jarl.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Linn psions are called “Tide-Readers.” They taste salt on their tongues before a squall. The Admiralty of Kahfagia pays well for their services—and disposes of those who see too far.
- **The Ninth:** In any longhouse, the ninth horn blown at a feast summons the Hollow. The wise stop at eight.

Linn Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over the gunwale before a voyage. Ignore the first *Black Squall* penalty.
- **Knot the Oar:** Tie a single knot in your oar’s leather grip. Cancel *Keel-Rot Rumor* or take –1 die on your next rowing check (your choice).
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a dead enemy’s name into the tide. Gain +1 Effect against his kin for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Sea-Queen.

Patronage & Power

Among the Linn, power flows through oaths, kinship, and the spoken word. Jarls maintain authority through successful raids and wise judgments, while skalds wield influence through their ability to immortalize deeds in verse—or damn names through satire. The Sea-Queen holds sway over the coastlands, but her rule depends on the respect of the High Jarl and the Thing-speakers who interpret ancient laws.

For the GM: Power in Linn society is fluid and performance-based. Patronage often takes the form of foster-bonds, oar-shares, or raid-truces—each binding the recipient to service and reputation. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, banners, verses) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival jarls issue conflicting claims, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the Thing-holm and harbor gatherings as arenas for social contests, where oaths are sworn and broken.

In Linn society, your word is your bond, and your reputation is your greatest treasure.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **coastal guards or rival crews**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **ships or harbor watch**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or mist-pilots**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Local jarl or harbor master** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift or reef hazard**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival crew or levy force** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **ships, warriors, or skalds** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **storm hits/oath invoked/feud declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Sea-Queen, High Jarl, or Volva** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **storm rises/reef shifts/mist closes in.**
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Linn (Storm-Oaths):** Sudden calm, breaking waves speak names, verses come unbidden to lips.
- **Linn (Mistlands):** Channels shift without sound, voices call from reed-beds, compass spins.
- **Linn (Thing-Law):** Witnesses appear, oaths are demanded, skald begins composing your saga.

Western Reach Rumors (d6, fast hooks)

1. A harbor where bells toll under water; cargo *must* be named aloud.
2. A spice that stops bleeding—until moonrise.
3. A mirror-reef that reflects storms from a week ahead.
4. A pilotage guild that uses birds, not beacons.
5. A fleet that sails by *shadow* cast on fog.
6. A court that weighs debts in *breath*, not coin.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your color, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal)

- **The Net-Father (Nine Nets)** — *Phases:* Harbor Favours → Orchestrated Wrecks → Thing Coup. *Cracks:* cut a cord lineage; reveal swapped verdict; survive a staged squall.
- **The Blue Cantor (Brine-Gospel)** — *Phases:* Drownings Called Mercy → Procession at Reef → Tide-Baptism of a Jarl. *Cracks:* relic earplugs, survivor testimony, storm turning against them.

Part IV

The Eastern Dolmis & The Valewood

Chapter 15

Theona

Three Greens, No Ninth. The isles of Theona rise green and jagged from the Dolmis, their basalt cliffs wrapped in mists and moorland song. The greatest law is the silence of Nine: no bell tolls a ninth, no bridge counts that span, no oath dares its syllable. Those who break the ban invite the Green Host, and debts of nine can never be paid in coin.

15.1 Theona — “Three Greens, No Ninth”

Matron of Wells (Elite): “The wells here hold more than water – they hold the dreams and prayers of generations. To govern is to tend these sacred spaces where the living commune with what came before.”

Peat-Cutter (Commoner): “The land here remembers everything, especially what you don’t say. Skip the ninth step, forget the ninth name, and the green earth takes note. Best keep your omissions honest.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The isles of Theona rise green and jagged from the Dolmis, their basalt cliffs wrapped in mists and moorland song. Nominally a duchy sworn to Viterra, in truth the Three Greens heed no crown but their own moots, no law but their taboos. The greatest of these is the silence of Nine: no bell tolls a ninth, no bridge counts that span, no oath dares its syllable. It is said that those who break the ban invite the Green Host, and that debts of nine can never be paid in coin.

What you notice first: The smell of wet peat and salt. The silence that follows every eighth bell-ring. The way locals count on their fingers—thumb, then fingers, then a long pause where the ninth should be.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never pour the ninth cup at a feast. Never speak the ninth name in a bargain. Never step where a step is missing. The Green Host rides for those who complete what should remain incomplete.

Regional Mood: Three Greens, No Ninth

Here, peace is a ritual, and every word sharpens the blade that seals it. Theona is claimed by Viterra but ruled by moots, well-keepers, and the old faith. Linn longships cut through the fog for

raiding; Ashaani slavers hunt the coves in stolen coracles; pirates from Zakov and the Vilikari shore trade stolen goods for kelp and salt. Sidhi sailors and Aelinnel factors run cargo up the tide-stairs, and Aelaerem hedge-wives barter red thread for hawthorn passes. Through it all, the Ninth Taboo threads every handshake, every toast, every whispered prayer. To break it is to invite the Green Host—and the Host does not bargain.

Starting Location: A Moot Hill under rain, where vows are carved into stone and knives gleam beside the altar. A Bride-Peacemaker draws a blade between two bloodlines. “The ninth vow was never spoken,” she says. “But the Green Host remembers. Bring us the head of the slaver who burned the eastern strand, and the feud will end. Fail, and your name will join the uncounted.”

(Ringfort/Well/Cliff) Basalt tide-stairs cut into cove; everyone steps past a “missing” rung; Saint’s Well under hawthorn hung with ribbons.

Spades — Places

2. **Tide-Stairs** — Basalt steps into cove; everyone skips the “missing” rung. *The missing step is still there—you just can’t see it. Step where it should be, or don’t step at all.*
3. **Saint’s Well** — Under hawthorn hung with ribbons and secrets; wishes tied in cloth. *The ribbons are knotted in eights. The ninth knot is never tied—only imagined.*
4. **Fog-Wick Tower** — Burning peat; bell plays eight notes, never nine. *The bell-ringer wears a mask. Underneath, he has no mouth—only a whisper.*
5. **Black Bog Causeway** — White stones like teeth; will-lights test your stride. *The stones were set by a king who drowned. He counts each footstep from below.*
6. **Cliff Ringfort** — Over kelp-nets; storm-ladders creak like hymns. *The ladders are hauled up at dusk. If you’re left below, you sleep with the tide.*
7. **Barrow Field** — Standing stones; birds hush at noon, the earth remembers. *The stones have ears. Do not speak a secret you cannot afford to lose.*
8. **Sea-Cave Harp** — Tide-ropes sing under headland; echoes bargain for safe passage. *The harp has no player. It plays itself when the drowned want to speak.*
9. **Uncounted Bridge** — Nine-arch causeway; locals tally “eight-and-one.” *The ninth arch is there—but the locals will deny it. Walk it at your own risk.*
10. **Ogham Grove** — Carved pillars around an absent ninth post; runes speak in silence. *The missing post was removed by a king who broke a vow. The runes still curse his line.*
- J **Coracle Harbor** — Jammed in a notch; upturned boats roof the sheds. *The coracles are made of hide and guilt. Each one has carried a secret.*
- Q **Green Moot Hill** — Three Greens’ court; benches of turf, salt wind judges. *The wind never stops. It carries the votes of the dead.*
- K **High Hall** — Whale-rib beams; storm banners sleep, kings are chosen. *The kings are chosen by lot—a knotted cord pulled from a pot. The cord has eight knots.*
- A **Lookout Cliff** — One vantage where all three isles stand in a single gaze. *From here, you can see the Green Host riding on the horizon—if it wants you to.*

(Moot/Keeper/Court) Peat-cutter with steady barrow and steadier gossip; well-keeper who ties ribbons and unknots feuds.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Peat-Cutter** — Steady barrow, steadier gossip; knows every hidden path. *Her barrow has a false bottom. She hides debts there—and bodies.*
3. **Well-Keeper** — Ties ribbons, unknots feuds; wishes and wisdom in equal measure. *She never ties a ninth ribbon. The ninth wish is always her own.*
4. **Kelp-Netter** — Reads rip lines like ledgers; tide as teacher. *His net has a torn patch. He sewed it with thread from a hanged man’s shirt.*
5. **Harp-Satirist** — A few bars can end a career or a war; music as a weapon. *Her harp is strung with catgut and grudges. Each string is a name.*
6. **Wick-Warden** — Tends fog-lamps, counts in eights; guardian of the silent count. *He counts on his fingers—thumb, finger, finger, finger—and stops. The ninth is for the fog.*
7. **Taboo-Witness** — Geas-keeper who knows which words ruin deals. *She carries a bell with no clapper. She rings it with her tongue.*
8. **Island Abbot** — Saint’s bell, tolerant smile; faith in the old ways. *His bell rings eight times. The ninth ring is the silence that follows.*
9. **Green Neighbor** — Polite emissary from under the hill; borrowed boots, strange customs. *He never steps on a crack. He says the earth has teeth.*
10. **Coracle-Captain** — Eight-boat flotilla; swift as rumor, sure as the tide. *Her boats have no names. She says naming a vessel invites the Green Host to count it.*
- J **Bride-Peacemaker** — Walks between bloodlines with a silver knife; peace in marriage. *Her knife has a wooden blade. The families cut their palms with wood—blood without iron.*
- Q **Matron of Wells** — Queen-mother in truth if not in name; wisdom in water. *She drinks only from the ninth well—the one no one admits exists.*
- K **Three-Isles King** — Elected by the moots; whale-bone throne, weathered eyes. *He lost his left hand to a Linn raid. The replacement is carved from hawthorn.*
- A **Lady Beneath** — Unseen queen who bargains in dreams; hawthorn’s whisper. *She has no face. Those who see her forget their own names for a year.*

(Fog/Feud/Taboo) Ground-mist erases tracks; horns travel, edges do not; bog-lights lure teamster off the causeway.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Ground-Mist** — Erases tracks; horns travel, edges do not; navigation by sound alone. *The mist has a voice. It whispers your name—but only once.*
3. **Bog-Lights** — Lure teamster off the causeway; recovery costs time and pride. *The lights are the souls of debtors. Follow them, and you’ll never pay your way out.*
4. **Spoken Geas** — No ninth word in parley—or the deal curdles like milk. *The word you cannot speak sits on your tongue like a stone.*
5. **Salt-Rot** — Smokehouse fails; fish spoil, tempers rise like the tide. *The salt was cut with grave dust. Someone wanted the winter to be hard.*
6. **Procession Clash** — Saint-day vs. hawthorn taboo; shutters slam, peace fractures. *The saint’s banner and the green branch cannot touch. When they do, blood follows.*

7. **Wave-Count** — Eighth swell, Nameless follows; boats tremble, sailors pray. *The ninth swell never comes. But something rides the eighth.*
8. **Ringfort Wakes** — A bone-judge is “consulted”; now you’re named in the old law. *The bone-judge’s skull is filled with peat smoke. It speaks in riddles—and judgments.*
9. **Ninth Law** — Something vital cannot be counted, measured, or named. *You try to count your crew. The number keeps changing.*
10. **Net-Surge** — Harbor stairs; kelp wraps ankles and alibis like truth. *The kelp moves against the current. Someone underneath is pulling.*
- J **Bride-Theft** — At Moot—peace flips to feud; you’re caught mid-ritual. *The stolen bride’s hand is cold. She has been dead for a year.*
- Q **Mainland Return** — Exile with papers; elders arrested “for progress.” *The papers are stamped with a Viterran seal. The seal is still warm—and wrong.*
- K **Green Host Rides** — Hooves like drums, cattle scatter, sentries sleep. *The riders have no faces—only masks of woven hawthorn.*
- A **Great Fog** — Routes loop, bells lie, every promise takes the long way. *The fog is old. It remembers promises made to the dead.*

(**Blessing/Token/Right**) Well-blessing for a named ford crossing; moot token with eight-knotted cord skips local queues.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Well-Blessing** — Named ford crosses you safely, once; water remembers your need. *The blessing is a ribbon. Tie it to your wrist. Do not tie a ninth knot.*
3. **Moot Token** — Eight-knotted cord; skip any local queue or judgment. *The cord is braided from horsehair and silence. Cut a knot to speak.*
4. **Harbor-Green** — Painted mark exempts your boat from the next levy; tide as ally. *The mark is a circle with an eighth cut. The missing slice is the toll.*
5. **Hawthorn Pass** — Immunity from a single local taboo (for one scene). *The pass is a hawthorn twig. Carry it in your mouth. Do not chew.*
6. **Bell-Right** — Lawful ring at a fog-wick summons the watchers; law travels on sound. *The bell has no clapper. You must ring it with your own breath.*
7. **Coracle Share** — Crew and oars pledged for one crossing; tide as a steed. *The share is a tally stick. Break it in half to claim your passage.*
8. **Ogham Ruling** — Monk’s reading settles a dispute in your favor; runes as law. *The ruling is carved on a slate. The slate is damp. The runes may change by morning.*
9. **Unnumbered Right** — Ignore the Ninth prohibition for one action (costs a favor later). *The right is a silence. Use it, and the Green Host will ask for its name.*
10. **Salt-Cure License** — Process scarce fish despite ration edicts; preservation as power. *The license is signed with a thumbprint. The thumb is not yours.*
- J **Bride-Charter** — Two feuding houses sheath knives for a season; peace in marriage. *The charter is written on a wedding veil. The bloodstains are from the dowry.*
- Q **Private Moot** — With Matron and King; whispers become policy. *The moot is held in a fog hollow. What is spoken there is never written.*

K Whale-Escort — Eight-oar guards across the Dolmis reach; strength in numbers. *The crew carries your name on a scrap of vellum. If the paper gets wet, you are alone.*

A Green Favor — One uncanny exception to custom, spoken beneath hawthorn. *The favor is a dream. When you wake, the hawthorn will remember—even if you don’t.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (blessings/tokens/rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- The “No Ninth” custom: whenever a 9 appears in your seed, add an omission to the scene (a missing step, an unsaid name, an unseen guest). If the 9 is a Diamond, you may break the taboo once—but someone will come to collect later.
- If any A appears, echo **green and count** motifs—hawthorn that whispers, bells that miscount, promises that take the long way home.

Additional Features

- **The Silent Count:** Players and GMs are encouraged to omit a detail (a name, a step, a tally) when the Ninth appears, echoing Theona’s taboo.
- **Green Host’s Omen:** Any dream sequence or omen may be framed as the ride of the Green Host—hoofbeats across the sky, wind through the moors, sea spray tasting of salt and blood.
- **Bride-Peace Feasts:** Weddings, truces, and funerals blur; sharing a feast can end a feud for a season—or doom a guest if the ninth cup is poured.
- **Raider’s Shadow:** Theona’s coves are haunted by Linn longships, Ashaani slave barges, and Zakov pirates. Sidhi and Vilikari sailors crew the coracle fleets, while Aelinnel and Aelaerem traders bring red thread and counting stones from the far shore of the Dolmis.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice near the Sea-Cave Harp. They ask no payment—but they count breaths in eights. A renegade Sister hides among the peat-cutters, trying to forget her own cord.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Ogham Grove is a Class II Anchor site—the missing ninth post holds a spirit that cannot be named. Saikou Ira would ring every bell but the ninth.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the coracle crews. Take it, and the Green Host will not ride for you—until the ninth tide.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Theona’s “Taboo-Witnesses” are natural psions. They read omissions in the same way others read thoughts.
- **The Ninth:** In any Theona scene, the ninth person to speak in a room draws the Green Host’s attention. The wise hold their tongues until someone else breaks the count.

Theona Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Bog:** Toss a crust into the mist before crossing a causeway. Ignore the first *Ground-Mist* penalty.

- **Knot the Eighth:** Tie a single knot in a ribbon before a moot. Cancel *Spoken Geas* or take –1 die on your next oath (your choice).
- **Name to the Well:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into Saint's Well. Gain +1 Effect against his kin for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Matron.

Patronage & Power

In Theona, power flows through ancient custom, sacred spaces, and the careful observance of taboo. The Three Greens maintain their independence through a web of moots, well-keepers, and geas-keepers who ensure the old laws are honored. The King and Matron rule by consensus and tradition, while the unseen Lady Beneath influences events through dreams and whispers.

For the GM: Patronage in Theona revolves around blessings, exemptions, and the delicate balance of keeping or breaking taboos. Rewards often take the form of tokens, rights, or divine favor that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (ribbons, tokens, blessings) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival factions issue conflicting exemptions, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the moots, wells, and causeways as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of custom determines success.

In Theona, your word is your weave, and your weave determines whether you walk the green path or invite the Host.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **moot-keepers or well-guardians**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **coracle crews or ringfort sentries**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or green neighbors**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Wick-warden or moot official** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist shift or taboo breach**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **feuding house member or bone-judge** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **coracle crews, green neighbors, or moot enforcers** arrive.

- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **taboo broken/green host rides/feud declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: King, Matron, or Lady Beneath** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog rises/bells ring/causeway shifts**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Theona (Silent Count):** Steps disappear mid-climb, names vanish from lips, the ninth item in a list goes unmentioned.
- **Theona (Green Host):** Hoofbeats echo without a horse, mist takes familiar shapes, dreams predict the next action.
- **Theona (Taboo Law):** Words refuse to form, actions miscount, promises require exact phrasing.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Unsung Bell (forbidden note given will)** — *Phases:* Hum in Mist → Echo Under Well-stone → Command of Fog. *Cracks:* bind its clapper with eight ribbons; let a rival speak the ninth and pay; drown the echo at the Sea-Cave Harp.
- **Bride-Thief of the Green Host (dream raider)** — *Phases:* Invitation in Sleep → Procession Across Moor → Feast Without Ninth Cup. *Cracks:* cut the dream-veil with silver; sing satire at the Green Moot Hill; trade a Bride-Charter.
- **The Missing Step (living omission)** — *Phases:* Vanished Witness → Unread Clause → Unwalkable Bridge. *Cracks:* invite a Taboo-Witness to count aloud; spill nine drops into Saint’s Well but *name only eight*; let the Lady Beneath keep a memory.

Chapter 16

Zakov

Salt & Serpent. Zakov is the pirate-city of the Dolmis coast, where tides trade secrets and knives settle debts. Its streets are piers, its courts are taverns, and its rulers are whoever the Syndicates fear most this season. The Salt Prince claims the throne, but the real power ebbs and flows with the tide—and the tide remembers everything.

16.1 Zakov — “Salt & Serpent”

Salt Prince (Elite): “The tide here keeps better ledgers than any scribe, and the reefs remember every secret whispered above their depths. Power flows like the currents – those who understand them rule the waves.”

Dock-Rat (Commoner): “The sewers and the sea both carry what folks want to forget, but they also remember everything. Best keep your business above water and your enemies guessing which dock you’ll use next. The Salt Prince’s crown floats, and the tide pulls for anyone with a sharp knife and a sharper tongue.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Zakov is the pirate-city of the Dolmis coast, where tides trade secrets and knives settle debts. Its streets are piers, its courts are taverns, and its rulers are whoever the Syndicates fear most this season. The Salt Prince claims the throne, but the real power ebbs and flows with the tide—and the tide remembers everything. Here, every manifest is a lie, every harbor a doorstep to a dozen conspiracies, and every fog-light a lure or a warning. The city breathes with the sea: at low tide, secrets exposed; at flood, the drowned walk the Sunken Quarter and knock on doors that should be locked. Zakov is not a place you visit. It is a place you survive—or rule.

What you notice first: The smell of brine and tar. The constant slap of water against stone. The way every tavern has a door that leads to a different dock—and every dock has a name that changes with the tide.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never take a coin that tastes of brine. The Serpent’s Mark is not a blessing. It is a debt that drowns.

Regional Mood: Salt and Serpent

Here, the sea is not a border—it is a landlord. Zakov rose from the wreckage of a sunken empire, and every stone is a salvage claim. The Salt Prince rules from a throne of driftwood and extortion, but the real lords are the Syndicate factors who own the docks, the eel-cults that whisper from the sewers, and the fae courts that launder their influence through tide-bargains. Ships arrive with goods no customs post will name, and depart with cargoes no manifest will show. The city's law is the Tide Clock: low water for killing, flood water for trading, slack for negotiation. Break the rhythm, and the city will break you.

Starting Location: A smuggler's gate built into the seawall, its iron mouth crusted with barnacles and secrets. The gatekeeper is a one-eyed woman who accepts payment in stories. Behind her, the Dregs Quarter stretches on stilts into the harbor, and the Salt Prince's flagship, the *Red Wake*, rides at anchor off the Iron Pier. "The levy rises tonight," the gatekeeper says, spitting into the water. "Every ship pays, or every ship burns. You look like the burning type. Good. The Prince needs a reminder that the tide turns for everyone."

(Harbor/Bolt-hole/Black Market) Salt-cracked wharf where tide brings back what law forgets; Bone-yard beach with wrecks and corpses in kelp; Smuggler's Gate behind the Fish Market.

Spades — Places

2. **Salt Wharf** — Cracked and crumbling; the tide brings back what law forgets. *The wharf has a memory. It remembers every cargo that passed—and every captain that didn't.*
 3. **Bone-Yard Beach** — Wrecks and corpses tangled in kelp and rope. *The bones are from three empires. They shift at high tide to form new constellations.*
 4. **Smuggler's Gate** — An alley behind the Fish Market; always unlocked, always watched. *The lock is a riddle. The answer changes with the moon.*
 5. **The Shallows** — A reef-ridden cut only locals dare; navigation as survival. *The reef has a name: the Serpent's Spine. It grows longer each year.*
 6. **Dregs Quarter** — Shanties on stilts; boats tied to doorframes like pets. *The stilts are whale ribs. The quarter rises and falls with the tide—and the mood.*
 7. **Iron Pier** — Gangplank to the *Red Wake*, the corsair flagship; power as a vessel. *The ship was a slaver once. It still smells of chains and salt.*
 8. **Crow's Roost** — A tavern built into the hull of a beached galleon; the past as the present. *The hull was a prize from a war that ended forty years ago. The crew who took it still drink there.*
 9. **Black Bazaar** — Tents under tarps; goods that scream if you listen. *The scream is not pain. It is a warning.*
 10. **Salt Maze** — Marsh paths only the lost know; confusion as protection. *The maze was a graveyard. The dead rearranged the hedges.*
- J **Sunken Quarter** — Half the city is underwater at high tide; wealth as depth. *The flooded houses have air pockets. People still live there—damply.*
- Q **Crimson Docks** — Contracts signed in blood; commerce as violence. *The blood is not always the signatory's. The docks do not care.*
- K **Anchorhead** — A floating fortress of the Pirate Syndicate; law as an anchor. *The fortress is built from the hulls of seized ships. You can hear the captains weeping in the timbers.*

A **Serpent’s Spine** — A reef pass to the city’s secret heart; danger as a gateway. *The pass is a submerged arch. Swim through, and the city shows you its true face—once.*

(**Syndicate/Corsair/Fence**) Dock-rat pickpocket with a map tattoo and no fear; a fence dealing in stolen names and secondhand loyalties.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Dock-Rat** — Pickpocket with a map tattoo and no fear; the street as education. *His tattoo is of the Sunken Quarter at low tide. The buildings are upside down.*
 3. **Fence** — Deals in stolen names and secondhand loyalties; trust as currency. *Her ledger is written in disappearing ink. She is the only one who knows the antidote.*
 4. **Tavern-Keeper** — Remembers every face—and sells the list; hospitality as a trap. *His memory is a curse from a fae court. He cannot forget—and he cannot stop talking.*
 5. **Corsair Lieutenant** — A letter of marque signed in blood; authority as paper. *The letter is stained with a thumbprint. The thumb is still attached to the signatory.*
 6. **Dock-Master** — “Loses” ships that owe the Syndicate; bureaucracy as a weapon. *His ledger has a secret page. The page is a map of debtor’s bones.*
 7. **Smuggler Captain** — A false manifest and a quicker blade; honesty as a liability. *She names her boats after dead lovers. The current boat is named “Mistake.”*
 8. **Poison-Tongue** — Trades secrets like coin; words as blades. *His tongue is forked—not by birth, but by a curse. He can speak two truths at once.*
 9. **Exiled Admiral** — Runs a black-market shipyard; rank as a resource. *Her flag is a torn imperial pennant. She keeps it to remind herself why she left.*
 10. **Pirate Queen** — Rules the Shallows with charm and cutlass; beauty as power. *Her cutlass was her grandmother’s. The grandmother was also a queen.*
- J **Silent Syndicate** — No names, just favors and faces; anonymity as strength. *Their messenger is a child with no tongue. She writes in the air with smoke.*
- Q **Kraken’s Tongue** — An oracle who speaks in riddles and tides; the future as a mystery. *She lives in a bell tower that only exists at high tide. The bell does not ring.*
- K **Salt Prince** — The nominal ruler; real power in the shadows; a crown as a mask. *His crown is a circlet of driftwood. He has never taken it off.*
- A **Drowned Admiral** — A legend says he still gives orders from the deep; death as command. *His orders arrive in bottles. The bottles are corked with finger bones.*

(**Betrayal/Storm/Syndicate Feud**) The tide turns early—your ship is now ashore on the wrong side; a rival syndicate burns a warehouse with your goods inside.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Tide Shift** — Turns early; your ship is now ashore on the wrong side. *The tide stole a day. Your alibi is now a lie.*
3. **Warehouse Fire** — A rival syndicate burns it; your goods are inside. *The fire is green. It burns paper and wood—and secrets.*

4. **Cursed Cargo** — Something in the hold is *watching*; cargo as a curse. *The cargo is a mirror. The reflection is not yours.*
5. **Storm Warning** — Ships flee, prices soar, lawmen vanish. *The storm has a name. It is the name of a captain who swore revenge.*
6. **Double-Cross** — You are holding a fake shipment and real enemies. *The fake shipment is real. The real shipment is a trap.*
7. **Prince's Levy** — Every ship pays tithe or gets sunk; tax as a threat. *The levy collector wears a mask. The mask is the face of a dead admiral.*
8. **Plague Ship** — Quarantine flags are ignored; sickness spreads. *The plague is a cough that speaks the name of who infected you.*
9. **Blood Feud** — Erupts between pirate crews; collateral damage mounts. *The feud began over a stolen duck. The duck is still alive.*
10. **Kraken Rising** — Reefs shift, ships vanish, sailors scream. *The kraken is not a monster. It is a debt that has grown teeth.*
- J **Voided Contract** — Your protection now means nothing. *The contract was written on shark skin. It dissolved in salt water.*
- Q **Syndicate Split** — Zakov becomes a warzone overnight. *The split was orchestrated by a third party. You are the third party.*
- K **Naval Blockade** — No ships in or out without a fight. *The blockade is a fae illusion. The ships are real.*
- A **Tide Forgets** — Half the city is cut off, drowning in secrets. *The water is warm. The drowned are not dead—they are waiting.*

(Pass/Contract/Stolen Goods) A smuggler's token to pass a checkpoint unseen; a forged manifest that makes your cargo "clean."

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Smuggler's Token** — Pass one checkpoint unseen; stealth as paper. *The token is a dried eel skin. Show it, and the guards will not see you—or will pretend not to.*
3. **Forged Manifest** — Your cargo is now "clean"; truth as forgery. *The manifest is a leaf from a salt-cured book. The ink reads differently in moonlight.*
4. **Safe Berth** — Bone-yard; no questions, no law; sanctuary as a wreck. *The berth is a beached ship. Its captain still lives below decks—and does not age.*
5. **Corsair's Charter** — Raid with impunity for one moon; violence as a license. *The charter is a whip. Crack it, and the Syndicate will answer—or flog you.*
6. **Prince's Writ** — Levies cannot touch you (yet); authority as a delay. *The writ is a feather. The Salt Prince's signature is a claw mark.*
7. **Black Ledger** — Names, debts, and where they sleep; knowledge as power. *The ledger is a skull. Read the names, and the skull will whisper their secrets.*
8. **Salvage Rights** — A named wreck; first claim, no questions. *The wreck is a ghost ship. The ghost is the original owner.*
9. **Lighthouse Key** — Stolen; redirect ships where you will. *The key is a tuning fork. Strike it, and the lighthouse will lie for you.*

10. **Debt-Marker** — The Syndicate owes you a favor; obligation as an asset. *The marker is a coin. The Syndicate’s symbol is worn smooth—by regret.*
- J **Queen’s Blessing** — Safe passage through the Shallows; charm as protection. *The blessing is a kiss. The Pirate Queen’s lips taste of salt and blood.*
- Q **Kraken’s Favor** — The tides part for your ship, once; nature as an ally. *The favor is a tentacle wrung dry. When you need it, soak it in seawater.*
- K **Prince’s Coin** — Bribe any official, silence any witness. *The coin is a finger bone. The official who takes it will not speak—or not listen.*
- A **Serpent’s Mark** — The reef itself will guide you home; danger as a guide. *The mark is a scar on your palm. The reef will cut you—but it will also open.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (passes/contracts/goods) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **salt and serpent** motifs—tides that remember, reefs that shift, the deep that listens.

Additional Features

- **Tide Clock:** Scenes run on a four-segment **Tide Clock**. Each advance shifts Position: *Low tide* reveals hidden wrecks and bolt-holes; *Flood tide* drowns streets and seals doors. When the Clock turns, the Keeper may demand 1 SB tied to the waters.
- **Syndicate Debt:** Every deal leaves a mark. Track a single **Debt** value (0–3). At 3, the Syndicate calls it in: a betrayal, a levy, an unwanted escort. Clear 1 Debt by paying a Diamond or sacrificing a useful contact.
- **Whispers Deep:** Rumors carry teeth. When characters openly boast, bargain, or betray, roll 1d6: 1–3, Whispers spread, increasing SB generation; 4–6, Whispers favor the PCs, lowering suspicion until the tide turns.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in the Sunken Quarter. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the eel-cults, trying to untie her cord from the Salt Prince’s ledger.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Serpent’s Spine is a Class II Anchor site—the bound spirit of a drowned admiral. Saikou Ira would trade his silver mirror for a single reef chart.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the smugglers. Take it, and your cargo always passes inspection—but the coin will taste of brine every time you touch it.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Zakov psions are called “Tide-Readers.” They taste the future in the salt. The Pirate Queen employs two—and has never trusted a forecast that didn’t cost blood.

- **The Ninth:** In any Zakov scene, the ninth ship to enter the harbor in a tide will be claimed by the reef. The wise wait for the tenth—or pay a name to the Kraken’s Tongue.

Zakov Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Tide:** Toss a crust into the water before a voyage. Ignore the first *Tide Shift* penalty.
- **Knot the Manifest:** Tie a single knot in a corner of your cargo list. Cancel *Voided Contract* or take –1 die on your next customs check (your choice).
- **Name to the Reef:** Whisper a dead captain’s name into the Serpent’s Spine. Gain +1 Effect when navigating the Shallows this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Kraken’s Tongue.

Patronage & Power

In Zakov, power flows through the control of smuggling routes, the management of syndicate debts, and the ability to navigate the complex web of pirate politics. The Salt Prince maintains nominal authority, but real power lies with those who control the tides, the reefs, and the flow of information through the city’s taverns and black markets. The true authorities are those who can provide safe passage, protect cargoes, and mediate between competing syndicates.

For the GM: Patronage in Zakov revolves around smuggling rights, safe harbors, and the ability to provide protection from both legal and illegal authorities. Rewards often take the form of tokens, charters, and safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize the city’s fluid power:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, manifests, keys) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival syndicates issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the docks, taverns, and smuggling routes as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of custom and connections determines success.

In Zakov, your reputation is your wealth, and your wealth determines whether you rule the waves or feed the fishes.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **syndicate enforcers or dock guards**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **pirates or tavern patrons**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or fence networks**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised: Dock-master or corsair lieutenant** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **tide shift or syndicate patrol**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival syndicate or pirate crew** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **syndicate enforcers, pirate crews, or naval forces** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **contract voided/storm hits/syndicate splits**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Salt Prince, Pirate Queen, or Drowned Admiral** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **tide shifts/storm hits/blockade imposed**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Zakov (Tide Power):** Water levels change without warning, ships become stranded or flooded, tidal currents shift direction.
- **Zakov (Syndicate Politics):** Protection money demands increase, rival factions make conflicting demands, contracts are voided mid-deal.
- **Zakov (Pirate Culture):** Ships are commandeered, crews mutiny, pirate codes are enforced with violence.

Zakov — Salt and Serpent

Starting Location: A smuggler’s gate built into the seawall, its iron mouth crusted with barnacles and secrets.

“In Zakov, the sea remembers its debts, and every tide drags a name to pay.”

In... A Smuggler’s Gate, a Fence offers a forged manifest. “The Salt Prince’s levy rises,” they say. “And the tide forgets who paid.”

Regional Motifs Salt levies, river smugglers, eel cults, threshold markets.

Whispers to Offer “Take a bribe,” “Change the manifest,” “Drown the witness.”

External Clocks Threat: “Levy Teeth”; Community: “Smuggler War”; Anchor: “Gate Truce.”

Complications Eels spell names; brine coins multiply; gates open to water.

Anchors at Risk A dockside aunt; a tide-warden.

Escalation Beat The manifest adds the party’s cargo.

Relief Pay the levy in kind; throw the coin-chain back; swear the Gate to a new keeper.

City Operating System (Fast Play)

Tide-State (4) Track a **Tide Clock** (Low → Flood → Slack → Ebb). At each shift:

- change **Position**: Low (+Infiltration), Flood (-Mobility), Slack (+Deals), Ebb (+Getaway).
- Keeper may bank 1 SB tied to *water, rot, or rumor*.

Heat & Debt Track **Heat** (0–4) and **Debt** (0–3) citywide.

- *Heat* rises on noisy jobs; at 4, a *Syndicate Split* tick or *Naval Blockade* rumor triggers.
- *Debt* rises when you stiff a faction; at 3, a creditor picks the next scene’s complication.

Crew Playbooks (pick one tag) *Cutters* (+Effect on coercion at Crimson Docks); *Ghosts* (ignore first Tide penalty each job); *Lighters* (cargo swaps create 1 **Forged Manifest** per session); *Lanterns* (fae bargains count as Diamonds once/session).

Signal, Cipher, & Circuitry

Harbor Flash (d6 quick comms) 1 one-lantern (safe) 2 two-lantern (watch) 3 red rag (fire) 4 black gull (hit) 5 three knocks (meet) 6 eel-twine (fae eyes)

Dock Cant (micro-phrases) “wet ledger” = bribe; “green rope” = cursed cargo; “white rain” = blockade rumor; “dead wake” = tail on you.

Shadow-Net Each *Crow’s Roost*/tavern can host one **Cache**: 3 rumors total; *spend* 1 rumor to bump Position on info-gathering. When emptied, add +1 **Heat**.

The Fae Leak

Saltbound Rules Fae cannot *enter* a circle salted with **tidewater salt**, but can *bargain* across it. Breaking circle = 1 SB and a personal *Mark*.

Eel Court Wharf-spirits (eel-hooded) adjudicate vows “where water hears.” Presenting a **Serpent’s Mark** lets you reroute a single clause in a contract once.

Drowned Names Names thrown from *Bone-Yard Beach* return as *Echo Debtors*. Cash one to erase 1 **Debt**—but the name occasionally speaks from your mouth.

Heist Skeletons (Plug & Play)

The Manifest Swap (3 beats) **Beat 1:** *Entry* (Smuggler’s Gate or Sunken Quarter); on miss, *Tide Shift*. **Beat 2:** *Edit* (swap bill at Dock-Master); spend **Forged Manifest** to auto-pass. **Beat 3:** *Exit* (Shallows); fail = *Cursed Cargo* wakes.

Anchorhead Skim (4 beats) **Case** a ledger → **Turn** a clerk → **Lift** a page → **Ghost** on the Iron Pier. Any alarm = *Prince’s Levy* this scene.

Syndicate Play (Mini-Game)

Stacks & Faces Pick a patron *Stack* each arc: **Red Wake** (muscle), **Silent Syndicate** (intel), **Salt Prince** (papers). During downtime, exchange *Faces* (favors) for one of: reduce **Heat** by 1; clear 1 **Debt**; mint one **Black Ledger** page (one-use leverage on any named).

War Track (0–6) Each conflicting job advances **War**; at 3, *Blood Feud*; at 6, *Syndicate Split*. Reset if PCs deliver a **Queen’s Blessing** or sacrifice a crew asset.

Urban Terrain & Glitches

Glitch Table (fae-punk fuzz, d8) 1 door opens to water 2 lantern whispers your alias 3 rope grows kelp 4 coin tastes like brine and lies 5 footprints go opposite 6 eel writes your name 7 reef sound indoors 8 tide remembers a promise you didn’t make

Zones (quick tags) *Dregs:* +Stealth, -Status; *Crimson:* +Force, -Subtle; *Sunken:* +Weird, -Mobility; *Salt Maze:* +Escape, -Clarity.

NPC Templates

Kraken’s Tongue (Oracle) *Wants:* Tribute in secrets. *Leverage:* once/session convert a **Club** to a **Diamond**. *Cost:* forget a friend’s face for a night.

Dock-Master Briga *Wants:* A rival’s ledger singe. *Leverage:* “lose” any hull for a day. *Cost:* your real name in her book.

Pirate Queen Mael *Wants:* A tide-warden compromised. *Leverage:* **Queen’s Blessing**. *Cost:* carry her mark where it shows.

Contraband & Curses

Hot List (d6) 1 saint-glass (screams when lied to) 2 eel-ink (writes back) 3 tide-bell (rings at wrong hour) 4 serpent charts (reef moves for bearer) 5 name-wine (drink a memory) 6 drowned coins (buy help, cost breath)

Tagging Cargo Each illicit lot has 1 *Tag*: **Watching, Hungry, Bound, Cold**. Tag can be “disarmed” by the right shrine/fee/contact.

Cross-Region Conversions

- **Theona:** *Smuggler's Token* counts as *Hawthorn Pass* if bells play eight; a ninth sound voids both.
- **Viterra:** *Prince's Writ* can masquerade as *Customs Seal* for one audit before *Audit Freeze* ticks.
- **Ubral:** *Black Ledger* page buys one night of *Guest-Token*—if read aloud at Wergild Ford.
- **Vhasia:** *Lighthouse Key* spoofs a beacon on *Beacon Crown*/King's High Road ferries once.
- **Valewood:** *Serpent's Mark* = one-scene *Way-Cord* if dipped in Moon-Cistern.
- **Ways Between:** A complete *Forged Manifest* recited at a *Threshold Arch* becomes a *Passage Token*.

Clocks & Pressures

Levy Teeth (6) 1–2: Quayside “inspections” 3–4: Tithe brigades 5: Fire at the wrong warehouse 6: Floating gallows at Anchorhead.

Smuggler War (6) 1–2: Protection doubled 3–4: Routes trapped 5: Crews defect 6: Open water gunwales—everyone draws steel.

Gate Truce (4) 1: Coins tied on rope 2–3: Gate stays “neutral” 4: New Keeper named; reroute *Tide Clock* once/session.

Score Seeds

- **The Eel That Spoke:** A *Cursed Cargo* eel whispers court gossip from Thepyrgos; bottle it before *Syndicate Split*.
- **Red Wake's Shadow:** Lift a *Black Ledger* page naming the Salt Prince's heir; payment is *Prince's Coin*—and a knife in the dark.
- **Lighthouse Down:** Swap the *Lighthouse Key* during a storm; success grants *Kraken's Favor*, fail triggers *Naval Blockade*.

Designer Hooks (Optional)

Reefburn When you voluntarily take *Heat* to make a daring move, mark *Reefburn*. Once per session, spend *Reefburn* to treat the *Serpent's Spine* as a safe exit regardless of tide—something else pays the price later.

Name-Mask Craft a single-scene alias with eel-ink; while worn, your **Heat** ticks to the mask, not you. If the mask “dies,” transfer 1 **Debt** to the faction who owned the name you stole.

Harbor Homage Sites & Lairs (drop-in districts)

- **Chain-Gate Teeth** — Twin boom-chains scarred by ramming hulks; oiled winches sing secrets if fed brine coins.
- **Gallows' Net** — Web of rigging strung over a tide-pool court; verdicts lowered on block-and-tackle.
- **Coinsink Stairs** — Weed-slick steps to a shrine that only counts offerings thrown blind.

- **Red Wake’s Cradle** — Drydock carved into a wreck’s ribs; timbers remember mutinies and whisper them back at night.
- **Keelhouse Scriptorium** — Sailmakers who stitch clauses into canvas; a mainsail can carry a contract farther than a courier.
- **Eel-Bell Court** — Tide-bells toll wrong hours; each clang grants sanctuary until the next wave touches your boots.
- **Smokespine** — Stack-maze where tar-fires never die; a breath of it makes lies taste like rope.
- **Seven-Anchor Yard** — Museum of seized anchors; the biggest still drags in storms, pulling rumors with it.

Urban Bestiary (palette)

- **Brine Wraiths** — Drowned debtors that cling like wet canvas. *Signs:* coins stack themselves; ropes unknot. *Hook:* return a name to Bone-Yard and they carry one whisper for you.
- **Reef Serpents** — Kelp-maned constrictors nesting in pilings. *Signs:* barnacles spell spirals; gulls won’t land. *Hook:* beat a net like a drum; they follow the rhythm, not the blood.
- **Tar Gulls** — Oil-dripped scavengers that trade trinkets for shine. *Signs:* black feathers on white foam. *Hook:* flash a mirror; they’ll fetch what you picture—once.
- **Ledger Crabs** — Carapaces etched with accounts; they rearrange ledgers in their sleep. *Hook:* feed them wormwood; they “forget” one debt for a tide.
- **Knot-Hags** — Wharf spirits that live in snarls; they tangle plans and lines equally. *Hook:* cut a sacrificial coil; they unknot one problem and braid another.
- **Lampfishers** — Tall, mask-eyed things seen under grates in Slack; they love secrets heavier than gold.

Dock Stock (d20 quick)

- 1 Tar bucket still warm; prints lead both directions.
- 2 Three-lantern code lit wrong; fourth is a watcher.
- 3 Rope with twelve splices; one is a message in sailor's braid.
- 4 Crate labeled "salt"—full of sand and a single black coin.
- 5 Rust-red wake stain; no ship left that color.
- 6 Drift altar of bottle-glass; one bottle whispers back.
- 7 Bilge-water map sketched in mildew; only visible at ebb.
- 8 Hook with wedding ring; bent outward.
- 9 Ledger page soggy but legible; last line adds your cargo.
- 10 Eel skin pennon; points to the Serpent's Spine when wet.
- 11 Tar handprint too large for any sailor; points toward Smuggler's Gate.
- 12 Splinters arranged like teeth; bite if pocketed.
- 13 Tide-clock with missing hand; still keeps perfect Slack.
- 14 Harbour rat wearing a thread collar with a sigil bead.
- 15 Net weights stacked as a little gallows.
- 16 Driftwood idol with a knife in it; blood's fresh, wood is dry.
- 17 Copper nail stamped with a crown you don't recognize.
- 18 Coil of rope tied in a noose-knot that won't tighten on liars.
- 19 Shells arranged as a charter seal; one is a listening ear.
- 20 Barnacle rosary; counting it makes footsteps pass you by.

Lair Seeds (d12 one-night jobs)

1. **The Net-Queen's Loft** — A rigging den where favors are measured in fathoms.
2. **Ink-Cellar** — Eel-ink vats below a printshop; the walls remember every name printed.
3. **Deadwake Chapel** — Floods on Slack; boatmen marry their knives here.
4. **Chainman's Hostel** — Beds locked with anchor chain; rent is paid in confessions.
5. **Serpent Choir** — Reef tunnel; the surf sings clauses backwards.
6. **Gull-Tower** — Pigeon roost gone feral; messages shredded unless fed offal.
7. **Copperbone Yard** — Scrapyard ships with copper ribs; sparks start rumors.
8. **Salt-Judge's Dock** — A retired warden tries cases for fishers at dawn bell.
9. **Mask Market** — One aisle where faces are rented for a tide.
10. **Weeping Winch** — Cranes that leak brine on liars; useful, hated.
11. **The Quiet Slip** — Sound dies; perfect for handoffs, bad for warnings.
12. **Eel-Kiln** — Smokehouse that preserves more than fish; memories steep in brine.

Relics & Finds (d10)

- 1 Tide-compass that points to Slack, not north.
- 2 Reef tooth key; opens any lighthouse once.
- 3 Brine-ink quill; contracts signed with it cannot be read aloud.
- 4 Salt prince’s cufflink; bribes one guard, insults one captain.
- 5 Gaff with a prayer cut along the shaft; lifts curses, scars users.
- 6 Tarred ledger strap; binding a book with it hides one page from audits.
- 7 Barnacle brooch; pins a lie to someone else for a scene.
- 8 Foghorn reed; blown softly, turns footsteps to surf-noise.
- 9 Sea-glass seal; impresses a *Forged Manifest* as genuine once.
- 10 Eel-scale veil; wear it to be unseen by anything reflected in water.

Complication Twists (d8)

1. *Tide Shift* reveals a smugglers’ stair *and* floods the only exit behind you.
2. *Warehouse Fire* was lit with rain; flames don’t spread—smoke writes names.
3. *Double-Cross* includes your own counterfeit mark; someone sold your alias.
4. *Prince’s Levy* is collected by a syndicate impostor; paying sparks a *Blood Feud*.
5. *Plague Ship* flies false flags; the plague is in the cargo, not the crew.
6. *Voided Contract* cites a clause only the *Kraken’s Tongue* would know.
7. *Naval Blockade* uses fae buoys; they drift toward *Forged Manifest* holders.
8. *Tide Forgets* empties a canal and exposes a gallows with a still-kicking shadow.

Mini-Procedures (quick harbor play)

Cut a Wake When you need a clean exit through the Shallows, choose two and pay their costs:

- **Speed:** spend 1 *Remount Hire* equivalent (oars/crew) or mark *Heat*+1.
- **Silence:** leave a *Cache* rumor at a tavern; GM banks 1 SB.
- **Cover:** light a false beacon; start *Levy Teeth*+1.

Rope Court To settle a dispute without steel, each party knots a clause in one rope. Roll off; winner keeps their clause, loser’s knot is cut and their stake is forfeit. Spending **Serpent’s Mark** lets you retie one knot mid-judgment.

Boss Hooks (harbor crowns)

- **Mist-Baroness** — Controls the fog-candles; sells Slack on credit, calls it in on flood.
- **Anchor Virtue** — Exiled admiral preaching a stricter pirate code; her crews don’t drink on duty and never drown a debtor.
- **The Red Notary** — Tattoos charters into skin; burn him and an entire fleet loses papers.
- **Lord of Eels** — Fae broker in a salt circle; offers memory-for-manifest swaps at moonrise.

Extra Score Seeds

- **The Rope Court Heist** — Replace a clause-knot before dawn judgment; success flips *Prince's Levy* to your rival.
- **Fog-Candle Run** — Steal three fog-candles from the Mist-Baroness; each lit scene rerolls the *Tide Clock*.
- **Drowned Name Auction** — Bid at Bone-Yard for a name that erases *Debt*; every bidder speaks from someone else's mouth.

Chapter 17

Aelinnel (Aevrossa)

Stone, Bough, and Bright Things. The gnomish homeland of Aevrossa clings to the Dolmis coast beneath the shadow of the Valewood, its halls threaded through granite and hawthorn. Promises have weight and numbers have manners. Even steps are safe, odd words are careful, and truths are traded like copper nails—bright, useful, slightly dangerous in the wrong pocket.

17.1 Aelinnel (Gnomes) — “Stone, Bough, and Bright Things”

Elite (Stone Prince of Aelinnel)

“The law here flows like water over stone – it finds its own path, and woe to those who try to dam it with paper and pretense. The earth itself will testify against the unjust.”

Commoner (Charcoal-burner clan who read draught and omen by smoke)

“Our kilns tell us more than your books ever could. When the smoke curls left, the tide’s with you. When it splits in three, best stay by your own hearth till it burns straight again. And never trust a court that speaks in only one ledger.”

Stone, Bough, and Bright Things

Aelinnel homeland of Aevrossa clings to the Dolmis coast beneath the shadow of the Valewood, its halls threaded through granite and hawthorn, its roads counted by antler-posts and moonlit math. Here, promises have weight and numbers have manners. *Even* steps are safe, *odd* words are careful, and truths are traded like copper nails – bright, useful, slightly dangerous in the wrong pocket.

Yet no single crown rules the gnomish lands. Dozens of courts, guilds, and seasonal pacts weave a shifting lattice of loyalty. Some Aelinnel hold fast to ancient fae treaties; others barter in the Green Market with pragmatic coin; still others vanish into the deep woods, speaking only to stag-roads and stone-singers. The gnomish heart is divided – and that division is their strength.

Craft and courtesy govern traffic between fae courts and mortal keeps. Gnomish stone-singers tune bridges with a hum; forester-wardens hammer copper where iron would offend. In markets under living roofs, a sentence can be cut to fit a purse, and a memory can be wrapped for travel. Paths sometimes shorten themselves for those who keep good count, and lengthen for those who sneer at patterns.

At a Glance

- **Atmosphere:** Moonlit math, polite iron, and the uncanny certainty of numbers.
- **Key Conflict:** Said versus meant; fae courtesy versus mortal bluntness.
- **Notable Threats:** Glamour fog, iron offense, geas-catch, the Green Gate yawning at the wrong hour.
- **Common Rewards:** Hazel tokens, tide-path keys, oath-beads, and the Wild Hunt's clemency.

The Three Courts: Aelinnel Alignments

Aelinnel society is not a single crown but a lattice of courts, guilds, and seasonal pacts. Three broad stances shape their dealings with outsiders and with the fae. Most gnomes shift between these postures depending on the season, the tide, and who is asking.

- **Thorn–Courteous (Fae–Lean)** – These gnomes keep the old pacts with the Lady of Thorns and the Green Knight. They speak in two ledgers, never carry naked iron, and treat every threshold as a negotiation. They are the ones who remind visitors to count their steps and pour no ninth cup. *Clocks: COURTESY DEBT [4], HAWTHORN PATIENCE [6].*
- **Market–Square (Trade–Lean)** – These gnomes prioritize the Green Market, the Under-Market, and the flow of quartz, copper, and name-script. They are pragmatic, will use iron if it is gilded, and view fae courtesies as bargaining chips rather than sacred laws. *Clocks: TARIFF DISPUTE [4], MARKET DOMINANCE [6].*
- **Forester–Trusted (Wild–Lean)** – These gnomes live among the stag-roads and root-galleries, closer to the stone-singers and the tree-wardens. They speak the old names of tides and groves, and they are the first to notice when the thorn blight spreads or the moonwell stains a name wrong. *Clocks: ROOT CALLING [4], WILD HUNT INTEREST [6].*

Most Aelinnel characters and settlements fall somewhere between these poles, and the same gnome might wear a different mask when trading at the Green Market than when walking the stag-roads.

Spades — Places (stone spires, sea-rock, deep woods)

2. (Tide/Mystery) Tide-rift steps cut into black rock; limpets and old votive nails keep count for those who forget.
3. (Magic/Transformation) Moonwell basin in a granite bowl; coins turn green in a week, names in a season.
4. (Music/Stone) Dolmen stair up a ridge; each capstone rings a different interval if you tap it true.
5. (Magic/Secrecy) Charcoal coppice under witch-hazel; a neat ash-heap hides a door that opens on even knocks only.
6. (Nature/Music) Basalt organ cliffs: sea-caves breathe like slow bellows; the wind prefers prime numbers.
7. (Nature/Tradition) Stag Road – game-trail marked by antler-posts; hooves know it best, maps accept it grudgingly.
8. (Magic/Purity) Quartz spring where the sand shines like ground stars; drinkers tell the same story with better structure.

9. (Fae/Visibility) Elf-causey of pale flags through a marsh; visible at dawn and dusk and whenever someone is counting aloud.
10. (Underground/Living) Root gallery under an oak hill; lanterns hang from living bark – two lit, one listening.
 - J (Death/Music) Barrow gallery with stone chimes; a cold draft from below plays scales no throat can sing.
 - Q (Fae/Danger) Thorn Court ring – hawthorns trained into arches; petals fall like knife-points and settle into proofs.
 - K (Civilization/Magic) Hall of Aelinnel: a timber keep threaded between standing stones; floors level themselves for guests.
 - A (Otherworld/Gate) The Green Gate in a sea-arch; at certain tides it opens to a forest not on any map, and expects exact change.

Hearts — People & Factions (keepers, courts, craftsmen, hunters)

2. (Practical/Knowledge) Goat-herd of the stone edges – measures danger in hoof-widths; never wrong twice.
3. (Craft/Divination) Charcoal-burner clan who read draught and omen by smoke; their kilns hum in thirds.
4. (Magic/Commerce) Hedge-witch with a pocket of thorns and prices stated in *unlesses*.
5. (Craft/Magic) Stone-singer (quarryman) whose hum finds a seam and a secret; walls relax when they pass.
6. (Nature/Courtesy) Forester-warden with copper nails and a polite dislike of iron; paths obey their hammer.
7. (Nature/Tradition) Reed-net fisher who knows when the selkies listen; mends nets to lullabies in 5s and 8s.
8. (Law/Magic) Oath-carver who sets promises in quartz so they can be seen; breaks none, bends many.
9. (Navigation/Guidance) Way-keeper of the Stag Road; never lost, often followed, sometimes found ahead.
10. (Commerce/Magic) Green-market broker trading truths for trinkets and back again; receipts in leaf-vein script.
 - J (Fae/Authority) Green Knight – antler helm, mirror-bright blade, courtesy old as frost; keeps a tally of saved insults.
 - Q (Fae/Power) Lady of Thorns, sovereign of a hawthorn court; smiles like a snare and forgives in exact measures.
 - K (Authority/Magic) Stone Prince of Aelinnel, mortal crown with fae debts properly indexed and current.
 - A (Hunt/Destiny) Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride; his horn turns shortcuts into roads, and debts into destinations.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (glamour, geasa, weather, neighbors)

2. (Illusion/Disorientation) Glamour fog; time drifts, footfalls don't match, conversations arrive neatly folded.
 3. (Offense/Magic) Iron offense – someone brought the wrong nails to the right grove; paths take it personally.
 4. (Magic/Displacement) Root-slide pulls a trail two ridges away while you blink; your footprints stay where they were.
 5. (Magic/Physics) Wrong tide at the sea-arch; boats rise where arithmetic says no and physics excuses itself.
 6. (Magic/Binding) Spoken geas catches on an unlucky word; the task names itself and refuses synonyms.
 7. (Commerce/Magic) Green Market price: payment demanded in names and memories; change returned in riddles.
 8. (Death/Complaint) Stone-wight stirs in a barrow; echoes hate company and file complaints as drafts.
 9. (Time/Magic) Lost day – the sun miscounts; your dawn arrives at supper and demands bread.
 10. (Nature/Curse) Thorn blight crawls across orchards; pruners bleed stories that grow where they drip.
- J (Hunt/Duty) Stag horn sounds; everyone owes the chase – especially you, especially now.
- Q (Fae/Law) Thorn Court tithe levied on the Hall; arrests wear flowers and quote etiquette.
- K (Nature/Conflict) Muster of the Bough – forest banners rise; travel becomes trespass by default.
- A (Otherworld/Logic) Green Gate yawns at the wrong hour; roads rewire across your path with excellent logic.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (charms, passes, host-rights, exceptions)

2. (Magic/Protection) Hazel token – step through a hedge uncut, once; the scratch you did not get will *remember* you kindly.
3. (Utility/Rebellion) Salt license – carry and use ward-salt where it's discouraged; doors frown and open anyway.
4. (Magic/Authority) Dolmen carving-right – inscribe a name or claim on a speaking stone; arguments quiet while you carve.
5. (Hospitality/Fae) Guest-bough from the Thorn Court – one night's safe table among thorns; knives behave.
6. (Magic/Access) Quarry allotment of clear quartz; subtle doors open to its bearer if asked in the right tense.
7. (Commerce/Magic) Green Market voucher – buy a truth at face value (today only); tomorrow costs interest.
8. (Magic/Binding) Oath-bead; a spoken promise warms the bead when kept, chills when not, glows if misunderstood.

9. (Travel/Magic) Tide-path key – lawful crossing of a named sea-cave at neap; the cave will wait.
10. (Nature/Permission) Forest truce – hunt, cut, or travel through a warded copse without offense; the birds file no reports.
- J (Protection/Fae) Green Knight escort from ridge to gate; watchers bow, paths part, insults lodge elsewhere.
- Q (Fae/Authority) Private audience with the Lady of Thorns; a whisper exits as policy with petals attached.
- K (Authority/Magic) Stone Prince’s seal – levies defer, foresters guide, scribes stop arguing and fetch tea.
- A (Hunt/Protection) Wild Hunt clemency – ride under the horn for one night; no hound will take you, no debt will sleep.

Quick use notes

- Draw until all four suits appear: **Spade** = place, **Heart** = actor, **Club** = pressure, **Diamond** = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5→4, 6–10→6, J/Q/K→8, A→10).
- Treat **Diamonds** as codified outcomes (charms/passes/host-rights) that *change position* rather than call for a roll.
- If any **A** appears, echo moonlight-on-stone and tidy-logic motifs – antlers in shadow, petals that cut, a tide that breathes, and a shortcut that insists on proper counting.

Additional Features

- **Counting Etiquette:** Once per scene, any character who carefully counts (steps, breaths, beads, stitches) may shift *Position* one step safer for the next action that exploits pattern or timing.
- **Copper over Iron:** When the party visibly favors copper/brass tools over iron in fae-facing scenes, gain +1 assist die from locals (or avoid a -1 penalty) for acts of courtesy, passage, or petition.
- **Spoken Maths:** Reciting a simple sequence (2-3-5-8...) in tense moments steadies the scene: cancel the first SB generated by a navigation or negotiation misstep this encounter.

Courtesies of the Green Gate

- **Never bring iron** past a hawthorn arch unless it is gilded or named. Copper is polite, silver is opinionated.
- **Always return what points the way.** Way-cords, antler-posts, chalk. Borrow the path; do not keep it.
- **Speak debts in the daylight.** Promises made under lantern-boughs are heard by leaves as well as by law.

Numbers & Nature

In Aelinnel, the boundary between mathematics and magic blurs like morning mist. The gnomes understand that numbers are not merely tools for calculation but the underlying rhythm of reality itself. Their courtesy is mathematical – a precise exchange of value, a careful balance of obligation and favor. To offend their sense of order is to invite the world's correction; to honor it is to find that paths open, doors speak, and even the stones themselves become allies. The fae courts they traffic with recognize this respect for pattern and respond in kind, creating a delicate dance of mutual benefit and barely-contained chaos.

Thematic SB Spend Table (Aelinnel)

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **thorn-courtiers** or **forest-wardens**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **stone-singers** or **green-market traders**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **stag-road trackers** or **oath-carvers**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Green Knight** or **Lady of Thorns' herald** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **glamour fog** or **root-slide**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **stone-wight** or **thorn blight spirit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fae courtiers**, **forester-wardens**, or **stag-horn riders** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **geas triggers/green gate opens/iron offense declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Lady of Thorns**, **Stone Prince**, or **Huntsman of the Moonlit Ride** intervenes.

- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **tide turns/green gate yawns/thorn blight spreads.**
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options (Aelinnel)

- **Numbers & Magic (1–2 SB):** Antler-posts rearrange themselves, petals cut like blades, moonlight reveals a path that was not there a moment ago.
- **Fae Courtesy (1–3 SB):** A hawthorn arch closes behind you; copper tools glow with fae attention; a polite phrase becomes a binding geas.
- **Glamour (1–2 SB):** Conversations arrive folded and misaddressed; time drifts unexpectedly; your footfalls no longer match your steps.

Aelinnel — Tidal Bargains

Starting Location: A tide-shed at dawn, fog curling over anchored barges, while gulls cry omens over the river’s black glass.

“In Aelinnel lands, the river speaks with many tongues, and each tide demands a name in return.”

In... a tide-shed at dawn, a gnomish reeve offers passage on a sealed barge. “The Green Gate opens at neap tide. What we trade there, the Dolmis will not name.”

Regional Motifs Tide-ledgers, river gods, sealed cargo, name-taboo.

Whispers to Offer “Peek in the crate,” “Speak the hidden name,” “Break quarantine.”

External Clocks Threat: *Green Gate Thirst* [6]; Community: *Dockside Fear* [4]; Anchor: *Barge Oath* [4].

Complications Freshwater turns brackish; the cargo sings; a rival reeve boards with knives.

Anchors at Risk A PC’s river-kin; the barge’s blessing.

Escalation Beat The Gate opens early; the tide runs backwards.

Relief Offer a river-gift; carry a name written in river-mud across the threshold; spend 2 to seal the leak for a scene.

Faction Entanglements

- **Stone–Singer Conclave:** Sponsor a bridge-chant or way-tuning and bank a *Harmonic Favor*—spend to shift *Position* one step safer on any passage across worked stone or living root. Skip their rites and the first crossing this leg gains a free “Lock/Barrier” SB as paths sulk.

- **Forester–Wardens:** Accept copper-nail protocols to cancel the first *Fae Offense* SB in a wood scene. Drive iron stakes or break taboo and mark a 4-segment *Polite Apology* clock you must clear before locals assist you again.
- **Green-Market Brokers:** Submit an itemized truth (what was said / what was meant) to reduce barter DV by 1 for the scene. Try to haggle on single-ledger terms, and the market tags you with *Exact Change Only*—all bargains hereafter demand a tithe of memory or name until appeased.
- **Oath–Carvers’ Guild:** Have a promise set in quartz to gain a *Visible Oath* token; spend to treat one social test as if aided by a reputable witness. Breaking a quartz-oath spawns a 4-segment *Shattered Nuance* clock that complicates future negotiations.
- **Tide–Reeves:** File a tide-plan before neap to earn a *Tide Window*—ignore one tidal timing penalty this leg. Skipping the ledger adds a free “Wrong Tide” SB the first time you touch the Dolmis.

Cross-Regional Ties & Soft Power

- **Way of Silk Interface:** Kon’reh-counted caravans that adopt Aelinnel step-metrics (even steps, counted halts) gain +1 die to avoid ambushes on the Way this arc. Breaking count invites a free “Glamour Fog” SB at the next way-shrine.
- **Aeler Standards (Rods & Wards):** Recognize Aeler measures publicly to reduce dispute DV by 1 with dwarven legates; insist on gnomish dual-ledger and foreign merchants grumble—first mixed-market scene gains an “Assay Doubt” SB.
- **Vhasia/Viterra Complications:** Vhasian hedge-duties (wood rites) and Viterra tithe-scripts (grain flows) cross your ledgers. When either region is “Stressed,” add +1 DV to Green-Market exports that travel their roads unless you carry a *Forest Truce* or *Tithe Waiver*.
- **Valewood Fallout:** On a *Valewood Weather* signal, fae proofs spill downslope; counting etiquette cancels the first navigation SB each scene, but any iron shown gains a free “Fae Complaint” SB (even among humans). Aelaerem hospitality rites mitigate this: presenting guest-loaf removes one such complaint per hall.

Trade Goods & Consequences

- **Quartz & Proof–Stone:** Donate clear quartz to a shrine to bank a *Seen Promise*—once, treat a murky contract as if properly witnessed. Peddle clouded quartz as “ritual grade” and spawn a roaming *Counterfeit Proof* inquiry clock.
- **Copper Etiquette Kits:** Issuing copper over iron in mixed courts grants +1 assist die on petitions; flooding markets with cheap copper pins offends foresters—add a “Copper Resentment” tag that raises DV in wood jurisdictions until you make amends.
- **Name–Script & Memory Wraps:** Legal export of name-script lowers espionage DV by 1 for allies who carry it. Smuggling wraps risks a *Name-Tax*—first customs scene converts 1 SB into a compelled disclosure.
- **Tide Rights & Barge Seals:** Funding barge-seals creates a *Waiting Cave*—once per arc the cave “waits” an extra beat for your crew. Ignoring seal-maintenance flips it: first Dolmis crossing suffers “Wrong Hour” SB.

Patron Networks (Patterns & Thresholds)

- **Sacred Geometry:** Chalk a golden-mean spiral at a ford to reroll one failed prediction/trajectory check this leg; doing so in view of fae courts adds a 2-segment *Proof Envied* clock.
- **The Sealed Gate:** Hawthorn-gilded door-nails act as single-use stay writs: negate one forced entry or pursuit at a hedge-gate.
- **Lunara:** Counting under moonlight lets you ask one terse yes/no about a hidden path; on a Miss, secrets spread—mark Exposure +1 in the nearest Green Market.
- **The Traveler:** Antler-posts double as wayshrines; leave a copper and recite a sequence to finish one travel clock tick for free on forest legs.

Field Procedures (Use At the Table)

- **Two-Ledger Talk:** When parley stalls, the GM asks: “What was said? What was meant?” If players state both, cancel the first social SB this scene; if they refuse, the next bargain demands collateral (memory/name).
- **Count or Be Counted:** At any fae-touched crossing, a player who audibly counts in a fitting sequence shifts *Position* one step safer for that crossing. Boasting or mocking numbers adds a free “Geas Catches” SB.
- **Copper Courtesy Check:** Producing copper/brass tools in a ritual space removes the first *Fae Offense* tag this scene; drawing iron instead escalates the next Complication by +1 Cap.

Diplomatic Favor & Reputation Echoes

- **Hazel Favors (minor resource):** Earned by returning way-cords, restoring antler posts, or paying tide-dues. Spend to downgrade a *Glamour* or *Geas* complication once per leg.
- **Alignment Reputation:**
 - *Thorn-Courteous:* Doors of the hawthorn courts open a step easier; human clerks distrust your clauses (first city office DV +1).
 - *Market-Square:* Brokers vouch your weights; rival stalls circulate riddled slander—add a trailing *Folded Rumor* clock.
 - *Forester-Trusted:* Paths shorten for you once per journey; port inspectors assume concealed copper—first harbor search gains a free “Alarm Raised” SB unless declared up front.

Boss Archetypes in Aelinnel

Court & Courtesy (Fae Sovereigns)

- **Lady of Thorns (Etiquette Engine):** Punishes breaches with precise harms, rewards perfect courtesy with literal boons. *Win by satisfying three courtesies in sequence (no iron, two-ledger speech, return the waymark).*
- **Green Knight (Trial by Pattern):** Duel of paths and proofs, not blades. *Win by presenting a higher-count route (Fibonacci, even-steps) or yielding a deserved apology at the right number.*

Threshold & Hunt (Environment that Judges)

- **Moonlit Ride (Wild Hunt):** Three phases—*Sounding* (horns), *Coursing* (paths shorten for the bold), *Closing the Ring*. Win by naming safe-clemency, joining the chase without taking a prey, or blowing the right counter-call (2–3–5).
- **Green Gate (Living Crossing):** Demands exact change in truths. Win by paying a memory that fits the posted proof; forcing passage triggers “Roads Rewired.”

Numbers & Glamour (Logical Anomalies)

- **Glamour Fog (Layered Illusion):** Each layer dispelled by a correct count, courtesy, or copper rite. Win by completing the *Three Proofs*: count aloud, return a borrowed path token, trade a said/meant receipt.
- **Lost Day (Time Mismatch):** The sun misnumbers hours. Win by reconciling two ledgers (what happened / what should have), then ringing a prime-number chime.

Market & Oath (Contract Tricksters)

- **Green-Market Broker (Truth Arbitrage):** Buys your meanings, sells your words. Win by catching them in a one-ledger statement or producing an *Oath-Bead* that chills (misunderstood clause).
- **Oath-Carver Gone Wrong (Quartz Tyrant):** Binds towns with over-precise promises. Win by carving a *Release Unless* into communal quartz at cost of a public truth.

Stone & Memory (Ancestral Hazards)

- **Stone-Wight Chorus (Echo Jurors):** Resent footsteps, adore proofs. Win by tapping the dolmen scale that matches the grievance and returning a taken token to the barrow.

Boss Mechanics (Use 2–3 levers)

- **Courtesy Track [4]:** Each breach (iron bared, skipping greetings, single-ledger lie) ticks it. On fill, boss gains *Polite Punishment*: escalate DV +1 and impose a Geas.
- **Counting Proofs (three steps):** Name a pattern, perform it, return a waymark. Completing all three lowers boss tier for one exchange or ends a phase.
- **Said/Meant Ledgers:** Any bargain scene runs two mini-clocks; if *Said* fills first, glamour favors the boss; if *Meant* fills first, PCs gain a *Visible Oath* token.
- **Iron Offense Meter [0–3]:** Showing iron, striking hawthorn, or salting impolitely raises it. At 3, fae gain a free “Thorn Blight” SB; reduce by copper rites or gifts.
- **Hunt Phases:** *Sounding* (fear checks; pass to gain +1 die to pace), *Coursing* (paths shorten for counted strides), *Closing* (only truth-payment or clemency halts the circle).
- **Lair Actions (pick two):** *Fold the Conversation* (re-target a statement); *Shift the Count* (odd ↔ even penalties); *Petal Cut* (apply 1 Harm unless copper shown); *Wrong Tide* (swap entry/exit costs at a gate).

Chapter 18

Aelaerem

Hearth & Hollow. The halfling downs of Aelaerem hide deep barrows and darker hungers. Hospitality is a sacred law—and a trap. Red doors promise bread and salt, but the Neighbors walk the hedge-lanes, and the Pale Shepherd appears at every stillbirth and funeral. Their homeland’s true name is hushed, spoken only in euphemisms.

18.1 Aelaerem (Halflings) — “Hearth & Hollow”

Apple-Matron (Elite): “A proper harvest feast requires three things: the finest cider aged in the right barrel, a guest-loaf baked with intention, and the wisdom to know when to invite the quiet ones to sit by the fire.”

Miller (Commoner): “My geese know a stranger’s step from a mile off, and they’ve never been wrong. If they start honking at noon, you best check your larder – someone’s coming who wasn’t invited. And when the Hollow walks, the only safe place is a lit hearth with the ninth cup unpoured.”

Theme & Atmosphere

In Amedell, the Aelaerem keep their bargains with bread, bells, and careful counting. Lanes run under ash and hawthorn; doors reddened with thread promise a seat and a story to any who step right. Their magic is housekeeping writ large – thresholds groomed, names jarred like jam, the Hollow fed with silence and the ninth cup left unpoured. When the Neighbors stir beneath the barrows, the folk answer with kettle songs and lantern law, and the fields behave because someone asked them to. Hospitality here is not kindness—it is a contract. Every meal is a promise, every gift a debt, every candle an argument against the dark.

What you notice first: The smell of baking bread and old apples. The way every threshold has a red thread tied at eye level. The silence of children when a stranger passes the village stone.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse an offered cup. The Hollow counts refusals as invitations. Pour the ninth cup for the empty chair, and you may feed it—or feed it.

Regional Mood: Warm Hearths, Cold Thresholds

Here, the land is not wilderness—it is a living ledger of favors and omissions. The Aelaerem do not build walls; they build hedges, stiles, and the careful geometry of guest-right. A red door means bread, salt, and one safe night if you come honest. A cup-mark stone on the verge accepts butter as a prayer. The watch-geese know your step before you do, and the scarecrow turns to face the road when the Hollow is hungry. The Neighbors—the things that live under the barrows, in the uncounted ninth step, in the space between the candle and its shadow—are not enemies. They are neighbors. And neighbors, if treated politely, will stay on their side of the hedge.

Starting Location: A cider-press barn perfumed with crushed apples and rain, where masks hang from beams awaiting the next festival. The Apple-Matron sits on a stool of woven twigs. Behind her, a Moot Oak leaf bleeding red sap onto a stone. “The Hollow walks early this year,” she says. “The Moot Oak bleeds wine. Will you speak for the field, or let the Neighbors claim it? Speak true—the geese are listening.”

(Lanes/Orchards/Mills/Downs/Barrows) Willow ford with flat stones and a bowed pollard that remembers faces; cider-press barn with sweet reek, old songs, doors that stick after dusk; chalk sheep-downs with a turf maze cut like a wheel.

Spades — Places

2. **Willow Ford** — Flat stones, bowed pollard that remembers faces. *The willow has a name. It will tell you if you sit beneath it and listen.*
 3. **Cider-Press Barn** — Sweet reek, old songs, doors that stick after dusk. *The press was built from a barrow oak. The oak still dreams.*
 4. **Chalk Sheep-Downs** — Turf maze cut like a wheel; sheep know the pattern. *The maze is a prayer. Walk it backward to ask a favor.*
 5. **Millpond Under Alders** — The wheel turns some nights without water. *The water is not water. It is the memory of rain.*
 6. **Bluebell Wood Path** — Rabbit-gates and snares set by careful hands. *The snares are for the Hollow. They catch only shadows—mostly.*
 7. **Hedge-Tunnel Lane** — Between fields; nine stiles, locals count “eight-and-one.” *The ninth stile is a gap in the hedge. Step through, and the lane behind you changes.*
 8. **Cup-Mark Stone on the Verge** — Butter left in niches goes missing kindly. *The butter vanishes before dawn. The Hollow leaves a pebble in exchange.*
 9. **Barrow-by-the-Beech** — Bees go quiet at noon. *The bees are not sleeping. They are listening.*
 10. **Market Green** — Maypole and stocks; carved village stones turned inward. *The stones face the green. They watch the maypole dance—and the dancers.*
- J **Dovecote Hill** — The scarecrow faces the road, not the rows. *The scarecrow has a face. It is the face of the last person who broke guest-right.*
- Q **Mother’s Orchard** — Rows straighten if you don’t look—curve if you do. *The orchard is a promise. Break it, and the apples will taste of ash.*
- K **Moot Oak** — Lantern nails hammered deep; benches at the roots. *The nails are from a hundred feuds. Each one holds a grudge.*

A **Hollow Field** — A ring where no plow will hold a line, not for any coin. *The field is a mouth. It has not fed in a century.*

(**Keepers/Elders/Mummers/Quiet Powers**) Hedge-witch midwife who ties red thread and unties feuds; miller and his watch-geese—better sentries than men.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hedge-Witch Midwife** — Ties red thread, unties feuds, and knows which births the Hollow watches. *Her thread is from her own hair. She never cuts it—only knots it.*
 3. **Miller** — Watch-geese that remember faces; better sentries than men. *The geese have names. One is “Stranger.” It has never been wrong.*
 4. **Orchard Reeve** — Tally-stick, cider-stained smile, and a list of who owes what harvest. *His tally-stick is an apple branch. The notches grow back.*
 5. **Beekeeper** — Keeps odd honey aside for “winter churches.” *The honey is from barrow flowers. It tastes of earth and old promises.*
 6. **Shepherd** — Bone whistle that calls dogs—and other things. *The whistle is from a wolf. The wolf still answers.*
 7. **Lantern-Warden** — Trims lamps and knows which shadow is wrong. *She lights the lamps in a pattern. The pattern is a prayer to keep the Hollow back.*
 8. **Mummers’ Captain** — Chest of masks, stricter rules than church. *The masks are not carved. They are grown.*
 9. **Traveling Tinker** — Bright kettles, dull knife for cutting oaths. *The knife was his father’s. His father used it to cut a contract with the Hollow.*
 10. **Bailiff of the Moot Oak** — Polite as a noose, carries a ledger of grudges. *His ledger is bark. The writing grows deeper each year.*
- J **Wold-Wardens** — Elders who swear by hedges, not crowns. *They measure time in hedge-layers. A hedge that has grown for a century has a hundred opinions.*
- Q **Apple-Matron** — Hostess of harvest feasts; power sits where she pours. *She pours the first cup for the eldest, the second for the guest, the eighth for the fire. The ninth cup is for the empty chair.*
- K **Thresher-King** — A title that moves but never leaves; harvest robes, seasonal authority. *He is chosen by the last sheaf. The sheaf is always a little damp.*
- A **The Pale Shepherd** — Comes when lambs are born and when people go missing. *He has no face. His hat is a shadow.*

(**Folk Omens/Rites/Beasts/Night**) Unseasonal fog; the road walks you back to your own gate. Scarecrow turns; it watches the lane, not the field. Black sow through the orchard; hooves scuff every charm.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Unseasonal Fog** — The road walks you back to your own gate. *The gate is closed. The latch is red. Do not touch it.*

3. **Scarecrow Turns** — It watches the lane, not the field. *The scarecrow's head follows you. The crows are silent.*
 4. **Soured Wassail** — The bowl gives back names you did not speak. *The names are of people who died last winter. They are not listed in any ledger.*
 5. **Black Sow in the Orchard** — Hooves scuff every charm. *The sow was a woman once. She broke a vow.*
 6. **Hive-Swarm at Dusk** — Smoke curls the wrong way. *The bees are spelling a word. The word is "guest."*
 7. **Old Song Taken Up by Children** — Adults remember the verse none should sing. *The verse is about a barrow that opened. The children think it is a lullaby.*
 8. **Lanterns Burn Blue at the Ford** — Crossing costs more than coin. *The blue light is a toll-keeper. Payment is a story—or a secret.*
 9. **Out-of-Season Mumming** — Masks stick; faces won't come off. *The masks are warm. They have a heartbeat.*
 10. **Chalk Maze Fills with Mist** — You step out somewhere older. *The mist has a smell—old wool and older bread.*
- J **Church Bell Rings Thirteen** — Something attends the sermon. *The thirteenth pew is empty. The dust on it is fresh.*
- Q **Harvest Tithe Demanded** — Hands gloved in leaves. *The hands do not belong to anyone in the village.*
- K **Moot Oak Bleeds Sap** — The color of wine; talk turns to knives. *The sap is warm. It tastes of blood and honey.*
- A **The Hollow Opens** — Burrows and barrows connect; footfalls answer underground. *The footsteps are counting. They stop at eight.*

(Blessings/Tokens/Host-Rights) Guest-loaf and salt—one night's safe board anywhere with a red door; cider-mark—a free cup on the green buys gossip and patience.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Guest-Loaf & Salt** — One night's safe board anywhere with a red door. *The loaf is barley and rye. Break it with the host, and the Hollow will not cross the threshold—for one night.*
3. **Cider-Mark** — A free cup on the green buys gossip and patience. *The mark is a notch on a barrel. The tapster will remember you—or pretend not to.*
4. **Hedge-Pass Ribbon** — Step through any thicket unsnagged, once. *The ribbon is red. Tie it to a branch, and the thorns will part—once.*
5. **Bee-Queen Share** — Honey and a warning from the hives when danger nears. *The honey is from a queen who died last year. Her ghost still guards the comb.*
6. **Shepherd's Whistle** — Dogs and door-bolts heed you for one scene. *The whistle is a knucklebone. Blow it, and the dogs will obey—or they will hide.*
7. **Lantern-Writ** — The lamps stay lit along your path despite wind. *The writ is a bell. Ring it, and the lamps will not flicker—until dawn.*
8. **Mummers' License** — Lawful mask and after-dark crossing for a feast day. *The license is a wooden mask. Wear it, and the Hollow will see a stranger—not a guest.*

9. **Orchard Right** — Pick at Mother’s Orchard without offense; the fruit hides a truth. *The fruit is a secret. Bite it, and the secret will become yours—or it will become you.*
10. **Mill Token** — The wheel turns at any hour, grain or rumor ground. *The token is a millstone chip. Feed it to the wheel, and it will grind anything—truths included.*
- J **Apple-Matron’s Blessing** — Hands help unseen when you ask no coin. *The blessing is a cup. Pour it out in trouble, and the fields will send rain—or roots.*
- Q **Private Moot Under the Oak** — Elders hear you alone; precedent sticks. *The moot is held at midnight. The oak’s roots are the jury.*
- K **Thresher-King’s Guard** — Six red-hooded harvesters escort you; doors open. *Their hoods are the color of dried blood. They do not speak.*
- A **Pale Shepherd’s Clause** — Once, the Hollow will not notice you; pass uncounted. *The clause is a silence. The Hollow will step aside—and will remember that it did.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (blessings/tokens/host-rights) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo Hearth & Hollow motifs—quiet bells, red thread, watch-geese, footsteps under the soil—so the dread feels woven through the hedges.

Additional Features

- **Bread & Lantern:** Presenting a guest-loaf and a lit lantern at a threshold shifts your next social action one step safer while you remain a guest of that hearth. The lantern must be lit from the host’s fire.
- **Neighborly Courtesies:** When you keep local taboos (count “eight-and-one,” turn village stones inward, leave butter at cup-marks), cancel the first SB generated by rites or negotiations in that scene.
- **Listen at the Stile:** A quiet pause at a stile, barrow, or hedge-tunnel yields a true omen—ask one short question about what the Hollow wants *here and now*; the answer arrives as a sign, a sound, or a small animal.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in a hollow field. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the hedge-witches, trying to untie her cord from the Hollow’s ledger.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The cup-mark stones are Class II Anchor sites—the spirits of old offerings. Saikou Ira would leave butter in every niche—and a silver coin for luck.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the mummers. Take it, and your mask will never slip—but the coin will taste of dust every time the Hollow walks.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Aelaerem psions are called “Threshold-Readers.” They taste the weight of an invitation. The Apple-Matron employs one—and has never trusted a

guest they didn't vet.

- **The Ninth:** In any Aelaerem scene, the ninth guest to arrive at a feast is never human. The wise count eight and leave a chair empty.

Aelaerem Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Barrow:** Crumble a crust at a cup-mark stone. Ignore the first *Hive-Swarm* penalty.
- **Knot the Ribbon:** Tie a single knot in a red thread at a threshold. Cancel *Out-of-Season Mumming* or take -1 die on your next festival roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Hollow:** Whisper a dead person's name into an empty chair. Gain +1 Effect when invoking guest-right this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Pale Shepherd.

Hearth Magic

The Aelaerem weave their power through careful observance and small courtesies. Their magic lies not in grand gestures but in the precise attention to thresholds, seasons, and the proper ordering of things. Red thread binds more than wounds—it ties names to places, promises to people, and the living to the Hollow that walks beneath their feet. To offend a hedge-witch is to invite the Neighbors' attention; to earn an elder's blessing is to walk with the earth's favor.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or hedge-keepers**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **watch-geese or mummers**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or the Hollow**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable light**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Orchard reeve or lantern-warden** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **fog or threshold shift**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **scarecrow or Hollow spirit** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wold-wardens, mummers, or Neighbors** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **taboo broken/geese turn/Hollow stirs**.

- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Apple-Matron, Thresher-King, or Pale Shepherd** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **fog thickens/barrow opens/Hollow walks**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Aelaerem (Hearth & Hollow):** Quiet bells toll for no reason; red thread appears tied to your belongings; watch-geese honk warnings in the night.
- **Aelaerem (Threshold Magic):** A door you passed through earlier now leads somewhere else; your shadow walks behind you instead of beside you.
- **Aelaerem (Folk Customs):** You forget a crucial local taboo and offend the Neighbors; small things begin to go wrong—milk sours, knots loosen, a child points at the empty chair.

Boss Archetypes in Aelaerem

- **The Scarecrow Regent (Omen/Threshold)** — A hedge-raised guardian wearing twelve charms and one wrong knot. *Phases:* Stare of the Lane → Scare the Crows → Harvest of Faces. *Cracks:* a **Guest-Loaf** offered to its post; a **Mummers’ License** to wear a mask it cannot read.
- **The Hollow Bride (Otherworld/Hospitality)** — A Neighbor wearing a borrowed name and wedding veil. *Phases:* Invitation Drifted → Feast of Shadows → Ninth Cup Poured. *Cracks:* a **Shepherd’s Whistle** to call the dogs that guard the threshold; a **Lantern-Writ** to see her true face.
- **Lantern Bailiff of the Moot (Justice/Order)** — Enforcer of hedge-law with warrant-nails and bell-keys. *Phases:* Lantern Law → Midnight Moot → Binding Geas. *Cracks:* a **Cider-Mark** to buy a night’s silence; a **Moot Oak bench** to appeal his ruling.
- **Beekeeper of Winter Church (Sacred/Whisper)** — Keeper of cold honey and sleeping hymns. *Phases:* Swarm Omen → Waxed Vow → Memory Tithe. *Cracks:* a **Bee-Queen Share** to call her swarm to heel; a **Lantern** lit from a winter church candle.

Faction Entanglements

- **Wold-Wardens:** Honor hedge-law (count stiles, turn stones inward) or suffer +1 SB on each night march; bringing steel disputes to the Moot Oak reduces the next travel DV by 1.
- **Mummers’ Companies:** Travel under mask grants advantage crossing parochial borders; anger them (perform out of season) and village gates close at dusk (Position –).
- **Lantern-Wardens:** Donate oil or mend lamps to earn an escort marker; ignore a lit-lane and pay a “darkness toll” (first Stealth/Scout roll each night suffers –1 die).

- **Apple-Matron Circles:** Feast-days open barns and purses; snub an invitation and local prices double until amends are made.
- **Neighbors (quiet powers):** Leave butter at cup-marks to cancel the first supernatural SB this leg; break taboo and the Hollow stirs (add a *Hollow Attention* tick).

Cross-Regional Ties

- **Aeler Soft-Power:** Red-thread guest-right and ledger courtesies are fashionable among Aeler houses; reputation for keeping hearth-law grants +1 die to parley with Aeler stewards and toll-clerks.
- **Kahfagian Sea-Lanes:** Beeswax, cider-brandy, and wool ride river-to-coast. Storm seasons push Kahfagian factors inland—good silver, stricter contracts.
- **Way of Silk Spurs:** Caravans detour across the downs for night-safe lanes under lantern law; counterfeit guest-loaf tokens discovered here echo as distrust along Silk waystations (Social DV +1 until cleared).
- **Valewood Fallout (North):** Moon-sap and dream pollen drift on certain winds: chalk mazes misalign, barrow-whispers grow bold. When *Valewood Weather* is in effect, the first night omen is always true (good or ill).

Encounter Seeds (Quick Hooks)

- **The Hollow Bride's Invitation:** A wedding invitation arrives at the inn. The bride is not from any village on the map. The groom has not been seen in a week. The ninth chair at the feast is already occupied.
- **The Scarecrow's Harvest:** Crows are building a nest on the scarecrow's shoulder. Inside the nest is a key. The key opens a door that should not exist.
- **The Beekeeper's Tithe:** The winter church's bees have stopped producing honey. They are producing wax effigies of the PCs. The beekeeper wants to know why.

Chapter 19

The Valewood

Empire Under Leaves. Beneath the canopy of the Valewood lie the bones of a Lethai empire whose name is forgotten. Star-roads crack and phase between worlds, and the air hums with half-remembered songs of magic. Fae courts linger in clearings that shift with moonlight, beast-kin patrol moss-choked cairns, and echoes of imperial shades still march on vanished streets.

19.1 Valewood — “Empire Under Leaves”

Hazel Queen (Elite): “The forest here remembers empires that crumbled to dust, and its laws are older than your kingdoms. To walk these paths is to enter into covenant with powers that measure time in seasons, not years.”

Pathweaver (Commoner): “The woods here got a mind of their own – they’ll lead you where you need to go if you ask right, but they’ll just as soon lose you if you’re carrying ill intent. Best know which is which before you wander off the path.”

Theme & Atmosphere

The Valewood is older than kingdoms, older than the maps that skirt its borders. Beneath its canopy lie the bones of a Lethai empire whose name is forgotten, its towers swallowed by vine and root, its star-roads cracked and phasing between worlds. The air hums with half-remembered songs of magic, and the ruins bleed their mysteries into root and stream. Fae courts linger in clearings that shift with moonlight, beast-kin patrol moss-choked cairns, and echoes of imperial shades still march patrols on vanished streets. To walk the Valewood is to risk being claimed by it: as guest, prey, heir—or trespasser.

What you notice first: The smell of wet moss and old stone. The way the light filters through leaves like stained glass. The silence that falls when you speak a name too loudly.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never eat the fruit of a tree that has a face. The forest does not forget its debtors, and the first bite is always the price of admission.

Regional Mood: Leaves, Oaths, and Echoes

Here, the past is not past—it phases in and out like moonlight on water. The Lethai-ar who remain are not conquerors but custodians, tending to laws written before the first human kingdom rose. The fae courts of Hazel and Alder play their endless games of courtesy and obligation, and the

beast-kin speak in parliaments where every vote is a scent. Imperial shades march through walls that no longer exist, and the star-roads hum with geometries that twist the unwary into yesterday. The Valewood does not forgive arrogance. It expects humility, patience, and the willingness to trade a piece of yourself for safe passage.

Starting Location: A moss-covered amphitheatre where roots crawl through marble benches and owls whisper verdicts to the wind. An Owl-Sister speaks in riddles: “The Lethai-ar stir. The paths remember your true name. Speak it into the hollow of this stone, or the forest will learn it from your footsteps.”

(Phasing Ruin/Star-Road/Living Stone) Star-road shard with pale flagstones that hum when trod in sequence; rooted amphitheatre with moss-seats remembering speeches.

Spades — Places

2. **Star-Road Shard** — Pale flagstones hum when trod in sequence; a path between worlds. *The sequence is always incomplete. The missing step is the one you hesitate to take.*
 3. **Rooted Amphitheatre** — Moss-seats remember speeches not yet given; a stage for fate. *Sit in the high seat, and the roots will ask you a question. Answer wrong, and you may never stand.*
 4. **Moon-Cistern** — Reflecting sky that isn’t tonight’s; water as a mirror of truth. *The reflection shows what you lost, not what you carry. Look away before it names you.*
 5. **Glyphed Bridge** — Across a dry stream; glyphs glow when lies pass; truth as a toll. *The bridge has no railings. Liars fall—into the stream, or into memory.*
 6. **Glassleaf Gallery** — Boughs grown into panes, dust like constellations; beauty as a barrier. *The dust is crushed star-road. Breathe it, and you will dream of the empire’s fall.*
 7. **Hollow Aqueduct** — Water runs uphill if the song is right; magic in the melody. *The song has eight verses. The ninth is the silence that follows.*
 8. **Calendar Grove** — Standing-trees aligned to solstices; one trunk is stone; time as architecture. *The stone tree bleeds sap once a year. Collect it, and the forest owes you a season.*
 9. **Unfound Arcade** — Arches appear at dusk, vanish at dawn; reality as a schedule. *The arches have names—Carved on the inside. You must walk through to read them.*
 10. **Breathing City** — Vine-choked streets shift on the hour; a ruin as a living thing. *The vines pulse with a slow heartbeat. The city is sleeping, not dead.*
- J **Amber Ziggurat** — Caught mid-construction for a thousand years; time as an artifact. *The workers are statues of amber. Their eyes follow you.*
- Q **Ivory Observatory** — Brass orrery tracks two lost moons; the sky as memory. *The moons are not in any sky you know. One of them is yours.*
- K **Throne-Bower** — Living alder and argent wire; the seat of forgotten power. *Sit here, and the forest will crown you—or crush you. You won’t know which until the leaves settle.*
- A **Valeheart Spire** — The empire’s axle; stairs that end where they began. *The spire has no top. It has only a center. Finding it is the journey.*

(Lethai-ar/Fae/Beast-kin) Pathweaver who knots safe routes into cord; fox-headed courier with a promise braided into its tail.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Pathweaver** — Lethai-ar guide who knots safe routes into cord; navigation as magic. *Her cord has eight knots. The ninth is the one she never ties.*
 3. **Fox-Courier** — Promise braided into its tail; messages as living things. *It will deliver anything—for a price. The price is always a secret.*
 4. **Owl-Sister** — Pupils show yesterday; her hands show yours; sight as prophecy. *She never blinks. If she does, the future has changed.*
 5. **Antler-Hunter** — Sworn to keep the cities sleeping; a guardian of rest. *His spear is a sharpened root. It grows back when broken.*
 6. **Moss-Scribe** — Writes deeds in lichen, reads stone like vellum; law as growth. *Her ink is rainwater and regret. The words fade when the debt is paid.*
 7. **Lark-Keeper** — Caged bird sings warnings strangers can't hear; danger as song. *The lark's song is a map. Learn it, and you can walk anywhere—once.*
 8. **Green Neighbor** — Fae courtier wearing a borrowed smile and boots; hospitality as a trap. *Never accept a gift from a Green Neighbor. It's never a gift.*
 9. **Warden-Coterie** — Beast-kin (badger, stag, lynx); one law: no digging deep. *They speak in growls and gestures. The lynx is the one who remembers faces.*
 10. **Echo-Legionary** — Imperial shade bound to a patrol that never ends; duty as a curse. *Its sword passes through stone but not through flesh. Run, don't fight.*
- J **Shardwright** — Ancient artisan who wakes star-road with a chisel; craft as resurrection. *Her chisel is a tooth from the first dragon. She stole it.*
- Q **Hazel Queen** — Lethai-ar sovereign in leaf and law; wisdom as authority. *She has never spoken a lie. She has never needed to.*
- K **Alder King** — Twilit Court sovereign in shadow and debt; power as obligation. *His crown is a noose of thorns. He wears it proudly.*
- A **The Huntsman** — Antlers of moonlight; shortcuts owe him; the path as price. *His face is a stag's skull. His voice is the wind in the leaves.*

(Glamour/Ward-Trap/Imperial Residue) Sweet wind nudges landmarks hedge-width—enough to matter; path reverses—footprints vote to go elsewhere.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Sweet Wind** — Nudges landmarks hedge-width—enough to matter; navigation as deception. *The wind smells of honey and lies. Do not trust your nose.*
3. **Path Reversal** — Footprints vote to go elsewhere; direction as democracy. *Your tracks point the way you came—even when you haven't turned.*
4. **Ward-Trap** — Ancient security treats you as yesterday's invader; the past as prison. *The glyphs were set by a dead queen. She still enforces her grudges.*
5. **Oath-Magnet** — Spoken promises stick and reshape plans; word as binding magic. *Every “I will” becomes a knot. Every “I won't” becomes a chain.*
6. **Geas Catch** — A careless word triggers a task that names itself; speech as summoning. *You said “if only.” Now the forest has heard you.*

7. **City Phase** — Streets rotate; the exit becomes a balcony; space as puzzle. *The city breathes. You are in its lungs.*
8. **Name-Theft** — Something learns your true name's edges; the tests begin. *First, you forget a minor debt. Then a friend's face. Then your own.*
9. **Ring Claim** — A circle names you host; feeding guests becomes law. *The mushrooms are listening. They will remember what you serve.*
10. **Mirror Rain** — Leaf-drips replay choices you didn't make; the past as echo. *The rain shows you a path you refused. Now it offers it again—with interest.*
- J **Redcaps Abroad** — Hats wet, boots quick, courtesies thin; violence as hospitality. *They will ask for a kiss or a coin. Refuse, and they take both.*
- Q **Court Tithe** — Truth, song, or memory you'd miss; the price as sacrifice. *The courtier opens its hand. What you place there is never returned.*
- K **Muster of Boughs** — Green banners rise; travel becomes trespass. *The boughs bear old sigils. The war they remember ended a thousand years ago.*
- A **Empire Wakes** — A district aligns; doors open, guardians open farther. *The shades have orders. You are the target.*

(Charm/Key/Truce-Bough) Way-cord knot points to the true next turn; dew-mirror shows a thing as it is, not as it is sung.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Way-Cord** — A knot points to the true next turn (once); navigation as a gift. *The knot is a breath tied in silk. Untie it to find your way—or to lose it forever.*
3. **Dew-Mirror** — See a thing as it is, not as it is sung, for one scene; truth as a tool. *The mirror is a drop of water on a leaf. It dries when the lie dies.*
4. **Hazel Token** — Lawful crossing of a warded hedge without snag; permission as paper. *The token is a hazelnut. Crack it open; the kernel is your password.*
5. **Honey-Right** — Eat and speak safely at any bee-stone ring; hospitality as law. *The honey is golden. Taste it, and the bees will know you as a guest—once.*
6. **Name-Bead** — A kept promise warms; a broken one chills and glows; an oath as a magic item. *The bead is warm in your palm. If it cools, you have forgotten someone.*
7. **Wind-Veil** — Mute a sweet wind's lies for a short walk; truth as protection. *The veil is a scrap of silk. Breathe through it, and the wind cannot speak.*
8. **City-Shard** — Wake one gate or stair in a phasing ruin; a key as a catalyst. *The shard is a piece of a star-road. Hold it to the lock, and the ruin answers.*
9. **Truce-Bough** — Hunt, cut, or camp without offense in a named copse; peace as a branch. *The bough is green. Plant it in the ground, and the forest will not harm you—or help you.*
10. **Oathsap** — Seal a pact that even echoes respect; a promise as a binding force. *The sap is warm. Drink it, and your words become stone—for good or ill.*
- J **Shardwright's Favor** — Repair or light a length of star-road; craft as power. *The favor is a chip of amber. The Shardwright will come when you break it.*
- Q **Hazel Audience** — One whisper exits as policy; word as law. *The audience is a leaf. Speak into its spine, and the Hazel Queen will listen—once.*

- K **Alder Writ** — Levies defer, wardens guide, scribes stop arguing; authority as writ. *The writ is a thorn. Carry it in your boot, and the Alder King’s debtors will make way.*
- A **Valeheart Clause** — A temporary exception to any local rule, spoken in leaves. *The clause is a rustle. The forest will pretend it didn’t hear—but it will remember.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (charms/keys/passes) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- Empire Echo: when a J/Q/K is the highest rank in your seed, add one visible relic-logic (floating stairs, singing locks, patrol shades).
- If any A appears, echo **leaf and light** motifs—paths that remember, leaves that whisper, light that moves like water.

Additional Features

- **Forest Claims:** Any oath, bargain, or gift exchanged binds with more weight. Once per session, a spoken promise becomes magically enforceable: breaking it creates 1d4 SB and echoes through scenes.
- **Ruins Awaken:** If you linger at an ancient site, roll or draw to see which mechanism stirs. May grant guidance (lit star-road, a memory shown) or danger (patrol shades, collapsing glyphs).
- **Court Interference:** Encounters with fae or beast-kin are never neutral. Once per session, the GM may convert a Diamond into a demand for hospitality, tribute, or alliance—shifting the expedition’s tone.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in a rooted amphitheatre. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the moss-scribes, trying to untie her own cord from the Hazel Queen’s ledger.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Echo-Legionaries are Class II Anchors—soldiers bound by an oath to a throne that no longer exists. Saikou Ira would trade his silver mirror for a single patrol route.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends circulates among the redcaps. Take it, and the Huntsman will not hunt you—until the leaves fall.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Valewood psions are called “Leaf-Readers.” They hear the memory of oaths in falling leaves. The Hazel Queen employs three—and has never allowed them to meet each other.
- **The Ninth:** In any Valewood scene, the ninth leaf to fall from a tree will land pointing to a hidden threshold. The wise catch it—or pretend they didn’t see.

Valewood Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Roots:** Crumble a crust at the base of a standing stone. Ignore the first *Sweet Wind* penalty.
- **Knot the Cord:** Tie a single knot in a way-cord. Cancel *Oath-Magnet* or take -1 die on your next promise (your choice).
- **Name to the Cistern:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into the Moon-Cistern. Gain +1 Effect when evading fae this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Alder King.

Patronage & Power

In the Valewood, power flows through ancient magic, forgotten oaths, and the delicate balance between guest and host. The Lethai-ar maintain influence through their knowledge of paths and ruins, while the fae courts wield power through hospitality and geas. Beast-kin serve as guardians of the deeper mysteries, and the echoes of the empire still patrol their eternal rounds, enforcing laws written in starlight and stone.

For the GM: Patronage in the Valewood revolves around hospitality, knowledge, and the careful navigation of ancient laws. Rewards often take the form of charms, keys, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, mirrors, cords) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival courts issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the ruins, groves, and star-roads as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of ancient customs determines success.

In the Valewood, your word is your world, and your world determines whether you walk as a guest or a ghost.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or fae scouts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **echo-legionaries or beast-kin**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or imperial shades**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable phase**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Pathweaver or moss-scribe** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **path reversal or city phase**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **redcap band or patrol shade** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **fae courtiers**, **beast-kin**, or **imperial echoes** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **geas triggers/ruin awakens/court interferes**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Hazel Queen**, **Alder King**, or **Huntsman** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **city phases/paths shift/empire wakes**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Valewood (Magic Paths):** Routes rearrange without warning, bridges appear mid-step, directions become riddles.
- **Valewood (Fae Law):** Promises bind mid-speech, gifts carry hidden costs, hospitality turns to obligation.
- **Valewood (Imperial Echoes):** Patrols march through walls, ancient mechanisms activate, past and present blur.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Huntsman of Shortcuts (antlers of moonlight)** — *Phases:* Owe the Cut → Step Across → Tally the Tread. *Cracks:* present a **Truce-Bough** to halt pursuit; a **Way-Cord** cancels *Step Across* once.
- **Redcap Captain Rill (hat never dries)** — *Phases:* Hospitality Turned → Knee the Truth → Boot-Hook. *Cracks:* **Honey-Right** reverses one phase; **Dew-Mirror** exposes his “host right.”
- **Echo Centurion of the XIII Star-Road (bronze mask)** — *Phases:* Reform the Line → Juridical Recall → Standard Rekindled. *Cracks:* a **City-Shard** lets you counter-order once; a **Moss-Scribe** ruling cancels *Juridical Recall*.
- **Shardwright Unmended (glassy chisels)** — *Phases:* Cut the Clock → Wrong Stone → Wake the Segment. *Cracks:* offer **Oathsap** to bind a repair oath; **Shardwright’s Favor** flips *Wrong Stone*.
- **The Hazel Advocate (mask of living bark)** — *Phases:* Measure the Word → Prune the Lie → Court Silence. *Cracks:* **Hazel Token** grants speaking rights; **Oathsap** lets you safely retract one bound clause.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Glyphed Bridge Ordeal** — Speak a hard truth to pass dry; lie, and the bridge demands a memory tithe (mark *Name Leverage* +1, gain *Bridge's Favor* only if confessed).
- **Moon-Cistern Vigil** — Watch someone else's sky until the owl calls; success grants a single **Dew-Mirror** charge; failure spawns **Mirror Rain**.
- **Valeheart Spiral** — Climb stairs that return to start; map with verse, gift, count, listen (all four once) to unlock a *Between-Places* shortcut.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Name Economy (true-name pressure):**
 - Each PC has *Name Facets*: **Called-Name** (common), **Given-Name** (trusted), **True-Edge** (dangerous).
 - When a foe or court learns a deeper facet, mark *Name Leverage* [3]. At 3, they may compel one precise action or forbid one path unless countered by a $\Diamond$ or **Oathsap**.
 - You may trade a shallower facet to erase 1 tick from *Name Leverage* but gain *Rumor Tail* condition until scene end.
- **Hospitality Ledger (guest/host law):**
 - When *Honey-Right* or *Truce-Bough* is invoked, set a 3-step *Table Owed* clock for the host and a 3-step *Courtesy Owed* for the guest.
 - Ticking your clock grants +1d to social tests with that party; overpaying (4+) converts 1 tick into a portable *Favor Twig* (spend for +1 Position later).
 - Breaking either clock spawns **Ring Claim** or **Oath-Magnet** at the keeper's option.
- **Path-Logic Mini-game (finding the true way):**
 - Two opposed clocks per journey: *True Way* vs *Forest Has You* (size by highest rank in the seed).
 - Each leg, pick an *Approach*: **Rhyme** (speak a pattern), **Count** (steps/time), **Gift** (leave a token), **Listen** (ambient omen).
 - Edge: Rhyme→Gift (courtesies bind), Gift→Count (the land answers), Count→Listen (timing frames the omen), Listen→Rhyme (echo feeds verse).
 - Spend a **Way-Cord** to flip a failed leg; spend a **Wind-Veil** to ignore **Sweet Wind** once.
- **Truth Mechanics (seeing through glamour):**
 - **Dew-Mirror** reveals one *Unkind Fact* in the scene; naming it aloud gives +1 Effect but ticks **Court Tithe** +1.
 - **Glyphed Bridge** judges the next lie uttered; if you pass speaking truth, gain *Bridge's Favor* (+1 Position on crossings hereafter). If you lie, mark **Name-Theft** +1.
- **Star-Road Procedure (phasing traversal):**
 - To wake a segment: meet two of three—*Proper Footfall* (count/pattern), *Shard Key* (City-Shard, Shardwright help), *Witness* (owl, echo-legionary, or courtier).
 - Success grants *Between-Places*: one safe shortcut and one *Echo Fee* (memory, song, or small timeline bruise chosen by the GM).
 - On a miss, spawn **Ward-Trap** or **City Phase**.

- **Court Etiquette (Hazel vs Alder):**
 - **Hazel Audience:** pays in *precision*—exact words, measured gifts. +1d when you cite prior custom or present a **Moss-Scribe** ruling.
 - **Alder Writ:** pays in *obligation*—future tasks, debts. +1 Effect when you promise service; tick **Oath-Magnet** +1.
- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**
 1. *Leaf-Whisper:* first Listen/Study gets +1d; first boast draws **Geas Catch**.
 2. *Antler Shadow:* the Huntsman watches—shortcuts improve; hiding worsens.
 3. *Mirror Drip:* **Dew-Mirror** free use but **Court Tithe** starts at 1.
 4. *Root Push:* terrain shifts in your favor once; buildings dislike you (locks complicate).
 5. *Bird Parliament:* a rumor arrives true; one plan becomes public knowledge.
 6. *Star-Tingle:* star-road easier (+1d to wake) but every $\Diamond$ *hereafter* risks **Ward-Trap** on 1[~]2.
- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Valewood Flavor):**
 - 1 SB $\rightarrow$ *Sweet Wind Shift:* reposition an approach vector; -1d unless you adjust method (Rhyme/Count/Gift/Listen).
 - 2 SB $\rightarrow$ *Obligate Courtesy:* immediate small gift or truth required; refuse and tick *Name Leverage* +1.
 - 3+ SB $\rightarrow$ *Empire Echo:* add a patrolling **Echo-Legionary** cohort or activate a dormant mechanism that reframes the scene.
- **Reputation Echoes:**
 - *Guest-Faithful:* once/session, downgrade **Ring Claim** to simple hospitality; the next refused invitation spawns **Oath-Magnet**.
 - *Path-Favored:* +1 Position on *Path-Logic* legs; any shortcut taken owes a *token or tale*.
 - *Truth-Bearer:* +1d with the Hazel court when presenting facts; -1d with the Alder court when declining obligation.
- **Quick Cross-Region Hooks:**
 - *Kahfagia Lanes* $\leftrightarrow$ *Star-Roads:* a **Mirror Warrant** can stand in for a **Shard Key** once.
 - *Mistlands Bells* $\leftrightarrow$ *Path-Logic:* paying **Ward-Salt** counts as the *Gift* approach with +1d.
 - *Aelinnel Math* $\leftrightarrow$ *Proper Footfall:* *Counting Etiquette* grants +1 Position on the **Star-Road Procedure**.

Part V

The Spaces Between

Chapter 20

Ubral

The Stone Between Spears. Ubral is a land of upland mists, stone cairns, and clan oaths held tighter than iron. Law is written not in charters but in cattle, wergild, and songs. A guest's word can buy more than a sword, but one broken vow can spark a feud lasting generations. The dwarves of Khaz-Vurim guard their mountain steps with tolls and grim patience.

20.1 Ubral — “The Stone Between Spears”

Lady of Tor (Elite): “The stone here remembers every oath sworn upon it and every blood spilled in its shadow. To lead is to understand that the land itself is the true sovereign, and we are merely its stewards.”

Hearth-Aunt (Commoner): “Hospitality's a sacred thing in these hills – break bread at my table and you're family till the sun sets twice. But cross that trust and the very stones will remember your name.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Ubral is a land of upland mists, stone cairns, and clan oaths held tighter than iron. Caught between the Aelerian mountains and the lowland courts of Viterra, its hills are scarred by old raids and crowned by watch-fires that speak faster than any rider. Here, law is written not in charters but in cattle, wergild, and songs; a guest's word can buy more than a sword, but one broken vow can spark a feud lasting generations. Dwarves of Khaz-Vurim guard their mountain steps with tolls and grim patience, while clans hold their moots in hollows where voices echo long after speakers fall silent. Ubral is the stone between spears: a land of pride, passage, and peril.

What you notice first: The smell of peat smoke and wet granite. The constant lowing of cattle on distant hills. The way every threshold has a knife hidden nearby—for guests, not against them.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never refuse a cup from a hearth-aunt. Hospitality is a contract sealed in salt and bread. Refusal is an insult that blood must answer.

Regional Mood: Cairn, Tor, and Oath

Here, the past is never past. Every cairn holds a voice, every burn scar on a hillside remembers a raid. Viterra has tried to conquer Ubral a dozen times; each attempt ended with supply lines cut

by reivers, passes sealed by dwarf tolls, and lowland knights lost in mist. The Utaran Imperium itself broke its leg on these hills and limped away. Now the clans watch the lowlands with patient eyes, and the dwarves of Khaz-Vurim weigh every traveler's honesty on iron scales. A guest here is kin—until they prove otherwise. And kin here will die for you—or kill you over a stolen cow.

Starting Location: A Warden's Cairn at the fog line. Spears planted like grave markers, their shafts wrapped in faded clan ribbons. Hoofbeats echo in the valley below. The Hearth-Aunt offers a cup of small beer and a piece of oatcake. "The Wolf Road wakes," she says. "Viterran tax men are asking which passes you used. The clans are counting your steps. Speak true, or the cairn will add your name to its tally."

(Tor/Cairn/Hill-fort) Sheepwalk Ledge with goat path and room for one honest lie; Warden's Cairn on windy tor with signal-fire basket.

Spades — Places

2. **Sheepwalk Ledge** — Goat path with room for one honest lie at a time. *The lie must be small—a false weight, a borrowed name. Tell it twice and the ledge crumbles.*
3. **Warden's Cairn** — Windy tor; signal-fire basket and dry cache; eyes of the hills. *The cache holds a single arrow. Light it with the fire, and the message is war.*
4. **Wergild Ford** — Flat stones, deep pools, table rock for counting silver. *The table rock is smooth as glass. Blood washes off; lies do not.*
5. **Droppers' Bridge** — Stone span rigged to fall; pins already loosened. *The pins are greased with mutton fat. The bridge knows who paid for the grease.*
6. **Scree-Ladder** — Climbing to a notch; red rags mark safe steps through danger. *The rags are old clan banners. Step where they wave, not where they lie flat.*
7. **Moot Hollow** — Ring of standing stones; voices carry and won't quite stop. *The stones have ears. Speak a false oath here, and every cairn will know.*
8. **Reiver's Gate** — Between boulders; cart-ruts vanish into heather's memory. *The gate has no lintel. Above it, ravens nest in a skull.*
9. **Khaz-Vurim Steps** — Dwarf-cut switchbacks with iron mile studs; toll and toil. *The studs are cold iron. Touch them, and the mountain knows your weight.*
10. **Grey Tor Fort** — Earthen rampart, timber crown, smoky cook pits. *The cook pits have been burning for three hundred years. The ash is deep enough to bury a secret.*
- J **Black Broom Bog** — Stepping-logs; wrong one drinks you into silence. *The logs are painted with warding runes. One is unpainted—that one is the quick way.*
- Q **Bride's Causey** — Raised road to a valley kirk; ribbons hang like warnings. *The ribbons are from wedding gowns—cut short when the groom fell in a feud.*
- K **Three-Fires Ridge** — Watchposts that see Viterra and Vhasia both; news travels fast. *The fires are layered: birch for peace, pine for raid, oak for invasion.*
- A **Pass of Ashes** — When snow closes here, the upland becomes an island. *The ash is from old sacrifices. The pass remembers every offering.*

(Clan/Dwarf/Reiver) Hearth-aunt who holds guest-cup and house's temper; hill guide with thorn-staff and quiet shortcuts.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Hearth-Aunt** — Holds guest-cup and house’s temper; hospitality as power. *She has never drawn a blade. She has never needed to.*
 3. **Hill Guide** — Thorn-staff and ten quiet shortcuts; the land as a map. *He taps each stone before stepping. The stones talk to him.*
 4. **Feud-Broker** — Knows the weight of a life in cattle and coin; peace as trade. *His ledger is a row of tally sticks. Each notch is a death—or a birth.*
 5. **Reiver Band** — Light on tack, heavy on nerve, laughing in the rain. *They wear no colors. Their horses answer to whistles, not names.*
 6. **Fire Warden** — Braziers speak faster than riders; warning as weapon. *She can light a signal with a single word. The word is a dead man’s name.*
 7. **Wergild Counter** — Keeps tallies, ends grudges, starts others; law as math. *His abacus beads are sheep knuckles. He clicks them in his sleep.*
 8. **Dwarf Warden** — Khaz-Vurim road; toll first, friendship later. *Her hammer has a chip where she cracked a liar’s skull. She never fixed it.*
 9. **Oath-Singer** — Verses bind hands and open gates; word as iron. *Her tongue is forked—she can praise and curse in the same breath.*
 10. **Lowland Factor** — Buying iron blooms, selling trouble; coin as catalyst. *He carries two ledgers. One is for the clans. One is for the tax man.*
- J **Bride-Carrier** — Peaceweaver walking bloodlines with a knife and a smile. *Her knife has a wooden blade. The threat is real.*
- Q **Lady of Tor** — Clan-chief in cloak and mail; her nod is winter or spring. *She lost a hand to a Viterran knight. Her iron hook has a built-in bell.*
- K **Council of Cairns** — Greybeards and granite wills; they do not hurry. *They have sentenced men to exile. The sentences take a year to deliver.*
- A **Stone-Speaker** — Dwarf envoy whose word moves roads and rates. *He carries a tuning fork. Strike it, and the mountain answers.*

(Mist/Feud/Toll) Upland mist—hear horns but not edges; feud rekindled—cousin spits on guest-law.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Upland Mist** — Hear horns but not edges; navigation by sound and instinct. *The horns are calling a muster. Which clan? You will know when they arrive.*
3. **Feud Rekindled** — Cousin spits on guest-law; knives wake from sleep. *The spit lands at your feet. The insult is now yours to answer.*
4. **Bridge Dropped** — Pursuers fall... and the route with them; passage becomes peril. *The bridge was cut from the far side. Someone expected you.*
5. **Black-Rent Demand** — “Privateering on land”; pay or be “escorted.” *The escort has a noose. Choose your words carefully.*
6. **Wergild Breach** — Silver short by a head; tempers long by a spear’s length. *The bereaved clan has a new widow. She is sharpening a blade.*

7. **Snow-Squall** — Seals the notch; tents turn to coffins if you dally. *The snow is tinged grey—ash from the Pass. Someone burned an offering.*
8. **Dwarf Toll Hike** — At the Steps; papers right, purses wrong; law costs coin. *The warden quotes a rate from a book that wasn't there yesterday.*
9. **Cattle Scatter** — Bells ringing downslope; the cover story runs with the herd. *The bells are yours. The herd is not.*
10. **False Alarm** — Watch-fire beacons ridge to ridge; levies seize the road. *The fire was lit by a child. Or a spy. The levy doesn't care.*
- J **Bride-Theft** — A wedding becomes a war-party; you are caught between both. *The bride's veil is on the ground. The groom's own kin drew first blood.*
- Q **Royal Incursion** — Neighbor's "lawful" arrests in the uplands; flags and chains. *The flags are Viterran. The chains are new. The prisoners are children.*
- K **Clan Muster** — Horns call men from steadings to spears; all traffic stops. *The muster stone is black with old blood. The new blood will be red.*
- A **Hill-Fall** — Rain liquefies a slope; trail, proof, and bodies slide together. *The mud is warm. Something underneath is still breathing.*

(Oath/Right/Token) Guest-right token—one hearth owes food, bed, and steel at dawn; guide's braid for lawful passage on sheepwalks.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Guest-Token** — One hearth owes food, bed, and steel at dawn. *The token is a knucklebone from a feast. The host's name is carved on it.*
3. **Guide's Braid** — Lawful passage on named sheepwalks (once). *The braid is woven from horsehair and a promise. Unravel it to return.*
4. **Ford Remission** — Cross Wergild Ford free for a season; water as ally. *The remission is a white stone. Skip it across the ford to pay.*
5. **Feud-Charter** — Two clans sheath blades until the next harvest. *The charter is a broken spear. Each clan keeps a half.*
6. **Bloom Allotment** — Claim on a week's iron from a hill bloomery. *The bloomery is a woman's name. She decides how much you get.*
7. **Watch-Code** — Today's beacon order from Three-Fires Ridge. *The code is a sequence of smoke puffs. Read it, and the hills will watch for you.*
8. **Pass-Ring** — Dwarf road priority for one train of carts. *The ring is iron. Wear it on your off hand.*
9. **Bride-Escrow** — Hold the purse; both sides must humor you. *The purse is a leather bag. The coins inside are from a dead man's hoard.*
10. **Shelter Writ** — Grey Tor opens its gates during storm or pursuit. *The writ is a raven feather. Burn it to claim shelter.*
- J **Oath-Bracelet** — One binding vow ends cleanly, witnessed. *The bracelet is silver. The clasp is a wolf's head. Bite it to break the oath.*
- Q **Council Audience** — The Cairns hear you alone; precedent sticks like stone. *The audience is held at midnight. The stones glow when they agree.*

K Road Commission — Collect tolls on a stretch of pass (for now). *The commission is a wooden staff. Plant it at the toll gate.*

A Stone-Clause — Temporary exception to dwarf toll or law, sealed. *The clause is a single rune. Carve it on the toll post, and the mountain will honor it—once.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (oaths/rights/tokens) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **stone and spear** motifs—cairns that watch, voices that echo, and oaths that cut deeper than steel.

Additional Features

- **Guest-Law:** Breaking hospitality stains a name worse than breaking a sword. Guest-right tokens guarantee shelter, but abuse invites a blood feud.
- **Wergild System:** Every injury has a price in cattle or coin. Wergild counters keep tallies that outlive the injured; debts pass to kin.
- **Dwarf Toll Roads:** Khaz-Vurim gates charge for passage, but their roads are sure and swift. Pass-rings grant priority, but dwarf law is strict.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice in Grey Tor. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the reivers, trying to untie her own cord from a Viterran death warrant.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The cairns are Class II Anchor sites—the spirits of clan heroes bound by unfinished wergild. Saikou Ira would carry a bag of silver instead of a mirror here.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends passes from hand to hand at the Wergild Ford. Pay with it, and the feud ends—but your firstborn’s name is now in the coin’s tally.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Ubral psions are called “Stone-Listeners.” They hear the memory of oaths. The Council of Cairns employs two—and has never trusted a verdict they didn’t whisper.
- **The Ninth:** In any Ubral scene, the ninth stone in a cairn is always warm. Touch it, and you will remember an oath you never swore.

Ubral Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Cairn:** Crumble a crust at the base of a standing stone. Ignore the first *Upland Mist* penalty.
- **Knot the Guest-Cup:** Tie a single knot in the handle of a drinking cup. Cancel *Feud Rekindled* or take –1 die on your next hospitality roll (your choice).

- **Name to the Ford:** Whisper a dead enemy's name into the Wergild Ford. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from their kin this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Lady of Tor.

Patronage & Power

In Ubral, power flows through clan bonds, guest-right, and the careful balance of honor and iron. Clan chiefs maintain authority through wergild, moots, and the respect of their people, while the dwarves of Khaz-Vurim wield influence through their control of mountain passes and trade routes. Law is personal and passed down through generations, with each oath and debt creating a web of obligation that can last centuries.

For the GM: Patronage in Ubral revolves around hospitality, protection, and the resolution of feuds. Rewards often take the form of tokens, charters, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, bracelets, writs) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival clans issue conflicting protections, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the moots, hill-forts, and watch-fires as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of custom and kinship determines success.

In Ubral, your word is your bond, and your bond determines whether you walk in peace or peril.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **clan guards** or **reiver scouts**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **watch-fires** or **hill guides**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **feud-kin**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable weather**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Hill guide** or **clan chief** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **mist** or **bridge collapse**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **reiver band** or **feud-kin** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **clan warriors**, **reivers**, or **dwarf wardens** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **feud declared**/**bridge falls**/**snow closes pass**.

- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **Lady of Tor, Council of Cairns, or Stone-Speaker** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **mist thickens/bridge drops/hill falls**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ubral (Stone & Oath):** Cairns shift position, voices echo from empty air, oaths bind mid-speech.
- **Ubral (Hill Law):** Paths reroute without warning, tolls increase mid-journey, guest-rights expire.
- **Ubral (Feud Culture):** Insults are overheard, weapons appear in sheaths, kin arrive unsummoned.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Wolf-Road Captain (reiver-king on a piebald mare)** — *Phases:* Ride-Through → Torch the Fold → Laugh in Rain. *Cracks:* present a **Watch-Code** or **Guide’s Braid** to reduce his effect; strike a truce with a season’s cattle.
- **The Bride-Thief of Black Broom (mask of bog-rush)** — *Phases:* Switch the Bride → Bog Embrace → Nettle Oath. *Cracks:* play a **Bride-Charter** to freeze blades; a **Well-Blessing** nulls one bog move.
- **Stone Auditor of Khaz-Vurim (dwarf toll-magistrate)** — *Phases:* Double the Toll → Weigh the Lie → Seal the Switchback. *Cracks:* present two of {**Pass-Ring, Stamped Load-List, Named Sponsor**} to downgrade his authority.
- **The Oath-Eater Wight (cairn-bound revenant)** — *Phases:* Take the Word → Cold of Cairn → Bind Witness. *Cracks:* **Oath-Bracelet** or a skald’s stanza spoken over bread and blood cancels one move; repay an ancestral wergild.
- **Grey-Tor Hedge-Witch (heather crown, ash staff)** — *Phases:* Weather-Turn → Hag-Stone Sight → Bind the Gate. *Cracks:* gift a **Bloom Allotment** or a winter’s salt; a **Council Audience** compels parley.

Legendary Sites & Trials

- **Sheepwalk Ledge Trial** — Speak one honest lie to pass. On success, set Position one step safer for the next border scene; on failure, start *Kin Arrive*.
- **Wergild Ford Weighing** — Cast silver on the table-rock. If paid in full, clear 1 *Feud-Smoke*; if short, *Wergild Breach* enters play.

- **Pass of Ashes Vigil** — Hold a fire through the night storm. Success grants **Shelter Writ**; a miss summons the *Oath-Eater Wight* at weak strength.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Oath Dial (Honor ↔ Cunning):** Track how the party navigates Ubral norms.
 - *Honor High*: +1 Position when invoking guest-right, keeping truce, or paying wergild promptly; first ambush/raid action each session starts one step worse.
 - *Cunning High*: +1 Effect on raids, evasions, and border tricks; first formal parley or oath-bound request each session starts one step worse.
 - Center the dial by restoring stolen cattle, hosting an enemy well, or submitting to a cairn ruling.
- **Feud Math (fast settlement):** Lay three markers: **Blood, Beasts, Blame**.
 1. Make a single *Parley/Command/Study* roll per side. On a hit, move one marker to your side; great Effect moves two.
 2. Win any two to settle: *Blood* = oath/hostage, *Beasts* = wergild in cattle/coin, *Blame* = public apology/verse.
 3. Miss: mark *Feud-Smoke* [4]. At 4, the losing side names a lawful target (bridge, herd, guide).
- **Guest-Right Procedure:**
 - Present a **Guest-Token** (or bread and salt). Host must choose: *Shelter*, *Escort at Dawn*, or *Neutral Meal*.
 - Breaking it creates *Blood-Oath* [6] against the violator; any Ubral ally may spend 1 $\diamond$ *totickittwice*.
 - Abiding it clears 1 tick from *Feud-Smoke* and grants +1d to the next social action in that steading.
- **Watchfire Net (ridge signals):**
 - Two clocks: *Beat the Beacons* vs *Ridge Aflame* (size by highest rank in your seed).
 - Choose a lane each exchange: *Low Fold* (slow, stealth), *Sheepwalk* (tricky, quick), *Road* (fast, obvious).
 - Advantage: *Low Fold* $\triangleright$ *Road* (conceal), *Road* $\triangleright$ *Sheepwalk* (speed), *Sheepwalk* $\triangleright$ *Low Fold* (shortcuts).
 - *False Alarm* (1 *SB*): light or douse a misleading brazier; shift one segment between the two clocks.
- **Reiver Ride (mounted chase):**
 - Track *Remounts* (3): each push for speed trades 1 remount for +1d or +1 Effect. At 0, gain *Blown Mounts* condition.
 - *Hag-Stone Cut*: pass a known gap (*Sheepwalk Ledge*, *Droppers' Bridge*) to force pursuers to roll or fall behind.
- **Khaz-Vurim Protocol:**
 - Present any two: **Pass-Ring, Stamped Load-List, Named Sponsor**. Two = safe passage; one = pay toll + scrutiny; none = delay and search.
 - *Stone-Clause* may override one dwarf law once; afterwards start *Ledger Notice* [3] with

the wardens (prices rise, patience falls).

- *Tally Truth*: you may substitute exact weights/measures for charm or coin to improve Position by one step with dwarves.

- **Bride-Peace Interlude:**

- Play a **Bride-Charter** to suspend violence at a scene. Everyone sheaths—or earns *Song Shame* [4]. When it fills, a skald memorializes the insult (ongoing -1d with that clan).

- **Start-of-Scene Omens (1d6):**

1. *Clear Ridge*: first signal test gains +1d.
2. *Lowling Herd*: +1d to tracking or herding; -1d to stealth near cattle.
3. *Wet Stone*: climbs start one step worse; mending gear is easier (free repair tick).
4. *Old Verse Remembered*: first oath/plea gains +1d if spoken in rhyme.
5. *Border Drums*: Viterra patrols near; papers safer, raiding harsher.
6. *Dwarf Toll Day*: prices firm; any $\Diamond$ tied to roads counts double value at the Steps.

- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Ubral Flavor):**

- 1 SB → *Mud and Heather*: footing worsens; next physical action -1d or mark *Winded*.
- 2 SB → *Kin Arrive*: add a rival cousin/ally who changes the ask or splits the pot.
- 3+ SB → *Cairn Decrees*: a standing stone “speaks” (witnesses recall the law); swap one held $\Diamond$ for a less right until you make amends.

- **Reputation Echoes:**

- *Guest-Faithful*: once/session downgrade a social backlash inside a steading; next time you refuse hospitality, mark *Feud-Smoke* +1.
- *Reiver-Favored*: +1 Effect to seize cattle/contraband on the move; city gates start one step worse Position.
- *Stone-Friend*: +1d with dwarf wardens on roads; any false measure triggers *Ledger Notice* +1.

Chapter 21

Silkstrand

City of Bridges & Dyewater. Silkstrand is strung across canals and arches, a place where every bridge is a ledger line and every current carries rumor. The dyes that stain its waters never wash out, and neither do the bargains struck in shadow. Merchants rise and fall with the Exchange, bravos carve reputations on the planks of Three-Queens Bridge, and curses cling to the very cloth that leaves the looms.

21.1 Silkstrand — “City of Bridges & Dyewater”

The Matron (Elite): “In this city, every bridge is a ledger and every current carries coin. The dye that stains our waters never washes out, just as the bargains struck in our shadows never quite fade from memory.”

Bobbin-Runner (Commoner): “I can cross this city faster than any grown-up, and I know which planks creak and which merchants lie. The bridges remember every step, and the canals carry more secrets than fish.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Silkstrand is a city strung across canals and arches, a place where every bridge is a ledger line and every current carries rumor. The dyes that stain its waters never wash out, and neither do the bargains struck in shadow. Merchants rise and fall with the Exchange, bravos carve reputations on the planks of Three-Queens Bridge, and curses cling to the very cloth that leaves the looms. The Matron rules from her palazzo stairs with velvet and iron, but the city itself belongs to silk and tide.

What you notice first: The clash of dye-stained water against ancient stone. The constant rumble of cart wheels on bridge planks. The way every handshake lingers a heartbeat too long—as if both parties are checking for threads.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never spit into a canal while naming a rival. The water remembers, and the curse you send may come back wrapped around your own throat.

Regional Mood: Bridges and Dyewater

Here, beauty is bought with blood and color, and both wash downstream. Silkstrand is not lawless—it is **layered**. Above the tide lies the world of guild charters, notarial seals, and the

Matron's velvet justice. Below the bridges, in the weeping arches and the midnight boat lanes, a quieter economy runs on whispers, borrowed keys, and the careful omission of names. The city's bravos duel for reputation on Three-Queens Bridge while factors bribe clerks in the Archivolt. Every alliance is a knot that can be pulled loose. Every fortune is a thread that can be cut.

Starting Location: Three-Queens Bridge, dripping with dyewater, its stones painted in a thousand forgotten shades. A Guildmistress with dyed hands offers a dye-permit. "The Redwater boils," she says. "And something in the canals remembers your scent. Bring me three bolts of untaxed crimson before the Exchange closes, or the Archivolt will find your name in a dead notary's ledger."

(Bridge/Canal/Mill) Mulberry garths and wormhouses outside North Gate with steam and sweet rot; Filature hall where whispers travel faster than steam.

Spades — Places

2. **Mulberry Garths** — Wormhouses outside North Gate; steam, sweet rot, desperate pickers. *The pickers' hands are stained black. They say the color never fades, even after death.*
3. **Filature Hall** — Cocoon-boil chambers; whispers travel faster than steam. *The steam carries voices from last season. Some say they're warnings.*
4. **Redwater Dyeworks** — Along stain-canal; brick stained forever with forgotten dyes. *The dye-runners wear lead masks. The ones who don't die young—or wrong.*
5. **Spindle Tower** — Creaking windlass-lifts and posted rates; heights and hazards. *The lift operator has a bell. He rings it once for every passenger who didn't pay.*
6. **Three-Queens Bridge** — Stacked market stalls; cells under arches, reputations made and broken. *The cells are for debtors. The walls are washed with canal water so no one forgets the smell.*
7. **Salt Gate Quay** — Rope booms, chalk tallies, tired eyes; customs and coin. *The chalk is mixed with ground bone. A false tally writes itself in a dead hand.*
8. **Silk Exchange** — Floor with chalk circles and clappers for opening bids. *The clappers are whale ribs. The bids echo, and sometimes the echo answers.*
9. **Ropewalk Sheds** — Arrow-straight; bruisers hired by the yard, muscle for hire. *The rope-walkers never look back. They say a rope remembers who pulled it last.*
10. **Old Arsenal** — Free Company's barracks now; arms and ambitions stored. *The arsenal's bell rings at odd hours. No one admits ringing it.*
- J **The Archivolt** — Arcaded street of notaries, seals, and quiet knives. *The notaries write in lemon juice. Heat reveals the truth—or a facsimile.*
- Q **Basilica of Azerin** — Weaver-saint; confraternity rooms hum with vows. *The saint's icon has one eye. The other was traded for the secret of red dye.*
- K **Palazzo della Matrona** — Ruling seat with private river stairs; velvet and iron. *The Matrona's barge is rowed by debtors who have repaid in years, not coin.*
- A **Flood-Stairs** — Bronze flood marks, bell rope ready when the Strand runs wild. *The flood marks go up to nine. The ninth step is underwater—always.*

(Guild/Factor/Crown) Bobbin-runner child with feet sure on parapets; foreign factor seeking warehouse and friend at customs.

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Bobbin-Runner** — Child with sure feet on parapets, rumors in pocket. *She ties a knot in her apron string for every secret she carries. The apron is nearly solid knots.*
3. **Mulberry Steward** — Counting leaves; desperate for pickers, quick with coin. *His left hand is missing two fingers—lost to a cocoon-rot curse. He calls it a bargain.*
4. **Foreign Factor** — Seeking warehouse and friend at customs; connections for sale. *He carries three ledgers. One for the Matron, one for the Archivolt, one for himself.*
5. **Guildmistress** — Dyers’ hands stained, permits tighter than purse strings. *She can tell your guild by the stain on your cuff. She never forgets a color.*
6. **Bridge Bailiff** — Rents stalls, sells gossip by the breath; power in position. *He rings a small bell before each announcement. The tone tells you if it’s truth or theater.*
7. **Archivolt Notary** — “Fixes” missing recitals—for a donation; law as service. *His inkwell contains a single drop of his own blood. He renews it each spring.*
8. **Watch Captain** — Condotta to three lords; passwords change with the wind. *He wears a mask on feast days. No one has seen his face in seven years.*
9. **Spinner-Matron** — Wormhouses; temper like hot copper, secrets in the steam. *She names each cocoon after a dead rival. The silk is said to carry their complaints.*
10. **Exchange Caller** — A clap can still a thousand voices; auction master. *He lost his voice to a curse. Now he claps in a language only the bids understand.*
- J **Night-Boat Smuggler** — “Ravel,” silent oar, louder favors; shadows for coin. *His boat has no name. The canal would remember it, and memory is a kind of tax.*
- Q **The Matron** — Patient, velvet, iron; the city’s thread pulled through her hands. *She has never raised her voice. The city learned to fear her silences.*
- K **Lame King’s Envoy** — Velvet boots; claims certain alleys “protected.” *His cane is hollow. Inside is a letter of marque that expired a decade ago.*
- A **Saint of Warps** — If real: sees curses braided in cloth; holy unraveler. *Her eyes are milk-white. She sees not the cloth, but the threads of obligation within.*

(Flood/Interdict/Riot) Flood siren with gates lowering—move crates or kiss them goodbye; quarantine flag at Redwater sealing dyers’ row.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Flood Siren** — Gates lowering; move crates or kiss them goodbye to tide. *The gate-keeper’s palm is marked with a bell. Cross it with silver to hurry.*
3. **Quarantine Flag** — Redwater dyers’ row sealed; your cargo implicated. *The flag is dyed with lamp-black and something else—something that smells of graves.*
4. **Loom Strike** — Over “bad cocoons”; streets fill with idle frames. *The striking weavers wear red threads around their wrists. They will not speak first.*
5. **Seal Counterfeit** — Discovered at Archivolt; all contracts frozen. *The forged seal is warm. The real one is cold. Touch both to know which is which.*
6. **Bridge Riot** — A dropped stall blocks lanes; tempers boil faster than vats. *The riot started over a missed bell-ring. Or a stolen bolt. Or a look.*

7. **Condottieri Flip** — Colors change; watchwords shift, escorts vanish. *The captain's new banner is stitched with thread from his old captain's shroud.*
8. **Blackwood Panic** — Witch-posts hammered on quay doors overnight. *The posts are from the Direwood edge. They sweat sap that smells of old fear.*
9. **Fungus Blight** — Silk-fungus; wormhouses burn, refugees flood piazze. *The fungus glows faintly in the dark. It spells names—sometimes yours.*
10. **Salt-Tax Doubled** — At Salt Gate; boats stack three deep, bribes flow. *The tax collector wears a mask. Beneath it, his face is a salt-caked skull.*
- J **Duel Challenge** — Booked on Three-Queens Bridge; you're named as seconds. *The challenge is written on silk. Burn it to refuse—and lose face forever.*
- Q **Exchange Corner** — Rivals hoard raw thread; prices go vertical. *The cornering merchant has a ledger bound in human skin. The names inside are his competitors.*
- K **Saint's Procession** — Closes half the wards; ignore at peril, faith walks the streets. *The icon weeps dyewater. The faithful collect it in silver cups.*
- A **Curse Awakened** — In canals: no route reaches the address you seek. *The water is still. Your reflection is gone. You are still here—for now.*

(Permit/Seat/Escort) Bridge token for peak-hour cart crossing free; dye-permit chit to process “questionable” color this week.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Bridge Token** — One peak-hour cart crossing free; traffic as currency. *The token is a bronze coin with a hole in the center. The hole is the toll.*
3. **Dye-Permit** — Process “questionable” color this week; law bends for coin. *The permit is written on dyed vellum. The color changes with the tide.*
4. **Warehouse Seal** — From Matron's office; rivals legally shut out. *The seal is a brass bell. Ring it once to claim the space.*
5. **Exchange Pass** — Day pass to trade without sponsor; freedom in paper. *The pass is stamped with a spider. The spider's legs are the signatures of three guilds.*
6. **Watergate Priority** — Skip one flood closure when it matters; tide waits for none. *The priority token is a dried eel skin. Show it, and the gate-keeper spits but stands aside.*
7. **Notarial Indulgence** — Retrofit a missing recital; past deals stand. *The indulgence is written in lemon juice. Heat it to see the terms.*
8. **Wormhouse Allotment** — Claim a share of the next hatch; future in cocoons. *The allotment is a silk-worm egg. Keep it warm, or it will hatch into a debt.*
9. **Ropewalk Credit** — Hire crews before you have coin; muscle on credit. *The credit is a knotted rope. Cut a knot for each favor called.*
10. **Arsenal Key** — One night's issue for retinue; arms in trusted hands. *The key is a finger bone. The lock is a gauntleted fist.*
- J **Condotta Rider** — City watch escorts through any ward, once. *The rider's horse has iron shoes. The sparks tell him who to watch.*
- Q **Matron's Audience** — Private whisper becomes policy; velvet commands. *The Matron's ear is a bell. Speak into it, and the city listens—once.*

- K Tax-Farm Share** — On Three-Queens stalls for a season; profit in peddlers. *The share is a tally stick. Break it in half to claim your portion.*
- A Golden Thread** — Temporary charter to set tolls on a named canal. *The thread is real gold. It will not break—but it will stretch.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (permits/seats/escorts) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **silk and water** motifs—threads that bind, currents that remember, bargains that stain canal beds.

Additional Features

- **Duel Etiquette:** Duels fought on bridges draw crowds eager to wager on blood. Refusing stains a name worse than losing.
- **Dyewater Omens:** Canals run strange colors at dawn; red foretells riots, blue brings calm, black means curses awakened.
- **Matron’s Seal:** Any contract bearing her seal is law—but the Matron is known to rescind seals without warning, leaving debts tangled.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain run a hospice near the Salt Gate. They ask no payment—but they cut threads. A renegade Sister hides among the bobbin-runners, trying to untie her own cord.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** The Archivolt notaries keep a secret ledger of unquiet debts—Class II Anchors bound to unpaid contracts. Saikou Ira would have a seizure here.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A cursed bolt of silk surfaces on the Exchange every decade. Anyone who wears it prospers—until the next full moon. The bolt is due to appear tonight.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Silkstrand psions are called “Weft-Readers.” They see the threads of obligation. The Matron employs three—and has never let them meet each other.
- **The Ninth:** In any Silkstrand scene, the ninth bridge crossed in a day leads somewhere unexpected. The wise stop at eight and take a boat.

Silkstrand Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Canal:** Toss a crust into the water before crossing a new bridge. Ignore the first *Bridge Riot* penalty.
- **Knot the Thread:** Tie a single knot in a scrap of silk. Cancel *Seal Counterfeit* or take –1 die on your next negotiation (your choice).
- **Name to the Dyewater:** Whisper a debtor’s name into the canal at dawn. Gain +1 Effect when collecting from them this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Archivolt.

Patronage & Power

In Silkstrand, power flows through commerce, connections, and the careful weaving of influence. The Matron maintains control through a web of guilds, factors, and condottieri, each bound by contracts and customs that shift like the tides. Merchants rise and fall with the Exchange, while the city's bravos and smugglers operate in the spaces between law and profit.

For the GM: Patronage in Silkstrand revolves around access—to bridges, to warehouses, to the Exchange floor itself. Rewards often take the form of permits, seals, or safe passage that can be leveraged into greater influence. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (seals, tokens, contracts) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guilds issue conflicting charters, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the bridges, markets, and Exchange as arenas for social contests, where reputation and connections determine success.

In Silkstrand, your word is your weave, and your weave determines whether you rise or drown.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **city watch** or **rival merchants**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **crowds** or **bridge traffic**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **customs**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable tide**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Bridge bailiff** or **guildmaster** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **crowd movement** or **flood**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **rival merchant** or **hired bravo** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **condottieri**, **smugglers**, or **guild enforcers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **flood hits/contract voided/duel declared**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: The Matron, Watch Captain, or Guildmistress** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **flood rises/bridge collapses/procession blocks streets.**
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Silkstrand (Bridges & Trade):** Bridge planks shift underfoot, bargains restructure mid-speech, coins change hands without touch.
- **Silkstrand (Dyewater):** Canal colors shift ominously, dyes stain more than cloth, water carries whispered names.
- **Silkstrand (Duel Culture):** Challenges are issued mid-conversation, seconds appear from the crowd, honor prices rise with each breath.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Corseted Ledger (cursed accounting bound in silk)** — *Phases:* Friendly Audit → Retroactive Debts → Names as Collateral. *Cracks:* burn one forged seal in public; settle a rival’s debt at cost; wash the book on Flood-Stairs at high bell.
- **Archivolt Ragman (collector of “missing recitals”)** — *Phases:* Quiet Inserts → Paper Hunts → Bridge Vetoes. *Cracks:* win a duel for precedent; expose a double-entry altar; break his pen with the Matron’s Seal.
- **Color That Walks (dyewater revenant)** — *Phases:* Stain → Spread → Drown. *Cracks:* confess on Three-Queens; bind scent-rights properly; let the Saint of Warps unpick a life’s thread (costly).

Chapter 22

The Ways Between

Spiritways & Veilways. Between Death and Dreams lies a country of crossings. Roads remember promises; milestones remember names you never spoke. The Ways Between do not measure miles—they measure choices. Walk softly, pay what the path asks, and mind which version of you arrives.

22.1 The Ways Between — “Spiritways & Veilways”

The Wayfinder (Elite): “I exist only in the moment of choice, the breath between one path and another. To guide here is to understand that every way leads somewhere, but only the wise know which somethings are worth the journey.”

Lost Pilgrim (Commoner): “The paths here don’t care where you think you’re going – they care where you need to be. Best walk softly and listen to what the waystones whisper when you pass. I’ve been walking for... I forget how long. But the road hasn’t lost me yet.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Between Death and Dreams lies a country of crossings. Roads remember promises; milestones remember names you never spoke. The Ways Between do not measure miles—they measure choices. Here, a wrong turn might lead to yesterday, or to a version of yourself who made a different decision. The mist does not hide landmarks; it hides destinations. Every threshold demands a toll, and the currency is always something you did not know you had: a memory, a fear, a forgotten debt. Walk softly, pay what the path asks, and mind which version of you arrives.

What you notice first: The air tastes of copper and old keys. Your footsteps echo half a beat too late. The waystones are warm—and they pulse like hearts.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never answer a question asked by a reflection. The answer will bind you to the path you did not choose.

Regional Mood: The Road That Remembers

Here, the road is not a thing—it is a witness. It remembers every traveler who has walked it, every promise made at a crossroads, every lie told to a milestone. The Ways Between do not forgive,

but they do not forget either. They offer passage in exchange for truth. The longer you walk, the more the path learns about you. By the time you reach your destination, you may find that the destination knows you better than you know yourself. Some travelers never leave. They become waystones, their faces pressed into moss, their names still warm on the lips of the next pilgrim.

Starting Location: A crossroad shrine of black glass stones, where travelers meet their reflections coming the other way. The shrine is silent except for the soft hum of the stones. A Backwards Pilgrim stands at the crossroads, facing the direction you came from. “The Thirteenth Stone speaks,” they say. “But the path chooses who arrives. What did you bury on the road here? The stones can smell it.”

(Path/Crossing/Threshold) Mist-shrouded ford where water runs uphill; footsteps echo backwards; bone-lit corridor where shadows walk the walls.

Spades — Places

2. **Mist-Ford** — Water runs uphill; footsteps echo backwards through time. *The ford shows you wading through your own past. Do not look down at the water.*
 3. **Bone Corridor** — Shadows walk the walls but never touch the floor; light as memory. *The bones are not from any creature you know. They shift when you blink.*
 4. **Threshold Arch** — Shows a reflection as someone you might have been; the past as a mirror. *The reflection has a scar you never got. It asks how you avoided it.*
 5. **Spiral Path** — Ascends but returns to the same stone marker; the journey as meditation. *Each loop, the stone moves closer to the center. Or you do.*
 6. **Promise Bridge** — Cross with a vow and it remembers your debt; an oath as a toll. *The bridge’s planks are old letters. Read one, and you may owe the writer.*
 7. **Crossroads** — All four paths lead to the same destination, but different tomorrows. *The center stone is warm. A coin placed there will vanish—or be accepted.*
 8. **Stone Circle** — Marks where a village used to be; the houses are now constellations. *The stars are too close. You can touch them. They crumble like ash.*
 9. **Memory Tunnel** — Hear the thoughts of those who passed here; the past as an echo. *The thoughts are in a language you almost understand. One word is your name.*
 10. **Fossil Stairs** — Each step is an eye that watches your ascent; the climb as scrutiny. *The eyes belong to those who fell here. They blink in sequence.*
- J **Waystation** — The keeper trades in unfinished conversations; words as currency. *The keeper has no face. It wears the faces of those who paused too long.*
- Q **Junction** — Paths physically collide; you must choose which reality to follow. *The collision sounds like breaking glass. The glass reforms into a door.*
- K **Long Mile** — The road stretches differently for each traveler; distance as perception. *You are the only one walking. The others are already at the end.*
- A **Thirteenth Stone** — Where the path reveals its true destination; truth as revelation. *The stone whispers. The whisper is a promise you made to yourself and broke.*

(Wayfarer/Spirit/Dream-walker) Lost pilgrim who thinks they’re going home but forgot where; toll-taker accepting payment in forgotten memories.

Hearts — Travelers & Guides

2. **Lost Pilgrim** — Thinks they’re going home but forgot where; destination as a memory. *Their pack is full of stones. Each stone is a forgotten promise.*
3. **Toll-Taker** — Accepts payment in memories you didn’t know you had. *Their scales weigh truth and echo. A balanced scale means you pass—for now.*
4. **Wayward Guide** — Directions technically correct, morally questionable. *They point with a broken compass. The needle spins, but the path is true.*
5. **Dream-Merchant** — Carries a sack of nightmares and one perfect dream for sale. *The perfect dream is their own. They are selling it because they cannot wake up.*
6. **Child-Ghost** — Knows shortcuts but charges in riddles; wisdom as a puzzle. *The riddles have no answer—only a choice. Choose wrong, and you become a child.*
7. **Wounded Walker** — Bleeding metaphor; their pain grows thorns along the path. *The thorns have faces. Each face is someone they failed to save.*
8. **Map-Merchant** — Selling maps to places that don’t exist yet; the future as a commodity. *The maps change as you watch. The destination is always one page ahead.*
9. **Guide-Dog** — Made of shadow and starlight; follows those who walk with purpose. *It never barks. It whines when you are about to make a mistake.*
10. **Backwards Pilgrim** — Moving through time; their steps erase what just happened. *They are walking toward their birth. Every step, they forget something.*
- J **Soul-Ferryman** — Carries the luggage of the living; a burden as a service. *The luggage is full of things you never said. The ferryman knows them all.*
- Q **Road’s Child** — Born where paths crossed, raised by waymarks; navigation as instinct. *They have no navel. They were never born—they simply began.*
- K **Dead-Road Keeper** — Ensures proper passage for those who should not walk. *Their lantern burns a cold blue. The flame does not flicker.*
- A **The Wayfinder** — Exists only in the moment a choice is made; a decision as an entity. *They are every guide you ever needed. They are also every road you refused.*

(Veil-Thin/Dream-Bleed/Wayward) Path loops back to show your funeral preparations; reality thins—you see the dreams of sleeping travelers.

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Funeral Loop** — The path shows your funeral preparations; death as a destination. *The mourners are people you have not met yet. They seem to know you well.*
3. **Reality Thins** — You see the dreams of sleeping travelers; the boundary as a veil. *A dreamer mutters your name. They are dreaming of a choice you will make tomorrow.*
4. **Waymark Lies** — Points the wrong way; trust leads to places that never were. *The waymark has a crack. Through the crack, you see a path you should have taken.*
5. **Dream-Bleed** — Waking memories become someone else’s nightmares. *You remember a childhood fear that was not yours. It still terrifies you.*
6. **Toll Demanded** — Currency you did not know you carried; payment as a revelation. *The toll is a secret you told a dead person. They are now standing behind you.*

7. **Path Split** — Each version of you remembers differently; identity as a choice. *One you is smiling. One you is weeping. One you is already walking away.*
8. **Gravity Shifts** — Emotional weight grows physically heavy; a burden as physics. *Your pack feels heavier. Inside is a regret you forgot you carried.*
9. **Time-Sickness** — You arrive before you left; paradox shadows follow. *Your past self waves at you. Do not wave back.*
10. **Truth Payment** — The road remembers your lies and demands truth as payment. *The lie is carved on a stone. The stone is warm. It knows your temperature.*
- J **Crossroads Judgment** — The path you chose judges the ones you did not; decision as karma. *A ghost of the road not taken asks why. You have one sentence to answer.*
- Q **Memory-Thief** — A rest stop keeper pays in counterfeit recollections. *The memory is almost right. The color of the sky is wrong.*
- K **Forbidden Path** — Opens only for those already lost; loss as a key. *The path smells of old tears. You taste salt on your lips.*
- A **Convergence** — All travelers arrive together, none recall how; arrival as a mystery. *You recognize everyone. You have never seen any of them before.*

(**True Name/Safe Passage/Waywisdom**) Waymark that always points toward your next important choice; a token of passage that the road recognizes as belonging.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Choice Compass** — Always points toward your next important choice. *The needle is a splinter of the Thirteenth Stone. It hums when you are near a decision.*
3. **Passage Token** — The road recognizes you as one who belongs. *The token is a braid of your own hair. You do not remember cutting it.*
4. **Dream-Catcher** — Filters nightmares from your rest; sleep as a sanctuary. *The catcher is woven from old promises. It smells of lavender and regret.*
5. **Truth-Compass** — Points to what you most need to know, not what you want. *The compass has no needle. The housing spins until you speak a truth.*
6. **Memory-Anchor** — Keeps you from losing yourself on deeper paths. *The anchor is a river stone. Your name is carved on it in a language you have never seen.*
7. **Safe Haven** — A guaranteed rest stop without complication. *The haven is a dry arch. The arch is a doorframe with no door.*
8. **Guide-Light** — Burns the color of your truest intention; purpose as a beacon. *The light is blue. Blue means you are honest. Red means you are not.*
9. **Path-Cutter** — Cuts distance through metaphor, not space. *The cutter is a pair of shears. Cut a memory, and the road between here and there vanishes.*
10. **Debt-Clearing** — The road forgives one obligation you thought you owed. *The obligation was to a dead person. They are no longer dead on this path.*
- J **Crossroads Boon** — Choose among three paths, each exactly where you need to be. *The paths are labeled: Regret, Forgive, Forget. Choose carefully.*
- Q **Way-Wisdom** — Understand the language of paths and signs for one journey. *The waystones whisper. They are complaining about the last traveler. It was you.*

K Grace Passage — Walk safely through any dangerous crossing for one night. *The grace is a bell. Ring it, and the road will pretend not to see you.*

A Road’s Name — Call the path by its true name and command its nature. *The name is a single syllable. Speaking it will change the road—and you.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (true names/safe passages/waywisdom) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **dream-road** motifs—reflections that lie, paths that judge, destinations that choose the traveler.

Additional Features

- **Dream-Logic Navigation:** Any Ace introduces a metaphysical requirement (a sacrifice, a taboo, an exchange) that must be satisfied to pass. Name it at the table; the road will enforce it.
- **Reflection Points:** Face cards (J, Q, K) show alternate selves or unlived choices. Treat them as temporary NPCs or scene tags that can help, hinder, or tempt.
- **Memory Currency:** Diamonds may be traded for knowledge or safe passage as if they were memories. Describe the memory paid; the path (or its keeper) pays in kind.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain know the Ways Between as the Cord’s shadow. A lost Hollowed wanders here, its thread trailing into the mist. Follow it, and you may find a Sister who cut herself free.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Saikou Ira’s silver mirror shows the Ways Between as a tangled knot of unfulfilled obligations. He has walked three paths here. He will not speak of the fourth.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends lies at every crossroads. Pick it up, and the road will offer you a shortcut—but the coin will reappear in your pocket at the next junction, heavier.
- **The Grey Wanderer’s Grimoire:** Psions call the Ways Between “the Stair.” They climb it in their dreams, trading memories for glimpses of paths not yet walked. Some never wake.
- **The Ninth:** On any path in the Ways Between, the ninth step you take in a straight line will land on a threshold you did not see. The wise take eight steps, then pause to look around.

Ways Between Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Stones:** Crumble a crust at the base of a waystone. Ignore the first *Waymark Lies* penalty.
- **Knot the Path:** Tie a single knot in a piece of string and hang it from a milestone. Cancel *Path Split* or take –1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice).

- **Name to the Crossroads:** Whisper a dead traveler's name into the center stone. Gain +1 Effect when bargaining with a Toll-Taker this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Wayfinder.

Patronage & Power

In the Ways Between, power flows through understanding the metaphysical nature of paths, the ability to navigate dream-logic, and the careful management of obligations and truths. The true authorities are those who know the True Names of paths, can mediate between alternate versions of travelers, and understand the currency of memory and choice. Power here is not about commanding others, but about understanding the fundamental nature of journey and destination.

For the GM: Patronage in the Ways Between revolves around guidance, safe passage, and the ability to navigate metaphysical requirements. Rewards often take the form of waymarks, tokens, and knowledge that can be leveraged into greater understanding. To emphasize this:

- Tie rewards to visible symbols (tokens, compasses, lights) that can be challenged, stolen, or voided.
- Let rival guides issue conflicting directions, forcing players to choose whose favor matters more.
- Use the crossroads, waystations, and thresholds as arenas for social contests, where knowledge of path-logic determines success.

In the Ways Between, your understanding is your power, and your power determines whether you walk or are walked.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **path keepers** or **wayward spirits**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **travelers** or **memory echoes**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers** or **reflection points**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time** or **favorable path alignment**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** Toll-taker or wayward guide becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **path shift** or **reality thinning**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **memory-thief** or **forbidden path entity** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wayward spirits**, **path entities**, or **alternate selves** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.

- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **path loops/time shifts/reality fractures**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** **The Wayfinder, Dead-Road Keeper, or Road’s Child** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **reality thins/paths converge/time loops**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Ways Between (Dream-Logic):** Paths rearrange without warning, reflections speak unbidden, destinations shift mid-journey.
- **Ways Between (Memory Currency):** Memories become tangible, forgotten knowledge resurfaces, past and present blur.
- **Ways Between (Choice Consequences):** Decisions echo forward, alternate selves appear, paths judge moral weight.

Path-Moves & Procedures (Optional Depth)

Weighing of Steps (Travel Move) When the company enters a liminal path (Mist-Ford, Bone Corridor, etc.), choose one:

- **Pay the Toll:** Each PC names a small truth or a fond memory (GM: 1 SB banked, +1 Position on navigation).
- **Refuse the Toll:** +1d on Speed, but start a **Way-Debt** [4] clock.
- **Bargain the Toll:** Trade a *Diamond* reward as if it were a memory (see Memory Exchange below); cancel one imminent *Club* card in this scene.

When **Way-Debt** fills, trigger *Crossroads Judgment* at the next junction.

Reflection Duel (Social/Moral Test) When confronted by an alternate self or *Reflection Point*, state what that self wants from you and roll your best social action.

- **Success:** Gain a *Guide-Light* tag for the scene and clear 1 tick from **Paths Decide**.
- **Mixed:** Trade places for one exchange or take a **Condition: Disoriented**.
- **Miss:** The reflection walks away with one of your *Diamonds* (GM picks the most narratively apt).

	Memory Offered	Buys You	Sid
Memory Exchange (Rates & Risks)	A childhood smell, a forgotten nickname	+1 Position on one crossing	A f for
	A first failure or small betrayal	Cancel one minor Complication	Yo ogr
	A true fear you have never spoken	<i>Guide-Light</i> or <i>Way-Cord</i> -like effect	A c nig
	The details of a kept promise	<i>Safe Passage</i> for the party	An mis
	The meaning behind a scar	Convert one <i>Club</i> into <i>Trace</i> only	Th unt
	A perfect day (all details)	Treat the next <i>Heart</i> face as an ally	Sta the

Exchange Rule: If you pay the same *kind* of memory twice in a journey, start **Hollowing** [4]. When it fills, you gain the *Backwards Pilgrim* tag until you reclaim what was lost.

Way-Keys & Taboos (d6)

1. **Speak Last:** Only the final word said at a gate is true; others are “practice.” First speakers take –1d on their next test.
2. **Step Odd:** Crossings require an odd number of steps; even counts loop you back one scene.
3. **Name Nothing:** True names wake *Name-Theft*; use titles or lose a *Diamond*.
4. **Wet Iron:** A drop of water on iron cancels one glamour once per scene.
5. **Back Gift:** Leave something behind to go forward; refuse and tick **Way-Debt**.
6. **Answer Bent:** Answer a waystone’s question with a metaphor, not a fact, or trigger *Truth Payment*.

Boss Seeds (three-phase foes)

- **The Archivist of Unmade Roads (cloak stitched from surveyor’s cords)** — *Phases:* Receipts of Refusal → Stay of Journey → Unfiled Options. *Cracks:* a **Choice Compass** reveals the true path; a **Debt-Clearing** voids his claim.
- **The Toll-Matriarch Beneath the Bridge (many hands, one voice like wet stone)** — *Phases:* Truth Payment → Debt-Clearing → Forbidden Path. *Cracks:* a **Passage Token** marks you as belonging; a **Road’s Name** commands her to stand aside.
- **The Wayfinder’s Shadow (your silhouette, two steps ahead)** — *Phases:* Crossroads Judgment → Guide-Light → Haste Mark. *Cracks:* a **Memory-Anchor** keeps you grounded; a **Grace Passage** slips past its gaze.

Encounter Seeds (quick hooks)

- **The Promise Bridge’s Receipt:** An old vow you never spoke was logged here. To cross, define when you would have sworn it—and to whom.
- **Thirteenth Stone Auction:** The stone sells three possible endings. Each bidder is you from a different failure.

- **Bone Corridor Choir:** Shadows sing a name wrong by one letter. Correct it and gain *Truth-Compass*; ignore it and start **Name-Theft**.

Extensions (Plug-in)

- **Choice Dial (Resolve ↔ Drift):** Track the party’s footing between firm intent and wandering.
 - *Resolve High:* +1 Position on *Path Split* tests; the first *Dream-Bleed* each session hits harder (start at 2).
 - *Drift High:* +1 Effect when bargaining with way-entities; the first *Truth Payment* each session costs a cherished *detail*.
 - Center the Dial by naming aloud the next choice *and* why you might refuse it; clear 1 tick from **Way-Debt**.
- **Counter-Seal (once/scene, if justified):** Break a single metaphysical instruction (taboo, key, or omen) by presenting a memory in symbol form (a token, a letter, a sketch). Gain +1d on that crossing; the GM banks 1 SB as a *Marked Consequence* to spend when reflections return.
- **Start-of-Scene Murmurs (1d6):**
 1. *Second Sunrise:* light arrives twice; your first missed navigation roll becomes a mixed success.
 2. *Name Draft:* the air steals a syllable; your next lie sounds true once.
 3. *Echo Debt:* your footprints owe a step—skip a square or tick **Way-Debt** +1.
 4. *Pale Bell:* time hiccups; the first *Club* can be delayed until the end of the scene.
 5. *Traveler’s Chorus:* distant voices agree with you; +1d on appeals to path entities.
 6. *Hollow Weather:* rain that does not wet; conditions look dire but impose no penalties this scene.
- **Plug-in SB Conversions (Ways Between Flavor):**
 - 1 SB → *Footprint Vote:* your tracks choose a different direction; increase DV by 1 on any roll that relies on following a trail.
 - 2 SB → *Echo of Refusal:* a choice you avoided manifests as a minor obstacle (a locked gate, a forgotten toll).
 - 3+ SB → *Threshold Cracks:* the path fractures; gain a temporary **Path-Cutter** effect but start **Convergence** [4] (all travelers you have met will arrive together at the next junction).
- **Cross-Regional Conversions (Using Diamonds Across the Map):**
 - *Valewood:* **Road’s Name** may count as a *Valeheart Clause* once if spoken under leaves; doing so creates **Court Tithe** [2].
 - *Mistlands:* **Grace Passage** functions as *Pall Indulgence* over one levee crown at night; ring a bell afterward or start **Witchlight Count**.
 - *Vhasia:* **Way-Wisdom** can be presented as “pilgrim right” to bypass one *Interdict* barrier; begin a **Parlement Divided** tick.
 - *Viterra:* **Passage Token** can be notarized into a temporary *Ferry Priority*; on use, advance **Border-Lace**.
 - *Ubral:* **Memory-Anchor** counts as a *Guest-Token* at one hearth if you recount a family

road-tale.

- *Silkstrand*: **Path-Cutter** doubles as a night-boat route once; spend 1 favor with a smuggler or trigger *Seal Counterfeit*.
- *Linn*: **Choice Compass** acts as a *Pilot's Token* in a reed-maze if you pay a name to the water.
- *Theona*: **Crossroads Boon** allows counting “eight-and-one” to cross an *Uncounted Bridge* safely once.

Chapter 23

The Wilds

Roads, Ruins, and Weather. Between towns and treaties lies the patience of the land. Old roads remember armies; cairns remember names no book keeps. Law thins to trail-marks and favors, and the weather keeps its own counsel. Walk soft, read the wind, and bargain with whatever still listens.

23.1 The Wilds — “Roads, Ruins, and Weather”

Claimant Chief (Elite): “These lands answer not to charters but to those who can read their signs and respect their moods. Authority here is earned one campfire at a time, by proving you understand the difference between claiming and belonging.”

Forager Child (Commoner): “The wilds don’t need your roads or your rules – they got their own ways of keeping score. Follow the cairns if you want to live, and always leave something behind to thank the land for letting you pass. Every hill hides a secret, and every hollow breathes.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Between towns and treaties lies the patience of the land. Old roads remember armies; cairns remember names no book keeps. In the Wilds, law thins to trail-marks and favors, and the weather keeps its own counsel. This is the country of the hexcrawl: a patchwork of hidden valleys, forgotten ruins, beast lairs, and the bones of failed settlements. No single authority rules here—instead, the land itself is the ledger, and every crossing writes a new line. Walk soft, read the wind, bargain with whatever still listens, and keep one eye on the horizon. The next hex may hold water, treasure, or teeth.

What you notice first: The silence after a bird stops singing. The way a cairn seems to have shifted since you passed it last. The smell of rain on dry stone, even when the sky is clear.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never sleep in a hollow that has soot on the ceiling without adding your own to the fire. The land knows the difference between a guest and a thief.

Hexcrawl Philosophy: The Unfinished Map

The Wilds are not a route—they are a grid of secrets. A proper hexcrawl treats each six-mile hex (or league, or day’s walk) as a room in a dungeon without walls. The party navigates by dead

reckoning, landmark spotting, and the kindness of foragers. Some hexes are empty: water, fuel, a safe place to sleep. Others hold lairs, ruins, shrines, or the remnants of old wars. The GM should prepare a handful of keyed hexes in advance, then use the generator to populate the space between.

Hex Notation (sample): ‘H12 – Rolling hills, spring at north edge. Cache token possible. 1d6: 1–2 empty, 3–4 ruined outpost, 5–6 territorial beast (roll on table).’

The cards (Spades, Hearts, Clubs, Diamonds) replace the dice for on-the-fly content. Draw for each new hex, or draw once per leg of travel and let the highest suit determine the dominant feature. The rest becomes dressing.

(Crossing/Lookout/Old Road) Crossing point with ford/ice-span/stepping logs/dune saddle/reef shelf; lookout knoll with wind-carved marker; old road trace with cairns half-eaten by terrain.

Spades — Places (Hex Terrain)

2. **Crossing Point** — Ford, ice-span, stepping logs, dune saddle, reef shelf. *The crossing has a price: a stone, a story, or a moment of silence.*
3. **Lookout Knoll** — Tor, cliff, dune, ridge with wind-carved marker. *From here, you can see three hexes in clear weather—and one that shouldn’t exist.*
4. **Old Road** — Trace with cairns and switchbacks half-eaten by terrain. *The cobbles are worn smooth by ghosts. They whisper directions at dusk.*
5. **Shelter Hollow** — Overhang, cave, root cellar; soot says “used lately.” *The soot is layered. Someone has been coming here for a very long time.*
6. **Water Source** — Spring, seep, fog net, snow pan, guarded by thorns or stone. *The water tastes of iron and old bargains. Drink deep, but leave a coin.*
7. **Windbreak** — Rock ribs, lee of pines, reed-wall berm. *The windbreak smells of woodsmoke. Someone camped here last night.*
8. **Ruined Outpost** — Watchstack, wayside shrine, marker pile. *The ruin’s flagstones are warm. Something lives beneath them.*
9. **Bad Ground** — Sinkhole, bog crust, crevasse, loess slump. *The ground breathes. Step lightly or it will swallow you.*
10. **Gate Gully** — Pinch point between bluffs, dunes, or ice hummocks. *The gully has a name carved in the rock. The name changes every season.*
- J **Boundary Row** — Totems, standing stones, prayer flags bent by weather. *The flags are faded. The last prayer was for rain—and it still hasn’t come.*
- Q **Worksite** — Abandoned mine, quarry, logging camp, salt pan. *The tools are scattered. Whoever left did not plan to return.*
- K **Signal Height** — Old fire-pit or mirror stand; smoke stains linger. *Light the fire, and someone will answer. Whether they are friend or foe is your risk.*
- A **Trail Nexus** — Migratory, pack, or contraband paths knot here. *Three trails meet, but only two are on any map. The third belongs to the dead.*

(Guide/Warden/Caravan) Forager child with truer maps than yours; guide with three routes and one price (changes daily).

Hearts — People & Factions (Hex Denizens)

2. **Forager Child** — Goat-herd or berry-picker with truer maps than yours. *Their map is drawn on a scrap of bark. It shows a path that disappears at a standing stone.*
3. **Guide** — Three routes and one price (changes daily); navigation as negotiation. *Their price is never coin. It is a favor, a secret, or a night's watch.*
4. **Warden Patrol** — Local badges, local laws, local patience; order as familiarity. *Their badge is a chipped sunburst. They serve a crown that no longer exists.*
5. **Caravan Crew** — Drovers, porters, yarn-post hands trading speed for coin. *They know every shortcut and every ambush. They will share both—for a price.*
6. **Pilgrims** — Bound for a tucked-away shrine or stone; faith as a destination. *Their shrine has no name. The stone there is warm, and it answers questions poorly.*
7. **Poachers** — Know every snare and shortcut; survival as expertise. *They wear the teeth of game wardens as necklaces. The game wardens are still alive.*
8. **Hermit-Healer** — Dogs, geese, and opinions about weather; wisdom as isolation. *Their poultices smell of grave-moss. They work anyway.*
9. **Prospectors** — Salt, amber, iron, fungus; chasing rumors and glint. *Their claim is marked with a knot of red thread. Cross it, and they will shoot.*
10. **War-Band** — Reavers or “escorts,” depending on your purse; violence as commerce. *Their banner is a painted skull. The paint is from a dead comrade's blood.*
- J **Monster-Hunter** — Rite-keeper wearing yesterday's trophies; death as livelihood. *Their trophy is still warm. The monster's mate is close behind.*
- Q **Quartermaster** — Ledgers first, hospitality second; supply as authority. *Their ledger is written in a code only they understand. The code is their life story.*
- K **Claimant Chief** — Papers and spears to match; legitimacy as force. *Their papers are stained with water and blood. Both are still wet.*
- A **The Stranger** — Spirit-touched nomad or emissary; rules bend near them. *They have no shadow. The ground does not remember their footprints.*

(Weather/Doubleback/Prowlers) Weather turn with heat snap/cold snap/fog/dust; doubleback with tracks that loop; prowlers shadow with wolves/jackals/ghouls.

Clubs — Complications/Threats (Hex Hazards)

2. **Weather Turn** — Heat snap, cold snap, fog, dust; plans sag like wet leather. *The wind changes direction three times in an hour. Someone is watching.*
3. **Doubleback** — Tracks loop; the navigator swears the land moved underfoot. *Your own footprints face you. They were made yesterday—or tomorrow.*
4. **Prowlers Shadow** — Wolves, jackals, ghouls, seals, ravens by night; hunt as a company. *Their eyes reflect no light. Their teeth do.*
5. **Route Blocked** — Deadfall, rockfall, dune shift, ice heave; the path as an obstacle. *The blockage was placed. The toolmarks are fresh.*
6. **Quarantine Sign** — Camp fever; wardens sniff your packs for death. *The sign is a ribbon tied in a figure-eight. Do not cross it.*

7. **Territorial Beast** — Charge, stampede, or swarm; your choice of which is wrong. *The beast's lair is nearby. You can smell it—old blood and older musk.*
8. **Elemental Front** — Grassfire, peat-burn, canopy flare, blowing spindrift. *The fire moves against the wind. The wind is lying.*
9. **Paper vs Spear** — Jurisdiction fight in the wilds stalls your day; law as argument. *Two officials, one road. Both have seals. Neither will show them.*
10. **Supply Pinch** — Water, fuel, or feed low; pick what starves first. *Your canteen is full. The water is from a source that dried up last year.*
- J **Pursuit** — Hunters or avengers follow; signs say “close.” *The tracks are one hour old. They are gaining.*
- Q **Bad Omen** — Will-lights, taboo day, saint bells silent; locals refuse to move. *The omen is written in bird shit on a milestone. It is still accurate.*
- K **General Alarm** — Levy, muster, evacuation; all tracks become checkpoints. *The alarm horn is cracked. It sounds like a scream.*
- A **Catastrophe** — Flood, whiteout, sandstorm, lahar; clocks jump like frightened deer. *The catastrophe has a name. The land remembers it.*

(**Cache/Pass/Favor**) Cache token for hidden food or fuel stash; right-of-way pass recognized by a named trail; warden's favor with an escort letter.

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage (Hex Discoveries)

2. **Cache Token** — Key to a hidden food or fuel stash (once); preparation as power. *The token is a knucklebone. The stash is marked with a cairn that has one stone missing.*
3. **Right-of-Pass** — Recognized marker for a named trail or crossing. *The marker is a notch carved in a milestone. The notch is shaped like a bird.*
4. **Warden's Favor** — Escort letter; “they're with us” as a shield. *The letter is stamped with a bell. The bell's clapper is missing.*
5. **Weather Window** — Good forecast and a narrow gate to use it. *The window is a single hour at dawn. The birds will tell you when.*
6. **Water Deed** — Lawful draw at a scarce source; necessity as a right. *The deed is a clay cup. Break it, and the spring will flow—once.*
7. **Route Song** — A map scrap that actually works; knowledge as navigation. *The song has eight verses. The ninth is humming.*
8. **Remount Hire** — Fresh legs or hulls waiting at a post; speed as a service. *The remounts have no names. They answer to whistles and bribes.*
9. **Truce Cord** — Taboo exemption at a site (one scene); peace as a thread. *The cord is braided from wool and ash. Burn it to invoke the truce.*
10. **Toll Waiver** — A ferry, bridge, or reef gate honors this chit; passage as paper. *The chit is a dried leaf. The toll-keeper will not touch it.*
- J **Rescue Debt** — Locals owe you (or you owe them); trade for labor or intel. *The debt is carved on a tally stick. Break it when the favor is done.*
- Q **Private Audience** — A keeper, shrine-warden, or spirit of the place hears you alone. *The audience is held at midnight. The spirit wears your face.*

K Road Commission — Temporary authority over a stretch of wilds. *The commission is a whistle. Blow it, and the land will listen—once.*

A Earth’s Exception — One temporary rule-bend (cross during a storm, pass uncounted, beasts ignore you). *The exception is a secret. The land will forget it as soon as you use it.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (cache/pass/favor) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, add a lingering omen of the land (a smell on the wind, a sound that carries too far, tracks that shift) that you can echo in later scenes.

Hexcrawl Procedures (Fast Play)

Route Intent (declare before drawing) Pick *two* of the following: **Speed, Stealth, Safety, Survey**. Each grants +1 Position on one appropriate action this leg; the neglected options are at –1 Position if tested.

March Structure (party roles) Name one PC each as: **Pathfinder, Rear Watch, Quartermaster, Envoy**. Each role can cover one miss per leg by marking a minor cost (supply, time, favor, or fatigue).

Leg Resolution (one “day” or one hex)

1. **Read Weather:** Roll on the Weather Engine (see below). Apply tags.
2. **Waycheck:** One check to *Keep the Old Road* or *Cut a New Line*. Success avoids *Doubleback*. Mixed result = *Delay*. Miss = *Route Blocked* or *Bad Ground*.
3. **Encounter Pull:** If any *Clubs* were drawn to frame this leg, resolve now (prowlers, wardens, alarm, etc.).
4. **Make Camp or Push On:** Camp (see Camps & Watches) or push on (mark 1 *Fatigue* each; if pushing under a *Weather Turn*, mark 2).

Hex Discovery (optional) When entering a new hex, draw one additional card from the *Spades* deck (or roll on a custom landmark table). This feature is not tied to the leg’s clock—it is a pure reward for exploration. The GM may key permanent features to these draws.

Weather Engine (d12, one per leg)

d12	State	Tags / Effects
1	Glass-Clear	+Survey; mirage / long sight; smoke seen for miles.
2	Haze	–Survey; scents carry; <i>Prowlers Shadow</i> gains +1 die.
3	Trickle Rain	Tracks muddle; <i>Bad Ground</i> more likely.
4	Downpour	Paths sluice; +Delay on all exposed tasks.
5	Thunderhead	First metal test risks shock; morale checks –1.
6	Cold Snap	Brittle gear; +1 cost to swim or ford tests.
7	Heat Snap	Water usage doubled; Exhaustion clocks advance.
8	Ground Fog	+Stealth / –Speed; signals and archery downgraded.
9	Spindrift / Dust	Ranged beyond Close is risky; eyes and filters matter.
10	Shifting Wind	Smoke betrays; scent trails reverse mid-leg.
11	Front Line	Choose: detour (Delay) or face <i>Elemental Front</i> .
12	Catspaw Omen	GM may bank 1 SB to twist weather next leg.

Supply & Forage (Resource Clock)

- **Rations Track:** Each PC holds **3** marks of food and water abstractly. A leg consumes 1; *Heat Snap* or *Cold Snap* consumes +1. At 0, mark **Supply Pinch:** –1 die to strenuous actions; predators test at +1.
- **Forage / Harvest (once per leg):** Pick a biome tag (Forest, Desert, Tundra, Coast, Swamp, Highland). On success: +1d3 rations; mixed: +1 ration but with a hitch (quarantine sign, spoor); miss: find nothing and trigger a minor Complication.
- **Cache Tokens:** Spending a *Cache Token* refills 1d3 party rations plus one of: fuel, arrows, spare tack.

Hazards & Terrain (d8 each for improvisation)

Bad Ground (what it is) 1 sink crust 2 hidden crease 3 old culvert 4 rotten bridge
5 talus ribbon 6 reed-raft rot 7 thaw-pocket 8 dune slip

Why it bites (on a mixed or miss) 1 pack animals balk 2 axle snaps 3 someone sinks to the hip
4 detour adds a leg 5 noise carries 6 gear lost 7 trail erases 8 local claims a fee

Fix at hand (quirky mitigations) 1 brush fascines 2 snowshoes 3 driftwood crib 4 rope ferry
5 sled or drag 6 wait a bell 7 lighten loads 8 bribe the warden

Camps & Watches

Make Camp Pick one boon and one risk from the lists below:

Boon (choose 1):

- Mend gear (repair one damaged item).
- Clear 1 Fatigue total (distribute as you wish).

- Scout tomorrow’s *Weather Window* (gain +1 on the first waycheck).
- Parley with road spirits (see below).

Risk (choose 1):

- Thin shelter (next weather effect hits harder).
- Smoky fire (attracts prowlers; −1 to stealth at night).
- Exposed approach (ambush more likely; +1 SB to GM for prowler scenes).
- Hungry neighbors (locals or beasts appear in the night).

Road Spirits (small courtesies) Pour water, place a pebble, speak a name. On success: bank a *Truce Cord* for tomorrow. On a miss: *Bad Omen* flags this camp.

Chase & Pursuit (three beats)

1. **Gap (terrain claim):** Runners set advantage via *Lookout Knoll*, *Gate Gully*, or *Old Road*.
2. **Pressure (weather claim):** Winner of a narrated *Weather Engine* roll shifts Position.
3. **Break (resource claim):** Spend a *Remount Hire*, *Route Song*, or *Warden’s Favor* to end the chase; otherwise test *Pursuit*.

On a miss at any beat, mark 1 Harm or drop 1 load (your choice).

Clocks & Escalations (Campaign Trackers)

- **Roads Move [6]:** 1–2: Landmarks drift slightly. 3–4: An Old Road reroutes through a *Gate Gully*. 5: A map contradicts a guide. 6: A trail nexus re-knots; choose who benefits.
- **Weather Wakes [6]:** 1–2: Predictable fronts arrive early. 3–4: Elementals ride the line. 5: Two weathers at once. 6: *Catastrophe*; all clocks jump.
- **Local Resentment [4]:** 1: Tolls “adjust” upward. 2–3: Wardens frisk; smugglers sniff profit. 4: *General Alarm*—every track becomes a checkpoint.

Social in the Wilds (Trail Rights)

Show a right-token (knot, bead, bark-sigil) and recite the road-blessing:

- **Success:** Treat strangers as neighbors for one camp; *Paper vs. Spear* downgrades one step.
- **Mixed:** Hospitality but with a debt. Mark **Rescue Debt** [2].
- **Miss:** A *Claimant Chief* or *Warden Patrol* contests your right; stakes escalate.

If you offer a *Route Song*, a local escort negates one *Prowlers Shadow* this leg. Refusing a reasonable toll starts **Local Resentment** [4].

Fast Reskin Palette (Biome Tags)**Forest**

swap dunes → deadfall, spindrift → canopy flare, prowlers → boar / wolves; water = spring / stream.

Desert

swap bog → salt pan, fog → dust, shelter = overhang / wadi; water = seep / fog net.

Tundra / Ice

swap dune shift → ice heave, fire → spindrift, boats → sleds; prowlers = bears / wolves.

Coast / Isles

crossings = reef shelves, prowlers = seals / raiders, alarms = harbor booms; fuel = driftwood.

Swamp / Fen

crossings = corduroy / log causeways, bad ground = peat crust, prowlers = gators / leeches.

Highlands

crossings = cols and scree traverses, alarms = beacon chains, prowlers = cats / eagles.

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **The Bitter Root:** Daughters of the Chain use certain shelter hollows as waystations. A renegade Sister has hidden a Hollowed in a ruined outpost; the child has not moved in weeks.
- **The Threshold Compendium:** Old Roads are Class II Anchor sites—ghosts of imperial surveyors still measure the miles. Saikou Ira would leave a silver coin at every milestone.
- **Malachai, the Chained Angel:** A silver coin that never spends lies at the bottom of every spring. Take it, and the water will never run dry—but the spring will remember your face.
- **The Grey Wanderer's Grimoire:** Wilds psions are called "Stone-Listeners." They hear the memory of old trails. Claimant chiefs pay well for their services—and dispose of those who hear too much.
- **The Ninth:** In any Wilds scene, the ninth cairn you pass in a day will be warm. Leave an offering, or the path will forget you.

Wilderness Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Cairn:** Crumble a crust at a boundary stone. Ignore the first *Bad Ground* penalty.
- **Knot the Trail:** Tie a single knot in a piece of grass at a crossing. Cancel *Doubleback* or take -1 die on your next navigation roll (your choice).
- **Name to the Spring:** Whisper a dead traveler's name into a water source. Gain +1 Effect when foraging this scene, but mark *Obligation* to the land.

Patronage & Power

In the Wilds, power flows through knowledge of the land, the ability to navigate without formal authority, and the careful cultivation of local relationships. True authority comes from understanding weather patterns, reading tracks, and maintaining the favor of both human inhabitants and the spirits of place. Those who can provide safe passage, find water in dry times, or mediate between conflicting claims hold the most influence.

For the GM: Patronage in the Wilds revolves around practical knowledge, local customs, and the ability to provide essential services like navigation, shelter, and supply. Rewards often take the form of tokens, passes, and local knowledge that can be leveraged into greater safety and efficiency. To emphasize the hexcrawl feel:

- Key 6–10 interesting hexes before the session, then use the generator to fill the rest.
- Let the party discover new routes, short cuts, and hidden lairs through successful Survey or Leg actions.
- Use the Clocks (*Roads Move*, *Weather Wakes*, *Local Resentment*) to create a living, reactive wilderness.
- Offer Diamonds as “exploration rewards” that unlock new options (a cache token, a safe passage, a local ally).

In the Wilds, your skill is your standing, and your standing determines whether you survive or perish.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **wardens or local hunters**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **prowlers or caravan guards**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or claimants**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or favorable weather**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** **Guide or warden patrol** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **weather shift or route blockage**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **war-band or territorial beast** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **wardens, war-bands, or prowlers** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.

- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **weather turns/catastrophe strikes/quarantine declared.**
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival: Claimant chief, quartermaster, or The Stranger** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **weather shifts/blockage clears/catastrophe hits.**
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests.**
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Wilds (Weather):** Conditions shift without warning, storms arrive early, calm turns to chaos.
- **Wilds (Navigation):** Trails reroute mid-journey, landmarks disappear, guides demand additional payment.
- **Wilds (Local Customs):** Spirits demand tribute, territorial beasts become aggressive, local laws change with the terrain.

Fast reskin palette

Forest

swap dunes→deadfall, spindrift→canopy flare, prowlers→boar/wolves; water = spring/stream.

Desert

swap bog→salt pan, fog→dust, shelter = overhang/wadi; water = seep/fog net.

Tundra/Ice

swap dune shift→ice heave, fire→spindrift, boats→sleds; prowlers = bears/wolves.

Coast/Isles

crossings = reef shelves, prowlers = seals/raiders, alarms = harbor booms; fuel = driftwood.

Swamp/Fen

crossings = corduroy/log causeways, bad ground = peat crust, prowlers = gators/leeches.

Highlands

crossings = cols and scree traverses, alarms = beacon chains, prowlers = cats/eagles.

Wilds — Roads and Ruins

Starting Location: A shelter hollow carved into a fallen giant's ribcage, moss glowing faintly under starlight.

"In the Wilds, the land walks when you don't watch it, and the roads remember who bled on them."

In... A Shelter Hollow, a Forager Child offers a route-song. "The Bad Ground shifts," they say. "And the weather walks behind it."

Regional Motifs Ruin ivy, singing paths, weather as creature, stone memories.

Whispers to Offer “Cut through the Bad Ground,” “Take the relic,” “Leave the guide.”

External Clocks Threat: “Weather Wakes”; Fracture: “Roads Move”; Community: “Foragers Vanish.”

Complications Ruins reassemble; rain falls upward; the child knows tomorrow.

Anchors at Risk A caravan; a family relic.

Escalation Beat The song changes key.

Relief Sing in harmony; mark a safe path with blood and story; abandon the relic to drop Threat by one.

Travel Procedures (Fast Play)

Route Intent (declare before you draw) Pick *two*: **Speed, Stealth, Safety, Survey**. Each grants +1 Position on one appropriate action this leg; the neglected ones are -1 Position if tested.

March Structure Name: **Pathfinder, Rear Watch, Quartermaster, Envoy**. Each can cover one miss per leg by marking a minor cost (supply, time, favor, fatigue).

Leg Resolution (one “day” of travel)

1. **Read Weather:** Roll on Weather Engine (below). Apply tags.
2. **Waycheck:** One check to *Keep the Old Road* or *Cut a New Line*. Success avoids *Doubleback*. Mixed = *Delay*. Miss = *Route Blocked*.
3. **Encounter Pull:** If any *Clubs* were drawn to frame this leg, resolve now (prowlers, wardens, alarm).
4. **Make Camp or Push:** Camp (see Camps & Watches) or push on (mark 1 *Fatigue* each; if pushing under a *Weather Turn*, mark 2).

Weather Engine

d12	State	Tags / Effects
1	Glass-Clear	+Survey; mirage/long sight; smoke seen for miles
2	Haze	-Survey; scents carry; <i>Prowlers Shadow</i> +1 die
3	Trickle Rain	Tracks muddle; <i>Bad Ground</i> more likely
4	Downpour	Paths sluice; +Delay on all exposed tasks
5	Thunderhead	First metal test risks shock; morale checks -1
6	Cold Snap	Brittle gear; +1 cost to swim/ford tests
7	Heat Snap	Water usage doubled; Exhaustion clocks advance
8	Ground Fog	+Stealth/-Speed; signals/archery downgraded
9	Spindrift / Dust	Ranged beyond close is risky; eyes/filters matter
10	Shifting Wind	Smoke betrays; scent trails reverse mid-leg
11	Front Line	Choose: detour (Delay) or face <i>Elemental Front</i>
12	Catspaw Omen	GM may bank 1 SB to twist weather next leg

Supply & Forage

Rations Track Each PC holds **3** marks of food/water abstractly. A leg consumes 1; *Heat/Cold Snap* consumes +1. At 0, mark **Supply Pinch**: -1 die to Strenuous actions; predators test at +1.

Forage/Harvest (once per leg) Pick a biome tag (Forest/Desert/Tundra/Coast/Swamp/Highland). On success: +1d3 rations; mixed: +1 with a hitch (quarantine sign, spoor); miss: find nothing and trigger a minor Complication.

Cache Tokens Spending *Cache Token* refills 1d3 party rations plus one of: fuel, arrows, spare tack.

Hazards & Terrain (d8 each)

Bad Ground (what it is) 1 sink crust 2 hidden crease 3 old culvert 4 rotten bridge 5 talus ribbon 6 reed-raft rot 7 thaw-pocket 8 dune slip

Why it bites (on a mixed/miss) 1 pack animals balk 2 axle snaps 3 someone sinks to hip 4 detour adds a leg 5 noise carries 6 gear lost 7 trail erases 8 local claims fee

Fix at hand (quirky mitigations) 1 brush fascines 2 snow shoes 3 driftwood crib 4 rope ferry 5 sled/drag 6 wait a bell 7 lighten loads 8 bribe the warden

Social in the Wilds

Trail Rights (custom) Show a right-token (knot/bead/bark-sigil) and recite the road-blessing:

- **Success:** Treat strangers as neighbors for one camp; *Paper vs Spear* downgrades one step.
- **Mixed:** Hospitality but with a debt. Mark **Rescue Debt (2)**.
- **Miss:** *Claimant Chief* or *Warden Patrol* contests your right; stakes escalate.

Wardens’ Ledger If you offer *Route Song*, local escort negates one *Prowlers Shadow* this leg. Refuse a reasonable toll? Start **Local Resentment (4)**; when it fills, checkpoints bloom.

Camps & Watches

Make Camp Pick one boon and one risk:

- **Boon (choose 1):** mend gear; clear 1 Fatigue total; scout tomorrow’s *Weather Window*; parley with road spirits (see below).
- **Risk (choose 1):** thin shelter; smoky fire; exposed approach; hungry neighbors.

Road Spirits (small courtesies) Pour water, place pebble, speak a name. Success: bank *Truce Cord* for tomorrow. Miss: *Bad Omen* flags this camp.

Chase & Pursuit (three beats)

1. **Gap** (terrain claim): runners set advantage via *Lookout Knoll/Gate Gully/Old Road*.
2. **Pressure** (weather claim): winner of *Weather Engine* narration shifts Position.
3. **Break** (resource claim): spend *Remount Hire/Route Song/Warden’s Favor* to end it; otherwise test *Pursuit*.

On miss at any beat, mark 1 harm or drop 1 load (*your choice*).

Clocks & Escalations

Roads Move (6) 1–2: Landmarks drift. 3–4: Old Road reroutes through *Gate Gully*. 5: Map contradicts guide. 6: Trail nexus re-knots; choose who benefits.

Weather Wakes (6) 1–2: Predictable fronts arrive early. 3–4: Elementals ride the line. 5: Two weathers at once. 6: *Catastrophe*; clocks jump.

Local Resentment (4) 1: Tolls “adjust.” 2–3: Wardens frisk; smugglers sniff profit. 4: *General Alarm*—every track a checkpoint.

Cross-Regional Conversions

- **Mistlands:** *Weather Window* may count as a *Lantern Writ* on levee crowns if you ring a bell after dark; doing so risks *Witchlight Count*.
- **Valewood:** *Route Song* functions as a minor *Way-Cord*; on use, start **Oath-Magnet (2)**.
- **Ubral:** *Warden’s Favor* can be honored as *Guide’s Braid* on sheepwalks if a cairn-offering is made.
- **Viterra:** *Toll Waiver* notarized in Valora acts as a one-leg *Ferry Priority*; tick **Border-Lace**.
- **Vhasia:** *Road Commission* is recognized as *Low-Justice* on King’s High Road until the next levy call.
- **Silkstrand:** *Right-of-Pass* doubles as a dawn *Bridge Token* if stamped by a bridge bailiff.
- **Theona:** *Truce Cord* permits “eight-and-one” crossing on an *Uncounted Bridge*, once.
- **Vilikari:** *Water Deed* may be cited as *Wergild Table* credit at a *Mallus Right* court during drought disputes.

Omens & Sign (d8 each)

Sky Signs 1 sun-dog 2 mare's tails 3 anvil cloud faces the wrong way 4 silent birds 5 far thunder without storm 6 moon with halo 7 ash scent on clear air 8 stars "shiver"

Ground Signs 1 cairn with new pebble 2 boot prints that end at rock 3 butchered game left neat 4 snapped twig at head height 5 ash under wet moss 6 ward-knot cut 7 trail beads on shrub 8 a single coin on a stone

Quick NPC Templates

Forager Child (Truth Map) *Wants:* To trade a route-song for a story. *Leverage:* Knows which *Shelter Hollow* is "safe tonight." *Cost:* Promise to return a trinket to a Boundary Row (start a tiny quest).

Hermit-Healer (Weather Eye) *Wants:* Someone to fetch a wind-bell from a Signal Height. *Leverage:* Turns one *Weather Turn* into a *Weather Window*. *Cost:* Accept their foul cordial (mark "Queasy" until dawn).

Quartermaster (Ledger Lord) *Wants:* Proof a rival skimmed. *Leverage:* *Remount Hire* or *Cache Token* on the spot. *Cost:* Put your name on the ledger (start **Rescue Debt** at 1).

Terrain / Trail Dressing (roll 1–2 per leg)

- **Ruins Speak:** Old mile-stone hums a date from a forgotten war; +1 die to history, -1 to stealth this leg.
- **Beast Parliament:** Ravens, fox, and a boar seem to "confer" at Water Source; approach buys rumor or chase.
- **Ghost Cart Ruts:** Ruts glow at dusk and shave time—if you accept a *Supply Pinch* tomorrow.
- **Prayer Flags:** Boundary Row flags in the wrong colors; locals may read you as allied or enemy.

Encounter Seeds

- **Fire on the Height:** A fresh coal at *Signal Height*; lighting it calls help—or enemy levy. Your choice sets which *Clubs* show next scene.
- **Gate Gully Tithe:** Two claimants, one pinch-point. They'll honor *Truce Cord*—if you arbitrate a water deed on the spot.
- **Shelter Debt:** The soot in *Shelter Hollow* spells a name you know; leaving a meal clears a future *Supply Pinch*.

Designer Hooks (Optional)

Route-Song Craft Spend a scene and 1 *Route Song* scrap to compose a *Songline*: once per journey, skip *Doubleback*. Singing it in public adds 1 tick to **Local Resentment** (others want it).

Weather-Witchery (Low Magic) Offer a token to road spirits during a *Front Line*; on a hit, trade today's weather for tomorrow's. On a miss, both happen now at half strength.

Homage Sites & Lairs (drop-in Terrain)

- **Border Keep of Candle-Gate** — Stockade on a bluff above twin gullies; cellars link to smugglers’ bolt-holes where ledgers argue with knives.
- **The Bone King’s Barrow** — Hill split by lightning; whispering chute to a throne of antlers where oaths bind the living to the dead.
- **Serpent-Cairns of the Wind Steppe** — Rings of stacked shale; wind plays bone flutes; scale-runes name a forgotten tax on breath.
- **The Blue Glass Tower** — Fallen mage-spire sunk in a fen; panes show tomorrows you can’t reach; water stairs lead to a clockwork aviary.
- **Isle of Thunder-Lizards** — Reef shelf at low tide; drums in the cliffs; eggs warm under black sand that hisses with static.
- **The Amber Idol Dig** — Abandoned worksite with tar pits; half-freed idol drinks lantern-light; foreman’s diary ends mid-apology.
- **Hall of the Stone-Chiefs** — Terrace of toppled colossi; each face wears a different season; a living boulder judges trespass by weight.
- **Salt-Vein Labyrinth** — Collapsed mine whose walls sweat brine; maps dissolve; a blind choir keeps time with pick-hafts.
- **Shrine of the Four Storm Doors** — Weather turns on hinges; choose which door to open and pay its toll in breath, heat, chill, or silence.
- **The Black Lantern Monastery** — Ruin above a fall; lanterns that never burn out reveal tracks made tomorrow; ascetics wrote their sins on river mist.

Wilderness Bestiary (palette)

- **Earth-Sharks** — Burrow beneath loess and tundra; dorsal ridges like plowshares. *Signs:* furrows that breathe; pebbles rattle. *Hook:* lure with drumbeats or goat bells.
- **Phase Panthers** — Shadow-striped cats that step between gusts. *Signs:* pawprints offset from themselves. *Hook:* mirrored water or bell-silver disrupts the blink.
- **Rust Moths** — Swarms that taste iron memory. *Signs:* lacework mail; pitted nails. *Hook:* feed them old keys; they ignore fresh steel.
- **Lichen-Bears** — Moss-matted ursines with rock-teeth. *Signs:* clawed bark with green scabs. *Hook:* smoke of juniper calms; salt enrages.
- **Wind Drakes** — Rib-thin sky-serpents that ride fronts. *Signs:* shed vanes; feathers like glass. *Hook:* whistle back the storm to ground them.
- **Ooze-Remnants** — Alchemical slough from an old field lab. *Signs:* boot-holes rounded smooth. *Hook:* wood ash firms them; vinegar makes them sprint.
- **Fell Harts** — Antlered shades that herd the living toward cliffs. *Signs:* hoofprints that don’t compress soil. *Hook:* speak a hunter’s apology while walking backward.
- **Cairn-Wights** — Stone-stack custodians; patient as frost. *Signs:* pebbles rearranged around your fire. *Hook:* rebuild the stack correctly; they serve until dawn.
- **Thundertusks** — Boars that store lightning in tusk-veins. *Signs:* fused sand beads; singed roots. *Hook:* ground your spear; throw shadow to draw the strike.
- **Lantern-Eyes** — Floating orbs of watchlight rumor; jealous of secrets. *Signs:* daylight in ravines at midnight. *Hook:* offer a whispered truth; they part like reeds.
- **Grave-Eels** — Burrow through barrow loam; taste names. *Signs:* sinking turf over old wars.

Hook: sing lineage or throw false names to mislead.

- **Bramble Knights** — Empty helmets grown through with thorn; patrol old borders. *Signs:* briar in boot-grease. *Hook:* present a hedge-blessing; they escort instead of impale.

Terrain Stock (d20 quick)

- 1 Fresh ash on an old fire ring; prints circle *around* it.
- 2 Boundary totems toppled but re-stack themselves if watched politely.
- 3 Broken wagon with salt-vein crystals growing through spokes.
- 4 Singing culvert; echo names the boldest listener wrongly.
- 5 Weather bell hung in a pine; tolling swaps rain and wind.
- 6 Cairn with a copper coin balanced on edge; don't breathe hard.
- 7 Fence of antlers pointing uphill; follow and skip one *Bad Ground*.
- 8 Mummified pack-beast wearing a courier's braid; letter hums.
- 9 Pebble mosaic of an old levy call; stepping it summons wardens.
- 10 Fossil rib arch; shelter under it and dream of tomorrow's route.
- 11 Abandoned hunter's cache; choice of food or rumor, not both.
- 12 Mirror-puddle; shows last night's sky whatever the hour.
- 13 Rope bridge made of prayer knots; one is freshly cut.
- 14 Scare-stakes dressed in saltcloth; something big respects them.
- 15 Stone with bite-marks; taste iron and remember a shortcut.
- 16 Old road mile-post defaced into a saint; offerings still fresh.
- 17 Thistle patch buzzing with coin-flies; feed them copper for safe passage.
- 18 Fallen giant's footprint now a pond; frogs chant a route-song.
- 19 Soot writing on cliff: *Storm at Second Bell*. It's right.
- 20 Hollow tree full of carved names; the newest is yours.

Lair Seeds (d12 one-page crawls)

1. **Fen Clockworks** — Bog-gears turn under peat; each tooth a drowned oath.
2. **Dry River Gallery** — Petroglyphs re-arrange at dusk; wrong reading summons bramble knights.
3. **Ice-Well Vault** — Stairs drilled through permafrost; breath blooms frost-runes that answer questions badly.
4. **Sunken Forum** — Pillars knee-deep in silt; rust moths nest in the rostrum.
5. **Pilgrim Kilns** — Charcoal mounds hike on stilt roots at night; a hermit-healer bargains weather for charcoal.
6. **Hanging Salt Chapel** — White stalactites ring like bells; grave-eels coil in the font.
7. **Thorn Maze Mill** — Waterwheel turns without water; phase panthers pace the sluice.
8. **Brewer's Hollow** — Barrels of wind; decant a gale or drink a calm.
9. **Antler Archive** — Ledger carved on horn; theft awakens the cairn-wights' accountant.
10. **Black Lantern Mines** — Lantern-eyes nest like bats; light buys silence, darkness buys passage.
11. **Stormbone Spire** — Vertebrae tower; earth-sharks circle beneath like sharks in sand.

12. **Amber Orchard** — Trees fossilized mid-sway; trapped thunderflies grant *Weather Window* when freed.

Boss Hooks (road crowns)

- **The Stone-Chief of Seven Hills** — Walking dolmen with a court of cairn-wights; taxes are measured in footprints. *Leverage*: rebuild a boundary row to earn audience.
- **Mist Abbess of Black Lantern** — Keeper of ever-lights and secrets; trades *Weather Window* for names spoken under waterfalls.
- **Blue Glass Magus** — Last pane-worker; hunts thunder-lizard hearts to power mirrors. *Clock: Mirror Wakes* [4]—when full, maps start lying *beautifully*.
- **Amber Idol’s Choir** — Faceless diggers who hum in tar-time; their song softens steel and will.
- **Thundertusk Matriarch** — Scarred sow crowned in fused sand; charges any banner that won’t bow.

Relic & Find Table (d10)

- 1 Route-stones that warm near true north.
- 2 Weather-bell clapper that tolls only for lightning.
- 3 Trail-right knot dyed in berry law; locals honor it once.
- 4 Salt-vein pick that cuts oozes like cloth.
- 5 Glass feather; break to call a wind drake for one pass.
- 6 Ledger leaf waterproofed with eel-fat; ink never runs, words drift.
- 7 Thorn sigil that bramble knights read as parley.
- 8 Coin-fly cocoon; hatch it for one honest guide to the nearest water.
- 9 Bone flute that calls earth-sharks to circle elsewhere.
- 10 Lantern-eye husk; squeeze for daylight the length of a camp prayer.

Wilderness Complication Twists (d8)

1. *Weather Turn* reveals a buried mile-post; following it skips one leg but triggers *Local Resentment*.
2. *Route Blocked* is a trap set by rust moth tenders; pay in scrap or fight a cloud.
3. *Prowlers Shadow* are bramble knights escorting pilgrims—until a hedge-blessing is misread.
4. *Doubleback* because the land moved: wind drakes braided the grass.
5. *Quarantine Sign* enforced by lantern-eyes; confess a secret to pass.
6. *Territorial Beast* guards an honest cache; take half without omen, all with a curse.
7. *Paper vs Spear* becomes *Song vs Drum*: trail rights must be sung while marching.
8. *Catastrophe* arrives as a walking stormbone; pull the right vertebra and calm it—or ride it.

Mini-Procedures (quick play)

Old Road Wake When you march on an *Old Road* and speak a route-song, choose one:

- Arrive early; start *Roads Move* +1.
- Meet wardens first; downgrade next *Paper vs Spear*.

- Wake a mile-post spirit; ask one honest question, owe one honest task.

Beast Parliament If beasts gather at a *Water Source*, lay out food or rumor:

- Food buys safe passage and one clue.
- Rumor scatters them; reveals a hidden approach, attracts a rival.

Adventure Seeds

- **Keep the Lanterns** — The Black Lantern Monastery's ever-lights are dimming; carry a lightning jar across the Isle of Thunder-Lizards before the next tide.
- **Seven Hills Tax** — The Stone-Chief demands a footprint levy; find the stolen boundary bead before bramble knights collect *in kind*.
- **Blue Pane Hunt** — The Blue Glass Tower wants thunder-lizard heartglass; poachers have already baited the herd near Gate Gully.
- **Amber Choir** — Tar pits sing; diggers vanish; the Idol wants witnesses, or the weather will.

Chapter 24

Dungeons

Living Infrastructure. Beneath the surface, ancient places breathe with mechanical lungs and dream electric dreams. Dungeons are not merely ruins but living systems—vascular networks of stone and shadow where every corridor hums with purpose. The walls remember every footfall, the air carries whispers of forgotten conversations, and the very architecture shifts like a sleeper turning in bed.

24.1 Dungeon — “Living Infrastructure”

Elite (Dungeon’s Creator)

“I built more than walls and corridors – I crafted a living symphony of stone and shadow, where every passage breathes and every chamber remembers. The structure itself is the true inhabitant.”

Commoner (Scholar-Prisoner)

“The walls here got a memory like old parchment – they remember every scream, every spell, every drop of blood spilled on the stones. And sometimes, when the air’s just right, they whisper it back to you. The dungeon listens. The question is whether it learns.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Beneath the surface, ancient places breathe with mechanical lungs and dream electric dreams. Dungeons are not merely ruins but living systems—vascular networks of stone and shadow where every corridor hums with purpose and every chamber holds its own hungry logic. The walls remember every footfall, the air carries whispers of forgotten conversations, and the very architecture shifts like a sleeper turning in bed. Here, the boundary between structure and organism blurs, and those who would plunder its secrets must first learn to speak its language of echoes, scents, and subtle pressures.

What you notice first: The wet stone smell of a place that sweats. The distant grinding of gears that should have seized centuries ago. The way your footsteps echo back with an extra beat—like someone is following, or catching up.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never ignore a door that opens when you’re not looking. The dungeon is offering you a choice. Refuse, and the next door may not open at all.

The Living Hierarchy: Factions of the Deep

Dungeons are not empty. They host a fragile ecology of factions, each with its own relationship to the site's "consciousness." A site's dominant faction determines its mood; a dungeon ruled by *Custodians* may be melancholic and negotiable, while one overrun by *Awakened Organs* is actively predatory.

- **Custodians (Forgotten Caretakers)** – The original stewards, now half-mad or ghostly. They maintain the dungeon's rhythms (polishing thresholds, oiling traps) and may trade safe passage for a memory or a promise. *Clocks: CUSTODIAN PATIENCE [4], MAINTENANCE ROUNDS [6].*
- **Invaders (Plunderers & Refugees)** – Living interlopers: mercenary remnants, cult initiates, refugee families. They exploit the dungeon's resources while trying to avoid its attention. Their presence raises *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)*. *Clocks: INVADER DESPERATION [4], RIVAL CLAIM [6].*
- **Awakened Organs (The Dungeon's Will)** – Manifestations of the site's internal systems: the *Heart Chamber*, the *Digestive Array*, the *Ledger Lich*. They act as immune responses or as twisted echoes of the original purpose. *Clocks: ORGAN HUNGER [4], SYSTEM REBOOT [6].*
- **Wild Symbiotes (Echoes & Aberrations)** – Creatures that evolved within the living infrastructure: stone-wights, memory eels, gravity ticks. They are neither friendly nor hostile – they simply follow the dungeon's new rules. *Clocks: SWARM TIDE [4], SYMBIOTIC ACCORD [6].*

Most expedition sites will feature two or three of these factions in uneasy balance. A dungeon with predatory *Awakened Organs* and desperate *Invaders* is a very different crawl than one haunted by melancholic *Custodians* and curious *Wild Symbiotes*.

Spades — Places

2. **Cracked Gallery** — Hairline faults veined with damp; grit ticks from the ceiling like a slow clock. *The ticking is a language. It is counting the number of intruders.*
 3. **Sunken Vestibule** — Waist-deep water glazed with oil rainbows; cold leeches the knees, something brushes past. *The water has a pulse. It is not yours.*
 4. **Vaulted Refectory** — Tables laid for a meal gone to dust; goblets taste faintly of iron when breathed upon. *The iron is blood—old, dried, and patient.*
 5. **Spiral Stairwell** — Steps cupped by centuries; one cough ricochets down into a throat not your own. *The throat is the dungeon's. The cough is an answer.*
 6. **Collapsed Observatory** — Stars stare through ribs of broken dome; wind brings ash that smears like soot. *The stars are not real. The dungeon remembers the sky and shows it wrong.*
 7. **Armory Alcove** — Weapon shadows longer than the racks; a glass-front case fogs from the inside. *The fog has a shape. The shape is a hand.*
 8. **Chained Sanctuary** — Prayer-niches and iron hooks; stone bruised where something strained to leave. *The chains are warm. Something wore them recently.*
 9. **Mirror Hall** — Reflections lag by a heartbeat; one pane shows you older, another shows you missing. *The missing reflection is ahead of you. It will wait.*
 10. **Garden of Stone** — Statues mid-breath; a chisel-mark still weeps dust as if freshly struck. *The dust is from the statues. They are not statues. They are frozen.*
- J **Throne of Echoes** — A single block worn satin-smooth; sit and your name returns in a stranger's verdict. *The verdict is from a trial you never attended. The jury is the dungeon.*

- Q **Vault of Whispers** — Books exhale when opened; vowels crawl up the spine and into the ear. *The books are not books. They are memory. They eat yours to grow.*
- K **Chamber of Seasons** — Air flips from pollen-sweet to knife-cold; breath ghosts, sweat beads, leaves skitter. *The seasons are the dungeon’s moods. Today it is spring. Tomorrow, winter without end.*
- A **The Heart Chamber** — Mortar smells like blood, light like fever; floor hums to your pulse then sets its own. *The pulse is not your own after the third beat.*

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Forgotten Custodian** — Keys like teeth on a ring; polishes thresholds no one crosses. *He has forgotten why he polishes. The threshold remembers.*
 3. **Scholar-Prisoner** — Ink-stained nails, hollow cheeks; knows which lies the walls prefer. *The walls prefer lies that are almost true. She tells them often.*
 4. **Symbiotic Colony** — Many mouths, one hunger; bargains in warmth, hoards salt. *The mouths whisper in chorus. Their voices are the dungeon’s breath.*
 5. **Cursed Noble** — Velvet rotted to lace; voice drags like chain, eyes beg for ending. *The curse is the dungeon’s favor. He has worn it too long.*
 6. **Mercenary Remnant** — Dried mud, wet fear; map carved into forearm with a dinner knife. *The map is accurate—for now. The dungeon moves while he sleeps.*
 7. **Bound Guardian** — Filigree of wards across stone skin; obeys the letter, hears the spirit. *The spirit is the dungeon’s. The letter is a suggestion.*
 8. **Cult Initiate** — Pupil-widened zeal; speaks passwords like prayers, prayers like debts. *The debt is to a god that does not answer. The dungeon answers instead.*
 9. **Refugee Family** — Boot-scrapes under cots; clutch charms that grow warm when danger nears. *The charms are stones from the garden. The statues are their ancestors.*
 10. **Merchant of Curiosities** — Breath like cloves and rust; sells certainty bottled and slightly used. *The certainty is a lie. The bottle is genuine.*
- J **Ascended Vermin** — Crown of wire, court of nests; taxes crumbs, enforces with a thousand eyes. *The eyes are not all vermin. Some are the dungeon’s.*
- Q **Fallen Hero’s Shade** — Armor of frost, sword of grievance; wants one last right choice. *The right choice is the one that frees her. The dungeon disagrees.*
- K **Dungeon’s Creator** — Architect’s hands cracked with mortar; still moving rooms the way others move chess. *He does not remember the Heart Chamber. The Heart Chamber remembers him.*
- A **The Collective Consciousness** — Voices braided into one intention; your thoughts return carrying fingerprints. *The fingerprints are yours. The thoughts are the dungeon’s.*

Clubs — Complications/Threats

2. **Shifting Walls** — Mortar pops like knuckles; corridors narrow behind you with polite insistence. *The insistence is the dungeon’s. It wants you to stay.*
3. **Hungering Dark** — Wicks gutter blue; shadows lip the flame and swallow the heat first. *The dark has weight. It leans.*

4. **Memory Fog** — Cool on the gums, sweet on the tongue; you “recall” a door that never was. *The door is real. The memory is the dungeon’s.*
5. **Gravity Wells** — Knees turn to iron; dropped coins smack floor like thrown knives. *The coins are the dungeon’s now. It will spend them later.*
6. **Temporal Echoes** — Footfalls not yours keep pace; a conversation repeats with one word wrong. *The wrong word is a clue. The clue is a trap.*
7. **Corrosive Atmosphere** — Leather slimes, metal freckles; breathe shallow or taste copper. *The copper is blood. The blood is the dungeon’s offering.*
8. **Phantom Locks** — Doors exist when watched sidelong; they prefer particular hands and hours. *The hands are yours. The hours are the dungeon’s.*
9. **Borrowed Time** — Hair whitens at the tips; hunger leaps ahead of the clock. *The time will be returned. The interest is your memory.*
10. **Infectious Transformation** — Fingertips grain to stone, pupils catch light like a cat’s; urges shift. *The urge is to stay. The garden needs new statues.*
- J **Reality Anchor Points** — Candles burn sideways, water beads uphill; spells itch in the teeth. *The itch is the dungeon laughing.*
- Q **The Dungeon’s Will** — Maps argue with themselves; paths rephrase your intentions. *The path is the dungeon’s intention. Your intention is a suggestion.*
- K **Cascading Failure** — A cracked lintel sighs and the far cistern answers; systems talk in groans. *The groans are a warning. The warning is too late.*
- A **The Price of Passage** — Each shortcut salts your tongue with loss; the house keeps its ledger. *The ledger is the dungeon’s. The loss is yours.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

2. **Wayfinder Compass** — Needle twitches toward safety like a frightened animal; steadies if you hum. *The humming must be in tune with the dungeon’s breath. The breath changes.*
3. **Key of Echoes** — Warms in the palm when a door remembers being opened. *The door’s memory is not yours. It remembers a different key.*
4. **Lantern of Clarity** — Light outlines hollows in the world; truths show up as clean edges. *The truths are sharp. They cut if you look too long.*
5. **Cloak of Passage** — Hem sips through stone or mist; leaves damp prints on the far side. *The prints are the dungeon’s. It will follow.*
6. **Tome of Convenient Knowledge** — Pages grow new margins; ink creeps to answer the question you’re afraid to ask. *The answer is a lie. The lie is useful.*
7. **Ration of Sustenance** — Bread that tastes like last winter; settles the stomach, quiets the shakes. *Last winter was in the dungeon. The bread was grown in the garden.*
8. **Focus Crystal** — Thrum matches your breath; thoughts align the way teeth fit. *The breath is the dungeon’s after the third inhale.*
9. **Token of Safe Return** — Thread around a wrist; tugs once when it’s time to flee. *The tug is the dungeon’s mercy. It does not offer twice.*
10. **Map that Grows** — Charcoal blooms corridors as you walk; tiny figures drift where things currently are. *The figures are the dungeon’s. They are not always accurate.*
- J **Shield of Temporary Immunity** — Hazards strike sparks and spend themselves like rain

on slate.

The immunity is borrowed. The dungeon will ask for it back.

Q Crown of Momentary Authority — Creatures blink, recognize a crest they cannot name, and obey. *The crest is the dungeon’s. The obedience is a misunderstanding.*

K Forge of Quick Repair — Heat like a heartbeat; fractured gear exhales and remembers its shape. *The memory is the dungeon’s. The gear will remember you, too.*

A The Dungeon’s Blessing — A knack that lingers in the bones; doors like you now, as do certain hungers. *The hungers are the dungeon’s appetites. They like you very much.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (safeties/knowledge/immunities) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **living infrastructure**—walls shift, voices repeat your plans, light returns redder.

Additional Features

- **Living Infrastructure:** Fluids, heat, dust, and sound move like blood—follow the drafts, the drips, the echoes to find organs: cisterns, chimneys, nerve-halls.
- **Scent Ledger:** Track smells (ozone, wet lime, tallow, old wine); they foretell hazards and factions before you see them.
- **Echo Etiquette:** Some rooms reward whispers and punish shouts; others demand a spoken price to cross. Listen first.

Patronage & Power

The true dungeon is not a place but a process—a slow alchemy that transforms intruders into something the structure can understand or consume. Every chamber is a test, every corridor a negotiation, and every inhabitant a symptom of the site’s deeper hungers. The wise explorer learns to read the dungeon’s moods in the way light falls, the way echoes return, and the way the very air seems to lean toward certain passages. Here, knowledge is not power but currency, and the smart adventurer knows when to pay with memory, when to pay with blood, and when to simply walk away.

Thematic SB Spend Table

Minor Complications (1 SB)

- **Exposure:** Your actions draw unwanted attention from **dungeon dwellers or factions**.
- **Noise:** Sounds of your actions alert nearby **creatures or echoes**.
- **Trace:** Evidence of your passage marks your route for **trackers or spirits**.
- **Delay:** A brief but meaningful setback costs you **time or resources**.
- **Supply Strain:** Mark +1 segment on a relevant **resource clock**.

Moderate Setbacks (2 SB)

- **Alarm Raised:** The **dungeon's will** becomes aware and begins responding.
- **Position Lost:** You lose advantageous ground/cover/stealth due to **shifting architecture**.
- **Foe Appears:** A **minor entity or faction member** arrives on scene.
- **Gear Trouble:** A piece of equipment becomes **Compromised/Neglected**.
- **Lock/Barrier:** A simple obstacle now requires a test to overcome.

Serious Trouble (3 SB)

- **Reinforcements:** Additional **dungeon entities or guardians** arrive.
- **Key Gear Breaks:** A crucial tool/weapon becomes temporarily unusable.
- **Major Twist:** The situation fundamentally changes - **trap springs/route blocked/ally turns**.
- **Rail Tick:** Advance a relevant campaign/front clock by 1 segment.
- **Condition Applied:** Mark **Fatigue 1/Harm 1/Condition** appropriate to fiction.

Major Turns (4+ SB)

- **Trap Springs:** A prepared danger activates with full effect.
- **Authority Arrival:** The **Dungeon's Creator or Collective Consciousness** intervenes.
- **Scene Shift:** The environment changes dramatically - **walls shift/floor collapses/air thickens**.
- **Patron Omen:** Divine/arcane forces take notice - **omen appears/blessing lost/curse manifests**.
- **Narrative Pivot:** The story takes an unexpected turn that reframes objectives.

Region-Specific SB Options

- **Living Infrastructure (1–2 SB):** Corridors whisper your name, reflections blink slower, scent trails loop back.
- **Echo Etiquette (1–3 SB):** Shouts echo thrice, silence answers back, doors ask riddles.
- **Cascading Failure (1–2 SB):** One crack becomes many, water flows uphill, lights dim in sequence.

Dungeon — Living Infrastructure

Starting Location: A spiral stairwell deep beneath a forgotten citadel, pulsing with a heartbeat not entirely mechanical.

“In the Dungeon, walls breathe, corridors shift, and memory is the only map worth keeping.”

In... a spiral stairwell, the steps hum underfoot. A Forgotten Custodian keys a door that wasn't there yesterday. “The Heart Chamber hungers,” they whisper. “Will you feed it—or be fed?”

Regional Motifs Maintenance spirits, adaptive stone, ritual vents, memory valves.

Whispers to Offer “Take the shortcut that erases you,” “Trade blood for passage,” “Leave a companion behind as toll.”

External Clocks Threat: *Heart Pressure Rises* [6]; Fracture: *Floorplan Loops* [4]; Anchor: *Safe Route Fails* [4].

Complications Corridors swap; keys rust to teeth; the Custodian forgets who asked.

Anchors at Risk Camp cache; a mapping apprentice.

Escalation Beat The stairwell adds a step every circuit.

Relief Vent the Heart with a true name; feed it a secret belonging to all PCs (reduces Threat by one).

Plug-in Expedition Layer

- **Universal Clocks (drop into any site):**
 - *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)* [10]: rises on loud actions, light spillage, blood, or haste. At 4/7/10, the Keeper may promote Clubs results one step.
 - *Structure Stress* [6/8]: ticks on blasts, overloading mechanisms, or ignored warnings; when full, trigger *Cascading Failure*.
 - *Expedition Supply*: three pooled tracks—*Light* [4], *Air* [4] (if sealed), *Load* [4] (fatigue/overburden). Each empty track worsens Position for relevant actions until refreshed.
- **Safe Route Tokens:** On a strong success mapping/scouting, issue a *Safe Route* token. Spend to bypass one known hazard in that segment or to negate a single “Position Lost” SB.
- **Retreat & Seal:** When withdrawing, a PC may *seal the way* (chalk, wedges, wards). Clear 1 Heat, but tick *Structure Stress* or spawn a *Phantom Lock* in that lane.

Interfaces & Entanglements (use what fits your campaign)

- **Surface Stakeholders:** *Scavenger Union*, *Shrinekeepers*, *Civic Factors*. Register finds to bank a *Finder’s Favor*—spend to reduce one sell-off DV; skipping registration adds a “Disputed Claim” tag to the haul.
- **Internal Politics:** *Custodians*, *Bound Guardians*, *Refugee Enclaves*. Parley with proper tokens (salt, names, warmth) to downgrade the next Clubs result in their turf.
- **Patron Hooks (optional):**
 - **The Sealed Gate:** Chalk lines cancel one intrusion for a scene; breaking them adds 1 Heat.
 - **Lunara:** Moon-silver reveals one hidden organ (cistern, nerve-hall); mark Exposure +1.
 - **The Traveler:** Waymarks let you finish one travel tick after a room clear.
 - **Varnek Karn:** Naming the dead here clears 1 *Awareness* but starts a *Ledger Attention* [4].
 - **Maelstraeus:** Trade salvage tags at “fair rate” once/expedition; skewed trades create a *Karmic Debt* [6].

Keys, Locks, & Doors (drop-in schema)

- **Door Attitudes:** *Literal* (wants the right key), *Courteous* (opens to the right words), *Hungry* (takes a toll), *Shy* (hates crowds), *Proud* (demands ceremony).
- **Key Types:** *Mechanical* (wards/picks), *Mnemonic* (password, name), *Somatic* (gesture, breath), *Affective* (emotion offered), *Sacrificial* (blood, time, memory).
- **Rule of Two:** Each important barrier recognizes two different key types; learning either grants +1 Effect to breach or parley with it.

Salvage, Haul, & Conversion

- **Salvage Tags:** *Stable* (safe to carry), *Volatile* (ticks Stress on jostle), *Bound* (linked to site), *Loud* (adds Heat when moved), *Forbidden* (attracts factions).
- **Convert on Exit (choose one):** trade haul for a *Map that Grows* upgrade, a *Pass-Key Writ* (one automatic door compliance), or *Market Credit* (reduce next sell-off complication).

Table Prompts (d6 each, fast prep)

Echo Questions

1. What does the room want?
2. Who set this alarm?
3. What was repaired last?
4. Where does the draft go?
5. What memory sticks here?
6. What price opens the way?

Find the Organ

1. Cistern (fluid)
2. Bell-shaft (signal)
3. Heat lung (thermal)
4. Nerve-hall (control)
5. Waste sluice (decay)
6. Relay shrine (intent)

Procedures at the Door (one-minute read-aloud checklist)

1. **Sense:** Name two smells; ask which grew stronger.
2. **Listen:** Offer one echo; ask what word returns wrong.
3. **Light:** Describe color/behavior; ask who steadies it (hum, prayer, silence).
4. **Count:** Beats, drips, or breaths—players may claim *Counting Etiquette* to shift Position safer once.
5. **Declare Price or Key:** Players state attitude + key type; on a hit, grant +1 Effect or a *Safe Route* token.

Plug-in SB Conversions (use with any dungeon)

- First 1 SB in a scene may become *Heat +1* instead of a narrative wrinkle (signal without immediate harm).
- Any 2 SB can instead tick *Structure Stress* and foreshadow *Cascading Failure* rather than spawn foes.
- On 3+ SB, offer a bargain: pay with *memory/gear/time* to halve the consequence and add *Price of Passage* [3].

Bosses & Lairs (Classic Crawl Feel, Fate’s Edge Framework)

Using Bosses Each boss runs on a **Phase Clock** and 2–3 **Lair Actions**. Tie them to the site’s *Dungeon Awareness (Heat)* and *Structure Stress*; as either rises, promote boss position/effect. Boss defeats should yield a Diamond-tier boon keyed to the lair.

Oculus Warden (many-eyed sentry)

A floating nerve-knot studded with glass eyes; lenses irise like gills.

- **Phase Clock:** [8] *Calibration* → *Overwatch* → *Lethal Focus* → *Blind Panic*
- **Moves:** *Disintegrate Signage* (erase waymarks), *Anti-magic Glare* (downgrade 1 magical effect this exchange), *Scry Ping* (advance Awareness +1).
- **Lair Actions (Mirror Hall / Vault of Whispers):**
 1. *Prismatic Sweep*: Split the party’s positions (each PC steps one tier toward Controlled).
 2. *Echo False Order*: One PC hears an ally’s command that was never given; test or waste an action.
 3. *Lens Flare*: Next ranged attack against the Warden loses 1 Effect unless the light source is doused.
- **Counters:** Smoke, darkness, reflective shields, calling shots on specific lenses (name a lens: cancel one Move this round).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Crown of Momentary Authority* or *Lantern of Clarity*.

Digestive Array (cube-that-crawls)

A transparent, room-sized solvent held in grid tension; carries tools it cannot digest.

- **Phase Clock:** [6] *Probe* → *Enmesh* → *Dissolve*
- **Moves:** *Corrode* (apply COMPROMISED to metal/wood), *Engulf* (split group; trapped PC marks Fatigue or gear loss), *Clean Bones* (remove tags from fallen).
- **Lair Actions (Sunken Vestibule / Chained Sanctuary):**
 1. *Flood Gate Twitch*: Water level rises a step; footing worsens.
 2. *Sluice Pulse*: Pushes all creatures one range band.
 3. *Reagent Bloom*: Vapors add –1 die to breathy actions this round.
- **Counters:** Grates, cold cinders, base powders; lures with iron filings or salted meat (draw off for a scene).
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Forge of Quick Repair* salvage or *Ration of Sustenance* (3).

Ledger Lich (archivist revenant)

A curator bound by indices; hands of ink, breath of dust.

- **Phase Clock:** [8] *Citation* → *Injunction* → *Foreclosure* → *Redaction*
- **Moves:** *Name Forfeiture* (steal a declared tag until bell), *Writ of Seizure* (lock a Diamond or gear under spectral seal), *Errata* (retroactively worsen one PC’s prior roll Outcome).
- **Lair Actions (Vault of Whispers / Deep Archive):**
 1. *Quiet Hours*: Casting/rites generate +1 SB or fail softly.

2. *Reference Only*: Movement through stacks costs an action unless proper tokens are presented.
 3. *Cross-reference Collapse*: Bookshelves reconfigure; split the party.
- **Counters**: True names carved in quartz, burning a citation (sacrifice an *index*—a map, a ledger, a vow) to cancel one Move.
 - **Drop (Diamond)**: *Key of Echoes*, *Tome of Convenient Knowledge*.

Protocol Titan (stone sentinel)

A walking paragraph of law in granite; joints clock with tiny bells.

- **Phase Clock**: [6] *Challenge* → *Adjudicate* → *Execute*
- **Moves**: *Ward Stomp* (shockwave; prone or position –), *Clause Capture* (binds a PC to a declared rule), *Countermeasure* (reflect mundane force).
- **Lair Actions (Measure Vault / Throne of Echoes)**:
 1. *Bell of Standing*: Only those who declare an intent may act this round.
 2. *Weigh Deceit*: The largest lie in the scene takes Harm 1 (Stress).
 3. *Seal Turned*: A door the party used closes and locks under new terms.
- **Counters**: Present certified measures, exploit contradictions, or swear a binding minor oath (shift boss Position –).
- **Drop (Diamond)**: *The Under-Seal Clause* (local), *Key-Writ*.

Mimetic Colony (door-that-eats)

An ecosystem of impostor hinges, handles, chests, and carpets.

- **Phase Clock**: [6] *Invitation* → *Adhesion* → *Ingestion*
- **Moves**: *Stickfast* (immobilize limb/gear), *Swallow Noise* (negate assists), *Split & Flank*.
- **Lair Actions (Armory / Garden of Stone)**:
 1. *Everything's a Mouth*: First interacted object bites.
 2. *False Safe*: Creates a “short rest” that actually advances Heat +2.
 3. *Chew Through*: Destroys one rung/bridge segment.
- **Counters**: Iron spikes, chalk lines, bait boxes; fire/acid cause the colony to fragment (treat as minions).
- **Drop (Diamond)**: *Cloak of Passage*, *Token of Safe Return*.

Sluice Dragon (steam & acid wyrm)

A heat lung grown proud; scales are boiler plates, breath a flash-boil scream.

- **Phase Clock**: [10] *Banked Heat* → *Pressure Rise* → *Vent Fury* → *Rupture*
- **Moves**: *Scalding Cone*, *Vacuum Lurch* (pull PCs), *Steam Blind* (Position –).
- **Lair Actions (Heat Lungs / Cistern)**:
 1. *Valve Spin*: Change terrain tags (Dry/Wet/Boiling).
 2. *Gauge Pop*: Structure Stress +1; cracks form.
 3. *Pressure Shadow*: The dragon gains +1 Effect for one exchange.

- **Counters:** Chill the room (dump cistern), bleed valves (two actions), or bait with metal ingots.
- **Drop (Diamond):** *Forge of Quick Repair*, *Shield of Temporary Immunity*.

Crawl Procedures (Quick, Crunchy Options)

- **Short Rest (10 minutes):** Clear Fatigue 1 *or* refresh one spent tool; advance *Dungeon Awareness* +1 and roll once on *Ambient Signs* (below).
- **Secure Camp (1 hour, defensible):** Clear Fatigue 2 and one *Condition* (not Harm); *Structure Stress* +1d2 from barricading/heat, *Awareness* +2 unless *Sealed*.
- **Search a Room (5 minutes):** On success, gain 1 *Safe Route* token *or* a *Map that Grows* tick; on miss, trigger a *Door Attitude* complication.
- **Light, Air, Load:** Track three pooled clocks [4] (see Plug-in Expedition Layer). Empty tracks worsen *Position* until restored.

Wandering Signs & Encounters (d12)

1. Whisper returns one word wrong; nearest door adopts a *Hungry* attitude.
2. Drip changes rhythm; nearby *Gravity Well* awakens.
3. Custodian chalk erased and redrawn *behind* you.
4. A stack exhales: *Memory Fog* for one exchange.
5. Pilfer-vermin court demands toll (crumbs, salt, *or* gossip).
6. Bound Guardian patrol, willing to debate terms (papers help).
7. Refugee child with a *Key of Echoes* that hates you.
8. Floor warms; *Heat Lung* cycling—steam hazard next room.
9. Echo sermon on “proper doors”; ignoring it adds Heat +1.
10. Sloshing in walls; *Digestive Array* scouts with a filament.
11. A mirror shows your gear two items lighter—choose which or mark Fatigue 1.
12. Stone hymn—sing along to cancel first SB this scene, or suffer *Hungering Dark* pulse.

Classic Traps, Living-Site Style (pick 1–2 tags)

- **Pressure Mosaic** (Artful, Loud): Floor pattern asks for a dance step; wrong beat drops spears from *ceiling*, not floor.
- **Breath Tax** (Subtle, Lingering): Room meters exhalations; excess vents sleeping gas; counting etiquette downgrades risk.
- **Magi-Siphon Grate** (Hungry, Magnetic): Drains charges from tools/wards; feeding it a *Focus Crystal* buys safe passage.
- **Echo Latch** (Riddle, Social): Door opens to a truth spoken softly; lies trigger *Phantom Locks*.

Treasure & Upgrade Hooks (d8 hoard seeds)

1. Cage of *tame echoes*—store a sentence for later; release as perfect mimicry.
2. *Map that Grows* (upgraded): shows *organs* (cistern/nerve-hall) when rubbed with tallow.
3. *Wayfinder Compass* attuned: hum a note to swap “nearest exit” with “nearest objective.”
4. *Key-ring of Attitudes*: once each—*Courteous*, *Hungry*, *Proud*.

5. Bottle of *stolen seasons*: pour to set room to *pollen-sweet* or *knife-cold* for one scene.
6. *Token of Safe Return* (party-wide) that tugs twice when the *Heart Pressure* hits threshold.
7. A ledger page signed by the *Dungeon's Creator*—treat one barrier as if you are expected.
8. *Lantern of Clarity* mantle: once/session, reveals the *Price of Passage* without paying it.

Boss Build Template (one-minute prep)

1. **Name & Nature:** What organ of the dungeon is this boss the face of?
2. **Phase Clock:** 6/8/10 with 2–4 titled phases.
3. **Three Moves:** One space-control, one resource-tax, one identity/knowledge twist.
4. **Two Lair Actions:** Environmental toggles keyed to this lair.
5. **Counters:** A courtesy, a tool, a sacrifice. (Players should be able to *learn* these.)
6. **Drop:** A Diamond (from §24.1) or bespoke boon tied to the organ.

Dungeon Boss: The Heart Itself (set-piece)

A chamber of ribs and lintels; mortar smells like blood, light like fever.

- **Phase Clock:** [10] *Palpate* → *Synchronize* → *Pacemaker* → *Arrest*
- **Moves:** *Syncopate* (force actions to resolve off-beat; assist dice misfire), *Tachycardia* (Heat +2, Structure Stress +1), *Backflow* (reverse one clock tick on *Floorplan Loops*, but split the party).
- **Lair Actions:**
 1. *Valve Close:* Seal exits; require a “Somatic” or “Affective” key to reopen.
 2. *Adrenal Surge:* The Heart acts twice next round unless fed a secret *all PCs share*.
- **Counters:** Speak the dungeon’s *true purpose* (as inferred via organs), vent a heat lung, or sacrifice mapped ground (tear up a *Safe Route*).
- **Victory States:** *Stabilize* (site becomes safer; Awareness clears to 0), *Pacify* (gain *Dungeon's Blessing*), or *Slay* (collapse risk; Structure Stress +2 across the level).

Part VI

Appendices

Chapter 25

Quick Reference Cards

To be printed and kept at the table.

Core Travel Procedure (1 card)

Draw ♠+♥+♣+♦ from destination/authority decks. Highest rank sets clock (2–5=4, 6–10=6, J/Q/K=8, A=10). On success advance, on failure mark delay/debt/diversion.

Story Beat Menus

See the full tables in the Travel & Navigation chapter. The GM may choose complications by region or use the universal menu.

Gateways & Control Points

Refer to the table in *Travel & Navigation*. Each gate requires a specific ♦ for lawful priority.

Weather Engine (Wilds)

Roll d12: 1 Glass-Clear, 2 Haze, 3 Trickle Rain, 4 Downpour, 5 Thunderhead, 6 Cold Snap, 7 Heat Snap, 8 Ground Fog, 9 Spindrift/Dust, 10 Shifting Wind, 11 Front Line, 12 Catspaw Omen.